

Sverris saga

Kings' Sagas

Norse Sagas

translated by John Sephton, 1890

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PROLOGUE

1.1

HERE WE BEGIN to speak of events which happened a while ago, within the memory of the men who related them for this book; to speak, that is, of King Sverri, son of King Sigurd Haraldsson. The beginning of the book is written according to the one that Abbot Karl Jonsson first wrote when King Sverri himself sat over him and settled what he should write. The story has not come far [from its source]. It tells of certain of his battles, and as the book advances, his strength grows, foreshadowing the greater events. They therefore called this part of the book *Gryla*, that is, bugbear. The latter part of the book is written according to the relation of those who remembered what happened, having actually seen or heard it, and some of them had been with King Sverri in battles. Some of these stories were fixed in memory, having been written down directly the events occurred, and they have not been altered since. Possibly, if this book is seen by those who have full knowledge of the events, they may think many matters passed over hastily, and many left untold which they regard as worthy of mention; they may well cause these to be written down if they wish. And though, in telling of battles against large numbers, some things are here said to have occurred otherwise than seems most probable, let all know of a certainty that nothing has been added. To us it seems probable that the stories are true which are told in books concerning famous men who lived in old times.

THE SAGA OF KING SVERRI

2.1

Sverri's birth, and early life in the Faereys.

2.2

BISHOP HROI WAS at that time in the Færeys. He had a brother called Unas Kambari, who married a Norse wife named Gunnhild late in the reign of the brothers Ingi, Sigurd, and Eystein, the sons of Harald Gilli. Before long, Gunnhild had a son, who was called Sverri, and was said to be the son of Unas. His coming into the world was heralded by remarkable dreams, such as ever precede remarkable events. His mother Gunnhild told of a dream that came to her before he was born. She dreamt that she was in a goodly upper room, and about to give birth to her child, and her maid was seated at her knees ready to receive the child at its birth. After the birth a great terror seized the maid, and she cried aloud saying, "Gunnhild, my Gunnhild! you have brought forth a wonderful and awful birth." Three times she cried out, using the same words. And when Gunnhild heard the maid utter the same cry so often with trembling voice, she inquired what it was that was born; and it seemed in her dream to be a stone, very large, white as snow to the sight; and it glowed fiercely, so that it emitted sparks in all directions like iron at a white heat in the fierce blast of a forge. And she said to her maid, "We must have a watchful care of this birth and let no one know aught of it, for all who see it will think it a strange sight." So, in her dream, they took the stone and set it in a large chair and hid it under a fair covering. But cover it as they would, sparks continued to issue from it which flew in all directions through the covering to every part of the room, and they were greatly affrighted at the awful issue from the stone. Then Gunnhild awoke.

2.3

Unas and Gunnhild had a son named Hidi; a daughter, who was married to Svina-Stefan, and had a son named Petr Steypi; and also several other daughters.

2.4

When Sverri was five years old he sailed from Norway to the Færeys, and was there brought up as the foster-son of Bishop Hroi. The Bishop put him to books, and admitted him to Holy Orders, and he was ordained priest. But when he reached a ripe age he did not shape

himself to the priesthood, and was rather unruly. He had a quarrel with Bryniolf, son of Kalf Sendiman, who was then King's bailiff in the islands. Sverri had struck a man, and Bryniolf, with a large company, went to seize him, but he escaped. Yet they pressed him so closely that he ran into a stove-room to conceal himself. A woman hid him in the oven, and set a flat stone before the oven's mouth; then she lighted a fire outside. His pursuers sought him in the room, but did not find him. And afterwards, when people saw what he became, they thought there had been many signs pointing to supernatural power in him.

2.5

Sverri's dream.

2.6

2. Sverri had remarkable dreams, which some men regarded as nonsense and made sport of. He told of one in which he dreamt that he was in Norway, and was become a bird, so large that its beak reached the boundaries of the land in the east, and the feathers of its tail as far north as the dwellings of the Finns, while its wings covered the whole country. He told this dream to a wise man named Einar, and inquired what he thought it might portend. Einar answered that the dream was dark to him, but that it probably pointed to power of some kind. "Possibly," said he, "you may become Archbishop."

2.7

"It seems to me very unlikely that I shall become Archbishop," replied Sverri, "when I am not well suited to be priest." Sverri was twenty-four years of age before he was told who was his real father, and he remained one year longer in the Færeys before he proceeded to Norway.

2.8

King Magnus of Norway and his father Earl Erling.

2.9

3. At that time King Magnus and Earl Erling were strong in the support of mighty men and of all the commons. The King was beloved and popular; the Earl was powerful and wise, energetic and blest with

victory, and held all rule over the land. There were many, great and small, who wished him ill, especially in the communities of the Thronds north of the land. But Archbishop Eystein, who controlled all the north, was a very dear friend of King Magnus, and secured to him its whole strength.

2.10

King Magnus had all the greatest men in the land on his side; some of them served in his bodyguard, and others held royal grants; while the commons, with one consent, agreed to exalt him and maintain him in the kingdom. His ancestry was the greatest advantage to him; for all the people of the land loved him because of it, preferring rather to serve a descendant of Sigurd Jorsala-fari than one of Harald Gilli.

2.11

Sverri learns that he is a son of King Sigurd Munn.

2.12

4. A strange matter now happened: Gunnhild, the mother of Sverri, left the land to go south to Rome. There, to one who heard her confessions, she confessed that the man whom hitherto she had stated to be her son's father was not so; but that a king was his father, and her son himself knew it not. This confession being laid before the Pope, she was commanded in her penance to inform her son of his real parentage as soon as she found him. Not long after her return home, she sailed to the Færeys, and told Sverri that he was the son of King Sigurd Munn. This information caused him much anxiety, and his mind wavered greatly. To contend for the kingdom against King Magnus and Earl Erling seemed difficult; and yet, supposing he were a king's son, it seemed contemptible that he should do nothing more than a plain yeoman's son would, do. But when he called to mind the interpretation put upon his dreams by wise men, those very dreams quickened his courage to avenge his kinsmen.

2.13

Sverri dreams that he aids St. Olaf in fight.

2.14

5. Sverri related in these words a dream which appeared to him. He dreamt that he had come to Norway over the sea from the west, and had attained some position of honour, chosen to be bishop most likely. And there was much unrest in the land, because of the contention of kings. He dreamt that King Olaf the Saint was contending against King Magnus and Earl Erling, and he was pondering in his mind which side he should join. He chose rather to go to King Olaf, and on his arrival the King welcomed him with great joy. He had not been long with him when this event happened. One morning, as it seemed to him in his dream, there were few men with the King, not more than fifteen or sixteen, and the King was washing himself at a table in an upper room. When he had finished, another man wished to go to the table and wash in the same water, but the King pushed him aside with the hand and bade him desist. He then called Sverri Magnus by name, and bade him wash in the same water; and Sverri dreamt that he did as he was bid. When he had washed, a man rushed into the room with the sudden tidings that the King's foes were at the door, and he bade them seize their weapons as quickly as they could. But the King spoke, and said there was no danger, and bade the men take their axes and swords and march out, while he himself would take his shield and protect them all. And they did as the King commanded. Then he took his sword and offered it to the young man Sverri, and placed his standard in Sverri's hand, saying, "Take my standard, Lord, and know of a surety that henceforth you shall be its bearer always." And Sverri in his dream received the standard, though with a feeling of dread. Afterwards the King took his shield, and they all walked out together somewhat hastily. The vestibule seemed long as they marched through, not less than sixty ells in length, and while they were in the building, Sverri was unable to carry the standard upright. But when they reached the door through which they had to pass, seven men came against them with weapons, intending to cut down the standard-bearer. But the King moved forward in front of him, and with his shield protected him and all the others, so that they were unharmed. Afterwards they came

in his dream to an open country and a fair field, where he carried the standard upright, and bore it against the array of King Magnus and Earl Erling. And as soon as the attack was made, that host fell away. Then Sverri awoke, and pondering his dream, considered it better than no dream, though it seemed a strange one. He told it afterwards to his friends, that is, a few, and succeeding events agreed fairly with their interpretation. And when such things came into his mind he was greatly strengthened.

2.15

Sverri arrives in Norway; meets with Earl Erling; and visits Earl Birgi Brosa in Gautland [1174-1176].

2.16

6. Sverri now made ready for a voyage to Norway to see what would happen, and he arrived there at the time when Eystein had let himself be proclaimed King. Now Eystein and he were cousins, sons of two brothers. And when Sverri heard of Eystein's doings, he made careful inquiry into them, and found many of his plans and designs quite immature; this checked him, so that he did not feel it right to join Eystein.

2.17

Afterwards he journeyed to the north of the land, for his foster-father, Bishop Hroi, had advised that he should present himself before the Archbishop and tell his difficulty to him. As he went on the voyage he made inquiries of men who had come from the north. He delayed for a time at Selia, because he found friends. And there was a priest who gave him accurate information about all he wished to know, from which Sverri perceived how strong an opponent the Archbishop had been to his brothers. There seemed to him small hope that he would be exalted where his brothers had been abased.

2.18

He then turned south to leave the land, and sailed to Tunsberg with the crew of a merchantman, and thence to Konunga-hella. Here he had constant speech with Earl [Erling] himself, and dissembled with such

success that the Earl neither knew who he was nor what his mind was brooding over. Sverri mixed much with the body-guard and others of the King's men, and his cheerful manner and conversation were a pleasure and amusement to them at all hours. By prudent speech he so sounded them that he became assured of many matters which they would never have disclosed if they had known who was among them or with whom they conversed. He applied his mind diligently to observe if the commons showed doubtful loyalty in their language, taking care that his own words roused no suspicion, and that no one perceived what his mind was brooding over. But he only found that the whole of the commons were loyal to King Magnus.

2.19

From Konunga-hella he passed to Liodhus, enduring much fatigue and toil; and thence into East Gautland, where he arrived weary and exhausted. Three days before Yule he came to his kinsman Earl Birgi Brosa, who had married his father's sister Brigit, and he laid bare his difficulty to the Earl and his wife. But they looked coldly on the project of helping his cause. There were two reasons for this: the first, that his kinsman Eystein had raised his band of followers by their aid, and so long as he lived they would help no one else; and the second reason, a rumour had come to the ears of Birgi that Earl Erling had sent Sverri to him in "mockery. Sverri remained here during Yule, and constantly spoke to the Earl of his difficulty, begging him to give wholesome advice as to the plans he should adopt. Now there happened to be men present, such as constantly are met with, fuller of malice than kindness, and their presence was a source of great danger to Sverri. For as they were mostly shortsighted men, they believed the rumour and wished to slay him; but Earl Birgi would not have him slain without just cause, and he wished rather to inquire what were his usual habits. So they gave him to drink wine and mead, that he might become drunk, and he proved criminal out of his own mouth. But Sverri, anxious about his cause at every moment, gave little heed to either mead or wine though placed before him in plenty, and when he

found that answers were drawn from him on all matters of moment to himself, he grew more and more cautious; so that those who would make him drunk found nought of which to accuse him.

2.20

Sverri visits his sister Cecilia in Vermaland [1177].

2.21

7. After Yule-tide was passed, Sverri, perceiving that he did not obtain from the Earl such an answer as he wished, turned his course to Vermaland. He was not accompanied by a large crowd of followers, for he had only one man with him when he left the Earl; and he endured much fatigue and toil on the road. His condition most resembled that of royal children in the old stories, under the curses of step-mothers. For six or seven days together he strayed through wide and unknown forests, suffering cold and hunger in his wanderings. Arrived in Vermaland, he met men who had come from Norway, and asked them minutely of the tidings. They were able to tell him of what had lately happened: that King Eystein had marched from the north, east into the Vik, and had fought a battle at Re against King Magnus, in which he had fallen with a great part of his force. Those that escaped had fled to Vermalana, or Thelamork, or south to Denmark. The sorrows and perplexities of Sverri seemed greatly increased by this event, and he went first of all to his sister Cecilia, who, as soon as she had heard of her brother's movements, had prepared for him a hospitable reception. She was glad at his coming, and welcomed him with much joy. Afterwards brother and sister deliberated what plan he should follow. To return to Norway was not safe, for information of his affairs and movements had found its way there. It seemed to them the best course that he should visit foreign lands for a time and wait for the tidings that God would send him.

2.22

The Birkibeins, having lost their leader, offer to serve under Sverri. He refuses their offer.

2.23

8. And now the miserable band that had lost its leader learnt that a son of King Sigurd Munn had come to Vermaland. All of them that heard the news went to see Sverri, and they begged him to put himself at the head of their cause and become their leader. The troop was in a very shameful condition: some had grievous wounds, some were without clothes, and well-nigh all were weaponless. So very young, too, were they all, that they appeared to him unfit for any great enterprise. He answered them in this manner: —

2.24

“It does not seem to me desirable for either you or me that we take that course. You are poor men, and I am without resources and unknown to you. If my resolves are not to your liking, you may say that you do not clearly know whom you serve. I was brought up where men are little accustomed to such high aims or labours; and you and I, it seems to me, have small foundation for comradeship together, except poverty and trouble. I am not prepared to join your perplexities to my anxiety. But inasmuch as you have applied to me, I will give you advice that seems to me good. Birgi, my kinsman, and his wife Brigit, have three sons, who have an equal right with King Magnus Erlingsson to rule the land. Go to Birgi and ask him to give you one of them as your leader. Besides, I have carefully viewed and considered your band, and I observe in particular that there is little to distinguish one man from another among you. It is quite out of my power to take up with this band. I see great hindrances to a common cause, especially in the absence of that which either of us can least afford to lack; for there is good reason to suppose that your company has not in it the elements of such great influence in the land as is needed to cope with Earl Erling. And for myself, brought up on an outlying rock, remote from other lands, I am incapable of enterprise. Little acquaintance had I even with the customs of other men, until lately when I came to your land; far less have I the knowledge to lead a warlike host, or direct the government of the country. I am capable of nothing, being unknown to every one. No man knows from what family I spring: all are ignorant, except so

far as I myself may tell of it. Possibly you will now say of me, as of your former leader, that you did not know what manner of man he was to whom your service was given. Thus your chief will ever be held your reproach wherever you meet your foes. Let all men set their hopes on the sons of Birgi, no one on me.”

2.25

The Birkibeins consult Earl Birgi about a leader, and he sends them back to Sverri. Sverri's favourable answer.

2.26

9. These men, still in search of a leader, went to see Birgi Brosa. He bewailed their loss greatly, and thus spoke: “My sons are children in age, unable to form plans either for themselves or others; they are not capable of such — chiefly, though, because of their youth. Among the men of your band I see none to choose that are able to form plans for my sons, and I could raise no force here, because the men of Norway will not suffer a Gautish host to invade their land. But I will lay before you the plan that seems to me the best; God will decide how it turns out. A son of King Sigurd was with us during Yule, and he will be now in Vermaland. Take him for your leader; he is of the right age, and of a suitable understanding. Ask him to place himself at the head of your cause.”

2.27

“We went to that man,” they answered, “and he gave us a refusal.” The Earl then became the more urgent and said: “It is my belief that your cause will find no success unless it comes from him; and so if you will take my advice, you will go to him. You may bear him this message from me, that I promise him all such friendship as I can afford, and he shall bring his force here as to a friendly country whenever he comes into the realm of the Swedes. Give him the choice either to yield to the need of you all or to lose his life.” Now they had set men to keep watch over him while they went to consult Earl Birgi; because Sverri had formed a design to visit Jerusalem, thinking that he knew no men in Norway from whom he might expect protection. For King Magnus and

Earl Erling had so fearfully bewitched the whole of that region that no man dared speak of Sigurd or Hakon by the title of King.

2.28

These men now came the second time to Sverri, bringing letters from King Knut and Earl Birgi containing these words: "It is our prayer that you be moved to help this poor band, and show no disregard to our words. And notwithstanding that we looked coldly on your cause aforetime, yet now we will support and strengthen your rule in every way that we can." But although they used this fair, enticing language, Sverri none the less perceived his lack of means for so great a design, and again refused the men's prayer. They then called to mind the last words of Earl Birgi and offered Sverri the choice of two courses: would he prefer to take pity on their cause or look for sharper trouble from them; and they spoke in this manner: "We have long served your kinsmen. For your father's sake we have lost our fathers, brothers, well-nigh all our relations, and we have no land wherein we may dwell peacefully. And now we all again offer our duty to you yourself, but you prefer to despise both us and your own honour. Know then of a surety that we will slay you and all belonging to you, and so purchase to ourselves peace with *King Magnus*; we who were most loyal to you in time past will now be most stem." Sverri's position now seemed to him one of great and fresh difficulty, and he pondered it in himself. He saw that he would bring all his kindred to a very swift end if he risked these threats of evil. He chose otherwise, and on the Lord's day before Lent, he entered into fellowship with them; the Monday following, seventy men swore fealty to him. Some became his Guardsmen, some his Gests, and some his House-carles.

2.29

Sverri dreams that he is anointed by the Prophet Samuel.

2.30

10. The next night Sverri had a dream. He dreamt that he was at Borg, where the Raum-Elf falls into the sea, and King Magnus, Earl Erling, and their force were in the town. There was somewhat of a stir,

because a king's son was supposed to be in the town, and all the people were busy seeking where he might be. And it seemed to Sverri that this stir was about himself. He dreamt that he was making his way secretly out of the town, and had come up to Mariukirk, which he entered for the service. As he was at prayers in the church, there appeared to him a man who came and took him by the hand, and leading him into a chapel that lay north of the choir-door, thus spoke to him, "Come with me, brother, I have somewhat to tell thee in secret." Sverri went in his dream with the man, carefully observing his appearance. The man seemed to him to be very aged; his hair was of a snowy whiteness, his beard was long, and his garments trailed upon the ground; his face was ruddy, with short hair around it, and he inspired great awe. — Sverri's mind was full of concern, wondering what the man might want. The old man perceived his anxiety and said to him, "Fear not, brother, for God has sent me." Then Sverri, in his dream, sank to the ground before him, and asked, "Who art thou, Lord, that I may be assured that God has sent thee." The old man answered a second time, bidding Sverri fear not, and saying that God had sent him to him. But Sverri's fear became rather greater than less. Then the old man took him by the hand and raised him up, saying the third time, "Fear not, brother, peace be with thee. I am Samuel the prophet of God, and I have a message from God to deliver to thee." After this, the old man took a horn from a scrip which he carried about his neck, and the horn appeared to Sverri to contain holy oil. And the old man said, "Let me see thy hands." And Sverri stretched out both his hands towards him. And the man anointed them, saying, "May these hands be sanctified and made strong to hate foes and opponents, and to govern much people." Then he kissed Sverri, and taking his right hand in his own, said, "Be thou strong and valiant, for God will give thee help." Sverri then awoke and related his dream to the twelve men, two priests and ten others, who slept in the same room with him. They all considered the dream remarkable and of great import, and all of them were somewhat gladdened by it. But when he asked them to interpret the

dream, no one had the confidence to explain it, though all thought the dream better than no dream. When Sverri perceived that there was no interpretation of the dream forthcoming, he bade his men avoid speaking of the vision, though it had appeared to him.

2.31

After this dream his disposition seemed to all who were about him to undergo a great change. It was altogether a trying experience for him to live in a strange land and among a people altogether strange. And at the very same time that he took on himself the charge of his company he had to bear the burdens of those who served him; for in the troop that he had accepted, and whose lot he had bound to his own, there was not a man besides himself able to form a plan.

2.32

Sverri leads his troop into the Vik, where his men make him King. He returns to Vermaland.

2.33

11. The following Wednesday, which we call Ash-Wednesday, Sverri took with him this troop, and started from Hamar in Vermaland with not more than seventy men. He marched into the Vik, and on the way, men crowded to his band, so that when he reached Saurby in the Vik he had three and a half hundred men. Here he caused an Assembly to be summoned, at which his men would have him accept the title of King. But he excused himself, saying that it became him better to wait until his cause was strengthened by some clear evidence of its truth. Then they declared that they would not listen to him: "They were unwilling," they said, "to serve one who had no higher title than any one of themselves." They gave him, therefore, the title of King the first Lord's day in Lent, and swore fealty to him, laying their hands on his sword.

2.34

He had not been long ruler of the band before he saw, what he had already suspected, that he would not gain much strength from their counsels. He began, then, to take the whole burden on himself, and

while he stayed in the Vik with his men he studied diligently their ways and proceedings. They seemed to him a very unequal band, some of them gallant and orderly men, others unruly. Then he formed the design of putting them to the test if they would follow him for any other object than pillage and disorder. He returned to Vermaland, being unwilling to plunder in the Vik, and desirous rather of fighting for the land that was his by birthright. Thence he continued his journey, intending to march north. He proceeded as far as Eidaskog, where he reviewed his troop, and found that many who had become his liegemen lacked manliness, and had thought of plunder rather than of fighting for the honour of their King, for he had then no more than seventy men of the four hundred He now saw that he had not the means to attain his object; his troop was too small to confront such overwhelming odds as he might expect to meet. He could put no trust in a force that was unwilling to follow him north and back again. They seemed, indeed, more willing to bring down the wrath of the commons on their heads by pillage and disorder than to support him in dangerous undertakings. And this brought him much depression of mind, because almost from the outset he had been compelled to accept the title of King, and those who compelled him had given him no loyal support afterwards. Then he pondered on the plan he should follow. He could see, as he thought, no way to separate himself from his force, because those who were his most eager followers kept careful watch over him, now that he had accepted the title of King and become known to all in the land. So he turned again into Vermaland, and kept Easter with a priest who prepared a grand entertainment for him. Afterwards he sent letters into Norway, to Thelamork, because its people were at variance with King Magnas and Earl Erling, and he promised them some amendment of their laws if they would turn to him.

2.35

He also appointed that they should meet him north in the land, if they would join him or afford him assistance.

2.36

King Sverri's toilsome march north through the forests.

2.37

12. Easter week being past, Sverri perceived that he would not be able to reach the north of the land unless he made a laborious march by strange paths. For directly it became known that a rebellious troop was forming in the east of the country, great preparations to meet it were made over the whole land, so that no progress was possible through well-peopled districts. To turn towards the Eystra-salt seemed his best plan. The first wood through which he marched with his men before they reached Aekisherad was twelve miles long. And when they passed thence, they had to march through another wood quite as long, before they came to Molung. Thence they marched fifteen miles through a wood to Jarnberaland. In all these woods there was no food except flesh of birds and elks. For many reasons the marches were toilsome and difficult, for they were made chiefly through uninhabited districts, and the men suffered hunger, cold, and much weariness; they were unable to make use of horses or other means of progress, for the roads were in the worst condition, as at that time the snow was melting in the woods and the ice thawing on the waters. At one time they marched over bogs or wide moors, at another through dense forests or over great felled trees.

2.38

Jarnberaland is under the rule of the King of the Swedes, and was at that time a heathen land. Its people had never before set eyes on a king, and they were unaccustomed to the visits of kings. It might even be said, there was not one among them who understood what king's men were, or knew whether they were men or animals. There was great difficulty in making way among so rude a people. But Almighty God and Holy Maria gave such abundant grace to King Sverri, that when the people heard his words they furthered his progress and permitted him to pass through their land. But his road lay for the most part by wild forests, mosses, deserts, great streams and lakes, rather than by

human dwellings. From Jarnberaland he marched eighteen miles through a wood to the district called Herdales, which was his own land. Thence he marched thirty-two miles through another wood, in which his men were so distressed that they found nothing to eat except the bark and sap of trees, and such berries as had lain all winter under the snow.

2.39

King Sverri the subject of a miracle. Continued sufferings of his men on the march north

2.40

13. It happened that King Sverri had to pass over a large lake in a forest, and as there were no boats in the neighbourhood, his men constructed rafts of trees, three or four together, just as they then could. The raft which bore the King was not large, and had four men on it. The lake was half a mile across. As soon as they had moved a short distance from shore, the raft sank until the water reached half-way up the legs of those who were on it. At this moment a man came running to the edge of the lake, much exhausted by the march, for they were in the very thick of the forest, and the whole troop had now been two days without food. He called to those on the raft, begging them to save him, as he was almost dead of exhaustion. Now the rest of the troop were well on their way over the lake. The King heard the man's cry, and saw that his life depended on their taking him; yet the raft seemed scarcely able to bear those already on it. But he had the raft pushed to land and took the man on, though it was no easy matter; and when he came on the raft, the water reached above their knees. In this way they crossed the lake, and then quitted the raft, landing by means of a single log. The King was the last to go on shore, and as soon as he left the raft it sank like a stone. All marked the singular and marvellous character of the event. For having beheld the raft float when carrying its human freight, and sink the instant they left it, all saw clearly that it had borne one who was destined to do great deeds that were yet undone, and to hold higher rank than he yet held.

2.41

They passed the next two days in the wilds without nourishment, except from chewing pine-shoots for the sap, and sucking birch-wood. The third day the whole troop was in extreme need. Yet they marched with such vigour through this wilderness that only thirteen short miles yet remained. And now it came to pass that the troop crossed a large river, and as they reached the other side they lay down on the bank, having lost all desire to go farther, so weaned had they become. The King was among the last three that crossed, and the current bore them a long way down the river, but at last they drifted to land and took rest. Then the King bade his men be of good courage; they were not far now, he said, from the abodes of men, and their hopes would again shine bright if they should come at last to a Christian people.

2.42

King Sverri marches through Jamtaland and comes to Nidaros. The men of Selbu and Gaulardale submit to him.

2.43

The King now reached Jamtaland, and the Jamts wished to oppose him. He therefore sent forward Sigurd of Saltness, supposing they would be less on their guard against wise schemes before he himself, the chief of the band, came up. And his supposition proved true, for Sigurd in his expedition got possession of all their ferry-boats, which they had prepared for the defence of their land. When the King himself arrived, the yeomen felt the loss of their boats, and, as the best course before them, submitted to him. King Magnus had many barons in the land, and they all made peace with King Sverri; they prepared receptions for him» and full entertainment; they supplied him with sixty men. Afterwards he proceeded on his march, and again his troop suffered great distress, so that no man tasted food for five days; neither had they time for sleep, because the King did not wish intelligence of his march to precede him. On the Friday night before Whitsunday he came into the neighbourhood of the town [Nidaros]. The townsmen heard of his approach, and crossed the river Nid to oppose him with twelve

hundred men under Sigurd Nikolasson, Eirik Amason, Ivar Horti, Ivar Silki, and Ivar Gíafvállsson. When the King became aware of this force he went himself to spy them out, taking with him a man named Jon, and coming right among them, obtained an accurate knowledge of the odds against him; and seeing that with one hundred men he was unable to fight against twelve hundred, he turned away for the present.

2.44

Then the men of Selbu gathered together against him to the number of three hundred. But King Sverri's men were so exhausted by their toilsome march and long want of sleep that they were forced to take rest. So he sent messengers to Vigleik of Digrin, bidding him give his men food, and Vigleik thought good to obey the message. On their departure from Digrin, God so furthered the King's cause that he and his troop got between the Selbu host and their boats, the whole of which they took. They then sailed to the abodes of the very men who were eagerly plotting against their lives, and found a lodging in their houses, whether the owners of the farms liked it or not. And when these reached their homes, there was not a man of them but consented to all the King required; and he laid on them the charge of half a month's provisions. The King then occupied an island in the lake of Selbu, afterwards called the King's-holm. This place they left in the night, no one knowing of their departure but themselves, and marched into the Vatsfell. Here they lay, no one being aware of them; and they learnt all that occurred in the town, and heard much that was said of themselves. The men of Gaulardale also had gathered a great host together, which the Birkibeins watched closely, but this force was disbanded when, after some days, nothing was heard of the King. Forthwith the Birkibeins, seeing them disperse, followed close upon their heels and came quite unexpected to their abodes; the inhabitants then gladly submitted to all that King Sverri demanded. This news was soon told in Nidaros, and a force was again despatched from the town to go after him. But King Sverri again withdrew for a time and

marched up into Soknadale. When he arrived there he heard that But and eighty men, all well armed, had come from Thelamork. This was in answer to the message and letters, already mentioned, which the King had sent to Thelamork. He rejoiced greatly to hear the news, and then marched up to Rennabu to meet them.

2.45

King Sverri's victory over the men of Nidaros.

2.46

15. After this the King turned back, having now with him a hundred and eighty men. They marched until they came to the mouth of the Gaul, which they crossed on ferry-boats. The twenty men who first reached the other side were sent forward by the King as scouts under Jon Gudrunarson. The townsmen [of Nidaros] had also sent out scouts on their part, seven in number. These two bands met; five of the townsmen were slain, one was taken prisoner, and one escaped, who bore the news to the town. Hereupon the townsmen went forth, twelve hundred in number, drawn up in orderly array. And Ivar Horti spoke, saying, "We must use craft in hunting them down; let us hide some of our force, for if they see the whole they will not venture to attack." So they placed seven hundred men behind a fence, to come forth and attack the enemies' rear when the hosts were engaged in close combat. The townsmen showed such audacity — barons and yeomen as they were — that they took the banner of King Olaf the Saint, to bear it against King Sverri; but you shall hear now what came to pass. The man who bore the banner was mounted on horseback, and as he rode behind the force he could not stop his horse, which ran against two men. One of these was killed, and the other so injured that he never fully recovered; the rider himself was thrown, and let the banner fall to the ground. Against these five hundred men, all in battle array, the King drew up his force, setting his bowmen all together; and every man made good use of his weapons. The ambush behind the fence only became aware of the fight by the whizzing of the arrows over their heads. These all whom Ivar supposed to have the victory in their

hands were the first to flee, each man running against his fellow; and those who, considering their numbers, might be thought unlikely to win, were made glad by victory. King Sverri in this battle slew Ivar Silki and Ivar Gíafvallsson, and more than a hundred men besides. They captured the banner of King Olaf the Saint, which they bore to the town in glorious triumph, while the chiefs who escaped from the battle ran hither and thither like mice to their holes. Eirík Arnason was there taken prisoner. Afterwards quarter was accepted, and many came with meekness into the presence of Sverri who before, in excess of pride, had been loudest in their talk against him. And now King Sverri gave thanks to Almighty God, to Holy Maria the Mother of God, and to King Olaf the Saint, for the glorious victory which God had given him; and he showed his thankfulness by granting pardon to every one that asked it. Many great men had escaped, and he was conscious that they would lay plots against him if he were not on his guard.

2.47

After the battle the King sent forth spies from the town both by sea and land. These returned after three days, bringing with them tidings that the Inner Thronds had collected twenty hundred men, and were already on the way thither; and that Ivar had fifty ships at sea, near the Raudabíorg. As soon as these tidings came all at once to the ears of the King, he perceived that he could not remain where he was, and his men hastened on board eleven cutters which they procured. When they had rowed a short distance beyond Holm, they beheld the fleet of the Inner Thronds sailing from the inner part of the Fiord, and came within range of them. There were nine ships of burden at anchor near the Raudabíorg, but the King would not attack them, for they were a merchant fleet come from Vaga, and he would never do harm to merchants if they would value themselves aright. Near the Raudabíorg, also, lay eleven cutters and one long-ship which Ivar had got together. These fled immediately, for they dared not fight with the Birkibeings; and the King sailed on to Agðaness, where he came upon nine cutters,

and at once made at them. Their crews did some trade — trade of this kind: they bartered their clothes and weapons for knocks and shame. They lost everything of value they possessed, but the King would not allow the men themselves to be slain. Then he took his ships seaward to Folskn, where they met with a ship of burden, owned by Ivar; and on board of it was property to the value of six marks of gold, which they took. After this they sailed south to Mœri, where they came upon twelve or thirteen cutters, and a like market was made for these as for the former crews. Both fleets were intending to join Ivar, if there came no ‘trolls in the way between outhouse and home.’

2.48

The Assembly at Eyra accepts Sverri as King. He marches into the Uplands and gains two victories.

2.49

16. After this the King turned back north to Thronðham, and, coming to Nidaros, was received as befitted a king by the townsmen, who had the bells rung throughout the town and went in procession to meet him. He then caused the Assembly to be summoned at Eyra, calling to it twelve men by name from each of the eight shires that lie within Agðaness. At this Assembly of the eight shires, met together, the title of King was given to Sverri, and ratified by the brandishing of weapons; land and liegemen were confirmed to him by oath in accordance with the old laws of the land.

2.50

Tidings of these things spread abroad rapidly, and reached King Magnus and Earl Erling, who straightway gathered a force together and sailed north coastwise. On hearing this, King Sverri would not wait for them, but with his ships and men sailed away into Orkadale. Here they dragged the ships ashore, set fire to them, and burnt them completely. They now turned to the Uplands. Having passed over Dofrafell into Gudbrandsdales, they held an Assembly, after which they marched on till they came to the lake called Miors, where was a gathering of barons with eighteen ships. There were three barons,

Hallvard of Sasteads, Saebiorn Sindrason, and Ivar Gæsling. They had another force on land which numbered twelve hundred men. King Sverri had two hundred men. He now sought counsel of his troop what plan he should adopt; and they all wished to fight. But the King thus answered them: "It does not appear to me as to you; for I think there are great odds to deal with. I intend to avenge my sorrows another way, a way more promising than that of walking into such a snare, for my father, brothers, and many ancestors besides, will not be avenged by my biting the dust or being driven to flight." So by the King's advice, but against their own wish, they marched thence two days' journey. The King sent forward forty men to Hadaland, to the lake called Bond, and they seized all the ships that were there. And when the King arrived he found three hosts gathered together — in two places three hundred men, and five hundred in the third. He then divided his force into two, himself taking one half, a hundred men, and the other half he sent to the homestead of Ozur Bilsí, which they plundered to the amount of twenty marks of gold. The King did not wish to be idle while they were absent, and he decided to attack with the force he had a host of three hundred before him. Both sides made ready as best they could, and marched against each other. But as soon as the Birkibeins brandished their weapons, the yeomen fellows were struck to the heart with fear. They took now a better course. They asked for quarter, threw down their weapons, and so showed their fear. The King acted as before, and gave every man quarter that asked. A second host of those gathered together, seeing how their fellows were dealt with, also reconciled themselves to the King. They promised such obedience as never before was promised in Hadaland, and an Assembly was summoned at which the King should conclude peace. But this meeting for peace was not meant by the yeomen to be free from guile, for seeing that the King had but a small force with him, they intended to fall upon him at the Assembly. On the day appointed for the meeting, those who had been sent to plunder Ozur's homestead returned, and as the King's force was now more numerous than the yeomen expected,

they dared not utter a word in opposition to what the King wished. He therefore laid upon them such terms as he liked, and they promised all that he demanded. Thus they were reconciled, so to speak. But yet the yeomen fellows showed somewhat of a deceitful disposition as before; for they decided to send word to Orm Kings-brother, who was then at sea on board ship, and ask him to sail up from the Vik against the King, whom they said they would oppose if he should attempt to escape. Orm therefore collected a numerous force, and had large ships dragged out of the lake called Tyrfi, to go to Rond and attack King Sverri, who was there on board ship.

2.51

The King's bailiffs had arranged to have in Heidmork at that time fourteen ships on Miors. King Sverri, having intelligence of these, formed his plan. He made as though he would go to meet Orm, and sent forward all his scouts in that direction. Then he went into the wood with forty men, and they felled trees. No one knew the reason of this; but the King had commanded his men to follow him, which they did, and passed the night there. At daybreak the next morning the trumpets were sounded, and the whole force arose, not knowing what business the King had in hand. When the men were dressed, he arranged them, and bade them drag the ships from Rond, five miles along a road never before passed by ships. No need now to ask why the King had those trees felled in the wood; they were the rollers. No pause was made on the road until they came to Miors. Arrived there, they rowed forward and made an unexpected attack on the barons. The encounter so ended that he whom God favoured gained a victory, and King Sverri routed all his foes. When he had cleared the place he sailed to Hamar-Kaupang, where he held an Assembly, and no man spoke a single word against the King. The barons fled before him to the south of the lake, and there was now a long distance between them, for Miors is so large a lake that it is more like a sea.

2.52

King Sverri defeats the barons near Lake Miors,.

2.53

17. Hallvard of Sasteads and other barons held a great feast at Sasteads, to which he invited all who wished to be invited, that their following might be as numerous as possible. It was the anniversary of the dedication of the church. Three hundred were bidden, but more than three hundred attended; for the Birkibeins came to the festival, all prepared for battle. Both sides drew up their array, marched against each other and exchanged shots; the barons and their host were soon in flight, seven being slain and five taken prisoners. And now the unbidden guests were they that enjoyed the feast, and they that prepared it were chased away. These ran to Orm Kings-brother, and told him that their paths had not been smooth. King Sverri now inquired of the men made prisoners where their ships lay hidden, and being told, he seized all the ships on Miors, both small and large. He took of the property of the barons and of all those who fled away, likewise all the land dues which King Magnus and Earl Erling expected for themselves.

2.54

The whole of the Uplands and the Eystridales were now in the possession of King Sverri, and those who submitted to him had ever a better lot than those who steered away from him. And as men perceived his power growing, more by wise counsels than a multitude of adherents, they were ever the more eager to cultivate his friendship. His host increased so that he had three hundred men. After this, King Magnus and Earl Erling came into the Vik, and having heard all the tidings now related of the Birkibeins, they gathered troops together afresh from over all the Vik, collecting a warlike host that was irresistible; and when King Sverri was told of it, he perceived the unwisdom of awaiting danger there from this innumerable force.

2.55

King Sverri marches across country to Sogn, intending to go to Bergen.

2.56

18. King Sverri now made ready to march into Sogn, intending to proceed to Bergen. And inasmuch as Almighty God and Holy Maria have given King Sverri many a glorious victory, it is possible, if we speak only of his victories, that envious and foolish men will not believe our story, but will assert that we must be untruthful. We shall therefore check their incredulity and show the fairness of our narrative by telling both of good and evil fortune; for many a wretched road had Sverri to travel and his men to tramp, before he had avenged the many grievous sorrows which he had to requite the King and his father the Earl, and before he was able to win by the sword the inheritance of his fathers from his powerful opponents with the small force at his command. And though he always had much trouble and fatigue through his labour, yet he never was so tried by weariness and bad weather, by loss of sleep and want of food, as in the journey that he now undertook.

2.57

He started on his march to Bergen, but when he reached Sogn his enemies had preceded him with the news of his approach, and he was confronted by a large gathering. At the beginning of his descent from the mountains into Sogn with his troops, his road lay along a narrow path; on one side was a river so rapid as to be one constant waterfall, and not a living creature could cross it but a bird on the wing; the other side was a sheer precipice that might not be scaled in any way. So narrow was the path that it afforded passage for but one at a time. Above, on the crags in front, the yeomen sat in large numbers, having a store of logs and stones ready to cast down on the King's men as they passed under. When the King perceived them, he used stratagem to meet stratagem, and thus addressed his force:

2.58

“Stand under shelter of the rock, and don't let these men have opportunity to hurt you; taunt them, nevertheless, as much as lies in your power, and I will see if I can make a stir in their troop.” Then with some of his men he found a way as he best could to the fells above, and

came upon his foes, quite unawares, in their rear. Straightway they took to flight, and some of them were slain. Afterwards he marched forwards with his men into the peopled district and entered Leradale. Next morning Ozur Bilsí arrived by sea with six-and-twenty ships before they were aware of his coming. The Birkibeins seized their weapons and went to meet the foe; but though the ships' crews formed a numerous host, they did not venture to come on shore. There was danger ahead where they saw Birkibeins awaiting them on land quite close to the harbour, and they stood aloof.

2.59

King Sverri marches from Leradale to Vors, and then turns back. The sufferings of his men.

2.60

19. The King now perceived, since intelligence of his approach had already preceded him, that he would be unable to obtain ships. He therefore proposed to march up to Vors, and thence down into Bergen. This was a journey full of danger at the beginning of winter, because large parts of the road lay over mountains where much snow was to be expected. But the resolution was made, because destiny had ordained a battle for the Birkibeins at that time. They marched up to Vors, where danger did not cease to await them in many forms, the chief one being a hostile gathering of all the men of Vors, and many of Sogn, Hardangr, and South Hordaland, an irresistible host. All this force came upon the Birkibeins unawares on Simun's mass-day, as the King sat at meat before continuing his march. As soon as the Birkibeins became aware of their approach, they leapt up from the tables, put on their armour, and awaited the arrival of their comrades in arms, for they had not all passed the night in the same quarters. When their whole force was come together, the Birkibeins drew up in battle array, and the yeomen likewise. But though the Birkibeins were the smaller host, they were not the less eager to begin the attack, and so fierce was their first onset that the enemy's vanguard recoiled before them. The yeomen fled down a steep descent to a river, which they crossed; on the other side

was a steep ascent, and as the chasm was narrow, both armies exchanged shots across it. Each host now proceeded up the river on its own side, the yeomen wishing to get ahead, so as to be in the rear [when the Birkibeins turned]. The higher they marched, the broader became the chasm, which widened above into a lake; so that the farther the two hosts marched, the greater became the distance between them. Night came on and they lost sight of each other, so that nothing further might be done.

2.61

No advantage could be gained now by going on to Bergen, as the news of the King's approach would precede him all the way, and at Bergen there was a force so numerous and strong as to make the place unsafe for the Birkibeins. The King now wished to march back by the way he had come, and took with him five guides, men who had the most accurate knowledge of the ways. This was then needful, for the weather had become so stormy that the like had seldom been seen, and snow fell deep beyond experience. To tell of the march briefly, they lost more than one hundred and twenty horses with gilded saddles, and also precious chattels of different kinds, cloaks, weapons, and many other valuables. In addition to this trouble they lost knowledge of their way. They were without food, and unable even to obtain water; for eight days they tasted nothing but snow. The day before All Hallows' Mass the weather was so stormy — those who hear this story will deem it incredible — that the storm hurled one man to the ground with such violence that he was killed, his back being broken in three places. When the squalls passed over them they could only cast themselves down in the snow and hold their shields over them with all their strength. Their guides lost hope, for they knew not where they had come, and the darkness was so thick that they could not see before them. Hunger and weariness, and in some cases the cold, had crushed completely the whole force, and their strength was so exhausted that not a man would proceed farther. As soon as they could see just in front of them they found that they had arrived at some steep rocks.

Thereupon an evil murmur ran through the Kings host. Some declared that they would suffer no longer, but leap from the rocks and bring their severe torment to a speedy end. Others said, “We shall show more prowess in calling to mind the deeds of old time, and in following the courageous example of those who turned their weapons against one another, and met death at each other’s hands rather than endure misery.”

2.62

King Sverri encourages his men under their sufferings.

2.63

20. The King now began to address them, and having called for a hearing, spoke thus, as God taught him: —

2.64

“I have considered your design,” he said; “it seems a hopeless one, and your purpose will not help you in the least. To leap from the cliffs and kill yourselves is the expedient of madmen who are unable to guide their own steps. And as to your wish to turn your weapons against one another, that is a custom of the heathen who know not God. We are Christians, the children of Christians, and know that whosoever inflicts death upon himself has no hope in God. The suggestion is an instigation of the Fiend, and we must not do his will. Turn we now to the mercy of God, and let this sink into our minds, that though His chastisement seems severe, He will not inflict much where little is merited. Let us repent of our sins, and recognise that we are chastised by God for our evil lives, and not from cruelty on His part. We must therefore submit ourselves to Him, in meekness and lowliness, as He himself has taught us. ‘Learn of Me,’ He said; ‘for I am meek and lowly in heart, and ye shall find rest unto your souls.’ Now every one may see that it is better to submit to God’s mercy and make vows than to fall by evil deeds into the power of the Fiend. I desire your promise, therefore, the promise of you all, to join heartily with me in what I wish to take in hand. We will all with one consent appeal to God’s mercy, to the Blessed Maria, and to King Olaf the Saint, and make holy vows.”

2.65

At the close of the King's speech they bound themselves straightway, by joining hands and clashing weapons, to perform the solemn vow the King should make. And such was the fierce violence of the storm when the King began to utter it, that those who stood nearest heard him with difficulty; but as soon as he had given utterance to the vow, God granted them His gracious mercy so speedily that no one at the moment could say from what quarter the wind then blew; sunshine, bright weather, and a balmy air, as if the time were midsummer, broke suddenly over them. They now perceived where they had come, and that they had marched in a direction quite athwart their proper course; and so weary and exhausted were they that twenty of them fell down dead within a short space. But the troop took courage, and though their progress was slow and difficult, they reached some mountain sheds, where they cast themselves down and found repose. After this they sought to kindle a fire for themselves if they possibly could, for there was great need of it and midnight was at hand. But so utterly worn out were the men that not one was capable of kindling the fire. And now, as in other straits, there was one place to look to, through God's mercy; life depended on their obtaining fire, and he who brought the greatest good fortune to that troop, and guided all their undertakings, King Sverri himself, kindled it for them. He struck a flint and lighted a wax-candle, which he handed to his men, and with its help they made a large fire and dried themselves. There was a small house a short way off, and the King went to the yeoman who lived there and passed the night, while some of his force went to the main homestead. When the King saw that his troops were refreshed, he went himself to keep watch, taking with him those that seemed most capable; for the approach was by a single narrow path, and if that was well guarded, all were safe. Three days the King kept watch, and then he wished to go forward to a more thickly peopled part. To pass between the two was very difficult; he must either march a long journey across the fells, or over steep rocky slopes that were very dangerous. The King's men did not wish to go across the fells, for they

would have encountered the same stormy weather as in coming where they were.

2.66

King Sverri marches through Valdres into Gudbrandsdales, and surprises Thorgrim, one of King Magnus's men.

2.67

21. King Sverri next marched up into Valdres and was entertained on the royal estates. Thence he passed into Gudbrandsdales, where half a month's entertainment was prepared for him and all his force at the King's estate of Steig. After this it was not possible for him to remain in quiet. There were twelve yeomen of Heidmork who had met and agreed that each of them should raise a hundred men. These twelve were King Magnus's men from Hamar-Kaupang. When the King was informed of these tidings he prepared to depart from the Dales, not wishing to be shut in, if his foes should beset the main entrance. The ringleader and head of the gathering was a yeoman named Thorgrim. Now the King marched in haste, as he wished to carry the news of his journey himself rather than let others tell of it. And one night he left his force, not wishing the whole of it to be delayed on the business he had in hand. Taking five men with him, he went to seek Thorgrim, whom he found at home with eight men, and their meeting was of another kind than Thorgrim had expected. For God so ordered between them that the nobler man had the upper hand: the yeoman was bound prisoner and his House-carles were beaten. The affair ended by the King taking much wealth from Thorgrim; and over and above, Thorgrim paid King Sverri half a mark of gold, glad, however, that he was able to do it and be free. Upon this they separated.

2.68

King Sverri's further marches. He passes Yule in the Eystridales.

2.69

22. After this King Sverri marched to Hamar-Kaupang, where he took Harald Gudbrandsson prisoner. Harald was a kinsman of the King, and many persons begged that he might not be slain. He paid to the King

twelve ounces of gold. Others of King Magnus's men escaped by flight, forsaking much wealth in property of all kinds. The King next marched into Eystridales, where he arrived five days before Yule. The yeomen, supposing that the troops of the Birkibeins intended to live during Yule at their cost, adopted means of prevention, and not one of them prepared either ale or other stores for the Yule banquets. The King, perceiving their design, laid his own plans to meet theirs; for he and his men needed Yule fare none the less though the yeomen should fail in affording them hospitality. He therefore turned away elsewhere, pretending a march east into Vermaland, and came as far as Eidaskog on the right way. Arrived there, he divided his force, and sent one hundred men through the forest to Vermaland, where they were well received. The King himself, with two hundred men, then turned back to the Dales, for he suspected that as soon as he had left the yeomen they would hold their Yule banquets. The King's foresight proved true on this occasion, as on many others. He reached the district at Yule-tide, and his men all made themselves at home, regardless of 'Sheafbeard's' pleasure. So the King had the best of entertainment the whole of Yule.

2.70

Earl Erlings attempt to surprise King Sverri [1178].

2.71

23. At this time Earl Erling was staying east in the Vik, and heard of these proceedings. Immediately after Yule he summoned a levy, thinking to make a din at the door of the Birkibeins, and shut them up in the Dales, like sheep in pens ready for slaughter. But craft met craft, for King Sverri soon espied the snare in which they intended to take him. He had made his plans so that the places where he was first entertained lay in the northern parts of the Dales. As Yule passed on he drew south towards the main entrance, and before the Earl could reach that spot he was away east in Vermaland, leaving his pursuers to whistle in his rear. The Earl now resolved to follow him east into Vermaland; but the Vermans opposed his passage, and cut down trees

before him on his march through the wood, saying that this march should be the worst he ever made. Thereupon he turned right back again.

2.72

King Sverri assaults the house of Simun of Skriksvik. He defeats Simun in a pitched battle.

2.73

24. King Sverri now gathered together all his force, and rode with five hundred men down into the Vik to Simun's homestead in Skriksvik, which they seized. They burnt his house, all his long-ships, and a new ship built for trading in the Baltic, and drove off forty cattle into Vermaland. When Simun heard of his loss he sent the war-arrow round about summoningthane and thrall to join him in a march against the Birkibeins. Simun was a great and mighty chief, whose bidding no man dared withstand, and in a short time he had collected a large force, one of four hundred and twenty men. Meanwhile the King had passed right away east to the Elf, and reached the boundary of the land. Simun therefore marched up along the Gaut-Elf. Now the King was staying by the river in a small village, and his men were dispersed in quarters a short distance off, because the village was small; besides, the King knew not that danger was so swiftly overtaking him. But his friends sent him word during the night from Gautland that Simun was coming with an overwhelming host, and would quickly be upon him if he were not on his guard. As soon as King Sverri heard this he hastened to dress and take his weapons; and then sent to call together all his men, which was not a matter to be done quickly, for they were scattered here and there. He then went into a wood known as the wood of Hufuness, where he waited for them. And when they were come, he took counsel with them what plan they should adopt "It will be difficult for us to fight against King Magnus and Earl Erling," he said, "if we flee before barons, even though in our ignorance of their numbers we should find a large force against us." His men all said they would fight against Simun rather than flee, not supposing Simun's

force so great as it was. They marched, therefore, against Simun, and the two armies met before day in such pitchy darkness that no man saw the foe till his standard was waving over them. Fighting began at once; the battle was fierce, but not long, and in the end God gave the King a glorious victory. There fell a hundred and forty of Simun's men, and seven of the King's. Simun and his men fled, but the King did not venture to pursue the fugitives on account of their numbers and the darkness.

2.74

King Sverri in the Vik. He avoids King Magnus, and marches to Vermaland, and thence northwards.

2.75

25. After this battle King Sverri set out for Konungaheila, where he obtained much wealth, the property of those who fled on his approach. He also laid a tribute on the town, twenty marks [of silver] by weight. But he stayed no longer than two days, for he considered that a force so large as the one that had fled under Simun would probably return. He passed on therefore to Liodhus, where he abode several days. Meanwhile King Magnus and Earl Erling, with all the barons of the Vik, collected a large force, and the two armies marched by chance towards one another, yet without knowing it. For King Sverri was then planning to gain some further advantage in the Vik, if opportunity offered. At one time the two armies were quartered for the night not more than a mile apart, and yet neither knew of the other. The next morning they marched towards one another, till only the fourth of a mile separated them. And now King Sverri became aware of the presence of the hostile force under King Magnus and the Earl his father. He turned back instantly until he came east to Vermaland. Here he held a meeting with all the most powerful men and the wisest, and inquired whether they would form a compact with him and he should become their protector, or would they reject his offer. To this they answered that they would gladly bargain to help him in battle as if he were their King. The men of Sunndale said they

would make an unpleasant rear attack on those who came against him there in the east. When King Magnus and Earl Erling heard of these things they turned away without more ado. But they despatched Orm Kings-brother into the Uplands, a country where his kinsmen dwelt in great force, and bade him lie in wait against Sverri, should he again come there from Vermaland.

2.76

King Sverri, seeing it hard to face them, set out to march as far as the Eystrasalt, having with him not more than two hundred men. When he reached Jamberaland he was opposed by a great gathering, that cut down the trees in his way, saying they were not used to royal visits, and, moreover, did not want them. The King rode forward and conversed with them; and at the end of the parley they allowed him to go on with his journey, and furthered it in every way they could.

2.77

Raving passed through Jarnberaland and Helsingialand, King Sverri conquers the Jamts.

2.78

26. From Jarnberaland King Sverri marched into Helsingialand, and when he reached Alpta he was met by a great crowd collected to oppose him, not less than thirty hundred men, all prepared for battle, and one hundred of them were clad in mail. All this force had decreed to declare every man a traitor who should give quarter [to the Birkibeins] or let them march forward, and had all ratified it by clash of weapons. Moreover, they suffered none of King Sverri's men to come to their Assembly or speak a word there; but at length leave was given all the Kings men to attend and listen to what was said. Then King Sverri spoke to his men that they should form in warlike order and be prepared for what this people should attempt. And when the men of the land saw this, their courage failed them, so that they sent to say the King might attend the Assembly, but should not himself be allowed to speak, though his men might speak for him. The men of Helsingialand now declared that the King must not go forward, and

they offered him no course but to return by the way he came. At length, however, the King was allowed to make one speech, and he thus began: "We know not what charges you can lay against us; but you should consider this, that we all acknowledge one God and call Him our Father. There is then great need — yea, it is our bounden duty — that we be at peace one with another, and care for one another as for ourselves. My men have never done you wrong. Consider, too, how small are the benefits for which you are indebted to King Magnus and Earl Erling." Then having commanded two horses to be brought forward that they might be slain for food, he said that if they were so sparing of their food, the story would be told in every land how Christian men, to preserve life, were compelled to eat horse-flesh in their country. When he ceased speaking, one of the yeomen offered to entertain him and seventy of his men. This was he who had made the proposal to declare every man a traitor from whom Sverri should obtain aid. And after him the yeomen offered entertainment to the King and all his men.

2.79

The Jamts, having learnt what had occurred among the Helsings, gave King Sverri and his men a good reception, and he passed from the east over their land, receiving entertainment. Coming to the north of it, he showed great confidence in the friendly promises of the Jamts, and so arranged his night-quarters that his men were dispersed about the neighbourhood, and he kept with him no larger a force than one hundred. On one occasion, about the middle of the night, a man came to him with information that the Jamts had collected a force in the east of the land and were marching after him, purposing to slay him and all his men; all the barons were in the plot. King Sverri arose instantly and had his men roused, bidding them put their armour on. He told them what tidings he had learnt, and said he feared very greatly that his men, scattered over the district, were slain. Straightway, the same night, he marched with the force he had with him, towards the place where he heard the Jamts were. How they had

advanced in three divisions, that each might approach the King from a different side and so surround him; and as King Sverri was passing over a creek of the lake between the Undurseys and the mainland, the host of the Jamts came upon him and surrounded him. The host was twelve hundred men. Then the King charged his men: "Make use of the same password and encourage one another in the same phrases that you hear the Jamts use; and as soon as possible withdraw from their host and pass over to the islands. But first let us make a fierce attack on them and try if they will give way." The Birkibeins now raised the war-cry and ran forward boldly as the Jamts came upon them from all sides. A great battle followed, with sharp fighting, but the night was so dark that no man could see to recognise another. When the sharp attack was over, the Birkibeins withdrew from among the crowd of yeomen. These did not perceive the stratagem at once, and fought against each other for a long time, until near dawn. When they ceased fighting, having discovered that they were slaying one another, the Birkibeins set upon them with such fierceness that the yeomen recoiled before them; and seeing the ill luck of their force, they fled, followed hard by the Birkibeins, who slew as many as they wished. Nearly one hundred of the Jamts were slain, and a great number were wounded. King Sverri had a hundred men, and the Jamts twelve hundred. In the morning the King sent for his other men, and all came. The Jamts now begged for peace, and brought hostages to the King, and were reconciled to him. He laid a heavy tribute on them. They agreed to become his subjects, and he appointed bailiffs to collect fines and other dues. The Jamts confirmed the agreement with many oaths, and when the tribute was paid, the King departed from them without more ado.

2.80

King Sverri is compelled by his men to attack Nidaros against his judgment.

2.81

27. Hereupon King Sverri set out on his journey over the fells, and came down into Naumudale, where he betook himself to the ships owned by the yeomen, and sailed out to the Skillinga. He held a council

of his men here, for he did not wish the people to know of what they spoke. The King then discussed with his men how they should go on with their journey, saying that three courses appeared open: one, to make a voyage north to Halogaland, obtain there friends and ships, and then sail south to Bergen to see if he could win a victory over his foes; the second course, to leave the land and sail west to the islands, where was a good prospect, he considered, of obtaining support; the third course, to go on a plundering expedition to Ireland or other western lands, for he was of opinion that the popularity of King Magnus and Earl Erling would grow less the longer they ruled over the country. "At present," he said, "their power is great, and to contend with them will be a hard matter." His men all answered him that they wished to go on to Nidaros; there was nothing to prevent their reaching the town; and as it held no forces of either King or Earl, but contained many friends of King Sverri, they would be able to win it and so increase his resources. But the King replied, "I am not eager for this, and my feeling has been confirmed by a dream. You would act more wisely in following my advice, as on former occasions, and attack the town later on." As nothing would satisfy his men except an attempt on the town, the King said they should have their wish. So, against his desire, they now sailed south to the entrance of Throndham. Arrived at Folskn, the King wished to sail on to Bergen and not enter the Fiord, saying that no honour would be gained, in his opinion, by going at present to Nidaros. But the men said there was no wiser course, and nothing to prevent them reaching the town; and all, the King excepted, agreed with one consent that they must go to Throndham. So they rowed into the Fiord to the Raudabiorg, where they anchored. The King then summoned all his men from the ships, and when silence obtained, inquired how they purposed to make their attack on the town, if they were so eager to make it. They answered that they meant to row up to the quays and try to effect a landing. "Your plan seems to me unwise," replied the King; "I don't suppose the townsmen will let us quietly take possession of the town. I expect they will defend it, for they will not

look on us Birkibeins as likely to forbear from plunder and pillage. It is my advice that, before daylight, we send a cutter up the Fiord past Stad and above Holm, to look out. Let it anchor under Hladhamra, so far from land as to be visible from the town when daylight appears, and let the awning be all gaily set up. Its crew should all go on shore into the wood, and march by the land road above Hladi, directing their course to the height above the bridge, where they will wait till daybreak. But we will row up the Fiord to Fladki, on the other side, and then keep near the shore under the Gaularas until we come close to the Gullhamar. I expect that at daybreak, as soon as they see a ship lying close to the Hladhamra, they will suppose it to be ours, and think that there are more ships where they see only one. They will then man their own ships and set out from the town. And while they are rowing towards Hladhamra our wisest plan will be, I think, to row from the Hefring up to Eyra; we may hope then that we shall have to defend the town against them, and not they against us." But Gudlaug, the King's marshal, answered, "Our force, probably, will not seem too numerous even if we do not divide it in two." The majority agreed with Gudlaug rather than the King. They decided to row to the town as soon as it was daylight. The King said he could go wherever they went, but declared that he was unwilling. "Your scheme," he said, "opposed to my wishes, will turn out, I imagine, badly."

2.82

Archbishop Eystein defends Nidaros against the Birkibeins, and defeats them of the Hattarhamar. The King's narrow escape.

2.83

28. Archbishop Eystein was present in the town, and had summoned a meeting the day before. He said he had received intelligence of the Birkibeins, who had come down into Naumudale in the north, and gone away south by sea. "We expect they will pay us a visit here in the Fiord," he said. "I have been told that their numbers are few and their ships small; the men, moreover, are in an exhausted and wretched condition. It befits not yeomen and merchants to give up their clothes

or goods to such thieves and evildoers as Sverri has scraped together. We desire rather to help you, if you will defend the town against them. I will contribute my ships, and all my house-carles present here at the Bishop's court, if the townsmen and merchants will offer themselves." This seemed to all of them a fit plan, and they declared their willingness to follow it, rather than be exposed to the landing of the Birkibeins. Four ships were then manned by the townsmen and merchants, and a fifth by the Archbishop, which contained his house-carles, and was the best manned of all; its captain being Sigurd, son of Ozur Bilsí. The townsmen set a watch on the Digrmull and raised a beacon, and at daybreak when the watch saw the ships at the Raudabiorg they fired the beacon. The townsmen, seeing it, summoned the crews on board and rowed out of the river. The Birkibeins had pulled down the awning of their ships, and they rowed across the Fiord under the Gaularas as the townsmen rowed over the bay; and when the townsmen were off the Digrmull, the two fleets came in sight of each other, and met in the bay within the Hattarhamar. The four ships of the townsmen came into the battle; also four of King Sverri, one only of which was a twenty-benched vessel. A hard and fierce contest began; and while the fighting went on, the weather was fine, and a light north-east wind drove all the ships together towards the shore until they touched land. After they had fought for a time there came in sight the Archbishop's ship, which had been the last to leave the town. And now the battle, which, before this ship came in sight, had gone hard with the Birkibeins, did not look more promising when they beheld her. So they broke into flight and leapt on shore from their ships. King Sverri was dressed in a long dark cowed cloak, and was one of the first that moved to the fore part of the ship to leap on shore. When he was beyond the mast, a plank slipped under his feet, and he fell into the hold. His men leapt thickly over him, and he was kept there a long time, unable to rise, while the crowd passed. One of the last to leap over him was Helgi, surnamed Byggvomb. As the King looked up, Helgi recognised him, and said, "'Tis a bad parting from our

King to leave him lying in the bilge-water;” and he caught hold of the King’s shoulder and raised him out of the hold. The King said, “Call me not Eng too freely for a while,” and they then leapt on shore both together. Three of the townsmen came against them on the beach, but Helgi ran towards them and fought with them, and the King climbed up a steep bank. When a good height up he stepped on his cloak, his feet slipped, and he then fell down on the beach. One of the three fighting with Helgi ran to the King to slay him, but Helgi seeing him, extricated himself from his two opponents, and going after the man, struck him a deathblow. The Eng looked up at him the second time. The two men who had already tried Helgi’s prowess had less mind now to renew the attack, and turned away without more ado. The King was not well able to walk, for he had been struck by a javelin in the battle and wounded in the foot. Serk of Riöd was the man that wounded him. Helgi now accompanied the King, and they climbed up the Gaularas and went along it, joined gradually by the King’s men who had escaped from the battle. The King moved forward to the fell and rested there, and they heard the voices of the townsmen discussing whether Sverri had fallen or not. Whereupon Helgi answered them so loud that they heard him: “King Sverri will raise a fiercer storm about you townsmen before he is dead.”

2.84

In this battle there fell many brave and valiant men. Sigurd of Saltness and his brother Jon Ketling were slain on the beach; their brother Vilhialm was escaping on board ship under the Gaularas and off the Ness, but the townsmen followed hard after him and he leapt on shore. He was slain on the beach; and the townsmen, after sharing among themselves the weapons of the slain, went back again. Gudlaug, the King’s marshal, received a severe wound, but made his escape up the Gaularas. He was dressed in a scarlet kirtle. A yeoman armed with a poleaxe met him, and perceiving that Gudlaug belonged to the fugitive host, struck at him, hitting him just below the nape of the neck. The blow felled Gudlaug. The yeoman, supposing him slain, stripped him of

his clothes, and left his body covered with brushwood. Shortly afterwards Gudlaug recovered from his swoon, and stood up and made his way to a farmhouse, where he was well received. Afterwards he followed the King and grew whole of his wounds, and henceforth the Birkibeins gave him the name of Gudlaug Gnitaskor.

2.85

Speech of King Sverri to his men after the defeat off the Hatttarhamar.

2.86

29. After this battle King Sverri and his men marched into the Uplands; some went down into Moeri where they slew Serk and eleven others, and then followed the King. When the Birkibeins were come east into the Vik, King Magnus and Orm Kings-brother heard of them, and proceeded to seek them; but the Birkibeins turned aside, for their force was small compared with that of King Magnus. King Sverri then addressed his men and thus spoke: —

2.87

“When we sailed with our force into Throntham to fight against the men of Nidaros it was done against my will. We lost men there, most valiant fellows. And now that our ill-luck has become known, we are chased and harassed wherever we go, and ail who know of our wretchedness think we are nobody of consequence. Before this battle, victory was always on our side, and men all dreaded to come to blows with us. You have learnt that King Magnus, now pursues us with a numerous force. We have only to let ourselves be driven by him over the land for a short time, and lo! the whole country,thane and thrall, will be upon us; our whole force will perish ingloriously, like all who fall in flight. It seems to me a braver course to confront our foes, though our band is not large. Even if we are overwhelmed by superior numbers, we may yet so behave as to obtain great renown in our fail, since we shall fight against King Magnus himself. But if we win a victory over him, then will our strength increase thereby. We must not expect to win this land and realm without seeing some time or other the banner of King Magnus on high. We have now been driven

quite long enough from place to place, and endured many troubles from our enemies.”

2.88

King Sverri then spoke many encouraging words to his men, and urged them stoutly; his heart, he said, assured him of success. He thus put courage in his men, and much applause followed his words.

2.89

King Sverri's success over King Magnus at the bridge over the Hirta [Hirtubru].

2.90

30. After this they marched forward until they had crossed the bridge over the river called Hirta, where they obtained accurate information that King Magnus was come near them. King Sverri made his men enter a thicket a little way from the bridge. King Magnus and Orm Kings-brother also had accurate information of the march of the Birkibeins, and when they arrived at the bridge, King Magnus straightway caused his banner to be carried over, and himself followed; Orm Kings-brother did likewise. As soon as King Magnus and a portion of his force had passed over the bridge, the Birkibeins made a violent attack on them. A sharp fight began, which did not last long before much of King Magnus's force fell; he himself, and Orm Kings-brother also, fled back over the bridge, both wounded. King Magnus lost many men in the battle. After it was over, the two armies shot at each other for some time across the stream, and then drew away. King Magnus went back to Tunsberg to his ships, and afterwards sailed east coastwise. King Sverri marched up into Raumariki and east to Liodhus, overland. Here he learnt that King Magnus was at Konungahella, and he marched thither, arriving unexpectedly. Some fighting again occurred, but no great slaughter. King Magnus sailed away down the river, and King Sverri seized some ships and had them burnt. King Magnus then sailed into the Vik, and came to Oslo, where he abode for a time, and sent forth scouts as far as to the Elf. King Sverri brought all the eastern bailiwicks under his rule, and drew tribute from them.

Both the Birkibeins and Heklungs were now in the Vik, and made frequent assaults on each other.

2.91

King Sverri's success in another skirmish.

2.92

31. King Sverri led his force north in the Vik, to plan the gaining of some further advantage if opportunity offered. And one night, in order to get information, he himself with six men rode into a certain wood a short distance from Saurby. The same night a captain of King Magnus was on the march with fifty men, intending to slay, if he could, some of the Birkibeins. The night was dark, and King Sverri heard them on their ride, for the men had drunk plentifully of mead and were talkative, having no fear for themselves. Their road was no wider than permitted the men to ride in single file. Then King Sverri addressed his men and bade them keep silent. "We must have our bows ready," he said, "and stand on both sides of the road. When they come right opposite, let every man shoot with all the speed he can. Possibly they may suppose our force more numerous than it is; but if we are overborne by superior numbers, we can then save ourselves." So the Birkibeins shot their bolts with all speed, being guided by the voices of the foe, for it was so dark that no one could see before him, and those who rode behind were ignorant of what hindered those in front. So they crowded all together, not knowing what was the matter; and meanwhile the Birkibeins continued shooting as fast as possible. The enemy, thinking there must be many men in the wood, ran away as quickly as they could. The Birkibeins followed after, and chased them as long as they were able; and in the morning when it was light, returning to the spot, they found eighteen men slain, and many horses.

2.93

Winter in Throntham. Miraculous escape of King Sverri off Stad in the following spring [1179].

2.94

32. In the autumn King Sverri marched north to Thronðham, and inflicted a heavy blow on the men of King Magnus at Kaupang [Nidaros], winning a victory and capturing ten ships.

2.95

The following spring he sailed down the Fiord with his force, and took the outside course, on the open sea, south to Moeri.

2.96

When he approached Stad from the north, he was met by a fleet of large ships, with a very great host on board, under King Magnus, Earl Erling, Archbishop Eystein, Orm Kings-brother, and many of the barons. As soon as the two fleets came in sight of one another, and King Sverri perceived the odds against him, he endeavoured to push out into the open sea, using both sails and oars to the utmost. King Magnus's men observing this, hastened after him, likewise using their sails and rowing furiously. They gained on King Sverri, so that the ship under Earl Erling's command came near enough to see the men on board King Sverri's ships. The Earl then bade his men lay to and wait for the others. The ships having all come up, the Earl called out to the men on board and made arrangements for an attack. They were likely to have a battle with the Birkibeins, he said, and he bade his men in that case to remember what great injury the Birkibeins had done them by manslaughter and robbery. He bade them beware of presuming, any one of them, to give quarter to the Birkibeins, though he would like Sverri to be taken prisoner, if possible, and brought to him alive. To this they all agreed, and then unfurled the sails and pursued the fugitives. King Sverri now perceived that the ships of King Magnus were much swifter than his, and were gaining on them; and there appeared no way out of his difficulty, fitting well the occasion, unless God would grant them His mercy beyond what then seemed likely. He betook himself therefore to prayer, and called upon King Olaf the Saint, pleading for his men with much eloquence. And at that instant a mist came down on the sea, so thick that they could not see from one ship to another. King Magnus and Earl Erling, not being able to see their

way, turned their ships round and sailed close up to shore. And the Earl said, "Luck fared not thus when it wished us well." Their whole fleet now arrived at the Hereys, and the following day they learnt that the Birkibeins had sailed with five ships through the sounds, and gone towards the fiord. The Earl therefore summoned the chiefs for conference and counsel, and thus spoke: "I cannot tell whether the Birkibeins sailed north or south along the coast when they came near land, and it seems to me that we shall need to send a force both ways. I desire therefore that the Archbishop and Orm Kings-brother, with the barons and captains whom I shall name, proceed south to Bergen to defend the land there; King Magnus and I will sail north with the greater part of the host." As the Earl directed, so they did.

2.97

The rival Kings at Nidaros. Proposals of King Sverri.

2.98

33. When Earl Erling and King Magnus reached Nord-Moeri they heard the tidings that King Sverri had sailed from the open sea, past Smyl and Aedey, and so to Knarrarskeid, from the north. Thence King Sverri sailed north to the entrance of Thronddham, and afterwards up the Fiord to Kaupang, where he brought his ships to anchor close to the quays. King Magnus and Earl Erling sailed north in pursuit of him. And when King Sverri perceived the sails of their ships, now but a short distance from the town, he summoned his men to a meeting, at which he declared his intention to leave his ships and go on shore. "Let no man presume," he said, "to take with him anything but his weapons, and the clothes in which he stands." After that, the Birkibeins armed themselves and went up into the town. They left their ships afloat, with all the awnings spread, in front of the quays; the hammocks lay in their places; the cabin chests remained on the ships, and the keys were set in the lockers. The Birkibeins were marching inland over the bridge as King Magnus and Earl Erling rowed into the river. King Sverri himself used to say how great a boast it was to him that few instances could be found where men in flight had left behind them

property or ships as his men had done; at a time, too, he said, when it was almost certain that others would in turn have the use of the property and clothes also. The fleet of King Magnus and Earl Erling was brought to anchor close to Brottu-eyri, outside Skipa-crook and the men landed there. As the Earl leapt on shore, he fell forward on his knees. Thrusting both hands into the ground, he said, "Fall portends fortunate journey." Each captain, as he landed with his ship's crew, arranged them in order and marched them up the street. The Earl and his troop were the first ready, and when he came beyond Kristskirk yard and the Bishop's court to the bridge, he beheld King Sverri's standard in rapid movement along the highroad to Kleppabu, and he supposed the King would be with it and the greater part of his force.

2.99

He therefore passed over the bridge to the Sprota-fields; but King Sverri, with the greater part of his force, lay in a valley a short distance from the bridge, above the lower Sandbreck. The Earl saw nought of King Sverri's ambush, for his mind was bent on cutting off some of the rear; and when the Birkibeins sprang forward to attack, the Earl retreated to the bridge and over to the other side. The Birkibeins pursued his men right up to the fence that divides the end of the bridge from the town; but when the force of King Magnus and the Earl moved up to meet them, the Birkibeins turned back again over the bridge, and the armies exchanged shots across the river. The Earl then bade his men move out of range, and they sat down on the Akr and watched what the Birkibeins did. King Sverri and his men sat down on the other side on the river bank near Sandbreck, and so both armies remained a large part of the day. King Magnus's men sent into the town to fetch ale. Many of the bowmen in both forces moved to the front to shoot at one another, and some of both sides were wounded. The day passed on, and when it was now the hour of Nones, King Sverri's marshal, Gudlaug, advanced to the end of the bridge, holding his shield in front, and called out to King Magnus's force, saying that he wished to speak with them if they would listen. Ivar Horti, one of

King Magnus's men, answered, saying that he would listen to whatever was said; and Gudlaug thus began: "King Sverri wishes to make three offers to King Magnus, Earl Erling, and, with them, to all their force. This is the first: if they will come over the bridge, King Sverri will retire with all his force to a distance, while the Earl arranges his men as shall seem good; let us join battle on the Sprota-fields, and let the side win that God wills. If King Magnus and Earl Erling will not accept this offer, King Sverri makes a second: if they will go out of the town to the castle and draw their men up in battle array on a fair open ground, we Birkibeins will pass over the bridge to you and leave the issue to fortune. If they will accept neither of these offers, there is yet a third: let them go out to Eyra, near their ships, and draw up in battle array as shall seem good, and we Birkibeins will pass through the town to encounter them. For King Sverri wishes to join battle now, if he has the opportunity." Then Ivar withdrew from the bank of the river to the Akr, and having found the Earl, delivered the message to him. King Magnus was near the Earl at the time, asleep, and the Earl, clapping him on the back with his hand, bade him awake. The King asked what was the matter, and the Earl told him of the offers that Priest Sverri had made. King Magnus bade the Earl choose, but the Earl said he would not choose any one of them. He would rather offer terms to Priest Sverri, he said, than have them offered by Sverri to him. Then Ivar went and bore the Earl's answer to Gudlaug, and Gudlaug returned and told it to the Birkibeins. They now crowded together for a while, and afterwards began their march, by King Sverri's direction, along the way on the east side of the river to Kleppabu. They so ordered their going that they walked in single file, and the force appeared to be very numerous, for the last man was long in starting. So the two armies separated for the present.

2.100

King Sverri now led his men along the river to a homestead called Kot, where they pulled down a building to get material for a float. On this float they passed over the river Nid, and about the sixth hour of the

afternoon they marched over Thiodmoors and came down to Staf. Here they crossed the Gaul on small ferry-boats; and when they had reached the other side the King bade his men take rest, saying that he felt heavy and wished to sleep. He soon fell asleep, and at supper-time a yeoman came up with packs of malt which he intended to sell in the town. The Birkibeins crowded around him, pretending they would buy the malt. The King awoke, and inquired what was the matter. Being told that a yeoman was there with malt, he said he would like to see him. And the King said to him, "We will not stop your journey to the town; but tell them the truth, that you met with the Birkibeins on the other side of the Gaul, and they intended to pass the night at Medalhus." So the man went his way, and the Birkibeins stayed there three or four nights before they advanced to the town a second time.

2.101

Earl Erling is forewarned of King Sverri's attack.

2.102

34 One day after the Earl had taken his evening meal, Sigurd Nikolasson and Jon of Randaberg came to him; and Sigurd asked him if the outposts were stationed. "We are told, Sire," he said, "that the Birkibeins will shortly pay us a visit. I would advise that we summon our whole force under arms to the castle and be ready for them if they visit us here. We believe it true that they have come into Gaulardale, and some say that they are making their way to the fell. But it is none the less likely, so we are certainly told, that they intend to attack us here."

2.103

"I wish it were true with all my heart," answered the Earl, "that they are coming here; I expect their errand would meet with a fit reception. But I think you may sleep the night through without fear of the Birkibeins, for they must have turned to the fell, I am told. Sverri will not venture to attack us here, if we are on our guard, as is the case now." Then Jon of Randaberg spoke: "The Earls promise, that we need not fear the Birkibeins, ought to presage good to us. But some men

there are, Sire, who say that you give yourself to excess in mead and wine rather than to devising firm purposes for the good of your men.” And the Earl answered in much anger: “Seldom hitherto has a charge been laid against me, other than of being too cautious. And now I know not whether it is, that you are somewhat more fearful than need be, or that I am capable, as you say, of no thought for my men’s safety. However, you shall be able to repose this night without fear, if you have faith in me, because I will keep watch myself. Aforetime that was thought full security, and we had greater odds to face then than now.” After this, Sigurd and Jon went away to their ships, and somewhat later the Earl retired to his bed to sleep. All his men did likewise, except the outposts, which were set as usual.

2.104

Speech of King Sverri to his men on the slopes of Steinbiorg.

2.105

35. We have now to say of the Birkibeins, that they reached Steinbiorg before daybreak Here the barons asked King Sverri the object of his march, and he told them that he meant to attack the Earl. And when they had mounted the ridge and were come to Feginsbreck, he alighted from his horse, fell upon his knees, and said his prayers. Afterwards he addressed a few words to his men, bidding them stand well together. “We shall now win a glorious victory,” he said. “I need not detail before you the distresses in which you were involved before our arrival in this land, nor the few gains on which you have laid hands since. I can well infer from my own feelings that you will think the time is come when you should receive more profit than has yet been in our reach from the toil and great danger you have undergone. What we have won by the sword we have taken; entertainment here, money there, where we found it. But now there is a prize to be won in the town of Nidaros, somewhat more valuable than those for which we have often contended. In the town before us are King Magnus and Earl Erling with many barons and King’s men; and we may aim at greater honour than comes generally, I imagine, within our power. Victory will be ours, I

feel sure, after the dream that has come to me. Let us now press forward the more eagerly, as we shall gather more fruit than hitherto. I will now make known to you what is to be gained: whoever slays a baron, and can bring forward evidence of his deed, shall himself be a baron; and whatever title a man shall cause to be vacant, that title shall be his: he shall be King's man who slays a King's man, and he shall receive good honour besides. Such is the prize to be won, and I believe they have no certain knowledge of our movements. There is good reason to suppose that Fortune has abandoned them, and they have come to the end of their days; but we shall win victory and honour, as is our due. Thus shall God decide between us and them. For a long time they have held possession of what is ours; maybe they will now lose what aforesaid they wrongfully seized, and will lose life as well. Let your first onset be fierce to the utmost; what remains will be done easily. Doubtless they are well steeped in drink, heavy with sleep, and so without resource; some of them are on board their ships, others here and there in the town, and they will scarcely know where to turn or what to do."

2.106

When King Sverri finished his speech, which was well received by all, they marched onwards down Steinbiorg.

2.107

King Magnus and Earl Erling are roused on the approach of the Birkibeins.

2.108

36. That night King Magnus's men were out on Eyra keeping watch and playing games. They perceived the force of the Birkibeins as it marched over Steinbiorg, and straightway blew the trumpets, and summoned their men to arm themselves and come forth. King Magnus's troops for the most part were sleeping in the town. They had drunk to excess in the evening, for the King had entertained them during the day, and they lay in the houses where they were quartered. When the Earl heard the tidings of war, he arose and dressed himself, and bade his men take their weapons. Then Ivar Horti, his kinsman,

came and said, "Our men are scattered throughout the town; many of them must have lain down to sleep in an incapable state, and we shall not get them together as quickly as is needed. I would advise the signal to be given for all to go on board. We can let the ships move away slowly from the quays, make our preparations at leisure, and fight if you think good. Or we might even row out of the river into the open sea, for the townsfolk here will not give us loyal assistance." And the Earl answered, "I almost think, Ivar, that your advice is the best, but I can't bear to see that devil's priest Sverri seat himself in my sons place." He stood up, therefore, and calling to his men, bade them all get ready as quickly as they could to go on land. When the force had come ashore, and also the Earl, and the standard was in front, the Earl marched through the town along the street to Kristskirk, which he kissed. He was here joined by King Magnus with his standard, by Sigurd Nikolasson, Jon of Randaberg, and Ivar Horti, with their companies. Many of the men fell on their knees and said their prayers. The Earl then turned away to leave the church, saying to his men, "Stand up and take your weapons. Some of us maybe will have the opportunity of resting here after awhile." Earl Erling was dressed in a scarlet kirtle of fustian, a cap of silk, and a coat of plate-mail, which was not closed in front. His sword was drawn, and as he held it aloft in his hand he said, "You shall say to-day that this old man knows how to make his sword bite." Then speaking to his trumpeters he bade them blow their hardest. And when they had marched beyond the church tower, the Earl glanced round to right and to left and asked, "What has become of all our men?"

2.109

Battle at Nidaros, and fall of Earl Erling [June 19, 1179].

2.110

37. King Sverri had about three hundred men, or somewhat more, from Gaulardale, but they were poorly armed. The yeomen had sent their labourers, because they themselves dared not join him, fearing the vengeance of Earl Erling. As the force passed over Steinbioig, one

of them ran forward before the rest He was tall and strong, and carried a huge wooden cudgel on his shoulder, but he had no other weapon. And Ozur Prest said to him, "What do you want, man? Why do you rush on in that way with your cudgel? Where are your weapons? Fighting against Earl Erling is another matter than thrashing com, where a cudgel may well serve." The man's name was Eyvind, and he answered, "The weapons I am going to fight with are on their way from the town, the Earl's men have them still" And Hiarrandi Hvida said, "Well spoken! fellow. You are surely a good man." He then gave him his own halberd and hand-axe, and said, "Fight with these weapons."

2.111

The Birkibeins now marched up to the town, and the two armies met on the Akr, a little above the town, beyond the church tower. King Magnus and Earl Erling had five hundred men. A great battle arose straightway, and a fight of the sharpest, but not of long duration. Thori Spæla was Earl Erling's standard-bearer, and after some slaughter on both sides, especially among King Magnus's men, a determined onset was made around the Earl's standard. Thori, closely pressed, thrust the pole of the standard into the ground, so that it stood upright. The Earl's ranks now began to yield, so that his standard stood almost at the back of those Birkibeins who pressed on most eagerly; and those in the rear, thinking the Earl was with his standard, were afraid, supposing their own men had taken to flight. When King Sverri perceived this, he had the standard cut down. About the same time Earl Erling received a thrust from a halberd which struck him in the stomach. "A serious thrust, Sire," said one to him. "Keep close to the King's standard," answered the Earl, "the wound will not hurt me" Presently, Ozur Prest and Helgi Thorfinnsson came near the Earl, and he struck Ozur across the face, making a deep and ugly wound. Afterwards he sank down, and his men who were nearest him fell fighting. Then King Magnus's men broke into flight. As the King fled he came to the spot where the Earl, his father, lay, with his face upwards. The King stooped and kissed him, saying, "We shall meet

again on the day of joy, my father.” The Earl’s lips quivered, but he had no strength to answer, and the King was unable to stay longer as he had to save himself. King Magnus fled into the town, and many with him, and escaped to the Earl’s ship, the Ryd, and sailed on her out of the river. There fell on the Akr, Sigurd Nikolasson, Jon of Randaberg, Ivar Sorti, Einar Litii, a baron, Botulf of the Firdi and his two sons. Biorn Bukk leapt into the river to swim over to Skeliingar-hella, but he was drowned; he wore a coat of mail and sank immediately. Many leapt into the river, some of whom perished, and others were saved. Ivar Sveinsson fell there, and Guthorm Snerill. All these were barons of King Magnus. Nearly sixty of the King’s guardsmen fell there, and many other men. King Sverri took possession of the Olafssud, the ship which King Magnus had steered hitherto. He captured almost all their ships. He likewise gained possession of his own ships that he had left.

2.112

Speech of King Sverri at the burial of Earl Erling.

2.113

38. Earl Erling’s body was borne for interment on the south side of the church, but his burial-place now lies within the church. King Sverri made a speech over the grave and thus spoke: —

2.114

“It is not fit that silence should be altogether kept at the burial of so noble a man as the one over whom we now stand. Times are greatly changed, as you may see, and have taken a marvellous turn, when one man stands in the place of three — of King, of Earl, of Archbishop — and I am that one. Much to be seen and known is occurring here now, of great import and a cause of thankfulness to men, in that both here and to other churches are borne the bodies of many who sided with King Magnus. For indeed, it is known to many that Archbishop Eystein and many other learned men have constantly said concerning all who die fighting for King Magnus and defending his land, that their souls will enter Paradise before their blood is cold upon the ground. We may here rejoice at the sanctity of many men who have become saints, if

what the Archbishop said is true, and all these have become saints who died fighting under Earl Erling. We may imagine how great a saint Earl Erling himself has become, who first of all, when King Magnus was a child, caused him to be chosen King, and from that day till now has constantly advanced and supported his kingdom. Of a truth, his intercession with Almighty God will be a powerful help to men, if so be that the Archbishop was not somewhat biassed in his pleading when he uttered the words. It has now come to pass that we stand over those who for a long time bore the helm of terror over us and many others. I see many now present here at this grave sorrowing who would have been filled with joy if they so stood over my grave, though the funeral had not been stately. That sorrow seems to me senseless and unkindly, judged by what has often been preached to you of the opinion we ought all to hold of death under such circumstances. It seems to me that it should be a great joy to you and to us that God has thus willed to dispose of men's lives. We might live somewhat more profitably and in less peril than hitherto, because we shall no longer feel dread of him at whose grave we now stand. But you have cause for even greater joy at the death of those with whom you no longer have bodily dealings, for consider now the promise of the Archbishop. The time has come when their blood is cold, and though we cannot yet rejoice at any miracles wrought by them, there must be an abundance of glorified saints in the town at this moment. You will not have lost them; rather, they will now be able to bestow on you great good if you worship them as saints according to your intention. But if, unfortunately, there should be a danger, as my heart tells me there may be, that all the fine promises made to them are unfulfilled, then have they suffered long enough on account of that lie and absurd nonsense, they and all who believed it. I would advise, therefore, another way of acting. Pray rather for those who have departed. Pray God that Earl Erling may be forgiven all the sins which he committed in this life — especially the great sin of arrogance, in that he, a mere baron, caused the title of King to be given to his son; and more than that, collected a force and raised his standard

against kings' sons, King Hakon and King Eystein, both of whom he deprived of their realm, over which he ruled with King Magnus without any more rightful title than I now declare to you. Let us pray too for the souls of all those who have come by their death, now and aforetime, in this wrongful trouble. Pray God that He will forgive their sins and save their souls. All the evil they have done to me I willingly forgive them for God's sake. Let every man among you do now what seems best, and what he thinks meetest for himself and for those departed. For they have been summoned hastily and without sacrament from the world, with somewhat less preparation and with sterner feelings than now they would desire. I will maintain that whatever good you do for their souls will be a saving help to you and a full measure of mercy, rather than hold it certain that they have no need of prayers."

2.115

After the King had said this, he changed his language, and spoke in the manner then customary at the interment of noble persons. He first thanked the clergy for their chanting and beautiful service, and then all the people for their prayers and such gifts as each man was minded to add for the soul's good of friend or neighbour. He exhorted each one carefully to perform for his intimate friend such kind offices as he himself would desire, declaring that he himself would find men to give burial to those who had none to care for them. So the King ceased speaking. All who heard his words were pleased with them, and many applauded his speech.

2.116

Meeting of King Magnus and Archbishop Eystein at Bergen.

2.117

39. King Magnus and those of his force that escaped sailed south to Bergen. Here he found Archbishop Eystein and Orm Kings-brother, and told them the tidings. He then summoned an Assembly of his men and the towns-people, spoke to them of his loss, and begged them to help him. Archbishop Eystein responded to the Kings speech, and said that

all doughty men would be well disposed to strengthen his rule with all their might. "The battle has had one issue, Sire," he said, "that many will welcome: you, whom all the people love, have come out of it safe and sound. And though Earl Erling was a wise and powerful man, yet many found his manner tyrannical, and thought it hard to endure. But all men will consent to risk their lives for yours, that you may win your realm and land." Great applause followed this speech, all professing that they would rather die with King Magnus than serve Priest Sverri. King Magnus and his men then sailed east to Vik. Here he passed the winter, and gathered around him a considerable force and many powerful men. Ships were built and great preparations made for war.

2.118

Effect on the Birkibeins of the victory at Nidaros.

2.119

40. After this battle and the fall of Earl Erling, King Sverri's power grew to such a height that there was no one in Norway, except King Magnus and his men, who did not call him King. Hitherto wherever in market towns or other places great persons were present, if a man was called Birkibein it was thought a mark of contempt; henceforth the name was a title of honour, and the bearers of it were highly esteemed. The very men who had been labourers, or even robbers or ribalds, and had joined King Sverri's force and had a share in the victory, now wore scarlet and fine cloth. They carried good weapons, which aforetime were borne by the guardsmen of King Magnus or the barons. Those who recognised them concealed the fact that they were the same men whom they had known in poverty; yea, the Birkibeins themselves would scarcely remember their former condition. It is a common saying among men that no braver troops have been seen in Norway than those with King Sverri at this time. The King himself bore witness to it ever afterwards, and spoke of those old Birkibeins whenever his men fell into sloth or overdrank, kept a careless watch, or complained of toil and fatigue.

2.120

King Sverri now distributed pay among his guardsmen, and conferred many titles of honour; and he appointed bailiffs over the whole of Throntham.

2.121

How the party of King Magnus got the name of Heklungs.

2.122

41. It happened east in Vik that an old beggar woman died, who left behind her a cowled frock or *hekla*, and a great quantity of silver was found stitched up in it. King Magnus's men heard of this, and took and burnt the frock, dividing the silver among themselves. This became known to the Birkibeins, and henceforth they called them Hekluarfs, that is *Cowl-heirs*, or Heklungs.

2.123

King Sverri's dream before the battle of Nidaros,

2.124

42. Before the fall of Earl Erling, King Sverri had a dream, from which he learnt beforehand, as he supposed, the issue of the action between him and the Earl. He dreamt that he was sleeping in an upper room of the town, on a bright night, and that a man entered the room and came up to the bed in which he lay. "Rise up, Sverri," said the vision, "and come with me." The man inspired him with awe, and he felt that he dared not do otherwise than he was bid. The man walked out of the town, and he followed until they came to a fire, on the embers of which a man lay roasted. Then the vision bade Sverri sit down and eat, placing the man before him. But Sverri thought in his dream, and so answered, that he had never eaten any unclean thing, and would not then eat. And the vision said, "Thou wilt and shalt eat, for so wills He who governs all things." Sverri dreamt that he now began to eat the flesh from the bones, and every mouthful seemed difficult to swallow. But the longer he ate, the less disgust he seemed to feel at eating the remainder. Coming to the head, he was about to eat it also; but the man who had led him there told him to cease eating, and took the head

himself. Sverri's unwillingness to leave off now seemed to him little less than his former unwillingness to begin, but the stronger man had his way. Then they went back into the town and to the same house; and when Sverri in his dream had returned to the same bed, he saw his guide leave the room, and then he awoke.

2.125

It was this dream that caused the King to urge his men forward so eagerly on their march to the town. He so interpreted it that the man lying on the fire was Earl Erling, then beginning to grow old, and that King Magnus and his men were senile in counsel and feeble in resource. His eating the man foretold that he and his troop would destroy the greater part of the barons and guardsmen; the uneaten head, that King Magnus would escape.

2.126

King Sverri and the Thronds. Voyage to Bergen and back.

2.127

43. After the battle, many rich men of the noble families of the Thronð communities crowded to King Sverri, and many who remained at home became his friends. The King placed great trust and confidence in the Thronds, for they had all along been unfriendly to Earl Erling, as was before told in his dealings with them. King Sverri ever afterwards spoke of Thronðham as his home. Of all the people of the land he held the Thronds in most affection, and always declared what trusty friends the Thronds had been to his father King Sigurd, to his brother King Hakon, and to Eystein the Birkibein, having always served under the same shield.

2.128

King Sverri remained for a time north in Kaupang. He made a levy of men and food over all Thronðham, and obtained ships from the yeomen of the districts. When he was ready he followed King Magnus south, but coming to Bergen, he found that the King had sailed away east with all his force. On this voyage from the north, King Sverri set

his bailiffs over all those parts of the realm; and in autumn he sailed back to Kaupang, where he abode during the winter.

2.129

King Magnus leads an expedition to Nidaros [1180].

2.130

“. — In the spring, King Magnus called out a full levy of men from the south of the land, from Lidandianess in the east, and north over Agdi, over Rogaland, Hordaland, and Sogn, from Firdi and the two Mceris, and from Raumsdale; and with all this host he sailed north to Throntham. He had with him Archbishop Eystein, Orm Kings-brother, Nikolas and Philippus, sons of Ami Kings-kin, and all the barons of the south country. As it is said here: —

2.131

“Followed the Ruler
Rygs and Hords,
A host from Firdi,
Fiali, and Sogn;
From Moeri all,
And Ranmsdale men;
Archbishop, and Thronds
From all the shires.”

2.132

King Magnus led his force north to Throntham, and anchored near the homestead of Stein, south of the Ness, where he lay some nights. King Sverri was then in Kaupang, and despatched Thorolf Rympil, Thiostar Svarti, Eyiolf Adason, and Havard Lax, with a large body of men, that they should plan to gain some advantage if opportunity offered. They reached a homestead called Langloar, where a well-wooded dale leads down to the sea, and they lay in the dale. King Magnus's men were unaware of them until the Birkibeins fell on them. King Magnus had gone on shore to the bath-room at Stein, but hurried back to the ships as soon as he knew of the presence of Birkibeins. Nearly thirty of his men were slain. King Magnus's men took their

weapons and leapt on shore, but the Birkibeins evaded them and made their escape. After this they returned to Kaupang and told King Sverri.

2.133

King Magnus's letter to one of Sverri's men, and King Sverri's reply.

2.134

45. King Magnus now sailed up the Fiord to Holm, where he stayed for a time, and King Sverri made himself ready in the town. Afterwards King Magnus despatched a ship, under the charge of Birgi Gorn and Thrاند Lyrta, to take and bring to him a yeoman named Afli, whose son Eyiolf was serving in King Sverri's body-guard. And to Eyiolf, whom King Magnus desired to have by him, he sent a letter by a man named Hedin of Hladi, in which was written, that if Eyiolf wished to save his father's life he must come to King Magnus and be his man. Hedin went into the town and brought the letter to Eyiolf, and he, finding himself in great difficulty, showed the letter to King Sverri. The King said, "Few bring such to me. We shall find a good remedy; fetch here the man that brought the letter." The King caused another letter to be written, in which he said, "If you, King Magnus, do harm or hurt to Afli, I will slay Eilif Eplastong, Skrudu-Eirik, and Eindridi Slandri. You have with you their sons: Thori Knapp, Eindridi's son; Ulf Kneiti, Eirik's son; and Gunnar, Eilif's son. The death you inflict on Afli, such shall they die, at the hands of Eyiolf." The messenger took back this answer and bore the letter to King Magnus. When the King saw it he sprang down from the poop of the ship with the letter, and said, "I see that you mean to decide, and not I, who shall be slain and who be kept alive." But Ulf and Thori and Gunnar had now something to say. They begged the King to be calm. The death of an old yeoman fellow, they said, would not bring the King nearer land; and they did not wish to expose their fathers' lives to King Sverri's evil devices. So Afli was set free, and returned to his home.

2.135

King Sverri's proposed to King Magnus. The Kings fix on a time and place for battle.

2.136

46. Some days after, King Magnus rowed to land at Eyra for a conference with King Sverri, who came there to meet him. King Sverri proposed that they should share the land between them, and both be Kings, as were the sons of King Magnus Berføtt and the sons of Harald [Gilli]. The proposal was much discussed, but came to nothing; some of King Magnus's men were favourable, others were opposed, but the King himself would not hear of it. The conference broke up, leaving matters as they were, and King Magnus rowed away again to Holm. While the ships lay at anchor near Holm, King Magnus and his men formed a plan of attacking the town, and supposed that King Sverri would be reluctant to come forth from the wooden castle. They took their anchors and fastened them by ropes to poles, intending to row close to Eyra and drop poles and anchors together on the yeomen's ranks. Preparations were made, but the plan was not carried out; many devices were proposed, but nothing was attempted.

2.137

On the Monday of Rogation week King Magnus rowed to Eyra for a conference, and the two sides incited each other to battle. The Birkibeins pressed King Magnus to land on Eyra, and King Magnus urged them to come out of the wooden castle and join battle with him on the fields of Ila. King Sverri then said, "We will consent to what you now ask." So the Kings pledged one another to meet the next morning on the fields of Ha and fight there. After this, King Magnus and his men rowed out to his fleet. King Sverri then caused all his force to be told of the battle, and bade them prepare by going to Confession, and getting their weapons ready. At sunrise of Tuesday in Rogation week King Magnus ordered the signal to be given for leaving Holm, the awnings were taken down, and the ships were rowed and brought to land under the rock, beyond the Ha. Here the men disembarked. The large sloop belonging to King Magnus lay out at anchor, but the cutters and smaller vessels were rowed to the shore. King Magnus and the whole force marched up Steinbiorg, where they remained waiting for the sun

to mount the heavens, so that they might not have it full in their faces. After a while they came down and drew up their force for battle. Then King Sverri led his men out of the wooden castle, and having put them in battle array, marched to the fields near the rock [Steinbiorg] to meet them. King Magnus had arranged his guardsmen with his standard on the wing that stretched towards the sea, because he saw the standard of King Sverri there. The standard was fine and large, and he thought the King himself would be with it; but it was the standard of the marshal, Gudlaug, who had with him the troops of the town, of the districts around, and the levies. King Sverri marched with his standard by the inland road towards the rock, for he expected the fiercest of the battle at that point, because King Magnus's men had not all left the rock. King Magnus had placed a numerous force to attack the Birkibeins in the rear, and had set over it Nikolas, son of Ami, the brother of King Ingi. To oppose it King Sverri had despatched a force having Ulf of Laufness for its chief. So the array of Nikolas came to be no help to King Magnus.

2.138

King Sverri's speech to his men before the battle.

2.139

47. Before the ranks joined battle, King Sverri addressed his men, beginning his speech in this manner: —

2.140

“A great host and fine body-guard are here come together, and it now appears that we have to deal with overwhelming odds. The ranks of King Magnus, with gilt weapons and in goodly raiment, cover the whole fields. It would be good work done if you carried arms and raiment into the town this evening. Lo! now, my brave fellows, it is enough to have a choice between two ways — the one, to win victory; the other, to die with honour. The task of hewing timber in a wood is not like yours, who must exchange blows with the barons of King Magnus. To receive and return heavy blows is no disgrace; and now comes to pass the saying of the poet —

2.141

‘Carle that combats earl has other work

2.142

Than cleaving wood for charcoal.’

2.143

Hear what a yeoman said who went with his son to the warships and gave him advice, bidding him be bold and hardy in perils.

2.144

‘Renown lives longest after one,’ he said. ‘If you were engaged in a battle and knew beforehand that you were bound to fall, how would you act?’ And the son answered, ‘What good would it be to forbear smiting right and left?’— ‘And now,’ said the yeoman,

2.145

‘if some one knew and told you of a truth that you would not fall in the battle?’ The son answered, ‘What good would it be to refrain from pressing forward to the utmost?’— ‘One of two things will happen,’ said the father: ‘in every battle where you are present, either you will fall or you will come forth alive. Be valiant, therefore, since all is determined beforehand. Nought may send a man to his grave if his time is not come; and if he is doomed to die, nought may save him. To die in flight is the worst death of all.’

2.146

Seven of King Sverri’s men volunteered to lead the attack — Thorolf Rympil, his brother Karl Kiotlær, and five others — and they placed themselves in front of the array.

2.147

King Sverri then spoke again: —

2.148

“Birkibeins! be assured of this: it will not avail to ask quarter of those Heklungs. There is only one way out: stand firmly fast, and give them no room to advance. It is well for you Birkibeins to try your swords on the mead-paunches of those men from the Vik. Our force is fine enough and our numbers large enough for battle. So great and overwhelming

are their numbers, they can't all be brought into action; besides, the greatest part of them are more at home at a wedding than a fight, and are more accustomed to mead-drinking than to warfare. I will march my guardsmen and my standard against the standard of King Magnus, for we must expect from his guardsmen the sharpest fight and fiercest onset. His barons will rather seek to spare themselves; and the crowd of yeomen dragged captive here against their will, care not who falls so long as they are unwounded. I know full well the thoughts of all his Thronds: they are those of the poet who says —

2.149

'I mean to make that maiden mine,
Ingunn with the rosy month,
Howe'er the fighting fare between
Magnus and Sverri, famous Kings.'

2.150

March well forward now, my brave fellows, and may God have you in His keeping." All this speaking inspired the Birkibeins with much eagerness; they relied greatly on the Kings prudence and his foresight of the issue of battles.

2.151

King Sverri's victory over King Magnus on the fields of Ila. [Battle of Iluvelli 27th May 1180.] King Magnus fees to Denmark.

2.152

48. And now the ranks met, and a fierce contest at once arose; for the Birkibeins hitherto had never brought into battle so large a force, and yet that of King Magnus was far larger. Around King Sverri's standard all his guardsmen and gests were drawn up, and as they advanced, the opposing ranks of King Magnus wavered and were soon in flight On the other wing the forces of Gudlaug and the townsmen recoiled before the advancing standard of King Magnus. They were on the point of flight. Some had begun to run, when King Sverri, who was on horseback, saw the ill fortune of his men, and galloped to them. "Why do you flee?" he shouted with a loud voice. "Turn again and fight as

best you can. Don't you see all their host in flight to the ships. Show your prowess like men, and drive the fugitives here, as over there." The men heard his words, and seeing the King, took courage and turned again straightway to face the foe. King Sverri's guardsmen too, seeing the troops of King Magnus in full flight, turned to the spot where they saw his standard, and attacked his guardsmen in the rear. And now a great slaughter befell. "King Magnus is fleeing," cried one. "Not yet," said another, and rushing at him, dealt him a death-blow. That was King Magnus himself. He and all his host now fled to the ships.

2.153

Philippus Arnason fell there, and Bryniolf Blanda, son of Eindridi Jonsson. Ivar Galli was seriously wounded, and as the host was fleeing, King Sverri, riding among the fallen, came to him, stooped from his horse, and asking if the wound could be cured, offered him quarter. Ivar answered that he had good hope his wound would heal if he obtained aid from leech-craft. Close by there lay a man seriously wounded, Bryniolf, son of Kalf Sendiman of the Færeys. He raised himself on his knees and struck at the King with a sword, aiming at his neck as he stooped down to Ivar. The King warded the blow with the rim of his steel cap, which the edge of the sword struck; but the King's ear was grazed, and his neck received a severe wound. He threw himself from his horse, on the other side, and at the same instant swords and halberds fell so thick on Bryniolf that he could scarce sink to the ground. Ivar Galli too was slain, and Sigurd Skiomi, his kinsman, who was supporting Ivar's head.

2.154

These barons fell on the fields of Ila: Nikolas Mondul, son of Andres, Jon Kula, Kolbein Gislason, and Eirik Lank. Nikolas Mondul was a man of the greatest strength, and wore a coat of mail so trusty that no weapon might pierce it. He wielded his sword with both hands, and was the last man to make a stand. He fell finally from exhaustion, and the Birkibeins stripped him of his coat of mail and then slew him. King Magnus's large sloop and many other ships were taken by King Sverri;

and the Birkibeins, hastening on board, pursued the fugitives. Near Digrmull they seized a ship with Eindridi Kalfsson and thirty men on board. Eindridi escaped to land; the others received quarter. Under the Raudabiorg another ship was taken and two store-ships. Nikolas Arnason and the force under him marched over the Gaularas down to Stein, where he obtained a cutter. Many of King Magnus's men escaped by land. King Magnus sailed south to Bergen and was well received by the townsmen. Then he held an Assembly, and the men of Bergen begged him to remain there; they said, though, that they fully expected a speedy visit from Sverri, and they offered to defend the town with him. Afterwards King Magnus caused all the merchant-ships in the town to be placed in a line, stretching across from Holm to Monks-quay, and fastened them together and to the quays, so that one could walk across the bay. But the King's councillors advised him that it was imprudent to trust the men of Bergen so far as to enclose himself and his ships in the bay. The King after that sailed away south, coastwise, and came to Denmark to his kinsman Valdamar, and dwelt with him for a season.

2.155

King Sverri's visit to Bergen. — Rising of the yeomen of Hordaland [1181].

2.156

49. King Sverri sailed south during the summer, and came to Bergen the day before Petrs-mass. He gave peace to all the townsmen; and they received him honourably, according to his due. He now brought the whole district into subjection. His barons planned whether they should make an attack on Pal, a baron of King Magnus, or proceed to Bergen. They decided to attack Pal, and reached him at morning-tide, so that he was not aware of them before he heard the sound of trumpets. Pal and his men tore down the awnings and made a brave resistance. There was great slaughter: Pal Andresson fell and many of his men.

2.157

It came to pass the same winter, on Monday night in the second week of Lent, that King Sverri's watchmen observed long-ships rowing into the bay, and on one of them a standard was raised aloft; they heard, too, a loud clashing of arms among the men on board. Instantly they caused the trumpets to be sounded, and a great din arose among the Birkibeins, and a rumour spread immediately that King Magnus had come with his host. Many dressed themselves with all speed; some seized their weapons, some not; but all fled either into the churches or up into the fell. King Sverri had left his room, and was out on the balcony when the first blast of the trumpets sounded. "Now God and King Olaf the Saint preserve us!" he said. Then he leapt down into the yard and ran along the street through the town, but saw no man on the way until he reached the Nunnusetr. Here a yeoman on horseback met him, and the King demanded his horse; but the yeoman refused and would not give it up. The King then began to contend earnestly for the horse, saying he would have it by force if he could not get it by other means. So great was his need of a horse that he strove with vehemence for one which no amount of gold or silver would have tempted him to ride unless compelled; for he always afterwards declared that he had never ridden a more wretched animal. However, he rode up to Alreksteads, where he found some Birkibeins. They waited there awhile, and others came up from the town, two or three, five or seven together. Then they learnt that this was not King Magnus's host, but yeomen from Vors, and Austrey, and Hordaland. Their leader was Jon Kutiza; they had rowed their ships to Jons-quay, on the other side, where they landed, and having drawn up their ranks on Jons-fields, had marched close to the head of the bay, but had made no attack on the town. A part of their force landed at Holm, at the entrance of the bay. These marched beyond Kristskirk yard, blew their trumpets, and raised a war-cry; some leapt into the King's courtyard, but acted rather cautiously. The night was dark, so that the Birkibeins could not see them, and therefore fled; if they had known the truth about them, they would soon have driven them off, for this body was a

smaller part of the yeomen's force than the one over on the fields. Now that King Sverri knew of a truth that this was a body of yeomen, and not the force of King Magnus, he called around him all his men present, and bade them return to the town. The whole force of the Birkibeins would soon rally, he said, when they heard his trumpet Andvaka; for he expected that many had taken refuge in the churches, or were hidden here and there in the town, and they would all come to him if they could. As the King marched back to the town, his men gradually collected around him. The day was now breaking, and when he reached Olafskirk he ordered Andvaka to be blown and his standard to be raised. Many Birkibeins had fled into Olafskirk and Krosskirk, Nikolaskirk and Steinkirk, and these all came forth to his standard, as well as many from the town. The King then arrayed his men above All-Hallows-kirk, and addressed them, bidding them march bravely to the battle. "The yeomen," he said, "will fare the worse at our hands the more there are of them together." The Birkibeins then cried out all at once, "May the man never thrive that is afraid of a yeomen's host," and raising the war-cry straightway, sprang out of the ranks and ran to the fields to the yeomen's array, shouting and calling and encouraging one another. As the day broke, and the yeomen beheld the King's standard wave on high, they were filled with fear, and each man got behind another. Then the weapons of the Birkibeins poured down upon them, and the foremost took to flight, and then the rest, one upon another. The Birkibeins pursued after them, and hewed them down like cattle. Some of the yeomen fled to the ships, others plunged into the water; many perished, and some were taken swimming. The Birkibeins followed them to the strand. After the host had been put to flight, the King turned back to the fields, and round the head of the bay into the town. Here many of the yeomen came to him, and he gave quarter to all who asked; and as he marched through the town he kissed all the chief churches. It was now daylight. Jon Kutiza had not left the ships, for he was an old man and infirm. When the yeomen were safe on board they rowed hastily out of the bay, and the sooner a man got

away the happier he was. And the truth came to them, that no expedition so imposing in magnitude as theirs had ever fared worse.

2.158

The yeomen make peace with the King.

2.159

50. A little later King Sverri sailed south coastwise, with a fleet of cutters into Hardangr, and far and wide over Hordaland. He received from the yeomen fines for reconciliation, because many of the South Hords had joined the yeomen's force. He summoned before him the men of Tors and North Hordaland. Many came and were reconciled; many fled east to the Vik to King Magnus, if haply they might find him.

2.160

King Magnus spent the winter in Denmark with his kinsman King Valdamar, having good cheer. He had bailiffs all over the Vik, and received tax and tribute. Orm Kings-brother was usually in the Vik, and some of the barons with him, others being in Denmark with King Magnus. Orm Kings-brother and those with him had a large body of followers all together, and when Lent drew to a close they sailed south, with their force to join King Magnus. King Sverri abode in Bergen until Easter was past, and then prepared to leave, taking with him a numerous and well-equipped force. His ships were large and densely manned. And King Sverri said to his men, "I have now in my pocket assurance of the fidelity of all King Magnus's barons except Nikolas Kufung." By this he meant that all the barons of King Magnus had sent him secret letters, in which they sought from him peace and friendship. These letters the King had in his pocket.

2.161

King Sverri sails to the Vik, and after a skirmish with King Magnus, hastens back to Bergen, followed by King Magnus.

2.162

51. Shortly after Easter week King Sverri sailed coastwise east from Bergen, and all the people submitted to him wherever he went. Then he sailed east to Vik, and collected tribute and fines in every place, and

whatever he demanded from the yeomen. He was informed that King Magnus and his force were in Denmark. King Sverri now advanced far east into the Vik and lay in Salteyar-sound, in the Spior. One day when the King went on the island to his watchmen on a certain rock, they saw a fleet of many ships sailing towards them from the east. "Those must be warships," said the King, and bade the trumpets call his whole force to land for a conference. And the King addressed his men, and thus spoke: "King Magnus comes against us with his host. It appears to me as if we Birkibeins will again have to contend against overwhelming numbers. And though I have a force so large and sure in fight, yet we need to take counsel of the wise men among you, such as Havard Earls-son, Ulf of Laufness, Ulf Fly, and others of our company, whether we shall join battle with King Magnui or sail away north. There we shall have friends in the land, and here we have none. With God's will we will take good counsel, and take it quickly." Then answered Havard Earls-son: "Quickly will I declare my wish. Let us go on board our ships, pull down the awnings, and row out of this winding creek; set up the masts, and sail away north. Don't let us fight here with King Magnus and his overwhelming force; if we lose our ships, we shall find the people of this land more evil-minded towards us than the worst of heathens; there is no hope of life for any one of us who comes into the power of Heklungs or Vikmen." There was much applause at this speech, and they all liked the advice well. So they rowed out of the harbour. And when the Birkibeins had hoisted sail, King Magnus's ships came upon them quickly from the south, out of the sound. The Heklungs' cutters first came within range, but their crews did not venture to attach them to the large ships of the Birkibeins. The Birkibeins fastened their cutters to their large ships, and the crews went on board the large ships, because it seemed likely that they would have to fight. Eyiolf Aflason steered a cutter called Refan, and he went on board Ulf Fly's ship, to which he bound his cutter. On Ulfs ship was a son of Nikolas Kufung, Pal Flida, who was quite a child. The Birkibeins had taken him a little while before, and

also his foster-father. This man ran to the boy, seized him in his arms, and leapt with him to the cutter. Instantly he cut the cable between the ships, and the stream carried away the cutter, which was taken by King Magnus's men. Thus Nikolas Kufung recovered his son. Men were wounded on both sides by missiles, and a few were slain. The two fleets were rowed under sail, and King Magnus's large ships never came within range, but there was no lack of inciting shouts and blowing of trumpets. King Sverri was on a cutter, and rowed alongside his ships, giving orders to his men; he bade them be quick and trim the sails, and turn the ships into a narrow sound between the islands. This they did. King Magnus's men kept the road along the middle of the sound, and did not observe that the Birkibeins had left it and turned between the islands, until their large ships had passed over it in full sail. King Magnus had a large ship called Skeggi, with twenty-six cabins for rowers; its crew were slow in taking down the sail, and slower still in rowing back against wind and stream. Others of his ships now rowed up, and [the chiefs] consulted together, and decided to go their own road. But of King Magnus's cutters and the other ships that turned after the Birkibeins two were captured. One was a smack, steered by a man named Andres; the other a cutter; and the Birkibeins slew every man on board the two. King Sverri sailed north over the Fold as rapidly as he could, keeping to the open sea, and arrived at Bergen the week before Whitsuntide. Here he remained for a while. King Magnus, also with great haste, sailed from the east over the Vik and all were glad to see him. He arrived at Tunsberg, where he remained a short time; then he turned his course northwards, having with him an innumerable host. Night and day he sailed after King Sverri, and only took shelter in harbour when the winds were contrary.

2.163

King Sverri's speech to his men before the battle of Nordness.

2.164

52. Sunday after Whitsuntide, King Sverri was in Bergen with his force, and his ships all lay ready in front of the quays with their war-

bulwarks in position. The greater part of his men were sleeping on board; the rest were in the town. King Sverri rose just before sunrise, and walked up the Bakka to Olafskirk, and afterwards to his watchmen. Then off Nordness they saw a cutter rowing to the bay from the south; its crew steered it to the Holm, and hastened at once on shore. The King saw that they were his scouts, and moved down to meet them; and as soon as they had greeted the King, the men told him their news, saying that they had seen King Magnus's ships, more than thirty of them, and they were now sailing from the south over the Hard-Sea. "Rather too near us," answered the King; and he called to his trumpeter and bade him blow hard. He went at once on board his own ship, ordered the awnings to be taken down, and the vessel to be rowed out towards the mouth of the bay. His men all did the like, and the ships were laid together in the bay. The King then addressed his force, and thus spoke: —

2.165

"King Magnus will soon be here with his host to meet us, and he has with him, as you will have learnt, more than thirty ships; we have not more than sixteen. Now you will not think our prospect bright if we join battle with so great a host; but if we don't fight we shall have to flee to the north of the land. I wish now to take counsel with you, whether you would rather fight with such strength as we have, or flee away. The worst time, methinks, our force has experienced, was the time between our flight from the Hattarhamar and the victory we won at Hirtubru. We have just fled before King Magnus, east in the Vik, and I imagine that if we again avoid an encounter with him there will be little dread of us left." Several then made answer, and said they would prefer to flee away, but begged the King, however, to decide; and then a great murmur arose among the troops that the odds were too great to contend against. Then King Sverri spoke in a loud voice: "With God's will, and that of King Olaf the Saint, make ready straightway, for I will fight King Magnus, and no longer be driven by him from place to place through the land. And although there is great difference in numbers

between the forces, yet, for all that, we have large ships, and so well equipped are they in men and weapons that the Heklungs, before we separate, shall have cause to remember how the Birkibeins can wield their swords. Let them have the same experience as before, and again betake them to their heels; they are always keen at the beginning, but fall short in all their efforts, while you are the surer and the bolder as your peril is greater and more lasting. I may tell you this, too, that every second man in their host will surely shake with fear directly they see you turn to meet them, and will desire to run away rather than come within reach of your weapons. I am persuaded that we shall win a victory over them, and you have seldom found my predictions falsified. Now as heretofore, our strength lies entirely in God and His Saints, and not in our numbers. And I make now my request to God, to King Olaf the Saint, and to Saint Sunnifa, and I pray that this encounter between us, King Magnus and myself, may end according as our claims are known by God to be sound." Loud applause followed the King's speech. "Well spoken! best of kings," his men cried out; "never has your word proved false when you promised us victory! May the man be called dastard who will not rather fight and fall, sword in hand, than flee in cowardice and fear." Then the King said, "May God give you thanks for this answer, as I do. Be undaunted now in the presence of our foes; row forth to meet them, and the braver a man is, the more forward let him drive his ship. I will not have the ships fastened together." After this they rowed out of the harbour, off Nordness, where they remained for a short time.

2.166

King Magnus's ships sailed off Hvarfsness from the south, and were soon borne in towards the harbour; his men then took in sail. And King Magnus gave the signal to lay the ships together, and confer with him. He then addressed his troops, and thus spoke: —

2.167

King Magnus's speech to his men before the battle of Nordness.

2.168

53. “We can now see the ships of the Birkibeins, and the good time has arrived when we shall be able to fight with them, though they have long evaded us. What shall I say to rouse men to the attack — the men, should there be any among us, who will neither remember now the loss of their kinsmen slain by the Birkibeins nor the insults we have borne from them. There seems a fair prospect now that they will suffer the same harm from us that we aforesaid suffered from them. And yet an encounter with them is no honour. We bring to the fight men of high position and brave gentlemen; they have only thieves and highwaymen and robbers, the kin of thralls and beggars, whom may God confound. Our honourable kinsmen would not be any the more avenged should we slay every Birkibein, but we should free ourselves from reproach by doing it. Let none of my men presume to give quarter to one of them. Our force is abundantly large and fine; let our first onset be such that they will not need a second. They have a small force, and God be praised that the last day of their life is come. Place our ships around the Olafssud, as close as there is room; by the time she is cleared, the crews of the others, I trust, will have lost heart. Let our cutters and light ships surround them, so that not a vessel escape.” Then Orm Kings-brother spoke: “I would advise that we prepare for this encounter as one in which the Birkibeins will meet us face to face, and offer fierce resistance, though their force is smaller than ours; and there will be abundant need for every man to do his best. This then would be my counsel — to disable first all the smallest of their ships; for, I imagine, they will not row their large ships out of our reach.” Now, though this was Orm’s advice, yet the plan of the King prevailed. King Magnus commanded the Skeggi, Orm Kings-brother the Gragas, Narfi of Sasteads and his kinsman Steinfinn the Hofdabuza. These three ships with seven others attacked the Olafssud. King Magnus had on board with him Asbiom Jonsson of Thioro, Nikolas Kufung, Pal Smattauga, Jon and Munan, sons of Gaut of Aeness, and many other noble men. His fleet consisted of thirty-two ships. After this they

pulled to the attack, and the Birkibeins rowed towards them from the entrance of the bay, and the two fleets met north of Nordness.

2.169

Battle of Nordness [31st May 1181].

2.170

54. These were the barons with King Sverri: Ulf of Laufness, Ulf Fly, Havard Earls-son, Bard Guthormsson, Ivar Silki, and Gudlaug Valli. The Olafssud, which King Sverri commanded, contained twenty-five rowers' cabins, and was fully manned; the Gorn, Gudlaug Vali's ship, had also twenty-five; the Harknif, manned by King Sverri's Gescs, had twenty-three, and was steered by Audbiom; the Fiardakolla, manned by the House-carles, was steered by Asgeir Hamarskalld. The Birkibeins had many large ships.

2.171

As they rowed to the fight the Olafssud held the outmost place, and on its seaward side it was attacked by nine large ships. This fight was long and stern. King Magnus's men pressed the Olafssud hard with atones and bolts and spears; but there was no close fighting, for the prows of the ships were turned to the Olafssud. But the shower of missiles was so thick, that of three men in a half-cabin on the Olafssud but one remained standing, and in some half-cabins not one. When King Magnus's men became short of stones and missiles, and prepared to board the Olafssud, the Birkibeins grasped their weapons and incited one another to the defence. Many a man struck to the ground by stones and missiles now rose to his feet, every one prepared to do the best he could, and they made a stem fight. King Sverri sprang on the high deck and strongly encouraged his men. He was clothed in a white cowl richly embroidered underneath, and carried a red shield. As he turned to look at the larboard side of the Olafssud, where lay the ship of his marshal Gudlaug, he saw that it reached no farther alongside than the aft pump-room; and he called out to Gudlang, "May the man never prosper who pushes a twenty-five cabined vessel so little forward." Gudlaug answered that he could not mend matters. The King

then took a palstave and thrust it against the bow of Gudlaug's ship, and bade his own men push the ship forward. This was done until it reached the fore pump-room; and soon there was not a man on Gudlaug's ship in front of the mast that was not wounded, so long, fierce, and bloody was the fight. Audbiom, the captain of the Greats, drove his ship alongside that of King Magnus's Greats. The daring shown in the encounter has a place among deeds of renown, for no man could tell which ship would prove the better.

2.172

Battle of Nordness. Exploit of Hallvard Goda.

2.173

55. Hallvard Goela was the name of a Vikman who was a bowman of the best. Once he shot an arrow to King Magnus's ship, and it flew over it; then a second, that struck the ship's side low down; and a third, that passed under the keel. And one said, "You shot straighter last summer when prizes were offered, and silver money for the best shot; you showed your skill then, and won the silver; yet there is more need now of a good shot, for there is the King's life to defend." And Hallvard replied, "Do you think I have not shot straight?"

2.174

"There is no man on our ship," answered the man, "who can shoot farther from the mark." Hallvard then took up a dozen arrows, and every one he shot struck a man on board King Magnus's ship, until the arrows were all used. When the twelve were shot, he placed the bow under his foot and broke it in two. The King then said, "Why deal thus with your bow? We have the same need of help as before," And Hallvard answered, "My hands have done their duty in shooting, and I shall now defend my cabin like another man." So he took sword and shield and went forward to the ship's side, and fought as well as the best.

2.175

Battle of Nordness. King Magnus is wounded, and the Heklungs flee.

2.176

56. When the battle was yet at its height, and men were uncertain how it would turn, King Sverri went forward on the deck, laid down his weapons, and fell upon his knees; then he stretched forth his hands towards heaven, and sang the sequence *Alma Chorus Dei* to the end, all the while being unprotected.

2.177

After this it came to pass that King Magnus moved forwards on his ship to the fore-cabin, where he fought with the utmost vehemence; and he sprang so close to the Birkibeins that, with one foot on the gunwale, he was about to strike a man with his sword. The Birkibeins recognised him by his arms and dress, and assailed him with a storm of weapons. One man cast a sword at him, which struck his instep and passed through his foot. The King turned sharply to save himself, but his foot slipped on the planking, which was covered with blood, and he fell backwards. The Birkibeins saw it, and raised a shout of victory. Then Orm Kings-brother asked his men what the shout meant, and one said in a loud voice, "King Magnus is fallen there."

2.178

"The country's fate is decided," said Orm; "cut the tie-ropes, and row away as hard as you can." And so they did. Asbiorn Jonsson fled the next, and then the rest, one after another. But King Magnus sprang up quickly and shouted, bidding them "not to flee, for he had received no hurt." But no one acted as if he heard. So they loosed the Skeggi from the Olafssud and rowed away. But the Birkibeins let their grappling-hooks fall on the Hofdabuza, and cleared her from stem to stem. The last man standing on her was Steinnfinn, who defended himself with the utmost bravery. The Birkibeins could not overcome him until they took a beam from the prow of the vessel and struck him with it, and he fell there with great glory. Many ships were cleared by the Birkibeins, who made great slaughter among the crews. King Magnus's whole host fled with him

2.179

Escape of Orta Kings-brother.

2.180

57. Orm Kings-brother landed over in Grafdale, for his ship was large, and heavy under oars. He and all his men went up the fell, and the Birkibeins seized the ship and all that was in it. Some followed after Orm, who was infirm, and led by two of his men. And when the Birkibeins pursued him closely, Orm ungirded himself of a heavy purse, and let the silver dribble out. Foremost after him were some Gests of the Birkibeins; these picked up the silver, and were delayed for a time, so that Orm got away among the fells, and they saw him no more. King Sverri rebuked them severely for letting Orm escape while they crept about among the brushwood for a few silver pennies. The Birkibeins had no strength to pursue the fleeing host far, so wounded and wearied were they. Altogether they captured eighteen of King Magnus's ships, which they brought into the town; there was abundant spoil in them for division, for King Magnus at that time was plentifully supplied with money. King Sverri remained for a while in the town. He appointed captains to the ships taken from King Magnus, and caused watch to be kept over King Magnus's movements.

2.181

King Magnus at Stafangr. His expedition to Bergen, and King Sverri's hasty flight to Nidaros. The Birkibeins' difficulty in obtaining intelligence.

2.182

58. King Magnus sailed at once south to Stafangr, and the large force that remained after the battle came together there.

2.183

It was computed that no less than three hundred of each force had fallen at Nordness. Bishop Eirik welcomed King Magnus in Stafangr, and strongly urged him to go back to Bergen; he declared that there was good ground for supposing the Birkibeins could not be well prepared for battle. The advice pleased the King, and Bishop Eirik procured him all the assistance he could, and manned a ship of war with his House-carles. He himself went with King Magnus, and the King obtained much help from the districts around. After a few days

they sailed north for Bergen, making the voyage with all possible speed. Eyiolf Aflason was on the look-out, but the crew of his cutter gained no intelligence of King Magnus's fleet before it faced them in the sound where they were; and they said to one another that they had rowed into a dangerous spot. Then Eyiolf said, "We must row forward up the sound, and act as if we were Heklungs; steer straight to King Magnus's ship as if we had tidings to tell him." The Heklungs saw them coming straight towards them, and took them for their own men who had tidings for the King; but when the cutter came near they found they were not their own men. They pulled down the awnings, therefore, and rowed up to attack them. But the Birkibeins plied their oars vigorously, and rowed away south, out of the sound. The Heklungs followed after them, Bishop Eirik's ship being foremost in the chase. His ship had many priests on board, and was unable to come up with the Birkibeins. And when Bishop Eirik saw that he made little progress in the pursuit, he bade his men turn the ship to land with speed, and lighten it by putting the clergy on shore. "They would then overtake the fugitives," he said. This was done; but meanwhile the Birkibeins pulled hard away, and the Bishop's men could not overtake them. The Birkibeins rowed into the open sea, and so back to Bergen, outside the islands. And they told King Sverri of their look-out, and of the tidings they had fully learnt. Directly it became known to the Birkibeins that King Magnus would be upon them speedily, King Sverri held a conference with his force, and took counsel with them how he should act. And now they were all even more unwilling to fight than before, and preferred to sail away north. They were not well fitted for battle, they said, many being grievously wounded, and all exhausted; for only a few days ago they had fought against great odds. Many said, too, that at Nordness they had been put to such distress that they would have fled gladly, if they had been free, in the battle. So they ended the conference, quite resolved to get ready as quickly as they could and sail away to the north. The men were now distributed among the ships, so that these might be able to make the voyage in one way or another.

The King set Eyiolf Aflason over the Hofdabuza, the ship that had been Narfi's; it was a large ship, and nearly without rigging. It was late in the evening when Eyiolf Aflason brought his tidings to the town, and the sun had only just risen the next morning when King Sverri was on his way from the town with his whole force; but the ships were so poorly manned that men were taken by boat from ship to ship to set up the masts and hoist the sails. The same day about the hour of Nones, Eyiolf left the town, and by the time his men had hoisted sail they saw King Magnus's fleet off Hvarfsness, on their way from the south. When the Heklungs saw Eyiolf's ship they felt sure that Birkibeins were on board. Five ships sailed after him, and chased him all the way north to Furu-sound.

2.184

All the time the contest lasted between Kings Magnus and Sverri, the Birkibeins had the greatest difficulty south of Stad in gaining intelligence. Whether they met with yeomen or lands folk, merchants or fishermen, it happened constantly that they never received information about King Magnus or his men — yea, though a single headland separated them at sea, or a hill when they were on land. But if King Magnus had the more numerous force, every one told his men where the Birkibeins were to be found; and this difference was a cause of much danger and loss of life to the Birkibeins. Friends and foes alike agreed that the scouts of the Birkibeins were exceedingly daring, and constantly escaped, when no one thought they had a chance of life — yea, and often turned to confront the enemy when no one believed there was any prospect of their gaining victory.

2.185

Off Nordness, Sindri Sæbiamarson fell, and Narfi Guthormsson, and many men of King Sverri's force. It is a general opinion that King Sverri and his men were never engaged in a fiercer conflict than this of Nordness, in which it was uncertain what the end would be until fate ordained victory. King Magnus's men fought in no timid way right up to the moment of night; and at the beginning of the battle they

considered they had victory in their grasp, especially as they did not believe the Birkibeins could fight well at sea; for once before, when there had been a battle with them on ships in the north, off Gaularas, the Birkibeins had fled.

2.186

King Sverri went on his way north, in great haste, and came to Thronðham, and then to Nidaros, where he was well received. He caused his ships to be drawn on shore within the town, and fenced around. The wooden castle which Archbishop Eystein built outside the town, near the fields of Ila, was put in good condition, and King Sverri now caused palisades to be set up from the castle to the sea and along the shore, but the work was not all done this summer.

2.187

Of Eirik, who claimed to be a son of King Sigurd Munn, and established his claim by ordeal.

2.188

59. The same spring, Eirik, said to be a son of King Sigurd Haraldsson, came to King Sverri. He had been a long time abroad, and as far as Jerusalem, and had entered the river Jordan bearing a lighted taper in his hand. According to his story, confirmed by his men, he had declared before entering the river, that God would let the taper come forth unextinguished, "if," said he, "I am really King Sigurd's son." Those who accompanied him to the river said that he came out holding the taper still alight. Eirik had been in the service of the Emperor Manuel in Miklagarth, and had also visited men of high estate, far and wide, in southern lands; he was courteous, well informed, short of stature, and plain in appearance. He requested King Sverri to give him leave to undergo the ordeal, that he might bring himself into the family he believed to be his, and prove himself King Sigurd's son. King Sverri first discussed the matter with his chiefs, seeking counsel of them; then he brought it up at meetings of the body-guard, saying that he wished to know whether the whole of the force would consent to it. From the force he obtained a unanimous

answer, that they desired to serve King Sverri and none other; but the chiefs wished to grant Eirik evidence of his paternity. Then King Sverri said to Eirik, “By the advice of my friends I will give you leave to undergo the ordeal, so that God may prove your paternity. But though it happen that you become really my brother, and are King Sigurd’s son, yet the name of King and the realm I now possess have cost me so dearly, so many worries, perplexities, and grave dangers, which I and the Birkibeins with me have endured, that neither to you nor any other will I grant the name of King, or give up the realm I now possess. Accept this condition, if you will, peacefully and with my leave; otherwise you shall depart hence, and go in safety as you came hither.” Eirik, who was a well-spoken man, thanked the King with fair words for giving him leave to undergo the ordeal, and said that he gladly accepted the condition in order to prove his paternity; after which his affairs would lie entirely in God’s power and the King’s. Shortly afterwards, preparatory to the ordeal, Eirik fasted; and when the time came that he should bear the iron, King Sverri dictated the form of the oath, and spoke thus: “for this cause you lay your hands on the Holy Belies and the Book, and make this appeal to God: that He will allow your hand to come unharmed from the iron if you are King Sigurd’s son and my brother.” And Eirik answered: “So may God let me remove my hand unharmed from this iron as I am King Sigurd’s son; but I will not bear the iron to prove the paternity of more men than myself.” After taking this oath he bore the iron, and his truth was made fully clear. King Sverri then acknowledged his kinship to Eirik, and made him a captain in his body-guard. Eirik was a popular man, most condescending, and ruled his company exceedingly well.

2.189

Kings Sverri and Magnus hold a conference, which leaves things as they were.

2.190

60. King Magnus came to Bergen with his force, and remained there during the spring. And when it was past, he made ready his host and sailed north to Kaupang, where he arrived on the later Olafs-mass Day.

King Sverri prepared to meet him in the town, and had a large force at hand, for the yeomen promised him their support; moreover, there was a large concourse of people in the town, which it was the custom to visit during guild-term. King Magnus lay out at sea, near Holm, a long time, for he thought an attack upon the town unadvisable against all that crowd which he saw with King Sverri, and he preferred to wait till the guild-term ended and the yeomen went home. During this delay the Kings parked for a time each day. King Sverri again made his former offer to King Magnus to share the land, and King Magnus should choose which half he would; but King Magnus would say neither yea nor nay after the parley. Afterwards King Sverri summoned an Assembly in the town, and told the yeomen of his offer and what had been said. The King's speech was well received, and the yeomen said they would be glad if peace were made. They were very eager that the conference should go on, and a truce was made while it lasted. King Magnus rowed in a cutter to the EYRA, where King Sverri sat on horseback, attended by a great crowd, of yeomen and townsfolk chiefly, who were curious to know what the Kings would say and how the conference would end.

2.191

Nikolas Arnason first began to speak on behalf of King Magnus. His address was in favour of peace, in accordance with the discussion already held, and he spoke long and eloquently. King Magnus's men had rowed some of their cutters into the river; and the Birkibeins went down to meet them, and had ale brought out of the town. They all sat down together on the Brottú-Evri drinking and talking; for though they belonged to two different bands, many in the one had kinsmen or relatives in the other, or friends of old standing. After this, King Sverri began to speak. He said that he desired to come to an agreement with King Magnus, that the land might be at peace; and he again made the offer that they should share the land equally, and both of them be Kings, as the sons of King Magnus Berfoett had been aforetime, and the sons of Harald Gilli. He said that from the time when King Magnus the

Good had granted half the land to his father's brother, King Harald, there had generally been two kings in Norway at one time, and sometimes more. They might well follow, he said, the example of former kings. The yeomen and townsfolk loudly applauded the King's speech and declared it excellent. King Magnus then stood up and declaimed in a loud voice, speaking his words calmly at first, and thus saying: "In the instances you bring forward where two kings reigned in Norway at the same time, the sharing of the land, I am told, was done in a friendly and agreeable manner by brothers or other closely related kinsmen, and yet the division invariably ended in unfriendliness, and sometimes in loss of life. And it bears closely upon our case that in those instances there were fewer causes of quarrel at first than now exist. I allude to the troubles which through ill-fortune have befallen me of late, the death of distinguished men, my kinsmen and friends. And this I know, that even if I were to accept a forced agreement, it will not be possible for Sverri and me to keep our guardsmen on good terms in the same market-town or the same place of payment, under such causes of quarrel as have here arisen among men. Though we should attempt a settlement, peace would be short-lived." Then answered King Sverri: "You speak truly, King Magnus, when you say of peace, that though we should desire to preserve it, others might break it; therefore, rather than our ill-fortune should become longer harmful to so many men, I will quit the land with my force if you will be bound by oath that I shall hold the government of one half and set my men over it in peace and freedom. I will then stay out of the land three years; and when I return, you and your men shall give place to us for three other years, under the same conditions as we did for you." Then King Magnus replied: "The condition I desire is this — that you, Sverri, and you, Birkibeins, go out of the country, yea, and never return. I was consecrated and crowned King by the legate from Rome with the unanimous consent of the people of the land, and I swore at my consecration that I would observe the laws of the land and defend it against the greed and enmity of wicked men with the sword

that I received at my consecration, and I promised that I would rather lose my life than go against the words of my oath. Let God decide how long my life shall last; but I will listen to no proposal that I should break through cowardice the oath I took at my consecration, and share the land with thee, Sverri. I have already lost through you, Birkibeins, one hundred high-born guardsmen, sixteen barons, and one, the seventeenth, a greater is to me than all those I have mentioned, Earl Erling, my father. Moreover, it is not possible for me to share the kingdom with you, Sverri, a man who, in my opinion, has no right by birth to be King either here or elsewhere. Most certainly I will either keep the whole of Norway, or lose the whole and my life with it." Then King Sverri spoke: "You call to mind, King Magnus, the losses that have befallen you only in our dealings, and you look not at those I have suffered from your kinsmen, greater and heavier than you have just reckoned up: first, when my father, King Sigurd, was slain, south in Bergen, and then King Eystein, my father's brother, east in Vik. Somewhat later, after King Ingi fell, my brother Hakon was chosen King over the whole country; and then Erling Skakki raised a band against him and slew him, south in Mœri, together with many barons and worthy gentlemen. Erling caused my brother Harald to be hanged up, like a young crow, south at Hvarfsness; my brother Sigurd was put to death in Bergen, and my cousin Eystein was slain at Re. Now I might well declare to you, as you have declared to me, that I could not possibly be King over Norway if I came to terms with you or shared with you the inheritance of my fathers; because it never happened in Norway that a man was called King who was not a King's son, before you, King Magnus. And there shall again be made to you on my part the same offer as formerly. Go up to the fields of Ila, prepare yourself and your force for battle, and I will come forth from the castle with all my force. You shall fare as badly as before when last we fought, or worse, for God doubtless desires that the rule you have held wrongfully for a time should now come to an end."

King Magnus then replied, “We will go no more to your bewitched field Do you go rather to your ships and man an equal number to ours; we will then sail out of the river and fight.” Then King Sverri answered, “Our ships are now drawn up on shore, and not fit for battle at present; yet I can take three ships; do you man three likewise, as shall seem good to you, and we will put these six ships to fight.”

2.193

“I am of opinion,” then said King Magnus, “that it will be a better plan not to let more men die than have already lost their lives in this quarrel; for what you say is true, that I have ever made a hasty retreat before your men. But you, Sverri, whenever battles take place, lurk in holes and hiding-places. Come forth alone with your weapons if you dare, and I will come alone and meet you, and we will fight together, and let whichever gains the victory have the land and realm,”

2.194

“Our ill-fortune is quite evident enough to other men,” replied King Sverri, “though we do not fight with one another ourselves. Our men are set to fight for us in battle, and it seems to me very unkingly to engage in a duel, like those champions who have no followers. But, King Magnus, since you desire a single combat with me, rather than others should take part, do you take a horse, and I will take another, and we will ride a tilt, as is the custom with men of rank.”

2.195

As the conference drew to a close, their followers who were drinking together, became more and more haughty towards one another; and King Magnus’s men all went on board ship, and rowed their cutters out of the river.

2.196

King Magnus returns to Bergen, and King Sverri marches through the Uplands to Oslo.

2.197

61. King Sverri caused cutters to be dragged over the Eyra to the sea, and his men, hastening on board, rowed after the Heklungs. They came

so near that spears were thrown on both sides, but the Heklungs rowed away. In this encounter men were slain on both sides, and very many were wounded. Karl Kiotlær died of his wounds. A few days afterwards King Magnus sailed out of Throndham and went back south to Bergen, and there was no battle at this time. He passed the winter in Bergen. That summer King Magnus received war contributions and all revenues south of Stad, and as far north as the entrance of Throndham; and King Sverri obtained no winter stores for his force except what they received from Throndham. King Sverri now learnt that King Magnus with all his force had come south beyond Stad, and had with him almost all his barons; he resolved therefore to start on a march overland to the Uplands. He gave the oversight of Throndham to his brother Eirik and a captain named Kol, son of Isak of Eolskn, and he left with them a numerous force to guard the ships; many other captains also were there. King Sverri marched all the way to the Uplands, and despatched men in advance to the inhabited districts to plan the winning of some advantage if Heklungs or their property came in the way. They slew Ozur, son of Jon Vagadraum, Eyvind Dyri, and many others. Afterwards King Sverri marched down to Oslo, and appointed his bailiffs over the whole of the Vik; but the Heklungs fled, some east, some north to King Magnus, and told him of King Sverri's marches.

2.198

Battle at Nidaros between King Magnus and Eirik Kingsson. The Birkibeins are defeated and lose all their ships.

2.199

62. King Magnus put his forces in order, and sent the greater part east to Vik, under Orm Kings-brother, to oppose King Sverri. He himself set sail with eight ships — seven long-ships and one cutter — and coasting north, came to Throndham shortly before Martinmas. Eirik Kings-son and Kol Isaksson heard a rumour of King Magnus's voyage, and set a watch at nights in the Guildhalls by the sea; but they had no certain knowledge of King Magnus's movements before his ships sailed into sight off the Digrmull. The trumpets at once summoned all the force,

and the men were drawn up in array; one body on the Eyra, and the other by Skipacrook. Eirik Kings-son commanded the latter; the former was under the charge of Kol Isaksson, who had with him some of the townsmen, but the greater part of the townsmen were drawn up at the quays. As soon as King Magnus's fleet came near Holm, the sails were lowered and the ships allowed to run under bare poles to the Eyra. The day of the week was Saturday. When they had come quite close to the cross the ships were all brought together, and remained "there a large part of the day, because King Magnus was then taking counsel with his men. But many of those who were on the Eyra waded out towards them; some threw stones, others shot at them, and incited them to land. No answer came back from King Magnus's men, because the chiefs were conferring and forming their plans. In the town Hagbard Muntari was then busy with his wedding-feast; he called aloud to King Magnus and said that he wished to invite him to the wedding and all his men with him. This was done in sport. About the hour of Nones, King Magnus's men set free their fleet, and applying themselves to the oars, rowed the four largest of the ships into the river, and the other four to the Eyra. The King himself rowed into the river and made his attack where the standard of Eirik Kings-son stood. The resistance was stem and short. King Magnus laid his ships alongside the beach, and his men pushed their gangways under the feet of the Birkibeins; they cast stones and missiles from the ships, so that the Birkibeins fell back. After that, the Heklungs decided to land, but the Birkibeins withstood them; many were wounded and some slain on both sides. The townsmen and levies grew tired of standing there longer, and thronged into the town. And when the Birkibeins saw their ranks growing thin, and the Heklungs pressing hard, they turned away and fled. The Heklungs followed close upon them, and many Birkibeins were slain.

2.200

How those that rowed to the Eyra leapt overboard at once, and the water reached to their arm-pits. As they came up, the Birkibeins

attacked them, and a fierce battle began. Then a man spoke to Kol: "I believe the Heklungs have landed at the river." Kol replied: "Then our best plan, surely, is to flee."

2.201

"Is it not too late now," said a Heklung, "for the Birkibeins to flee?" And Kol turned to the man: "There they are now, the devils," he said, and he smote the man and was smitten by him. After Eirik Kings-son and his force fled, some of the Heklungs turned to the Eyra and came upon Kol and his men with a troublesome attack on their rear. Kol was slain with many of his company, and all the force fled that remained.

2.202

Eirik Kings-son fled away beyond the castle, and on to Gaulardale. Many of his force fled with him, but some fled inland over the bridge. Many took refuge in the churches, and were nearly all slain; no church was a safe refuse this time. Men were dragged out of Kristskirk and slain, a deed that had never been done hitherto. One old Birkibein named Eyvind Skrapi, a valiant warrior, tall and strong, was taken from the choir, and dragged out of Kristskirk. They placed him on a sledge, dragged him to the Eyra, and slew him there. Gudlaug Vali was seized in a church, kept prisoner a long time, and put to torture, that he might be made to tell where King Sverri had stored his money, and where King Sverri's son Lavard was, who had been Gudlaug's foster-son. But he told nothing, and his firmness was remembered afterwards in his honour. He was slain by command of King Magnus. Scarcely a Birkibein had his life spared whom they had the means of slaying. King Magnus took possession of the Olafssud, and all King Sverri's fleet, thirty-three long-ships. Four of these, all they could take away, were launched and made ready; the rest were burnt.

2.203

King Magnus returns to Bergen.

2.204

63. King Magnus now made hasty preparations to leave the town, for he heard that Eirik Kings-son had a large gathering of yeomen up in

Gaulardale. And as he sailed down the Fiord he despatched men to seize and kill the cattle of Afli at Asta, of Tosti at Tsta, and thirdly, of Helgi at Rydas. They likewise seized the cattle of Eirik and Ami of Efa, and as long as they were in Throntham they behaved with violence wherever they could. Eindridi Torfi, son of Jon Kutiza, remained behind with a single ship at the mouth of the Orkna. The same day Bard Gruthormsson came with thirty men from the south, from Hefni, to the slope above Tunga. He saw the long-ship lying there, and suspected there were Heklungs, but did not venture to attack them. He stayed there during the night, which his men found very cold. Then he sent men to the homestead Gelmin to ask Cecilia Kings-daughter of the tidings. She told them many things in secret, and said that King Magnus's men were there. Bard's men wished to attack. "Don't let us lie here," they said. But Bard was unwilling, and prevailed. The next day the Heklungs sailed away, and followed King Magnus. Bard marched to Kaupang, where he stayed for a time, and found quarters for his company. The captains of the Birkibeins, Helgi Thorfinnsson, Ottar Knerra, and Eyiolf Aflason, came and joined themselves to him; but Eirik Kings-son marched east to Vik after King Sverri, and told him that his way had not been smooth.

2.205

King Magnus then sailed south to Bergen. Hall Snorrason was there with the King, and he composed these stanzas: —

2.206

"The Olafssud, prows gilded with red gold,
Weighted with wealth, cleaves Rodi's sounding plains.

2.207

The lavish prince has prospered on his way.

2.208

His happy voyage o'er, the awful King
Now comes with honour home, in generous mood.

2.209

The swollen ship on Dufa's bosom rods.

2.210

The fair prow-horse, prince-steered, appears off Holm;
By doughty ruler led, the reddened beaks
Glide o'er the roaring fields, retreat of whales.

2.211

The monarch, swift his folk to held
A moot of spears and swords with foemen brave.

2.212

Dag's son returns, renowned for glorious victory."

2.213

Affray between King Magnus's Guardsmen and Gests.

2.214

64. King Magnus had his Yule banquet prepared in Bergen; he entertained his Guardsmen in the large King's hall, and the Gests in Sunnifa's hall. The Gests were displeased because the Guardsmen had mead to drink and they had ale. The fifth evening of Tule, when the Gests had well drunk, they seized their weapons and rushed to the King's hall, intending to force an entrance. The King was told, and he ran hastily to the door to quiet them; but his thrall Bard Skiold pressed before him into the ante-chamber, and was slam immediately. Then the King turned back, and his Guardsmen barred the door, but the Gests broke it open. Then the Guardsmen who had been in attendance during the day hastened to defend the door, they alone having weapons; others seized the oven-stones and threw them into the ante-chamber. When this became known to the townsmen, and the House-carles of King Magnus, they armed themselves and went to the King's hall. The Gests took to flight, but many were wounded there. The following morning King Magnus ordered the Gests to be seized who had been the ringleaders; some had a foot cut off, others a hand, and a few were put to death.

2.215

King Sverri's reception of Eirik Kings-son after his defeat.

2.216

65. When Eirik Kings-son came east to King Sverri with his companions, he begged the King to march north to Throntham as speedily as he could. The Thronds, he said, had sent a message, and prayed the King to be their leader as he had promised them; for King Magnus, in sailing from Throntham, had threatened to come in like manner a second time when he had more leisure, and requite the Thronds the treason and guile they had practised towards him and his father Earl Erling. King Sverri answered that he would not march at their call. He declared that they had shown little wisdom in their plans, and he rebuked them sternly, as they deserved. The King said that he had prepared, at much expense and labour, to hold his Yule feast there, and he did not intend to move away until after Yule. And thus he did.

2.217

King Sverri begins his march from Oslo to Throntham [1182].

2.218

66. Orm Kings-brother came east to Vik with a large force. Then he sailed to Tunsberg, where his men remained constantly on board the ships. At times they sailed east over the Fold, at other times north to Agdi or about Vestfold. The two forces now surprised each other's men wherever they could; but the Heklungs did not sail to Oslo, and King Sverri could not go against them, for he had no ships. After Candlemas, King Sverri left Oslo, and began his march north to Throntham. And as they marched through Hadaland it happened that they rode over the ice on the Bond; and the ice broke under them, and seven were drowned, all distinguished men. Among them were Jon the Page, Hallvard Lepp Sunnifuson, and Ogmund Hallsteinsson, brother of Lodin. Neither men nor horses could be saved.

2.219

King Magnus sails to Throntham.

2.220

67. When Yule was past, King Magnus prepared to sail north to Throntham and left the town [Bergen] after Candlemas. He had his

Guardsmen and picked troops on board to the number of eight hundred men. The voyage was made with all speed, though they lay very long in harbour in different places weatherbound. Nevertheless they arrived quite unexpected at Throntham, and entering the Fiord, they reached the town [Nidaros] on the Saturday of the second week in Lent. They planned their approach so that some of the ships landed their men near the castle, some on the Eyra; others were rowed up the river, and their men rushed into the town. Two cutters proceeded to the opposite side of the river, off Bakki, and the men leapt ashore there above Erlendshaug, and marched towards the bridge.

2.221

Flight of the Birkibeins from Nidaros. King Sverri's march north.

2.222

68. We come now to speak of the Birkibeins. Many of them were in the bath-rooms, and all were unprepared to meet foes. Bard Guthormsson was the first to hear of them; he and all his men at once hastened away over the bridge. Ottar Knerra and Helgi Thorfinnsson ran to a cutter which they owned at the quays in the Kings court. Eyiolf Aflason was gone to the bath at Griot. He heard a child cry out, "Here come Heklungs," took his clothes in his arms and ran past Krosskirk up the town. Many Heklungs were then coming up the street. Then he ran past Kristskirk yard, and a troop came towards him that had marched up the town, so he turned to the quays and took refuge with many others on a cutter. Some of these brandished swords, others had bucklers or whatever they found to hand. They pushed the ship from land and swept across the river. But when they would land under Skellingar-hella, above Erlendshaug, the ship, they knew not why, would not go to the bank, and some thought they were spellbound, and that they were all doomed to die. But the cause was an anchor that hung from the ship, for they had taken no heed to haul it up, and it held the ship in the shallow part of the river near land. Seeing this, they cut the rope instantly, and soon came to land, and leapt on shore. Ottar and Eyiolf went together, and snow had fallen heavily. And now

the Heklungs who had landed at Bakki hastened up and met them at the junction of the roads above Erlendshaug, and all ran as fast as they could. Three of the Heklungs were very swift of foot. These overtook Ottar and Eyiolf, who were together, but did not attack them, and the two Birkibeins escaped along the road to their own men. They were now fifteen together in a valley below Berg; and Ottar said he wished to fight the Heklungs, but Eyiolf prevented him: "Help will come to them," he said, "but we shall receive no support." The Birkibeins held on their way to Kleppabu, and over the river Nid into Gaulardale. Here others joined them, and so all came together that had escaped. Then they marched inland through Soknadale and over Dalskog, making their way to the fells; and when they reached Hardkinn, King Sverri came up on his way from Vik. When they met the King they told him of their ill-luck and the loss of many of their fellows. The Birkibeins who had accompanied the King from the east spoke of the mishap rather scornfully. The following day as they marched down to Updale, those who had come with the King all rode on horseback, and not one of them would share his horse with any of the men from the north. So Bard Guthormsson marched on foot with all his fellows. He had with him the poet Biarni Kalfsson, who recited this verse: —

2.223

"Here's a custom of the worst I see:
Each common soldier rides a horse, and barons walk afoot;
A tedious route it is.

2.224

Guardsmen here must run while cook-boys ride;
The bargain is not fair, but I shall not Fret much about it."

2.225

King Sverri then marched down into Orkadale, where, at the homestead of Griota, King Magnus's bailiffs were, Sigurd and Hakon. The Birkibeins surprised them in the house, and slew them with all their company. One man escaped, Ottar Gasi, who got through a wainscot partition and slipped away. Five men on horseback pursued

him, and the one that followed the longest and came nearest was King Sverri. Ottar fled into a thicket and made his way to the mouth of the Orkna, over which he passed in a boat; thence to Stein and to Nidaros, over the Gaularas.

2.226

King Magnus's dealings with the yeomen of Thronðham.

2.227

69. We must now tell of King Magnus and his men. They spread over the town and slew many of the Birkibeins, for it availed none to mention quarter. The King remained in the town over Sunday, and sent a message into Orkadale that he would arrive there on the Wednesday following, and hold an Assembly of the men of Orkadale. And he sent a message into Gaulardale bidding the men of Gaulardale to come to the town on Friday, when he would hold an Assembly in the town. King Magnus sailed to Orkadale with all his force; the yeomen had come to the appointed place, and the King went up to the Assembly. Here he stood up and spoke: "It must seem a long time, in the memory of you Thronds, since we last held Assembly together. Three years have passed since you paid me any dues. It is now my will that you provide and pay over the war-tax, the whole contribution which you had to furnish for the last twelve months, and also two other contributions. To these must be added the tax for rowing and rigging, and contributions for service at sea, which are the King's right; likewise the land dues and fines that you have already provided and paid to our foes, for which deed may you feel Gods anger as well as mine." After this he made use of hard language, and became so angry that he swore, and the yeomen imagined for a time that he meant to fall upon them and slay them. One of them named Hroi of Kiarkasteads answered the King in a few words, craving peace and pardon for the yeomen, and some delay in the payment. The King appointed a meeting in a fortnight, when the whole sum should be brought to him in the town; and he promised the yeomen pardon if the payment were made. The Assembly then decreed the payment of war-tax to the King. The

bailiffs before mentioned, Sigurd and Hakon, went up to Griota, and in the evening the King sailed to the town.

2.228

News of King Sverri's approach brought to King Magnus by Ottar Gasi.

2.229

70. On Friday, matins being ended, no yeomen came to the Assembly. Then a few men were seen coming over Steinbiorg with cart-loads of wood. King Magnus was staying in the house of Eirik Araason. At this moment, Ottar Gasi, who has already been mentioned, arrived at the town and went straight to Eirik's house. Some Guardsmen there saw a man come up at a furious speed, and asked him if he knew aught of the Birkibeins. "I shall tell you nothing," he said. "Where is the King?"

2.230

"He is gone to Kristskirk to the meeting," they answered. So the man left the house instantly to go to the King. Shortly afterwards the King came to the house, running at a furious rate, and bade his men take their arms and go on board as soon as they could. "The Birkibeins are on us," he said. Then the trumpet sounded; they all took their weapons and clothes in the utmost haste, rushed on board ship, and rowed out to Holm. But as the day passed, the Birkibeins came not, nor any Gaulardale yeomen to the Assembly. It seemed strange that the Birkibeins were nowhere near, and they began to think the man had brought them false information; but he, who was on board the King's ship, persisted in his story. Many asked leave of the King to go back to the town; they had left their clothes behind, they said, or their weapons, or their money. Some wished to get drink, others had wives in the town. King Magnus forbade the men generally to go to the town, but permitted a few; nevertheless there were many that went.

2.231

King Magnus's hasty departure from Nidaros. Birkibeins and Heklungs compared. King Sverri's fortifications at Nidaros.

2.232

71. Kang Sverri and his men rested on the Gaularas, and had knowledge of all that passed in the town. On the morning of Saturday his followers wished to set out for the town, but the King advised them to wait until their foes were mostly in the bath-houses. But his men prevailed, being very eager for the prey, and started to go to the town early in the morning during a heavy shower of rain. They arrived in the town before any one perceived them; there was no resistance, and they slew a large number. Einar, captain of one of King Magnus's ships, was slain; others escaped to their boats and rowed out to Holm. Many boats were setting out at that time from Holm, ready to row to the town, before the Birkibeins were seen advancing to the castle. As soon as King Magnus knew that King Sverri was come, he sailed away with his force down the Fiord, and all the way south to Bergen.

2.233

Men remarked how evident it seemed that King Magnus and his men were unwilling to engage in a pitched battle with King Sverri and his force. For as soon as intelligence reached them of the approach of the Birkibeins, they fled from the town without a fight, although King Magnus had eight hundred men at the time, and King Sverri not more than three hundred and a half. Moreover, the wooden castle was then so strong, and surrounded by a trench, that it was easier to defend with half the number than to attack.

2.234

At this time King Magnus had in his sole possession the whole of the fleet, and by its means held under tax and tribute all the land and people south of the entrance of Throntham, except only when the Birkibeins made incursions south into Moeri with cutters. The men of both forces behaved with violence whenever no chiefs were present. The Birkibeins kept detachments of their force east in Vik, and over the Uplands, as they had the most hope of plunder there. The Heklungs made constant attacks on the Birkibeins, and the Birkibeins on the Heklungs; sometimes one side was victorious, and sometimes the other. Many stories might be told of them, but we shall prefer to write of

those matters which seem most noteworthy, and in which the Kings themselves were engaged.

2.235

During the spring King Sverri caused palisades to be set up, so that a complete line stretched [from the castle] along the sea-coast, then inland round the Guildhalls, and over the Eyra across to the river, and along the river to the quays. A catapult was fixed on Brottu-Eyri by the sea, and a blockhouse was built close to the bridge.

2.236

King Magnus makes a final and unsuccessful attack on Nidaros.

2.237

72. The following summer King Magnus prepared to leave Bergen, and a great host again gathered around him from the south of the land. Nearly all his barons were with him. When he came to Throndham he sailed with his host close to Holm, where he lay a few days. Eng Sverri remained in the town. King Magnus then sailed up the Fiord of Throndham, collected the war-tax, and sailed back towards the town. The first night he anchored off Depil within the Hladhamra, and on the following morning there was so thick a fog that they could not see farther before them than from stem to stern. King Magnus then rowed in a calm to Holm. King Sverri heard the noise of their oars, but as he saw nothing he thought they were about to make an attack, and he summoned his whole force by sound of trumpet to Eyra; but King Magnus remained that night at sea near Holm. In the morning they rowed to land, and came on shore at the fields of Ha with the greatest part of their host, and advanced close to the castle-keep. The Birkibeins came out to the castle against them, and shots were exchanged for a time. King Magnus and his men burned down the bridge over the Nid, thinking to stop all transport of goods to the Birkibeins in the town, by land as well as by sea. King Sverri led his force out of the town to the castle, where they set up tent-booths; and he took from the town two buildings, which he removed to his camp and set up near the castle. And now the two armies sat for a time

watching each other. Most of King Magnus's men passed the night on board ship, but detachments were appointed to keep watch near the castle; and there was always a numerous force on land, that kept huge night-fires burning on the fields. The Birkibeins observed that the enemy could see clearly as far as their fires; but beyond them they could see only a short distance in the darkness. And one night they took their weapons, came forth from the castle, and fell upon the Heklungs, who only became aware of the attack when the arrows whizzed over their heads; and they had not long to wait for the hurling of the spears. Next, the Birkibeins used their swords, and made a great slaughter in the night. All fled that could. Those on ship-board, hearing the noise of trumpets and the war-shout on the fields, rowed to land, set up their standard, and advanced to aid their fellows. But the night being dark they did not see them until the fugitives rushed into their ranks. And now many fell who would have escaped by flight if their own comrades had not stopped them. The advancing Heklungs next met the halberd-thrusts and sword-strokes of the Birkibeins. They made no resistance, and the very men who had been most eager to come on land fled at full speed to the ships. Many were slain; some rushed into the sea, and so reached the ships. King Sverri and his men returned to their land-booths around the castle, taking with them much booty in weapons and clothes, gold and silver. In the morning light the Birkibeins beheld the Seklungs lying thick on the fields, bleaching their sides. King Magnus and his men rowed out to Holm, and after a few days they sailed away from Thronddam, south to Bergen. The expedition had been most disastrous. King Magnus passed the following winter in Bergen, and King Sverri abode with his men in Kaupang.

2.238

King Sverri plans the building of the Mariusud. Events of the winter [1182].

2.239

73. This winter King Sverri began the building of a castle on the Steinbiorg; and the Kings rooms in it were ready by the early part of

Lent. He then moved into the castle, and abode there regularly during the spring with some of his troops; but others stayed in the town. This winter, too, he began to build a ship in Throntham, a much larger vessel than others then in the land. It contained thirty-three cabins for rowers, and there was room for more. It was called the Mariusud.

2.240

On a day in the early part of winter, King Sverri summoned by trumpet an Assembly of his troops and the townsmen, and spoke to them, saying: "We have had of late such great difficulties, troops and townsmen both, and also the yeomen of the districts, that hunger and starvation are at hand; as we might expect when so great a host has fed upon one fiord for two winters. All our trouble has arisen since we lost our ships, and I see not many vessels here within the Fiord that are fit for war service. I tell you of a truth that if I saw any hope that we Birkibeins could procure ships here, we should take our turn and attack the Heklungs by sea, as they attack us. But now that my men are tired of this close struggle, I see no other way out than to turn to the Uplands and thence east to Vermaland, or even to Gautland." The King ended his speech by ordering all his men to make ready for the march. The following week a hundred and twenty horses were shod, and preparations made day by day for the march. This became known to the merchants who went to Bergen from the north. A great number of men were gathered together in Bergen at this time, King Magnus and his barons and nearly all the chiefs. They had with them all their largest ships, and intended to sail north against King Sverri. But they put off their voyage when they heard that the King was preparing to leave Throntham. King Magnus's men then departed to their bailiwicks, and the whole of this gathering broke up. But King Sverri abode in Kaupang until after Yule. When Yule was past, he sailed south with a few cutters at high speed, hoping to come upon King Magnus unawares in Bergen. But when he reached Mœri he was met by contrary winds, and lay there for a time. Then suspecting that intelligence by land over the isthmus would reach Bergen before him,

King Sverri turned back north to Thronðham and abode there through the winter and following spring.

2.241

Vidkunn of Biarkey attacks and slays King Sverri's bailiff in Halogaland.

2.242

74 King Sverri had a bailiff named Thorgils, whose bailiwick extended over the northernmost community of Halogaland. He held also the right to travel among the Finns, and during the winter he journeyed into the fell to trade with the Finns and to collect tribute. At this time Vidkunn Erlingsson lived in Biarkey, the handsomest of all the men of Halogaland. He was now eighteen years of age, and had lately inherited his father's estate. King Magnus sent word to Vidkunn to come to him and be invested with the rights of a baron, to which his birth entitled him. It was a general opinion that the King's message to Vidkunn covered other matters, of a private nature, between the King and Vidkunn. Vidkunn had two sisters, both beautiful, and thought to be excellent matches; and Ragnhild, the sister of King Magnus, was unmarried. In the winter Vidkunn sailed into the fiords and got intelligence of the Birkibeins. By this time Thorgils had returned from the fell, having acquired a large store of wealth. Vidkunn then lay in wait for him within Oegisfiord, slew Thorgils and twelve men with him, seized all the booty, and took it with him to Biarkey.

2.243

Vidkunn is slain by King Sverri's men.

2.244

75. The following spring, Vidkunn prepared for his voyage from the north. He owned a ship called the Gullbringa, which had twenty cabins for rowers, and there was room in it for more; it had belonged to Archbishop Eystein. Vidkunn furnished this ship fully with men and arms, and carried his provisions in another ship. Both his sisters accompanied him, and Jon Drumbi, his mother's brother. They made the voyage boldly, apprehending no danger; the shields all hung at the stems of the ship, and the mail-coats were below in chests under the

deck. Intelligence of Vidkunn's proceedings reached King Sverri, and he despatched Bard Guthormsson and Ivar Silki north, with seven cutters, to meet him. As the Birkibeins reached Ongul they beheld Vidkunn's ships coming from the north, past Ofoti, and they rowed their cutters close to the rocks under Steig, and waited there. This was early on the morning of Ascension-day. Vidkunn and his men saw nothing of them before they were close upon them, and the ships had almost run into one another. They speedily pulled down the sail; but the Birkibeins attacked the ship on both sides, and made a fierce assault. Vidkunn's men had only swords to defend themselves with, and the fight soon became a slaughter. They endeavoured to launch the boat and remove the women from the ship, but did not succeed, so quickly was the fight over. The Birkibeins were victorious, slaying Vidkunn and almost all his force. They seized the Gullbringa and all that was on board, took her south to Throntham, and presented her to King Sverri. He praised their exploit highly.

2.245

King Sverri plans a sudden attack on King Magnus in Bergen [1183].

2.246

76. In the spring, when Easter was past, King Sverri held many Assemblies with his men and the townsmen, and brought before them various designs. But he came to no determination, and at the end no one seemed to know what plan he would adopt. Sometimes he spoke of a march east to Vik or to Gautland; sometimes he would go on board his cutters and sail west to the Orkneys, or even to the Sudreys. Full intelligence of this reached King Magnus as he abode in Bergen, where a great host with a multitude 'of ships again gathered around him. And now King Sverri decided on his plan. He went on board his cutters, twenty ships, all small, and told his men that he would sail north to Halogaland. But when he came to Agdaness, at the entrance of Throntham, there was a strong north wind blowing. He then summoned his troops together from the ships and held a council with them, and thus spoke: "I was not really earnest when I put out the

report that we should make a voyage to Halogaland or ride up to Gautland. It is a wearisome thing to row a toilsome voyage north, in a storm, for little profit, and place ourselves well-nigh in a blind alley with those Heklungs in face. I see now that it will be easier to let the cutters glide south before the wind through the sounds. 'He wins who risks,' so it is said, and we still have the choice whenever we will, of altering our course and sailing by the high seas east to Vik." The men all agreed this plan was the best. They sailed, therefore, all the way south until they came beyond Stad. Here the King commanded to lay the ships together, and he conversed with his men and said: "Our voyage seems to me to have succeeded so far, and now it is perhaps advisable to turn into the outer course and so east to Vik. It is good to drive home with a safe waggon.' And there is the chance of a voyage to Bergen if we should think there is something to be got there. The project is not very desirable, but I can promise the Birkibeins encouragement; however, I will not exhort you very much." The Birkibeins all preferred to sail to Bergen, deeming it an excellent thing to capture something from the Heklungs. Then the King despatched some cutters into Ulfa-sound, but himself sailed by the high seas to Aleyiar-sound. In Ulfa-sound the Birkibeins captured two cutters of the Heklungs that had been on the look-out, and slew nearly all on board; to some they gave quarter, and obtained information from them. They said that three cutters were lying in Aleyiar-sound on the look-out; that there was a fire-beacon south on Ha-ey, and a second farther in on Fenhring, visible both from the northern beacon and from the town. They told them also that the whole of King Magnus's host slept in the town, and in which house each great man passed the night. They said that the whole force had no thought of danger, and all the ships floated under awning in front of the quays. Then King Sverri's men came to him with these tidings. And as they sailed over the sounds from the north, King Sverri sent forward a force on the two cutters taken from the Heklungs; on their stems were bound shields that were the most easily recognised as having belonged to Heklungs. These cutters went

south; and when they sailed towards the fiord south of the Drifeys, the Heklungs saw them, and immediately recognising them and the shields, supposed their fellows to be there, and took no further heed. They only discovered them to be foes when they came on with the speed of fire in the sound. The Birkibeins hurled spears and missiles; the Heklungs sprang on shore, but some were slain. The Birkibeins now seized the cutters and everything on them, and waited there for the King. After that, the King's fleet rowed south along their route, and when they advanced into the sound he again sent forward the cutters taken from the Heklungs, and bade the men seize the beacon on the Ha-ey. But the Birkibeins were too eager, and rowed south faster than the King wished; and the watchman seeing them, set fire to his beacon, However, the fire was not seen at the southern beacon, for the Birkibeins came up swiftly, seized the man, and broke down the beacon. The King's men rowed south quite close to the shore, so as to keep within the shadow of the fells on the sea.

2.247

Before they rowed to Holdhella the King conversed with his force, and said, "No part of our plan has yet failed; it is possible for us to run south past the town, and so spring beyond their horns' reach." But his men all declared they were more eager to sail to the town. And the King answered that he would not prevent them. "It is likely," he said, "that the Heklungs will be of little use in defence of their King if they are roused up drowsy and drunk; and they will be terrified when we make a din at their doors. We shall thus arrange the attack. Eirik, my brother, shall row up to the rock with the ten largest cutters, and there land his men. They shall march with his standard beyond Kristskirk yard, and forward into the King's court. I will row past Holm to the quays, and aim at the ships. We shall land straightway, some south of the Sand-bridge, some beyond Miklagarth and up in Mariukirk yard, some beyond Petrskirk yard, and so march up the street. Ûlf of Laufness shall row to the head of the bay with two cutters,

and land there with his standard. Thence he will march along the street to meet those who dee that way; and sound the trumpets there.”

2.248

Flight of King Magnus from Bergen, and victory of the Birkibeins.

2.249

77. King Sverri now began the attack as arranged. The men struck in their oars, and rowed with all their might to the quays, where the long-ships lay; they cut the cables, and pushed the ships away from the quays; and the ships floated out into the bay, for there were no watchmen on board. The Birkibeins now sprang on the quays, set up the Kings standard and raised the war-cry. Then they rushed into the town to the houses where they knew they would find Heklungs; the whole multitude of whom took to flight, and many were slain. When King Sverri came up to Mariukirk he found there Jon Hallkelsson, who begged for quarter; and the King granted quarter to him and his two sons, Rognvald and Hallkel. The King then turned along the street [towards the Holm]; and some of his companies went [towards the head of the bay] along the quays, cutting the cables of merchant-ships and long-ships, so that the bay was full of them. Ulf and his company from the head of the bay turned along the street; they slew many, and met with no resistance. When Eirik and his detachment landed on [the northern side of] the Holm, they heard a loud war-cry in the town, and supposed that the Heklungs must have obtained intelligence, and were offering resistance. They knew that if King Magnus were prepared, it would be a desperate task to fight with him, for he had a large host in the town. Nevertheless they hastened up, raised the war-cry, and ran beyond Kristskirk yard.

2.250

King Magnus was passing the night in the hall with all his body-guard and the King's company. He was out on the balcony when he heard the first war-cry from the town, and he ran forward along the balcony to Postolakirk. He heard here the second war-cry from Kristskirk yard, and sprang over the balcony into the [Postolakirk] yard, a leap of

wonderful depth. Hence he proceeded past Bishops-court, and so above the Veisa, and above the Kopr, and inland above Nikolaskirk, where he was joined by his men. They passed along the upper road until they came to Olafskirk, where his force collected.

2.251

The Birkibeins had not ransacked the town, for they wished to get quickly to the Kings-court. As King Sverri's standard reached the Kings-court from the town, another standard came fast towards them along the court, and the two bands exchanged shots. A fight was imminent when King Sverri's men recognised Eirik Kings-son's men, and all together turned to the hall and made a fierce onset. King Magnus's men defended themselves with weapons and oven-stones. The fight was long, and many brave fellows were slain; but when they found that King Magnus was not there, King Sverri gave quarter to all that asked. —

2.252

Archbishop Eystein was with his ship on the other side of the bay at Jons-quays. His men sprang on shore with their weapons, and proceeded to Jons-fields, intending to assist King Magnus; but the Birkibeins met them, slew thirty men of them, and drove all the others back. Many of those who escaped were wounded. Two of the Archbishop's kinsmen were slain, Olaf Langi and Gudbrand Thorbergsson.

2.253

Hallvard Marar-drap and Pal Eiriksson of Updale fell at the King's Hall.

2.254

When King Magnus arrived above Nunnusetr a large body of his troops came about him, and the King asked if they thought good to turn back to the town and fight; he was told, he said, that the Birkibeins' force was small. But many answered him that it was not good for weaponless men to go to battle; there was scarcely a man of them fully armed, and many were thinly clad, for they had sprung out of their beds in haste; moreover, the King had no standard and no trumpet. Such being their

condition, they thought they were unfit for fight. They then turned south to Strind, and thence into Hardangr. Here they obtained a few cutters and ferry-boats. Many afterwards sailed south coast-wise day and night, and thus the King was followed by a large part of his force; some who were slow in leaving the town, turned up past Alreksteads, thence north over the fell to Ostrarfiord, and up into Yors; then they marched by the land road north through Sogn to Valdres, and all the way by the road east to Vik.

2.255

King Sverri recovers the ships. Reconciliation with Archbishop Eystein. King Magnus goes to Denmark.

2.256

78. King Sverri took in Bergen all King Magnus's fleet, and all his most famous treasures; the crown and gold wand which he carried when anointed King, and all his coronation robes. His men shared much booty among themselves. Archbishop Eystein had arrived from England early in the summer, having been there for three years, absent from his see. He now made peace with King Sverri, and sailed north in the summer to his see. When Jon Hallkelsson and his sons came before King Sverri, he bade them depart in peace wherever they would; north to their homesteads, or east after King Magnus. They begged that they might join King Sverri, but he objected.— "Twice already," he said, "you have sworn fealty to me, and neither time have you kept your oaths." Nevertheless they swore the third time to be loyal to King Sverri, and shortly afterwards they sailed away east to King Magnus.

2.257

King Sverri sailed after King Magnus as far east as Agdi, but they did not meet at this time, so he turned back to Bergen and abode there for a while. King Magnus sailed south to Denmark in the summer to visit King Valdamar, and thus fled out of the country the second time from the face of King Sverri

2.258

The yeomen of Sogn slay King Sverri's bailiffs.

2.259

79. King Sverri appointed his men to bailiwicks over all Rogaland and Hordaland, and sent Ivar Dapi as bailiff to Inner Sogn. The following autumn he sailed north to Throntham with all his force, and abode there during the winter. When King Sverri was gone away north, the men of Sogn showed no liking for his bailiffs. Shortly before Yule the bailiffs demanded contributions for the Yule feast which they intended to keep in Lusa-Kaupang. But the townsmen were indignant at this; and when the men of Soknadale and the Eid gathered together and marched to the market-town, arriving there on the evening of Yule, they were joined by the townsmen in an attack upon the King's bailiffs. The leaders in this evil design were Arathor of Hval, Isak Thorgilsson, and the sons of Priest Algeir, Gaut and Karlshofud. Ivar Dapi sued for quarter, and offered to leave the place with all his men. The yeomen refused, and fell upon them, slaying the bailiffs and well-nigh all their company. Some saved their lives by flight, and went north overland to King Sverri. They told him these tidings, and that the men of Sogn claimed to have slain thieves and evil-doers, and reckoned them among those for whom no weregild need be paid.

2.260

Launch of the Mariusud.

2.261

80. The same summer in which King Sverri captured the ships in Bergen the Mariusud was all finished; and in the autumn he had the ship launched. The ship was built above the town, and people said it could not possibly be launched without the destruction of houses. The King, they said, had displayed much self-will and arrogance in the building of the ship, and many foretold evil of it. But when the launch took place the King's foresight and judgment were proved, for the ship glided down, and there was no need to demolish houses or buildings. As the ship moved forward from the stocks into the river some of its joints opened. In the winter, while the ship was building in Kaupang, it happened that King Sverri sailed south to Moeri, and on his return he

found nine strakes finished on each side; and when he saw the work he said, "This ship is much less spacious than I wish to see; it must be cut in two and a length of twelve ells laid in the keel." The shipbuilder objected, but the King's will prevailed; thus there were many joints in the boards near the bottom of the ship, and when it was launched some of them opened. King Sverri was on board when the ship came into the water, and he stood up and thus spoke: "Praised be God, and the Holy Virgin Maria, and King Olaf the Saint, that this ship has reached the water in safety, doing damage to none. Many thought and uttered unfriendly things of us about it, which may God forgive them. It is my firm opinion that there are not many here who have seen a long-ship afloat on the water so large as this one. It will be a strong defence to the land from our foes, if good fortune attend it I commit this ship to the care and keeping of the Holy Maria, and name it Mariusud; and I pray that the Holy Virgin Maria will keep watch and guard over it And in token hereof, I devote to Maria precious gifts better suited to God's service; mass-robles, in which the Archbishop will be gloriously arrayed on festivals, if he will wear them. And I hope, in return, that she will look on these gifts with favour, and grant her help and good fortune to the ship and the crew, and to all who sail upon it" In the carved beaks of the ship, both fore and aft, the King caused holy relics to be placed; also he divided the mass-robles, sending the cope to Mariukirk, the gown to Helgasetr, and all the other robes to Nunnusetr, in Bakki. The Mariusud was not a graceful ship, the prow and the stem being short in comparison with the middle; this was chiefly because of the part that had been added. The damage done at the launch the King ordered to be repaired.

2.262

During the winter the King caused several long-ships to be built, and others to be repaired. The Hialp, Thorolf Bympil's ship, was now built; it had twenty-six cabins for rowers. Also the Vidsia, which in the number of cabins was almost as large; this ship was commanded by Ulf of Laufness.

2.263

King Sverri sets out from Nidaros on a voyage to Sogn [1134].

2.264

81. In the spring, when Easter was past, King Sverri prepared to sail south from Kaupang with twenty-three ships, mostly of great size. He was accompanied by his brother Eirik, Ulf of Laufness, Ulf Fly, Bard Guthormsson. Ivar Silki, Havard Earlsson; and they had with them a fine and numerous force. King Sverri commanded the Mariusud and two hundred and eighty men were counted on board of her. Three chests were sent on board by the King, each requiring four men to carry it, and no one knew exactly what was in them. Eirik Kings-son commanded the Oskmev, a ship with twenty-five cabins for rowers, or thereabouts. King Sverri sailed south with his force, keeping close to land; and in Steinavoe the King held a council and spoke in these terms: that he had no intelligence of King Magnus which would lead them to expect immediate hostilities; and he bade his men be gentle and peaceful, to listen carefully to what those near them said, whether they were of high or low degree, that they might be able to tell him all strange news, though it should appear to them of small import. The speech was short and eloquent. Among the Hereys the King held a second council, and spoke in quite the same terms as before. Thence they sailed south past Stad, where they met with a fresh wind with rough weather ahead, which greatly strained the Mariusud and made her joints give way. The King turned into Ulfasound; and while they lay there his men discovered what he had in the large chests, for he took spike-nails out to distribute among the ships. He also placed nails in each half-cabin, and bade the men in it to be on the watch and make use of them whenever there was need. King Sverri now proceeded on his voyage south and arrived at Sogn-Sea; here he informed his men that he would turn into Sogn, and claim weregild for his bailiffs, slain by the men of Sogn. Some of his men requested they might go on to Bergen, having business there; and as the King had no expectation of any sudden hostile attack, he permitted all to go who asked. Three

ships sailed south, over which Svina-Petr was put in command. The men now changed from ship to ship; those sailed south who had business to do, and others took their places in the cabins.

2.265

King Sverri fires the homesteads of the men of Sogn, in Soknadale.

2.266

82. King Sverri turned into Sogn, having with him twenty ships. He lay first at Rusli, whence he sent into Soknadale bidding the yeomen to come to him if they wished to be at peace with him, and he fixed Hvamsey as the place of meeting. Thither the King then sailed; and the yeomen met him and pledged themselves to pay compensation to the King. He condemned them to pay fifteen marks of gold, and summoned a meeting in three days' time, when the money should be paid. The yeomen sailed home and told how they had sped on their journey. And being ill-pleased, the yeomen all together formed a plan, and agreed to use the time which the King had given them, to remove all their property to the fells and woods, leaving all their homesteads deserted. When the appointed time was past, and the King found that the yeomen would disregard the summons, he weighed anchor and sailed up the fiord. Having reached the point where the fiord divides, he sent forward Ulf of Laufness and Thorolf Rympil with six ships to Lusa-Kaupang, bidding them "warm the bath-rooms there, and take such wages-as they wished" And this is the story of their voyage: they came to Lusa-Kaupang, stripped it of all the property they found, and burnt the market-town; but not a man did they take. King Sverri, with fourteen ships, turned into Norafiord and anchored close to Soknadale; this was on Wednesday, in the evening. On Thursday, in the morning, he summoned his force by trumpet to a conference, and told them his purpose. He bade the men arm themselves and inarch up the dale; two from each half-cabin should go, and one remain behind to guard the ships. Then he commanded to select the men from all the ships, and thus spoke: "You that go, go warily whenever you approach the woods or where there are hiding-places, lest you suffer injury from their

arrows. Slay only those that lie in ambush to attack you, and lay hands on property wherever you find it. If the yeomen avoid meeting us, and will not come to terms, they must expect, when we go away hence, to find fires to warm their backs, and smith's coals where now their homesteads lie. Let not a cottage stand anywhere; take care only of the churches wherever you can. Act like war-men, since you are bidden; for many at such times behave with violence, which I forbid under penalty of life or limb." The standard was now set up and the Guards began their march, the whole crowd eagerly following. The King then looked round and saw there was scarcely a man left behind at the ships; and he called out saying, "Let not the troops go on shore and leave the ships bare, to give our foes the opportunity of capturing them from us, for with much labour and danger we acquired them." But the people were so impetuous that scarcely one behaved as if he heard what the King said. Then the King himself went down to the ships and caused them to lie out at anchor, as there were few men on them. When the Birkibeins marched up the dale they perceived neither man nor cattle; wherever they came the buildings were all deserted. They marched up the dale on Thursday, and the following night they found a man who gave them the information that all the folk had fled with their cattle to the fells and moors. On Friday, just before sunrise, the Birkibeins turned back to go down the dale, and when some of them came to the homestead that lay highest up the dale they set fire to it and burnt it. Seeing this, those who were marching lower down did just the same; and so one after another they set fire to the buildings near them. The wind was light, and there was so much smoke when the whole village began to burn nearly at the same time, that it stretched from house to house all over the dale. Thus the Birkibeins passed right down the whole dale, and last of all they burnt Stedia. Here they remained a long time, because the church was in danger from the fire, and they stretched sails in front which they moistened; but when the buildings had fallen in, the troops all returned to the ships. Ten tens of homesteads that formed a very pleasant village were there burnt. The

King then caused the ships to be moved away to Hugastrand, on the other side, and they anchored at a place called Fimreiti.

2.267

King Magnus leaves Denmark, and visits Konunga-hella and Tunsberg.

2.268

83. We must now speak of King Magnus. After passing the winter in Denmark, he sailed in the spring to the Vik from the south. Wednesday in Easter week, Asbiom Jonsson, of the King's body-guard, arrived at Konunga-hella. A meeting was summoned, and he spoke, saying that the town might expect a visit from King Magnus; and he urged the necessity of receiving him heartily, for the King wished to make friends of all the folk of the land that were willing to show him honour or any reverence. He said also that the Danish King had greatly strengthened him with a numerous force, and had promised him yet more support; and that King Magnus expected friendly help from all the chiefs in the east of the land. "In return, he promises you a large grant," said Asbiom, "and his protection, if his rule grows in strength." He delivered his message eloquently, and there was loud applause at his speech.

2.269

The Lord's day after Easter week, King Magnus arrived at the town with twenty-four ships; a procession was formed to meet him, and he was received with much joy. Afterwards he went into the town and was entertained at the house of the lady named Ragnhild. There were with him many barons: Orm Kings-brother, Munan Gautsson, Hallkel Jonsson, Asbiom Jonsson, Harald, son of King Ingi, and many other great men. The King held frequent councils and spoke; he was a good speaker, and his speeches were usually short. They all listened to his speeches with pleasure; and after he had stayed three weeks in the town he set sail for Tunsberg. From Konunga-hella the King obtained two Icelandic trading ships, one was called Keipa, the other Vallabuza.

2.270

King Magnus's speech to the men of Tunsberg.

2.271

84. King Magnus had a hearty reception at Tunsberg. Many men came to him from the surrounding country, and he held a council, at which he spoke and said: "It must be known to you what great worries and afflictions we have suffered in the realm; and now I would ask some help from you that we may win it. I will promise you in return that I shall not need henceforth to lay this tax often upon you. It is not surprising if men are tired of the levy for service at sea with us, for oftentimes it has been fraught with danger. But forasmuch as I was anointed and crowned King over this land, therefore before God I dare not break the oaths which then I swore, and I will lay claim to this land with spear and sword, so long as life shall last and the people of the land will support me. There is another course I might follow, one that would bring me an easier life and less danger: I could accept a fief and emoluments from my kinsman King Valdamar." The King's speech was received with great applause, and they all declared as with one mouth that they would serve and follow him; better to die with him, a rightful King, than serve that priest who had no title by birth to be King. The men of Tunsberg supplied the King with a long-ship well manned by the townsmen. He stayed there half a month and then sailed north, the wind making his progress slow.

2.272

Of the Icelandic poet Mani and King Magnus.

2.273

85. King Magnus and his fleet lay for a week at Unnardys, in Lista. The poet Mani was with the King at this time, and he recited a verse: —

2.274

"Thou bounteous King of the sun's high seat,
We pray Thee grant to this great host
Quick breeze to Bergen.

2.275

It angers us that here at Unnardys
A north-west blast keeps back our men.

2.276

O'er-slow to the sound comes southern wind."

2.277

"Well recited, Tungli," said the King; and he commanded that the poet should have a kirtle, one of many which lay there in a heap, having been washed.

2.278

The King was on the frontier of the land, in the east, when Mani came to him, just returned from Rome in the condition of a beggar. The King was in the sitting-room with his train when he entered. Mani was not a handsome man at the time, for he had a shaven crown and was almost naked, yet he knew how to greet the King courteously. The King asked who he was. "My name is Mani," he answered, "and I am an Icelander just come from Rome, in the south. And the King said, "You must surely be acquainted with old-time stories, Tungli; sit down and recite one." So Mani recited the *Utfarar-drapa*, which Halldor Skvaldri composed in honour of King Sigurd Jorsala-fari, grandfather of King Magnus on the mothers side. The poem was received with great applause, and seemed to afford great pleasure. Now, there were two jugglers in the sitting-room. They had some little dogs, trained to jump over a stick when in presence of men of rank, and the nobler the spectator the higher the jump the dogs would make. "Do you see, Tungli," said the King, "what little account the jugglers make of you? Compose a verse on them, you may possibly be rather a gainer by it." Then Mani recited: —

2.279

"With fiddle and pipe the cunning fellow fares,
The juggler brings his scurrilous gestures here,
Over the rail he makes the red dog lean
To amuse the men. A merry show indeed!

2.280

Pray stop his horrid shout, men should not listen."

2.281

And again he recited: —

2.282

“The fiddle sounds, they strut, they grip the pipe,
The chalk-faced fellows their foolish antics play;
'Tis wonderful to watch the rolling eyes
Of him that sounds the trump, and then to see
The rascal's puckered chops and cheeks blown out!”

2.283

This produced great laughter, and the Guardsmen formed a ring round the jugglers, reciting the verse, ever repeating oftenest of all the words, “chops and cheeks blown out.” The jugglers felt much like being roasted, and escaped from the sitting-room. But the King took Mani to himself, and afterwards had him in his company until they reached Bergen.

2.284

King Magnus at Bergen. He days the Birkibeins whom he finds there.

2.285

86. On its voyage north the fleet lay for two or three days at a time in the same harbour. King Magnus's men were very merry, and wherever they were delayed, spent much of the time in games; but the King usually spoke little. They lay two days in Karmsound; here they obtained accurate tidings of King Sverri's movements from the merchants who came from the north. Thereupon the King despatched Eilif Orri, son of Clement of Grafdale, to Bergen, on the look-out. He sailed away on the Tuesday night, and came back to the King on the Wednesday with the news that there were three ships of the Birkibeins in the town, under the command of Svina-Petr. King Magnus bade his men take down the awnings with all speed, and start off on the voyage. “The Birkibeins are in Bergen,” he said, “and doubtless want a drinking bout with you; they will think you ought to pour out the drink for them.” When his men heard this they were glad; they hoisted the sails and used the oars, for there was a side-wind, accompanied with rain. King Magnus commanded the Skeggi, Orm Kings-brother the

Skialdmey; Nikolas Kufung had the Erkisud, which the Archbishop had given him, a ship of twenty benches; Munan Gautsson had the Hrein, and the Gests the great Fley, a Baltic trader. The wind now began to rise high, and the mast of Munan's ship broke, killing a man who was under it. On the prow of the Kings ship was a man named Thoraldi Thrym, and he said, "The front decks are all wet, and the rain drives over the prows; the men in the fore part think a slower pace would be better." The King stood up and answered, "I knew not that fires should be kindled in the prows;" and he bade that not a sail should be reefed, but every rope strained to the utmost. On Thursday, half-way between mid-day and nones, the King sailed into the bay; the men went straight to the quays and sprang on shore. They were messengers of woe to the Birkibeins, who had no intelligence of King Magnus's movements. They sprang up where each happened to be, some to their weapons, and all out of the town, as many as escaped with life. It was as if one saw a fire, to look up at the fell red with shields. Well-nigh thirty men were slain, some in the town, others above it. The Heklungs quickly stripped the dead of their clothes. King Magnus ordered that no one should have the audacity to bury the bodies before he came back to the town; and declared it their rightful due, to be left to raven and to dog. The King summoned an Assembly, at which he himself spoke, and said, "Here we look for troops and assistance from the men of this town; in former times you so aided both me and my father. Here I made my home continually while we were able to live in peace, and here are nearly all my kinsmen and foster-brothers. My first business now is to try if an encounter between me and Sverri can be brought about; and, after we separate, I 'purpose to come here to the town with peace and joy for us all." Great applause followed his speech. "God give you a safe return, Sire," said they all; "may you win in this voyage all that you desire." The King then went away to his ships, and gave the signal for departure. It is said that crows flocked to the King's ship in such numbers that every rope was covered; so marvellous a sight had never been seen before. In the evening King Magnus left the town with all his

fleet, except the Gesta-Fley which had grounded; it left the town in the night.

2.286

King Magnus sails north into Sogn to find King Sverri.

2.287

87. King Magnus sailed through the sounds on his voyage north and turned into Sogn-Sea. The wind was light. When the men of Sogn heard of his coming many rowed out in boats to meet him, and going on board his ships, sailed on the voyage with him. They told him the tidings that King Sverri had sent off many of his troops, all the bravest of them, and himself lay in Norafiord with few ships, after doing much evil there. These tidings were a great joy to many, and they said that at last the struggle was bound to end, for it was God's will to overthrow that riotous band, the author of so much evil in Norway that the land must wait long for a recovery. There was a distinguished man, named Ivar Elda, who lived at Syrstrand. He was seated at table when King Magnus's ships were seen sailing past. He rose up at once and went to his ship, then rowed out to the King's ship and went on board. The King welcomed him heartily, and Ivar went with him. King Magnus proceeded to the place where the fiord divides, and then turned into Norafiord. He had with him twenty-six ships, almost all large, and well equipped with men and weapons.

2.288

King Sverri's preparations for battle, and his speech to his men.

2.289

88. We must now tell of King Sverri. On the Friday after he had burnt the homesteads in Soknadale, he lay off Haugastrand, near a place called Fimreiti. He had twelve ships with him, two having remained behind in Soknadale. It was the hour of nones, and he sat at meat, and there were watchmen on the look-out opposite the King's ship. When the men had sat a while at meat King Sverri heard the watch say that they saw several ships sailing towards them along the Sogn-Sea. Sometimes they saw six or seven; but when the ships were more

scattered and sailed farther apart, ten or twelve could be seen. The watchmen were discussing what ships these might be: some said they were ferry-ships which the men of Sogn must have brought in a fleet from Bergen; others said the sails were more like those of long-ships. When the King heard this talking he rose up from the table and went on shore to the watch, followed by others from the ships. Each man now gave his own opinion what ships they were. The King stood up a while, looked at them, and then said, "We must not hide from ourselves that this is an enemy; those are certainly the sails of long-ships." Then he summoned all his men straightway to land; and when they were come together he began to speak, and thus said: —

2.290

"It may happen again to us Birkibeins, as it has happened before, to have work upon our hands. For there is no use hiding from ourselves, it seems to me, that King Magnus will soon come to visit us. You all know that a large part of our force has gone away from us: some south to Bergen, and what fate has befallen them is in God's hands: others to the market-town to burn it, and they can afford us no help. And though when encounters have occurred with King Magnus we have often been inferior in numbers, yet I expect, if we await him here, we shall most likely never have had to face greater odds than now. I will, therefore, that we now take counsel together: shall we offer resistance with such force as we have, or do you think it better to abandon the ships and go on shore? You will doubtless feel that we have not made good friends of the people that dwell here in Sogn. Our condition is clear if we leave the ships; wherever we go King Magnus and his force will march after us, and the whole multitude of the inhabitants with him. And to tell the truth, considering the great labour and difficulty I endured before obtaining these ships, it seems certain that if I should now lose them I will never again attempt to acquire ships in Norway, and every one of us will have to look to himself. Now, I do not wish to lead you, by any self-will of mine, into such great danger, if you all see

that it should not be done; but if the men of our force think it better to offer resistance, I shall not falter through fear.”

2.291

When the King finished his speech his men thought they perceived what he desired, and it seemed good to all of them to applaud what they saw to be his wish, although they did not see the promise of success. And now well-nigh all at once answered, and said they certainly wished for battle, and never without a contest would submit to flight, for which there was no cause whatever. They had constantly fought against great odds, they said, and yet won victory. And the King answered: “You have now chosen the course which is the more agreeable to my mind; and I may tell you something which will make you more eager to fight, and more valiant — you will send this day a king to his grave.” This speech caused great anxiety to many: “Which King would it be?” Then King Sverri commanded the awnings to be taken, down, and the ships to be rowed up the fiord close to land. “A cutter,” he said, “shall row with all speed up to Soknadales to our ships there, and bid them come to us. Of the three men in each half-cabin, let one sit at the oar, a second row in boats to land and fetch stones, the third, as well as all others who are free, prepare the ships and set up the war-bulwarks.” It was done as the King commanded; they took the nails which the King had given them, fastened rings of walrus hide all round the inner part of the ships’ sides, fixed in them the supports, and attached the war-bulwarks. Every man was now busily engaged, and it was easy to see that the Birkibeings were practised in such labour. The men sent with the cutter up the fiord met their comrades rowing down, and told them the rumour; and the crews of the long-ships bestirred themselves, struck in their oars and rowed with all their might. As they approached the fleet they came so close to each other, rowing in eager strife, that the oars collided and broke. “There is other business than smashing oars that you must see to,” said the King. And he bade them turn to shore, there to wait for King Magnus. Stones were then brought from land, as many as they wished, and the ships’

war-bulwarks set up. The King now commanded the stem-cables of all the ships to be brought on board, the prows to be turned seawards, and the oars placed for rowing. The King's ship lay close to the strand, nearest the entrance of the fiord. Then the King bade his men arm themselves and take their places in the cabins.

2.292

King Sverri went on shore and walked up to a little brook; here the King had water given him to wash his hands, and had his clothes brushed as if he were about to attend a banquet. His dress was all dark-brown. After this he went down to the rock under which his ship lay, and spoke a few words. He laid hold of the ship's prow, but his men removed his hands because the tar on the beak was not dry. And the King said: "Our ships shall not be tied together. We must reap advantage, if we can, from this, that our bulwarks are high, our men are bold and keen in fight. There is only one expedient whereby we may retain life — we must prove superior to our foes; flight will not avail us, nor yet begging for peace. Look to your weapons, and let no missile be thrown in vain from the ships. Defend yourselves first, let each man protect his neighbour, and may God protect us all." Then he commanded the standards to be set up. Alongside the ships a little cliff jutted forward and almost prevented a view of the mouth of the fiord. He therefore sent a cutter to look out for King Magnus's fleet; and after the oarsmen had rowed a few strokes from land they pulled back with half as much speed again, saying that the fleet was sailing in upon them. Straightway the trumpet sounded, and the Birkibeins began to row out all their ships to meet them, and raised the war-cry. The Mariusud was steered by Thord, brother of Finngeir.

2.293

King Magnus's speech to his men before the battle.

2.294

89. King Magnus now entered the fiord in pursuit of the Birkibeins. And when his men knew they were within a short distance, they lowered their sails and let the ships run under bare poles, keeping close

together. The Heklungs had put on their armour and were ready for battle. King Magnus then made a speech to them and said: —

2.295

“These large merchant-ships in our fleet are not fitted for rowing. Let them be tied between my ship and Orm’s. We shall row towards the big ship and attach ourselves to it; and I should not like the ships to be loosed until either theirs is cleared or ours. I, know that to many, in thought and speech, the result would appear good, if brought about, that Sverri and I should no more both need to demand these war contributions. And I think such result, dear to my mind and hope, might well be asked from God. I was five years old when the chiefs and folk of this land gave me the name of King, and seven years old when consecrated King by the Legate from Rome and Archbishop Eystein, assisted by all the people’s bishops of this land. I was then so much of a child that I could be master of neither word nor oath, and I thought it better to join in games with other young boys than to sit among chiefs. I strove not for the kingdom, and little pleasure and ease have I had in the kingdom. Now I am eight-and-twenty years old, and during the last eight my rule has been my own loss, and a loss to all the people of the land. But may God reward my men and the chiefs and the whole people for the loving help they have given me in many dangers. There is no need for me to urge you with words; you can all see our need that every one should do his manliest. We have abundant means; we have no lack of troops; God be praised, that wherever we touched land, men have joined our ranks. Sverri has now scattered his forces here and there, and has now but few men left with him, and they are enclosed here before us, in the fiord, like sheep in a pen. May God grant such an end to this encounter that we may have peace and freedom from our enemies hereafter, whether we remain alive or die.”

2.296

His speech was received with great applause. “Well spoken, thou best of kings,” they all cried at once; “may God give thee to tread down thy enemies.” Then Orm Kings-brother spoke: “I would advise, Sire, that

we attack first of all the smaller ships where we shall meet with little resistance. I expect the big ship will be difficult to win, so long as there is both a plentiful force of ships, and of men from the other ships, to help it." The King replied: "It seems to me as if all the ships are won if the big ship is won." So they did as the King commanded; the four ships were tied together, and the King's ship sailed nearest the south shore.

2.297

Speech of Asbiorn Jonsson before the battle.

2.298

90. Asbiorn Jonsson laid his ship alongside Orm's ship, and the two were fastened together. Then Asbiorn spoke: —

2.299

"The day is now come that we have all longed for, when Sverri and the Birkibeins are here in front of us, forced like sheep into a pen. There is an end now to his sleights and his tricks, for the Fiend, in whom he trusts, and by whom his counsels are inspired, will now fail him. Such is the Fiend's way with his friends. He grants them prosperity for a time, and fails them at their life's end. Sverri is now shiftless. He sent Svina-Petr away south to Bergen, an errand whereon he met his deserts. Others, the Gests, the worst of his men limbs of the Fiend, he sent into Sogn, under one who has done most evil, Ulf, the peasant's son. And now Sverri has added to his own evil deeds and violence the only evil he had hitherto left undone, for he has wasted with fire a Christian land; and he shall now pay for it. Let us set on these Birkibeins, two or three on one if it makes the work lighter; and let us deal heavy strokes at all before us, careless where the blows fall, for we use no care in chopping meat for dogs or ravens. As for their souls, let the men of Soknadale show them where to go." Great applause followed this speech, all saying that he had spoken well. Afterwards they fastened the ships together in fours or fives, and by means of oars on the outer side of the end ships rowed them all together side by side into the fiord near the southern shore.

2.300

King Magnus wore a kirtle of scarlet that was parti-coloured, half white, half red; and a kirtle of the same colour and cloth was worn by Magnus Mangi, son of Eirik Stagbrell. The King carried a sword that was named Fish-back, the sharpest of all swords.

2.301

Battle of Norafjord. Attack on ike Mariusud [15 th June 1184].

2.302

91. We will now relate some events that occurred in the encounter between the two Kings, of which somewhat has been already said. We return to the Birkibeins. As they rowed from land they saw King Magnus's fleet coming upon them, and there was an appearance in front of it such as is seen at sea when heavy rain falls during a calm. This shower soon passed over; it was a flight of arrows, and they had need of their shields. When they would turn the Mariusud, she described a large curve, and before she could be fully turned, the ships ran into one another. King Magnus's ships came against the bows of the Mariusud, striking her in the side, and the prows of the King's ships were turned towards her. The Skeggi lay against her fore pump-room, and the others in succession towards her prow, as they found place. Then a great and fierce battle began, King Magnus's men being very eager, and the Birkibeins keeping rather under shelter, while all the ships drifted together towards the strand. The Birkibeins at first were hampered in the attack as the Mariusud lay between them and King Magnus's ships. Thereupon King Sverri sprang into a boat, with one man, and rowed to Eirik Kingsson's ship. The King then called to them and said they were behaving wretchedly and timidly, and he bade them row forth past the big ship and aim at the smaller ships of the Heklungs, and try what they could effect. Bowing from ship to ship, the King incited his men, and told them where they should attack. The King's words had a good effect on the Birkibeins, and they pressed forward boldly, and made a fierce onset, which was returned in full by the others. Both sides now made use of every missile at hand. As the King rowed back to his ship, an arrow passed over his head and struck

the prow of the boat; then a second, directly afterwards, struck the boat's side above his knees. The King sat and moved not. "A dangerous shot, Sire," said his companion. "Comes near when God wills," answered the King. So thick was now the shower of weapons and stones upon the Mariusud that the King found he could not get back on board, and he rowed away to land. Munan Gautsson's men drove their ship to land, and leapt ashore, and threw great quantities of stone on the Mariusud, all about the fore-room and forward to the pump-room, and those who were there stationed suffered severely. The men in the prow were the most exposed to the onslaught of the Heklungs and the shower of missiles, and they said to one another that the fore-room men ought now to pay the King for their mead and kirtle-cloth. The men in the stem now called to the starboard oarsmen to row forward. This was done, and the ship was moved so that the Skeggi now lay opposite the aft pump-room. All the men of the larboard side and the fore-room men had enough to do, for there lay fourteen ships against one side of the Mariusud. The Heklungs then shot bolts, and threw spears and lumps of hard whetstone which they had brought from the east with them, from Skida, very dangerous to life. They cast also short swords and palstaves, but were not so near as to fight hand to hand. The Birkibeins sheltered themselves, unable to do more; yet many fell, and almost all were wounded by missiles or stones. They were so wearied and harassed that some who were unwounded, or but slightly wounded, yet died of exhaustion. But the Heklungs delayed to board the ship because of the difficulty in reaching her over the prows of their own ships; whereas if the ships had been placed alongside, one of the crews might have boarded the other's ship long before.

2.303

Battle of Norafjord. Eirik Kings-soris exploit.

2.304

92. Now those who listen to this story will regard what we say of the end of the battle as improbable; yet we shall now tell what most availed, with good fortune, to turn the victory in a direction that

seemed unlikely. Eirik Kings-son and the thirteen free ships of the Birkibeins rowed out past the big ship, as we have said above, and turned to the thirteen' ships of the Heklungs which, were the farthest from land and were not near the big ship. They laid the ships broadside to broadside, and a very hard fight took place. The Birkibeins had the larger ships and the more numerous force, and attacked with firmness and valour. The Heklungs offered a hard resistance, and fought so keenly that no one seemed able to judge whether the fight would be decided between them, or the big ship be cleared, the first. The men of Sogn had a great multitude of boats, and lay within range of the Birkibeins and shot at them. Eirik Kings-son placed his ship alongside the outermost one of those that had been tied together, and as his ship had much the higher bulwarks there was a very sharp fight, for the Heklungs resisted valiantly. A hand-to-hand contest having lasted for a time, the Heklungs were overborne by numbers; some fell, and others abandoned their half-cabins. Then the Birkibeins prepared to board the ship. A man named Benedikt, Eirik Kings-son's standard-bearer, was the first to go up, and with him were the forecastle men. The Heklungs seeing them, rushed to meet them, and slew Benedikt and others who had boarded the ship. Then Kings-son urged on his men, and himself and a few others resolved on a second attempt to board the ship. They were able to recover their standard, and made so fierce an onset that the Heklungs recoiled and sprang upon the ship that lay nearest. The Birkibeins followed hard after them. And now happened what constantly happens when fear seizes men in battle and they flee; seldom are the fugitives inclined to face the enemy a second time, however valiant their resistance at first. There was less resistance here than on the former ship; all leapt to the ship that was nearest, and so from one to another. The Birkibeins, shouting and crying after them, smote and slew every one that came in their way. And when the mass of fugitives rushed to the large ships, men leapt into the water from the King's ship because it lay nearest the land. But other four ships,

which were the largest, sank under the weight of the crowd. Thus sank Orm's ship, and Asbiom's ship, and the Gesta-Fley.

2.305

Battle of Norafjord. Death of King Magnus.

2.306

93. King Sverri was on land when he saw what was happening, and he went down to the boat with Petr, son of Bishop Hroi. The same moment a cutter rowed up, the crew intending to land. The King called to them, and said, "Turn back, see now they flee." The men did so, turned back, and seeing what has been told, struck in their oars and rowed away down the fiord. Petr said to the King, "Did you know these men, Sire? Why spoke you so?" And the King answered, "Was it not the only thing to say, whoever they were?" The King then rowed out straight to his ship, went to the aftcastle and began the Kyrie to celebrate his victory; and all his men sung it with him.

2.307

King Magnus leapt overboard from his ship, together with all the troops on it, and the whole host of them perished. The Birkibeins sprang on shore and met on the beach those who strove to reach land, so that no great number of them succeeded; a few cutters sailed down the fiord and their crews escaped. The Birkibeins rowed out in small boats and slew those who were swimming, but to some they gave quarter. All were spared who obtained audience of the King; and King Sverri's barons and other captains of ships gave quarter to their kinsmen and friends.

2.308

The following chiefs fell with King Magnus: Harald, son of King Ingi; Magnus Mangi, son of Eirik, and grandson, on his mother's side, of Earl Rognvald; Orm Kings-brother; Asbiom Jonsson; Rognvald, son of Jon Hallkelsson; Pal Smattauga; Lodin of Mannvik; Olaf Gunnvallsson; Eindridi Torfi, son of Jon Kutiza; Ivar Elda; Vilhialm of Torga; Andres, son of Eirik, the son of Gudbrand Kula; also Ivar Steig, son of Orm Kings-brother; Hallstein Snak Botolfsson, a kinsman of King Magnus;

Ketil Lafransson; Sigurd Hit, and Ketil Flugá. According to the general reckoning not fewer than eighteen hundred perished.

2.309

The battle was fought on the evening of Vitus's mass-day; about sunset the main body of the host broke into flight; by midnight the slaughter was at an end, the Birkibeins had moved all their ships to the anchorage, put up the awnings, and got ready for bed.

2.310

Speech of King Sverri the morning after the battle.

2.311

94. Early the following morning the King summoned a council, at which he spoke, saying: "God Himself we must praise for our victory, for much more evidently, in this battle than aforetime has He granted us strength and might. We cannot claim this victory as ours in any other way than as it comes through God's will and disposal. Therefore let us yield Him due thanks and acceptable return. First, we must keep truce firmly with all those who sued for life; let us also afford aid to the wounded; we must grant burial, too, with Christian rites, to all the dead that we may find. I bid all my men dutifully to search the strand for the dead, every man affording such help and means as he can. That will not only be pleasing to God, but will bring gain, for all must have had money on them, and some a great deal. The government of this land, I hope, has now passed to me, whether we wish to govern it well or ill. Thanks be to God that we are now peaceful and upright; and of this, many must feel there is need. I must now say to you, my men, may God reward you for the loving devotion you have shown me; I too will reward you with good, to the very best of my power. Sufficient to know that the estates and all the property lately owned by these gold-necks who lie here on the strand shall be yours. In addition, you shall make the best marriages to be found in the land, and receive such titles of rank as you yourselves wish. You have gained more in this sharp fight than in others; yea, and something besides of which we had

enough already, the envy of ill-wishers, against whom we must diligently guard ourselves; and may God guard us all.”

2.312

Loud applause followed this speech, and they thanked the King heartily for it.

2.313

The search for the dead. Finding of King Magnus's body.

2.314

95. After this, King Sverri caused the ships to be rowed up the fiord on the strand side, and anchored near shore at a place where it was hoped the smell from the bodies might not be perceived. Here the King lay for a time. The men of Soknadale and the market-town then came and made peace with him, and they said not a word now against the King's wish, but bound themselves by oath to perform it. And here was the saying fulfilled, “Many a man kisses the hand that he would fain see lopped.” The King obliged them and other yeomen to carry the bodies to burial; he also allowed every man to perform as fully as he wished the last rites for his kinsmen or friends. Many men, both King's men and yeomen, went out every day in boats to search for bodies off the strand. One day they found the body of Orm Kings-brother, which his friends took and carried south to Bergen; here the Vikmen received it and bore it east to Oslo; and Orm was laid in the stone wall of Hallvardskirk beside his brother King Ingi and King Sigurd Jorsala-fari.

2.315

The second Sunday after the battle, as evening drew to a close, many men went in boats to seek for bodies. The King rowed to them in a small cutter. In one of the boats was a man named Liot, son of Harald, and two others with him, Ami Gudmundarson and Jon Koll. And the King said to them, “You sit hard a-fishing here; how does the catch go?” At that moment they dragged up a body. And the King said, “A noble man you have drawn there to the boat's side; you have good luck in this.”

2.316

“Yea,” answered Liot, “an excellent bite that has been, Sire, if it is the King’s body.” And King Sverri said, “That is King Magnus’s body.” The men thrust a shield under and lifted the body into the cutter where the King was. Then they rowed to land, the body was taken on shore, and many went to look at it. It was easily recognised, for the features showed no change, the cheeks were still ruddy, and the body had not become rigid.

2.317

King Magnus’s body taken to Bergen. Speech of Svina-Petr on the victory.

2.318

96. The following Monday a coffin was prepared, but before the body was wrapped in cloths, the King commanded those who had served aforetime under King Magnus to come forward and recognise the body, that they might bear witness hereafter, if the Vikmen should set up a report that King Magnus was alive, and raise thereby a band of evil-doers. So they went to the body; scarcely any could refrain from tears, some who went kissed it before they retired. King Magnus’s body was then wrapped in a cloth and laid in the coffin, and King Sverri had it removed south to Bergen. The bodies of many great men had already been found. The King afterwards made ready to depart; the men of Soknadale had already paid him the fifteen marks of gold; and he sailed away south to Bergen.

2.319

Tidings of the victory had already reached Bergen. Towards the close of Saturday, the next day after the battle, a ship arrived at the town, and came to anchor opposite the Kings-court. It was completely bedecked with shields from stem to stern, and well manned. Some thought King Magnus must have come. The crew landed, a trumpet was blown, and proclamation made that Svina-Petr would hold an Assembly. All the townsfolk came, and Petr stood up and spoke: “The saying is here fulfilled, ‘Oft the same swine in the field,’ and my name is Svina-Petr. A short time ago, you remember, we were driven out of this town in rather a shameful way, but we have now come back again.

Weighty tidings we have to tell: King Magnus is dead, and Harald Ingason, Orm Kings-brother, Asbiom Jonsson, and many of the barons. You may expect King Sverri here in the town when he sails out of Sogn, and he requests you to receive him with the honour due to his rank. Now, what is the cause that you all hold your heads down, or cover them with your cloaks. God knows that never before have I seen such a marvel as you all are here. But I can tell you, and with truth, that however ill you now behave, whining and lamenting, King Magnus is none the less now dead, and all his host with him. You would bestow fairer funeral honours on them if you had the bells rung, or mass chanted for their souls, or gave gifts to the poor, or to clerks to offer prayers for them. Tour muttering and murmuring is of no avail to drive Master Sverri out of the kingdom, for King Sverri has now bent the necks of greater and mightier bucks than you, house-masters, rustics, and timid merchants, who tremble, one for his life, another for his money, and the third at wind and rain. I will give you wholesome counsel: let King Magnus go, as he has brought trouble on himself, and accept King Sverri, whom God has sent you. You will then have a just chief, wise and eloquent, gracious and righteous, peaceful and merciful, a famous conqueror, fearless in defending and ruling the land. The Sverri who visited market-towns with fire and sword is gone; gone, too, those same Birkibeins who wandered here over the town and carried off your stores with unclean hands. And with our King will come meek and gentle Guardsmen, who shall be latch and lock to secure the freedom and peace of this market-town and others. Let impostors, and deceivers, and traitors to their lord now depart from among you; and do you become loyal, and true, and faithful servants to your King. Let those retire when the King comes who have been convicted of treachery towards him and his men and have not sought reconciliation; but let them beware of the King's scouts, who waste no time in looking into a man's eyes, and whose swords are not versed in men's pedigrees. The King himself offers a truce and pardon to those

who come to him and seek it; for which cause God and all His holy saints will give him joy and guide him into peace.”

2.320

King Sverri's arrival at Bergen. Burial of King Magnus.

2.321

97. There was a fair wind as King Sverri sailed to Bergen. Before he sailed in front of the town the King commanded his men so to arrange the approach that their force might impress to the utmost the eyes of the townsmen, whether these were the better pleased or the worse. This was done. When the King arrived, the bells were rung over the whole town, and a procession was formed to meet him; he was received with a hearty welcome, and abode there for a time.

2.322

King Magnus's body was prepared for burial He was laid in earth at Kristskirk opposite the chancel, in front of the stone wall on the southern side. King Sverri stood by the grave, and Bishop Pal and all the people from the town. Before the body was enclosed in the stone coffin, King Sverri summoned men to look at it, that they might not afterwards be saying that this Magnus was fighting against him. Many now came forward to look at the body and went away weeping. One of King Magnus's Crests walked up and kissed the body, shedding tears the while. King Sverri gazed on him and said, "Scarcely could I believe that such there were." Fair speeches were made over the grave. Nikolas Sultan spoke, brother of King Sverri's mother, and one of the most eloquent of men. The King himself made a long speech, in which he said, "We stand here now at the graveside of one who was kind and loving to his friends and kinsmen; though he and I, kinsmen, had not the good fortune to agree. He was hard to me and my men; may God forgive him now all his transgressions. Yet he was an honourable chief in many respects, and adorned by kingly descent." The King spoke with many fine words, for he did not lack them on whatever course he was bent The burial-place of King Magnus was put in careful order by King Sverri; coverlets were spread over the tombstone, and a railing set up

around it. King Magnus rests in the same church in which he was anointed King.

2.323

Character of King Magnus.

2.324

98. King Magnus was a man blessed with friends and much beloved by all the landsfolk. He had most support from the men of Vik. It was a proof of his popularity that, however disastrous it was to follow him, he never lacked men for his body-guard while he lived. Further proof was seen long afterwards, as will be hereafter related, in the abundant support given to those who claimed to be his offspring. We believe that he enjoyed this advantage through the affection which the landsfolk all bore to the descendants of King Sigurd Jorsala-fari and his brother King Eystein; while all hated the family of Harald Gilli, and desired to destroy it, declaring that Harald's arrival in the land was the worst gift ever sent to Norway. King Magnus was condescending and cheerful, and, much after the manner of young men, was fona of drinking-bouts and the society of women. He took pleasure in games, and surpassed others in feats of agility. He was a very strong man, generous and liberal in his gifts, eloquent of speech. These qualities made him a favourite with men who were fond of pleasure. He was most active in the use of weapons, fond of finery, and ostentatious in dress. In stature he was rather tall, well grown, and muscular, had a slender waist, feet and hands well shaped and comely. His mouth was somewhat ugly in shape, but his other features were handsome.

2.325

Speech of King Sverri at the Assembly in Bergen.

2.326

99. King Sverri summoned all the townsfolk to Kristskirk yard, and there held an Assembly. Havard Earls-son first stood up and spoke in favour of the King, declaring the duty of accepting him heartily and becomingly. "Since he can help us honourably in many ways," he said. "let great and suitable effort be made that he may become our shield

and defence, as beseems him to be; and let us render him a firm and faithful support. You may now see the price he has paid before acquiring the realm; how many troubles and worries he has suffered, risking his own life and the lives of many others, gallant men. But God has now delivered him out of much danger, as you have now been truthfully told. To deserve well of the King is the one plain course for all, even though hitherto they have been opposed to him; and he will forgive all who desire to serve him with sincerity. Consider who fare the better, those who lean upon his friendship or those who resist his will. May you now do as God teaches you, and bring your case to a fortunate end.”

2.327

Then the King himself stood up, and having looked round for a long time, proceeded slowly to speak, beginning thus: “We will quote words uttered by the Psalmist, *‘Miserere met, Deus, quoniam conculcavit me homo, tota die expugnans tribulavit me;’* which mean, ‘Be merciful to me, O God, for man trod me under foot; all day he fought against me and tormented me.’ This prophecy, uttered many ages ago, is now fulfilled in our days; for Magnus, my kinsman, fought against me, prepared to destroy my life; but God delivered me, now as aforetime, and transferred his kingdom to me. At all times none have been so hated by God as the proud, and most sternly has He punished them. First, He drove away the angel who would make himself equal with God, and punished him, so that he became the wickedest of devils. Then when our first father Adam transgressed God’s will, he was driven from Paradise into the bondage of this world. And when kingdoms arose and Pharaoh straitened God’s people and His community, ten marvels come over the land such that no others like them ever happened in the world. So, too, after King Saul raged against God, he roamed over the land possessed by an unclean spirit. And though we pick out these, yet such has always been the order of the world. Possibly our speech may seem to you a filling of the cup close to the brim when we point to cases in our own land. Men here have raised themselves on high who

were not of kingly race, such as Kyrpinga-Orm's son, Erling Skakki, who caused the title of Earl to be given to himself, and that of King to his son. Then they struck down all who were of kingly descent, and no man might claim it but under risk of being slain. They were supported by the best counsellors in the land, and they seized all the realm of the kings who were the rightful heirs, until God sent from the outlying islands a mean and lowly man to bring down their pride. I was that man. We did not effect that of ourselves; God rather showed by us how easy it was for Him to lower their pride. And here the saying applies, 'A hungry louse bites hard.' We were not without provocation from King Magnus and Earl Erling, though this folk says that we attacked them wrongfully; nor are our memories so short that we do not remember what wrongs have been done to us. In the first place, the men of Bergen slew my father, King Sigurd, to whom the land belonged by inheritance. Then, with Earl Erling, they raised a band against my brother, King Hakon, and slew him.

2.328

Afterwards Earl Erling took my two brothers; one he hanged up like a young crow, and the other he put to death. We shall be slow to forget this; but such distress has ever lain upon us that we were much more eager to retire, if we had not beheld the misery of our folk under the lordship of those who had no right by birth to rule. Now they have been freed from bondage, yet you are allowing an unheard-of enmity to arise instead. Some say Sverri is fortunate in war; Sverri is wise; and they are answered, 'What is there strange? He has done much for it: he has sold himself to the Fiend.' Others say that I am the devil in person, come from hell; he has been let loose and has taken my form. Look to yourselves. Who are you, then, if you say that God has let loose the devil, and that I am he? What are you but the devil's thralls if you serve him continually, and much more wretched than all other folk in the world since you must serve him now, and burn with him in the other world? Are not such things immensely foolish, said of any person; and, above all, when said of your King? Sverri would be a fool indeed if, for

this miserable realm, which at no time has been held in peace — yea, and if it were founded on peace, would be of no value — he so laboured as to lose for it his soul and all salvation. It seems to me as if all are mixed together here, calves and wolves. Perhaps you think my sieve is a coarse one. Many a man now bows to the hand he would fain see lopped, and he who lately called me foe now calls me friend. This I think, that if we could see the thoughts of every one who has come here, and if a horn stood out of each man's forehead who thinks ill of men, may a man here would carry a short horn. Even the child that goes to fetch water will take a stone in his hand and say as he throws it down, 'Sverri's head ought to be underneath.' Thus you teach your children. The servant-maid says the same. As she goes out of the house with a batlet in her hand, she will strike it on the rock; 'Sverri's head ought to be underneath,' she will say. But it may be that Sverri will die in his bed, nevertheless. I would now warn King Magnus's men, who have been present at this meeting, to withdraw from the town before the third day from this time. And thanks be to all my friends who have attended this Assembly."

2.329

King Sverri sole ruler of all Norway.

2.330

100. In the summer, after the fall of King Magnus, King Sverri sailed east to Vik and brought the whole land into subjection right to the boundary; no man uttered a word opposed to the King's will. He also appointed his bailiffs over the whole land.

2.331

King Sverri was now sole ruler over all Norway. Seven years had passed since the name of King was given him, and five since the death of Earl Erling. King Sverri now gave titles to many of his men, to some bailiwicks, to others royal grants, and many by his aid made noble marriages. He made chiefs of many who had helped him to the land; he made many noble who had no right by birth; and ever afterwards they were his trusty supporters. King Sverri gave his sister Cecilia in

marriage to Bard Guthormsson of Bein; and Skialdvor, daughter of Andres Skialdvarar-son, to Ivar Silki. Petr Rangi married Ingibiorg, who had been the wife of Ivar Elda. The King found wives for many others who had helped him to the land, and he raised many to power, making them feudal barons. The year after the fall of King Magnus, King Sverri married, and took to wife Margret, daughter of Eirik the Saint, son of Jatvard and King of the Swedes. King Eirik rests in a shrine at Upsala, in Sweden. Maigret was sister of Knut, King of the Swedes. King Sverri had two sons: the elder, Sigurd, sumamed Lavard; the other, Hakon. His daughters were Cecilia and Ingibiorg.

2.332

Rise of the Kuflungs in the Vik [1185].

2.333

101. In the autumn of the year following the death of King Magnus, it came to pass east in the Vik that a band of men rose up; their chief was Jon, son of King Ingi, the son of Harald Gilli. Many chiefs joined in the plot: there was Simun, son of Aulru-Kari; Nikolas, son of Biora Bukk; Andres Brasadr; Jon Kutiza; Bard Sala; Thorberg, son of Pal of Herzla. These came down to Tunsberg on Michaelmas day, and an Assembly was summoned at Hauga, at which Jon was accepted as King, and the whole land was confirmed to him by oath. Jon had formerly been a monk at Hofudey. He gladly laid aside his cowl; but the Birkibeins replaced it on him, saying that by right of his monastery he could not retain less than the name, and they called him Kuflung, giving him that title for King's name. A host, numerous as well as fine, gathered round him, all the sons of the best men in the Vik, and they procured ships and sailed north coastwise. As the Birkibeins were collected together in great force in the Vik, the Kuflungs moved away as soon as they obtained ships; and the Birkibeins did not sail after them, as they had not a sufficient force of ships. When the Kuflungs reached Agdi all the people submitted to them, and thenceforward wherever they sailed they reduced the whole land to subjection.

2.334

At the time the Kuflungs came down to Tunsberg they slew Simun Skirpla, who was then bailiff in Tunsberg; his company of nearly thirty men fell with him.

2.335

The Kuflungs take Bergen and pass the winter there. They return to the Vik.

2.336

102. The Kuflungs then began their voyage north coastwise, and the people submitted wherever they appeared, and made no resistance. They came to Bergen, and directed their ships at once to the quays. Then they reduced to subjection all the land as far north as Stad, and passed the winter at Bergen. King Sverri, on his arrival from Sogn, had beached the Mariusud on the Holm and built a roof over her, but she never went to sea again. The Kuflungs, desirous of launching her, summoned all the people of the town; but the ship was so strained and shaken that her beaks broke, and she did not move from her place; so they set fire to her and burned her. —

2.337

At the time of the Kuflungs' arrival in the bay of Bergen, high mass was being sung in the town, and their coming was very unexpected. Askel Kussa had charge of the town, and kept his company there. He was attending mass at Steinkirk, and heard nothing of the Kuflungs before they appeared in the church fully armed. Askel ran up the staircase into the tower. The Kuflungs hastened after him, and there fell on the head of one of them a large stone from the tower and killed him. Then the Holy Rood sweat blood, and drops fell on the altar. Askel and his fellows barred the way into the tower, and long held out, until the townsmen ransomed them with money.

2.338

The Kuflungs remained a considerable time in the town, and then turned back east to Vik; and because great numbers joined them, they attacked the Birkibeins there. King Sverri had placed in the Vik, for the defence of the land, Ulf of Laufness, Ulf Fly, Havard Earlsson, Thorolf Rympil and yet more captains of companies. The two forces set

on each other fiercely whenever they could; but the strength of the Kuflungs so increased that the Birkibeins fled out of the Vik to the north of the land, except Ulf of Laufness, who held out against them with his company, and declared he would not flee.

2.339

King Sverri at Bergen. Tremble caused by drink [1186].

2.340

103. In the following spring King Sverri sailed south from Throndham with a very great host, and arrived at Bergen about the Vigil-time. There was a great number of merchant-ships in the town, come from well-nigh all lands. The Southmen had imported a large quantity of wine, so that wine in Bergen was then no dearer than ale. It happened on a time as men sat drinking wine, that they wished to be served with more, but the Southmen's boy would not fetch it, and they strove with him for not more than a single pot. They wrangled until the Northmen would go and break into the booth, but the Southmen defended themselves from the inside, and several men were wounded by sword-thrusts. This was told in the town. The townsmen and the Germans seized their weapons, and a fight took place; many fell, especially of the townsmen. The Southmen ran to their cogs, which they placed all together in the bay, and the townsmen prepared to set on them. But at last a truce was made. Many other disturbances arose that summer through drink. There was a man of the Birkibeins so witless through drink that he threw himself out between the hall and the King's sitting-room, thinking he was leaping into the water to swim, and he was killed. Another leapt from the quay in the King's-court and was drowned. King Sverri was not then in the town; but one day soon after he arrived, two drunken men happened to quarrel, the one a Gest of the King, the other a House-carle. They were about to use their weapons to each other, when Thorolf Rympil, the leader of the Gests, came out of the drinking-room. He had no weapon, but he took the steel cap from his head and struck the House-carle, who with his hand-axe returned the blow. Then the fight became general, every man

using the weapon he had to hand, all being mad with ale. Thorolf Rympil tore himself loose from the fray, went to his force and blew the Gests' trumpet, and when the Crests were all come together, Thorolf bade them take their weapons. The House-carles also gathered, armed themselves, and went on board their ship, under their leader Asgeir Hamarskalli. When the Greats came down to the quays, Thorolf Rympil flung his sword on the House-carles' ship, and himself leapt after it; having regained it he began immediately to fight. The Gests sprang on board after him. There was a great bande, and Thorolf and his men did not cease until they had cleared the ship. Many House-carles were slain, but most of them leapt overboard. When the King heard of the fray, he went to them and brought about a truce, and a meeting afterwards, at which peace was made.

2.341

King Sverri's speech about drinking to excess.

2.342

104. Shortly afterwards King Sverri held an Assembly in the town, at which he spoke, saying: —

2.343

“We desire to thank the Englishmen who have come here, bringing wheat and honey, flour and cloth. We desire also to thank those who have brought here linen or flax, wax or caldrons. We desire next to make mention of those who have come from the Orkneys, Shetland, the Færeys or Iceland; all those who have brought here such things as make this land the richer, and we cannot do without. But there are Germans who have come here in great numbers, with large ships, intending to carry away butter and dried fish, of which the exportation much impoverishes the land; and they bring wine instead, which people strive to purchase, both my men, townsmen, and merchants. From that purchase much evil and no good has arisen, for many have lost life through it, and some their limbs; some carry marks of disfigurement to the end of their days; others suffer disgrace, being wounded or beaten. Overdrinking is the cause. To those Southmen I

feel much ill-will for their voyage here; and if they would preserve their lives or property, let them depart hence; their business has become harmful to us and to our realm. Call to mind what overdrinking means, what it produces, what it destroys. First, to mention its least evil, whoever takes to overdrinking ceases to make money, and the price of overdrinking is the waste and loss of his wealth, until he who was blessed with wealth becomes poor and wretched and needy, if he does not forsake his ways. As the second evil, overdrinking destroys the memory, and makes a man forget all that he is bound to keep in mind. In the third place, it makes a man lust to do all manner of unrighteous deeds; he is not afraid to lay hands wrongfully on money or women. As a fourth evil, overdrinking incites a man to bear with nothing, word or deed, but to return far more evil than is deserved; and beyond that, it incites him to find means of slandering the innocent. Another evil follows overdrinking: a man strains his body to the utmost to endure labour, to keep awake until exhausted, to lose blood in every limb, and he will spill his blood till he is ill, and thus destroy all health. And when all wealth, health, and reason, too, are destroyed by overdrinking, it incites a man to destroy what is not yet lost, his soul. It incites him to neglect all right conduct and right ordinances, to lust after sins, to forget God and all that is right, and to remember nothing that He has done. Consider now, you men that overdrink: who will most likely seize the soul when your life and drinking-bouts come to an end at the same time. Call to mind how unlike is your conduct to what it should be, for a calm restraint should accompany all things. Warriors in time of peace should be gentle as lambs, but in war dauntless as lions; merchants and yeomen should go about their business, acquiring wealth justly, yet with toil, taking care of it wisely, and bestowing it with liberality. Those who are lowly should be grateful, and each one serve his master with good-will and according to his ability.” The King brought his speech to an end by bidding his men be well behaved and peaceful towards the townsmen, yeomen, and merchants.

2.344

This speech was highly approved by all wise men. In the autumn King Sverri sailed north to Kaupang, where he abode during the winter; nearly all his chiefs were with him. The Kuflungs were in the Vik.

2.345

The Kuflungs plunder Nidaros. King Sverri in the castle of Steinbiorg.

2.346

105. The same summer the Kuflungs made preparations to sail north to attack King Sverri; but they delayed, and it was autumn before they set out. When they came north beyond Stad a strong wind bore them to Agdaness. And Nefari recited this verse: —

2.347

“Smite the Birkibeins! Let Sverri’s lot
The worser be! We’ll brandish hard
And swift the tried salmon-of-the-shield [sword].

2.348

No bragging words; our boast shall be
The number of the slain. A smarting storm
We’ll raise, let God give luck.”

2.349

Then a light north-east wind blew, and at evening time they rowed into the Fiord, reaching Kaupang in the first part of the night. No news of their approach preceded them. King Sverri was staying in the castle on Steinbiorg, and few men were with him. His chiefs and nearly all the body-guard were in the town, and had no warning of the Kuflungs before the town was taken. Many Birkibeins and brave fellows were slain, but most of the Birkibeins took refuge in the churches. Bryniolf Rognvaldsson was slain, and Ottar Knerra, Sigurd Dotafinn, Andres Krista, and Andres Biugi. Jon Kuflung gave quarter to all the Birkibeins taken alive, and said they must become his men; but when they would accept him as their liege-lord, Kuflung remitted the oaths, saying they were doubtless brave fellows who would keep their word no less than their oath. As soon as evening was come, the

Birkibeins took their weapons, and, in groups of two or three, and sometimes five or more, went up to the castle to King Sverri. By morning they had all slipped away from the Kuflungs; and they told King Sverri how the Kuflungs had given them quarter and King Sverri said that Jon Kuflung had shown clearly by his action that he knew not how to be a chief. The Kuflungs seized all King Sverri's ships; some they took with them, some they burnt. And one night after darkness set in, they sailed away from the town, being afraid of some onslaught or other from the King; but the King abode all this time in the castle, deeming that he had not sufficient force for a battle with them. Jon Kuflung now sailed south to Bergen, and King Sverri remained behind in Kaupang.

2.350

The Kuflungs' want of success on other voyages north [1187].

2.351

106. The next spring Jon Kuflung sailed a second time north to Kaupang with a large force, and anchored near Holm for several nights. In the winter King Sverri had set up palisades along the road by the sea and above the town. Messages were now sent from one to the other, and King Sverri offered the Kuflungs to fight on shore, and he would permit them to land; but nothing came of this. The Kuflungs sailed back to Bergen without more ado. The same summer Jon Kuflung again sailed north with many cutters, hoping to surprise King Sverri, but the King sailed with a large force from the north to meet him. Then Blakk recited this verse: —

2.352

“Banners hoist before the King;
Heavy be to Kuflungs,
Let sharpened weapons bite and give
Bloody prey to ravens' claws,
Repel the band of foes; and peace
Procure with sword to our King's land,

Readen these our spears in gore;
Slay more than we leave alive.”

2.353

But the Kuflungs' cutters were parted from one another in the night by a storm off Stad. Five came north to Angr. After this King Sverri came up with many large ships, and slew several of their men, but the Kuflungs escaped by leaping ashore. Another force of the Kuflungs met with Birkibeins under Atli Skalmi, a Gest, and slew every child of man on board his ship.

2.354

Shortly afterwards Jon Kuflung was joined by his force, and they sailed south to Bergen, where they remained a short time and then sailed away east. King Sverri followed them as far as Bergen, and sent Ulf of Laufness and his own brother Hidi with six ships south in quest of them. Ulf and Hidi arrived in the night at Hrott, and there the Kuflungs lay in front of them with twenty ships and cutters; and they sailed into the harbour towards them, raising instantly the war-cry. The Kuflungs, supposing King Sverri had come with all his force, rowed out of the harbour and away south. Ulf took two of their cutters, steered by Erlend Gudbrandsson and Pal Varskinn, and slew every child of man on them. The ships of the Kuflungs sailed every one its own way, and Jon Kuflung's ship was for a long time quite alone until he was joined by his force. Then they sailed away and came to Tunsberg; and Blakk recited a verse: —

2.355

“The boasts of baleful Kuflung tongues
Men call once more to mind. Brave men
Of their own band have paid the price.

2.356

The rocks resound with quite another cry
At Berg. At Hrott the raven fed;
The sea rolls o'er their dead deformed.”

2.357

Death of Archbishop Eystein [Jan. 1188].

2.358

107. The following winter a great event happened in Thronðham. At the beginning of autumn Archbishop Eystein fell sick, and lay ill during the winter until after Yule. When his strength was passing away he sent word to King Sverri to come to him. The King did so, and they talked together of many things in which they had aforesaid been engaged; and at their parting the Archbishop begged the King to forgive him for God's sake all the wrongs he had done him while the strife lasted between King Magnus and King Sverri. They were then reconciled anew, and forgave one another all that had caused dissension between them. Archbishop Eystein died the night after Pal's Mass, and a grave was prepared for him in the vestry of Kristskirk. Shortly afterwards King Sverri made a speech to the choir in Kristskirk, and related what had happened in his conversation with the Archbishop the last time; and said that the Archbishop had admitted that in his opposition to the King he had gone beyond what he knew to be right before God, and that other things had not weighed against his feeling that he could not withdraw his support from King Magnus.

2.359

The Kuflungs abode this winter in Vik.

2.360

Eirik, Bishop of Stafangr, chosen Archbishop. Thorstein Kugad surrenders the castle of Steinbiorg to the Kuflungs.

2.361

108. The following spring King Sverri made ready his host, and with a large force sailed south to Bergen, where he abode much of the summer. A meeting of bishops and other men of rank was held there to discuss the choosing of an Archbishop, and Eirik of Stafangr was most favoured, because he had been specially recommended by Archbishop Eystein. King Sverri rather objected, asserting that Eirik was not well fitted to have the management of money, for he was an open-handed

man. He was answered by many that they ought to choose one to be Archbishop who was bountiful with his wealth, and they added that the see did not lack money. In the end it was resolved to elect Bishop Eirik, and he went abroad the same summer.

2.362

King Sverri sailed with his force east to the Vik. On the voyage he lost a ship, which was steered on the rocks of Agdi and there wrecked. The King ordered the hull to be burnt, and afterwards proceeded on his course. The ship was called the Hrein. The Kuflungs were at Tunsberg with a great host, but a small supply of ships. And as King Sverri came near the town they had news of him, and moved their ships, of which they had sixteen, out to Hrafnabiorg. When King Sverri arrived he anchored his ships opposite the island [Niotarey] near Smiorberg. The King had thirty ships, and he caused five of them to row to the town and anchor near the quays. Thus they lay for three nights. The King would not begin the attack, because the Kuflungs had a large force on the rock, and he considered it unwise to bring his ships where they would be exposed to great showers of-stones. The Kuflungs also did not dare to attack the King; but on the fourth night they moved their ships silently towards the quays before which lay the five ships of the Birkibeins.

2.363

The night was so dark that neither force could see the other until the moving ships ran into those at rest, and then a fight began at once. And when King Sverri became aware of the fight, he suspected his men might be in evil case, and rowed to them as speedily as possible; but the Kuflungs would not wait, and went on shore, many men on both sides being left dead.

2.364

The Kuflungs now marched north by land to Kaupang, and arrived there shortly before Michaelmas. Ivar Clementsson was present in the town with his ship's crew of about eighty men. All the troops, both Ivar's men and the townsmen, were now summoned to march to the

castle and defend it. The Kuflungs had eight hundred men, and made a fierce attack on the castle; the townsmen defended it. The battle was fierce but not long, for the Kuflungs broke into the wooden castle, and on their entrance the townsmen fled. Ivar Clementsson and nearly all his company were slain, and the Kuflungs took the town. Afterwards an Assembly was held on the Eyra at which Biorn Erlingsson gave the name of King to Jon. Thorstein Kugad had charge of the castle of Sion, in which there was no lack of stones for the defence. The Kuflungs marched up to the castle and shots were exchanged, but the Kuflungs could effect nothing. Seeing this, they fetched Nikolas Sultan, King Sverri's uncle by the mother's side, whom they had taken in Kristskirk. They brought him to the castle and raised a gallows, saying they were about to hang him there. "You, Thorstein, and the men in the castle," they said, "are to blame. We will give quarter to Nikolas and all of you if you give up the castle; but if not, Nikolas must die. King Sverri will hang you for it; no one will be worse off than you, and you will deserve it. You may expect also the like from us as soon as we have the power." Thorstein was now afraid, and thought they spoke truth, and that he would be the sufferer into whose-ever hands he fell if Nikolas were hanged. He resolved therefore to surrender the castle. The Kuflungs spared Thorstein and let him keep his property; to all the men in the castle they gave safety of life and limb, but the Kuflungs took all their property; then they set fire to the castle and destroyed it.

2.365

The Kuflungs seized many valuable possessions of King Sverri and divided much booty when they went to the town. The Kuflungs laid a heavy fine on the town, saying they would set fire to it if the money were not paid, and make a return to the townsmen for their resistance in force. The townsmen preferred to pay the money. The Kuflungs remained there a short time and procured ships for themselves, and the townsmen did not hinder them, but bade them farewell, with an eager desire that they would fare ill. The Kuflungs hastily prepared the cutters. When they were ready a rumour and report reached the town

that a force was marching over the Gaularas, and men thought King Sverri might be there. The Kuflungs heard the rumour, and ran to their ships, pulled down the awnings, struck the oars into the water, and rowed in a crowd out of the river, the townsmen begging them never to come again. The Kuflungs sailed down the Fiord. They behaved with much violence at every place they touched, and plundered the ships of burden that came in their way. One merchant-ship which they seized was an Icelandic trader, called the Stangarfoli; it had been driven back by contrary winds, and they robbed it of every penny. After that, they sailed south to Bergen, arriving there shortly before Yule.

2.366

Jon Kuflung is slain by the Birkibeins at Bergen. He is shown to have been an impostor.

2.367

109. The Kuflungs held an Assembly in the town, and demanded a contribution from the townsmen towards the Yule feast, saying that if it were not paid they would burn the whole town. The townsmen asked to be excused payment and begged for delay, but the Kuflungs threatened them with stem measures. So the matter stood for a time. One morning at daybreak, just before Yule, thirteen large long-ships were seen off Hvarfsness sailing to the town from the south. When the Kuflungs became aware of them they seized their weapons, and the most of them ran out of the town to the fell or into Olafskirk. Jon Kuflung summoned his men to their ships. He and his company sprang on board and rowed down the bay to meet the enemy; but seeing that they were not joined by their force they crossed over towards Monks-quay. Close to the other side, they rowed their ship on a rock, and it stuck fast. At that instant the ships of the Birkibeins came swiftly on them, and the Kuflungs leapt overboard and swam to land, but some perished. Jon Kuflung did not leap overboard, but awaited the Birkibeins on his ship, and was slain with one other man. The Birkibeins stripped the bodies. When King Sverri heard these tidings

he had the bodies removed to the town and taken to Mariukirk, where they were laid on the ground under the south wall and covered with a cloth. The Kuflungs now hastened down from the fell to Olafskirk, where they drew up in array, raised a war-cry against the Birkibeins, and incited them to fight. But the King bade his men have nothing to do with them. "We must not fight," he "with leaderless men. Tell them their chief lies here by Manukirk They meanly abandoned him, though he was not a good chief to guard." The Kuflungs did not go into the town, and there was no battle; they turned away, and so the armies separated.

2.368

There was a man in the town named Petr, the father, as the Birkibeins declared, of a man named Orm, whose mother was Astrid Steik. This Orm, the Birkibeins said, was the man whom the Kuflungs called their King, Jon Ingason, and he it was who then lay there by Manukirk. Petr was bidden to go there and acknowledge his son, mentioning, before he saw the body, any marks on it. Petr spoke thus of marks; "If he is my son Orm," he said, "there will be a mark on him, for when he was a boy he leapt upon a scythe and was severely cut on the sole of the right foot. If there is no mark of this, he is certainly not my son; but if there is, I will not disavow him." Then the King caused him to be taken where the body lay, from which the shoe and hose were now removed, and Petr declared that he recognised the mark which his son bore. King Sverri now made known, both to the townsmen and his own men, that this Jon, whom the Kuflungs had called their King, was named Orm, and was the son of Petr and Astrid, and that Petr was present and recognised the body of his son. "It must be known to you townsmen," he said, "if Petr and Astrid have such a pedigree, that their son should be King over Norway. You may see now the imposture under which that band of highwaymen has marched." Then the body of Jon Kuflung was laid in earth at Mariukirk This was the first time that King Sverri and his force came to Bergen, and the whole people

was glad to see him. King Sverri was now sole ruler over Norway. After these things he remained for a time in Bergen.

2.369

Of Sigurd Brenni and his followers [1189].

2.370

110. East of the country in the Marches there was a band which made raids into the Vik and did much injury, slaying some, robbing some, and burning down the homesteads of others. The leader of this band was a man named Sigurd Brenni, a son of King Ingi Haraldsson. Sigurd Brenni had visited Jon Kuflung, who had acknowledged kinship with him, and this was a sign that he had rightly come to power and high rank. Jon said that he very much resembled his family, and would be found hard in counsel and vigorous in action, and he invited him to stay. But Sigurd thought it a small thing to rule over the Kuflungs, confident that he was superior to Jon in governing a land and commanding a body-guard, in wisdom and popularity; all needed, he said, to cope with the designs of Priest Sverri. He said, too, that if he encountered Sverri he would pay scant regard either to his relationship or his ordination; he intended, he said, thus to treat his kinsmen, for he preferred to go his own way with his band. He had three hundred followers for a time. In the course of the summer, after the fall of Kuflung, the yeomen and some Guardsmen marched against Sigurd Brenni, surprised him and his men, and set on them in a sitting-room. They defended themselves bravely and manfully. When most of those in the sitting-room had fallen, Sigurd called to his foes and bade them listen to him. When he obtained silence, he said: "It is likely that you will fulfil your intention to take my life and slay me; and when you have done so, you will tell King Sverri and other chiefs that you have here slain and cut off the leader of this band, Sigurd Brenni, son of King Ingi. But your story is much less worth the telling than you think and many imagine, though you slay me; for I tell you, and it is the truth, my name is Hedin; I am the son of Thorgrim Hrossaprest, and an Icelander through all my pedigree; of a mean

family as to rank, though you were ready to consider me a king.” After this they shot at him, and he defended himself most manfully. At last they slew him, and they spoke of him as a most valiant man, and a very gallant hardy fellow.

2.371

Consecration of Bishop Nikolas.

2.372

111. Archbishop Eirik, having obtained the Pallium at Rome, returned to Norway the summer following the fall of the Kuflungs, and sailed north to Nidaros to his see. This summer Havard Earls-son died.

2.373

At the election of a Bishop for Stafangr the general choice fell upon Nikolas Kings-brother, son of Ami of Stodreim. King Sverri spoke against him; and when Nikolas heard of it he sent a letter to Queen Margret, in which he wrote many fair and smooth things of King Sverri and also of her, and made mention of his kinship to her. Whereupon Queen Margret sought King Sverri, and told him of Nikolas’s fair promises; but the King answered that he was unwilling to make Nikolas a greater man than he then was. “If Nikolas,” he said, “should obtain any more rule in Norway than he already has, I expect he will retain the same feeling towards me: his fidelity will not increase when he has reached a higher dignity than he now has.” The Queen begged the King not to oppose him, and mentioned the great losses sustained by Nikolas in the death of kinsmen during the contest between Kings Sverri and Magnus. To raise him to high estate would be the best compensation, she said, and he would not show unfaithfulness if he laid aside his weapons and was ordained. The King replied that he would grant her desire; “but I don’t expect,” he said, “that a long time will elapse before both we and others will repent.” Afterwards a letter was obtained from the King that Nikolas should be consecrated Bishop. And so it came to pass; the Archbishop consecrated Nikolas Bishop. At that time the Bishop in Oslo died, and Nikolas obtained permission

from the Archbishop to occupy the see in Oslo. Bishop Niai was then consecrated to Stafangr, and was Bishop there.

2.374

Dissension between the King and the Archbishop.

2.375

112. When Archbishop Eirik came to the see in Nidaros the canons welcomed him heartily. After that, he preached to the choir and used hard language of the Birkibeins. Forthwith many of the King's men set their minds against him, and an unfriendly feeling existed among them. Presently much dissension arose between King Sverri and the Archbishop, because of an agreemen made by Archbishop Eystein with the yeomen, which King Magnus and Earl Erling allowed to stand all the time they governed the realm. By this agreement, whenever the Archbishop had to receive fines, the ounce of pure silver should be the standard in these debts, whereas aforetime fines had been paid in the current ounce as in the King's suits. Earl Erling had brought himself to sanction this agreement, that the Archbishop might be willing to anoint his son Magnus King. Thus the money-standard became doubled King Sverri demanded of the Archbishop that the old legal satisfaction should stand in the Archbishop's as in the King's suits, and declared that Erling Skakki, ought not to have broken the laws of King Olaf the Saint to have his son anointed King. For Magnus was not rightly chosen, inasmuch as never before since Norway became Christian had one been King who was not a King's son; nor yet in heathen times; it was also forbidden in the land's law ordained by King Olaf the Saint. "There was a bargain between them," said King Sverri, "between Archbishop Eystein and Earl Erling, that the Archbishop should anoint Erling's son King, and Earl Erling should permit the Archbishop to carry out all that unlawfulness as far as his authority prevailed with the yeomen. It seems to me as if it had been done neither in accordance with God's law nor land's law. There is another way: if you, Archbishop, wish to increase greatly your due, then I wish you to give me leave to increase equally the King's due; and do you answer before

God, the yeomen, and the land's folk, that the government of the land is according to right." The Archbishop refused this; he would have his own due, and said that God's due ought ever to increase and never diminish. "Do you, Sire," he said, "take your dues and uphold the laws, as you have sworn, and answer for yourself before God and men whether you perform your oaths or not; for never in the payment of the Kings due has there been any raising of the standard of money."

2.376

Eirik Kingsson's expedition to Eistland. He is raised to the rank of Earl.

2.377

113. After the death of King Magnus, Eirik Kings-son asked of his brother King Sverri that he would grant him a higher title than he then had, and with it some share in the realm. But the King bade him remain with the body-guard, in command of a company, like the barons, being, however, the foremost of them in honour; and he declined to share the land. Eirik showed that he was not pleased, but matters remained as they were for a time. He had a large company, and as he was liberal to his men and had small revenues, his money fell short. The following winter he prepared to leave the country and sail to the Baltic to plunder heathen lands. Many of the King's troops entered his service for this voyage, and he had five ships, of which Ozur Prest commanded one, Thiodolf Pik a second, and Hermund Kvada the third. In the summer they sailed over the Baltic to Eistland, and plundered Viku and Tunta, and seized much booty. Then they turned back to Gotland, and having quarrelled with the Saxons, won two cogs from them and took immense wealth. Thence they sailed to Sweden and visited King Knut. They met with good cheer, and King Knut gave Eirik a long-ship before he sailed away. Eirik and his force sailed past the Swedish and Danish realms, behaving with violence, and returned to Norway about the time of autumn with eleven ships. This autumn — the Hrafnabiorg autumn — the Kuflungs were in the Vik. King Sverri was then in the Vik, and he shared the land with his brother Eirik, giving him the country from Svinasound in the east to Rygiarbit

north, and all the Uplands. At the same time he bestowed on him the title of Earl. After that, Eirik raised a body-guard for himself and became a very great chief. His wife's name was Asa.

2.378

Rising of Simun Karason and the Varbelgs. Defeat of Simun by the men of Tunsberg [1190].

2.379

114. Simun Karason and Olvi of Godrann and the captains of companies who had been with the Kuflungs sailed south to Denmark. Some went east to the Marches and remained there the following summer, and when the winter was far spent they proceeded to Denmark and there joined Simun Karason. He had a son of Magnus Erlingsson with him named Vikar. They now raised a band and procured a great number of men; in the summer they sailed north to the Vik with sixteen ships. They behaved with violence, robbing both yeomen and merchants; thus they passed over the Vik from the east. When the men of Tunsberg heard these tidings they hastened to their ships; they had some long-ships as well as merchant-ships. These they laid in front of the quays, and assigned a force to each ship, and prepared to defend the town. Simun's band was called Varbelgs. When he learnt what the men of Tunsberg had done, and what a force they had gathered together, he did not venture to go near the town, but sailed back east over the Fold. The men of Tunsberg heard of this, and sprang on board their ships and hastened after them, under Thorlak Ulfgestsson, Ulf Svarti, and Asleif Buandi. Simun and his force now sailed away east; the men of Tunsberg followed, seeking them, and found them in the south at Bridstein. They fell upon them without delay, and there was a great and fierce battle, the yeomen's ships being larger in size and higher in the bulwarks. After the fight had lasted for a time, it became a slaughter of the Varbelgs, and their ships were cleared. The contest ended so that scarcely one escaped, Simun Karason and Olvi of Godrann being slain with almost all their band. On the ship which Simun had commanded, Vikar, the King of the Varbelgs, a boy a few years old, was

found beneath the deck in the fore-room and was immediately slain. By this expedition the men of Tunsberg won great renown and much wealth, and they sailed back after the battle.

2.380

Death of Earl Eirik.

2.381

115. The same year in which the Varbelgs fell, Earl Eirik was taken ill. He was then in Tunsberg; and when his sickness increased he gave himself to a monastery and put on monks' dress. After he had lain there five days he died, and his wife Asa died the same day; and two days later their son died who was named Magnus. These events gave rise to much discussion, and many said that evil men must have given them poison and killed them. After this King Sverri took to himself the domain that had been Eirik's, and set bailiffs over it.

2.382

Ivar Silki died soon afterwards.

2.383

Rising under Thorleif Breidskegg. He is slain by the yeomen

2.384

[1191].

2.385

116. The summer that Earl Eirik died, a band arose east in the Marches under a man named Thorleif Breidskegg; he was said to be a son of King Eystein Haraldsson, and as a sign he bore between his shoulders the scar of a wound healed in the form of a cross. This band came into the Vik and behaved peaceably, purchasing meat and other needful things. Thorleif Breidskegg had been a monk, and his band had little strength. They soon fell short of money, and then some of the band stole, as they were forbidden to plunder. Many men seemed to have heard that Thorleif was so wise a man that no event took him by surprise, and also was so moral that his life more resembled a monk's life, subject to the rules of his order, than a layman's. He was also said to be so eloquent, and able to speak so persuasively, that no one could be angry with him

who heard him speak. But this was proved afterwards to be sheer falsehood and nonsense. This band abode chiefly in the Marches the following winter, and the next summer the yeomen made an attack on them as they were passing the night in a wood. It was then proved that Breidskegg neither had any knowledge of the attack beforehand, nor said what made his life any safer than before. He was slain with almost all his company, but some escaped in the wood. After the death of Breidskegg a rumour was spread abroad that he was a saint, but the poet Blakk spoke against it and recited this: —

2.386

“O’er Breidskegg’s tomb now burn, they say,

2.387

Bright lights. Lightless rather is their leader.

2.388

Fairer hopes have failed than his, I feel.”

2.389

Blakk composed a funeral dirge on Breidskegg, which had this refrain:

—

2.390

“Breidskegg’s life two marks did bear:

2.391

Lowest merit, loftiest pride.

2.392

The foe of peace is fallen.”

2.393

Strife between the King and the Archbishop. The Archbishop leaves his see and goes to Denmark to Archbishop Absalon.

2.394

117. About this time much dissension arose between King Sverri and the Archbishop, and the King appealed always to the law of the land, ordained by King Olaf the Saint, and to the law-book of the Thronds, called Gragas, written by command of King Magnus Godi, the son of

King Olaf. The Archbishop produced the book called Gullfiodr, written by command of Archbishop Eystein; also he produced God's Roman law, and a part of the Pope's brief which he had, with the Pope's seal. One subject of dispute between them was the old law and practice by which the King and the yeomen should build churches, if they wished, at their own homesteads and their own cost, and should themselves have the control of the churches and appoint priests thereto. But the Archbishop claimed rule and authority in each church as soon as it was consecrated, and over all those whom he permitted to officiate there. The King requested that the law should hold, but the Archbishop refused.

2.395

The King then caused the law-book to be read aloud at the Assembly, and there stood in the book that the Archbishop when on a progress in his diocese should have thirty men with him, and his ship should carry twelve shields, all white. And King Sverri requested that the law should hold in this matter, and thus spoke: "The Archbishop has no need of a body-guard, or of warriors, or of a ship all bedecked with shields; and he so far exceeds what the law says, that he sails in a smack having twenty benches, manned by ninety men or more, and bedecked with shields from stem to stern. We Birkibeins will call to mind the ship sent by the Archbishop to attack us under Hattarhamar, and that we thought the same far too hardily manned with his House-carles. So too in Bergen, when we attacked the fleet, the Archbishop's ship and his company were much readier with their weapons to fight against us than were the King's company. I should think it more righteous before God if the Archbishop had no Guardsmen beyond what is lawful, for no one will plunder him or the church property, and if he used the cost to set men to the quarries, to transport stone, to do masons' work, so as to advance the building of the minster, for which preparations have already been made. The Archbishop thus replied: "The Pope of Rome set me to manage this see and the property of the see; therefore I have rightful control over the property; moreover, it is God's property and

holy men's. Of a truth, Sire, it will seem better to most upright men to side with me in peace than with you in evil deeds, for few nowadays attain rest in life. And though my men possess weapons and good clothes, the property is their own; they have robbed no one of a single penny for it, and wherever they go they behave peacefully. It will not seem honourable, when told in other lands, that the Archbishop may not decide for himself whom he shall give his meat or clothes; while your bailiffs, whom you have raised from beggary, may have as large companies as they like, fall upon the yeomen and take meat and ale from them unlawfully, and yet the owner shall be fain that he is not robbed of more." King Sverri now demanded the law, and called upon the yeomen to declare judgment, and decide according to the law of the land how many House-carles the Archbishop should have. The King next summoned those of the Archbishop's men who were in excess of the number permitted by the scroll, to appear in five days, when they should all be outlawed, have their safety and property forfeited, and be slain wherever they were found. When the Archbishop heard this, he prepared in the utmost haste to leave the town, and took with him all his men and all the property they could.' The Archbishop then sailed all the way south to Denmark to visit Archbishop Absalom. He was well received, and abode there in comfort for a long time. Archbishop Eirik caught an illness whereby he lost his sight and became totally blind.

2.396

Rise of the Eyskeggs, under Olaf, a kinsman of Earl Harold of the Orkneys, and Sigurd, a son of King Magnus.

2.397

118. Hallkel, son of Jon Hallkelsson, married Ragnhild, daughter of Earl Erling and Kristin Kings-daughter. Hallkel had a plot in hand, in which many others joined him. Shortly before this time he had accepted a fief from King Sverri and the rights of a baron. There was an illegitimate son of Earl Erling named Sigurd, a foster-son of King Sverri, who had kept him at his side in high favour for a long time; he was privy to the

plot of Hallkel and Bagnhild. Olaf, a kinsman of Earl Harald, was also a chief mover in the plot with them. There was a boy named Sigurd, a son of King Magnus Erlingsson and Gyrid, daughter of Aslak Ungi, who had come under the protection and care of Hallkel and Bagnhild. This boy Sigurd Kingsson they decided to place in the hands of Olaf Earls-kin, who took him to Bergen. Olaf had frequent conversations with King Sverri, for no suspicion had as yet arisen. And once, when Olaf's ship was ready, King Sverri after a conversation said to him, "You ought now to be true to me, Olaf."

2.398

"Why do you speak thus, Sire?" he answered. The King had a knife in his hand; making a thrust with it in front of him, he said, "The fetches of our foes are now flitting about us." As Olaf passed into the vestibule of the sitting-room, the boy Sigurd ran to him. "We have had a narrow escape, foster-son," said Olaf. In the autumn Olaf took the boy with him west to Shetland, where he had great possessions. Eight years had now elapsed since the death of King Magnus.

2.399

Olaf and Sigurd visit Earl Harald. The Eyskeggs sail to Norway.

2.400

119. The following spring Olaf and Sigurd sailed south to the Orkneys on a visit to Earl Harald, and were well received by him.

2.401

The same spring Hallkel Jonsson made preparations for a voyage, giving out that he would sail on a Wicking expedition to the west; he had a long-ship well manned, and sailed west to the Orkneys. Here he met Olaf Earls-kin, and they told Earl Harald of the coming of King Magnus's son and pleaded his cause, and they begged the Earl to grant him some force. The Earl supported the boy's cause heartily and gave him a good long-ship, for King Magnus had been an excellent friend of Earl Harald. The Earl also gave leave to all who wished to join the expedition of Hallkel and Olaf and their companions. Hallkel and Olaf now gave Sigurd the name of King, and many accepted him as their

liege lord and swore fealty to him. A great multitude now gathered around him from the Orkneys and Shetland, and having procured ships, they started from the west in the summer. When they touched Norway they sailed east coastwise to the Vik with all the speed they could, and came unexpectedly to Tunsberg, where was Jon, a son of King Sverri's sister. They put Jon to death, and Helgi Bring, formerly King Sverri's standard-bearer, and slew many Birkibeins. Then they held an Assembly, at which Sigurd was accepted as King. This band was called the Eyskeggs. Afterwards they sailed up the fiord to Oslo, and all the lands-folk submitted to them here as elsewhere in the Vik, wherever they appeared. They behaved peacefully, leaving every man in possession of his own. But because they had a numerous force and obtained little from the land, they fell short of money. They decided therefore to move the whole force south to Denmark, and sailed as far as the Trafn. Here they captured a merchant-ship, and seized immense booty, chiefly cloth, but much in gold and silver; and turned back to Norway when autumn drew near. King Sverri was in Throntham when he heard of this band; he then despatched a great force by land to the Vik, where some of the chiefs already were. When they heard that the Eyskeggs were coming back to the Vik from the south, the Birkibeins gathered in Borg. Their chiefs were these: Sigurd Lavard, the King's son; Philippus, son of Earl Birgi; Hakon Galin, a son of King Sverri's sister; Petr Steypi; Hiarrandi Hvida, and still more, leaders of companies. They had with them three hundred men. The Eyskeggs heard of them and sailed up the Elf, and when they reached the Borg-fields they went on shore and set their force in-array. But the Birkibeins fled when they saw how great a force the Eyskeggs had; and the Eyskeggs pursued them, slaying some. The Birkibeins fled up into the country, and the Eyskeggs met with no resistance in the Vik henceforth. When autumn was drawing to a close they sailed north to Bergen, where they spent the winter, and laid all the land south of Stad under tax and tribute. They would have themselves called Gullbeins.

King Sverri defeats the Eyskeggs in the battle of Floruvœ [1194].

2.403

120. King Sverri caused a castle to be erected in Bergen on the hill above the Bishops-court, and it held during the winter a strong company of Birkibeins under the command of Sigurd Borgar-Klett. The Eyskeggs made constant attacks on the men in the castle, but succeeded in doing little beyond shooting at them. The Birkibeins returned the shots, and the Eyskeggs usually had the worst of the encounter. In the course of the winter many people crowded to the Eyskeggs and entered their ranks. Sigurd Earlsson, who was with the Birkibeins during the autumn in the Vik, had deserted to the Eyskeggs, and was now a chief man among them. He was considered a sagacious man. One holy day in the early part of Lent, Olaf Earls-kin happened to be hearing mass at Olafskirk on the Banks, and was standing outside close to the church during service with his hand resting on a pillar. One of the men in the castle drew a crossbow, and the bolt drove through the hand, and stood with its point fixed in the pillar; that was a grievous wound. The Eyskeggs despatched troops into the bailiwicks to various places, because they did not expect King Sverri before spring was well advanced. The King passed the winter in Throntham, and having called troops to his side from the districts, made continuous preparations, as if the Eyskeggs were coming there and then from the south. His men lay at the Guildhalls all winter until Lent and spring, when the King set sail from the north. His ships ranged downwards from those that had twenty benches, none being larger. The King sailed south to Bergen with all possible speed; and the Eyskeggs had no intelligence of his voyage before he was close to the town. On the Saturday before Palm Sunday they held an Assembly, at which Olaf Earlskin addressed his troops and said: "We have now learnt the truth about King Sverri's movements; he will soon be here to visit us, and we must decide whether we will await him here, and fight him with such force as we have with us, or determine on another course because many of our men are away. Sigurd Earlsson is south in Stafangr with

six ships; we could sail away south and endeavour to join him. Eystein Korp is in Sogn with three ships; his force can afford us no support.” Then answered Hallkel Jonsson: “In my opinion,” he said, “we are not short of troops at this time to fight King Sverri, if we don’t become more shiftless, and greater ill-luck does not befall us, than is likely. Those who have been opposed to King Sverri seem to me to have failed mostly in counsel; and I expect that we shall conquer him if we don’t proceed rashly. Against rashness we must be on our guard, for we are no less exposed to it than those who were overtaken by it aforetime.” So the more part were eager to fight; they went therefore to the ships and made ready, putting up the war-bulwarks; and when the evening was far gone they sailed out to Floruvøe, where they lay at anchor during the night. The same evening after sunset King Sverri came near Bergen, and going on board a cutter, rowed to the town, while the rest, of the fleet kept farther out and rowed south to Grafsdale. The King now obtained full and accurate information of what the Eyskeggs had done, and he landed on Holm and went up to Kristskirk. The death of Bishop Pal had occurred earlier in the day, and his body then lay in the church. Afterwards the King went up to the castle and bade the defenders to give him help for the battle. The King stayed a short time in the town, and rowed south to his fleet; and then the Birkibeins brought their ships to anchor at Hvarfsness. The King next sailed forth in a boat to Floruvøe, to look into the watch of the Eyskeggs. He there heard their talk, and the whole purpose of Hallkel and his men to fight as soon as it was dawn. “My advice,” said Hallkel, “is to lash our ships together; thus our men can best help one another. We will send a shower of stones on them as long as our supply lasts, then we must let go our missiles, and afterwards make a hand-to-hand onset such as they will remember; and that will soon decide the contest. Let each man do his best, and leave the result to God.” After this, King Sverri went to his men and told them all the intention of the Eyskeggs and their arrangements. “Me-thinks,” he said, “it would be the better plan for us to fall on them quickly, rather than let them attack first; they

will be unprepared to meet us. If we make the attack before light we will mark all our ships by knotting linen tape round their prows. We must be on our guard in the attack, for we have to fight against ships that are higher in the bulwarks than ours. Hold our ships unimpeded at first when the foe is most furious; look to yourselves and keep under cover at first while they throw their missiles; and take good care of your weapons and of the oars, for we shall need them whichever side wins.” King Sverri had twenty ships, rather small, and the Eyskeggs had fourteen, mostly large.

2.404

At dawn the next morning the Eyskeggs were lying in Floruvœ, without awnings to the ships. They next loosed the shore cables and rowed out of the bay; ropes were laid from ship to ship both fore and aft, and the ships were all rowed forward abreast to seek for King Sverri. But as it was dark they did not see King Sverri’s ships before he was close upon them, and both fleets at once raised the war-cry. The Eyskeggs seized the ropes furiously to drag their ships together, and they glided forward under bare poles; but as each ship came against another the oars were broken. The ships were now all tied fast together and glided on against those of the Birkibeins. The battle began immediately; the Eyskeggs made a fierce onset, and the Birkibeins held their shields over their heads so close together that they were nowhere seen uncovered. They let their ships hover about and made an occasional feint to attack; it was easy to see that they were used to such labour, so warily they acted. And when the Eyskeggs began to tire and the fierce storm of missiles to grow less severe, King Sverri urged the Birkibeins and said, “Stand up and use your weapons; be Birkibeins, and let it be seen how your weapons bite.” On this the Birkibeins rose from under their shields and began a second battle storm; some, cast stones, some used their bows, and they drove their ships so close that some used spears and swords. The Eyskeggs withstood them most bravely, reaping then the advantage of their loftier bulwarks. They fixed their grappling-hooks on the King’s ship,

slew the forecastle men and captured the standard, and almost cleared the fore part of the ship as far as the mast. But when they began to board her the King urged his men, and the Birkibeins advanced so stoutly that the Eyskeggs recoiled; some of them were slain, some fell back to their own ships. The Birkibeins now freed their ships from the grappling-hooks. All those that had approached so close to the large ships that the Eyskeggs were able to grapple them, suffered in the same way, and some were disabled; the shock had been most fatal, and the slaughter of the King's men much the greatest. Then the Birkibeins drew their ships away. And King Sverri said, "Take heart, my good fellows, they will not make many such attacks on us; let us bear our losses bravely; they must be no less tooth-sore than we." When the Eyskeggs saw the Birkibeins retire, they thought they meant to flee. And Olaf Earls-kin said, "Do your best now, for they are losing heart; thus it fares with all, I see, that strive against superior force. Let us follow up our victory; cut the tie-ropes and chase them now manfully." All were eager for this, and it was done. But when the ships were loosed asunder, and the men would take to rowing, they lacked the oars, and the ships were driven by the current, each its own way. The Birkibeins rowed up to them and laid two or three ships alongside one. At this moment the defenders of the castle came up from the town in a long-ship; ninety men were on board, all armed with coats of ring-mail. This force was of great help, and now they cleared the ships of the Eyskeggs; and as each large ship was stripped of its crew, the Birkibeins went on it, leaving their small cutters. The Eyskeggs had fixed King Sverri's standard, the *Sigrfluga*, on the prow of their leader's ship; the Birkibeins saw well where to find it, and they pressed hard and ceased not till they had won it. Then they boarded the ship and stripped it from stem to stern. Sigurd Kingsson sprang overboard and was slain in the water. Lodin, son of Pal Smattauga, and Hallvard Bratti, rowed away on different ships. Olaf Earls-kin leapt overboard when his ship was cleared, and swam towards land; but the Birkibeins waded into the water to meet him, and slew him before he came to the

shore. Hallkel's ship was the last to be cleared, for it was the best manned and had the highest bulwarks. Hallkel himself and almost all his crew were slain on board. In the fight nearly all the troops of the Eyskeggs fell, except those that received quarter. The King had commanded that mass should not be sung in the town until he came back from the battle, unless it were long past time. And now he rowed to the town and had all the ships taken with him. The battle had lasted so long that when the King returned it was the time of high mass; and mass was then immediately sung. Shortly after the battle Bard Guthormsson died, and Benedikt Litli, and yet more of the body-guard. In a little while the bodies of Sigurd and Olaf were found; and King Sverri caused the body of Sigurd to be shown to a large multitude, and told them it was the body of the leader whom that band had served. Then he caused the body to be buried south of the choir in Mariukirk yard. A large grave was made, in which were laid the bodies of the Eyskeggs, that of Olaf Earls-kin being placed at the top.

2.405

It is the general opinion that no other battle than this of Floruvœ has been won by a force under such a great disadvantage in the height of their ships' bulwarks. The sagacity shown by the two sides in the attack was very different: the Birkibeins were aided most of all by their experience in fighting; and the Eyskeggs were valiant with their weapons, but rather heedless in protecting themselves.

2.406

When Sigurd Earlsson heard these tidings, he sailed south coastwise as far east as Vik, and thence south to Denmark. Some of the Eyskeggs' force accompanied him, others were scattered in various directions, and many obtained quarter. Eystein Korp sailed west over sea.

2.407

Archbishops Eirik and Absalon send a letter to the Pope about King Sverri. The Pope's ban.

2.408

121. Archbishop Eirik and Archbishop Absalon sent messengers south to Rome with a letter to the Pope. In this letter there was written all about King Sverri, according to the testimony of Archbishop Eirik and his men; also about all the dealings they had with one another before the Archbishop went away from his see. The Archbishops obtained from the Pope the answer which they requested: the Pope pronounced King Sverri excommunicate if he did not allow the Archbishop to have all he asked and claimed. This letter was read aloud in Denmark by order of the Archbishop, and every Sunday the ban upon King Sverri was proclaimed in the chancel. When King Sverri heard of this, he spoke often about the affair in Assemblies, saying that it was an invention of the Danes, and not a message from the Pope, and that he did not suppose Eirik Blindi would put an end to his rule with lies. "The ban and curse," he said, "which he has uttered against me have fallen upon his own eyes, and he is now blind through them. Those who do the work of banning will fall under ban. I am a King's son, and lawfully chosen to this land and realm. I suffered many troubles and worries before I acquired this kingdom, and I will not loose my hold of it because of this ban. Let Eirik return to his see, though he is blind, if he is willing to keep the law of the land, as it is bound here to hold. But if both his eyes were whole, as surely as he is now blind of both, and blind also in the judgment to recognise what is right, yet would I not for his sake violate the law of King Olaf the Saint, though he should ban and curse for ever."

2.409

King Sverri orders the Pope's legate to leave Norway.

2.410

122. Shortly after Easter, King Sverri sailed east after Sigurd Earlsson, for he would scatter the band that held together. He sailed all the way to Konungahella in the spring, and a messenger from the Pope came there, a Legate, and his companions. King Sverri invited them to stay with him, and entertained the Legate for several days. They discussed together of many things, and the King sought from the Legate that he

would consecrate him King and crown him. The Legate received the request favourably; but when other clergy became aware of the design, they informed the Legate that the King was at enmity with the Archbishop, who had gone away from his see, and they said that the Legate should not consent to consecrate him. They laid these charges against the King; that he had been ordained priest formerly; also that he had taken to himself a wife, having already legally married one who was still alive; and they brought up many other matters to slander the King. The next time that King Sverri and the Legate talked of the matter, the Legate refused to consecrate him King, and bade him make peace with the Archbishop, who ought then to consecrate him. The King answered: "I see on what errand you have come to this land: 'tis to act like many others — deceivers. They hasten hither from other lands to get money for themselves, and when they have gone away they turn our kingdom into ridicule. I desire that you leave this land, for I don't wish you to cheat my lieges of their money here in my land." After that, the Legate went away.

2.411

Bishop Nikolas makes peace with King Sverri. The coronation of the King.

2.412

123. King Sverri turned back north into the Vik. Afterwards he despatched men to bring Bishop Nikolas, and when the Bishop arrived, the King demanded a private conversation with him. He told the Bishop that he had come to know that all the treasonous plot which Hallkel surd others had devised against the King had its origin under the roots of the Bishop's tongue, and he supported the charge against the Bishop with proofs. The Bishop denied and protested, but the King said the denial would avail nothing; he had known the whole truth before, he said; and he threatened the Bishop with harsh measures, calling him a traitor to his lord and his country. The Bishop prayed the King for mercy, promised him fealty, and offered to confirm his promise by oath; he declared that he would make such amends for all his offences as the King himself required. The Bishop at this time was

most meek; and King Sverri took him north to Bergen with him. The King sent word to Bishop Thori of Hamar to come as soon as possible to Bergen, and he did so. Bishop Nial also came from Stafangr, and they discussed who should be -chosen to the see of Bergen, in place of Bishop Pal. A man named Martein was chosen, King Sverri's chaplain; he was English in all his kin, and a good clerk. They consecrated him Bishop by direction of King Sverri; the Bishops present being Bishop Nikolas, Bishop Thori, Bishop Niai. Bishop Nikolas was now in close intimacy with King Sverri, an active mover with the King in all plans which the King desired to further. A grand banquet was then held in the Kings-court, at which it was determined that these Bishops should consecrate King Sverri and crown him. So it came to pass that they consecrated him King on the day of the Apostles Petr and Pal; he then took the crown, and Bishop Nikolas was the chief man at the consecration. The King gave good gifts to all, and they separated with much affection.

2.413

Meeting of Bishops in Bergen, and letter to Pope Celestinus [1195].

2.414

124. Bishop Thorlak the Saint had died in Iceland the previous winter, and in the summer Pal Jonsson, son of Jon Loptsson, came from Iceland and passed the winter in Norway, north at Nidaros. The following spring he made a journey overland east to Vik, and met with King Sverri at Oslo, where the King had stayed during the winter. Pal then sailed south to Denmark, and was consecrated Bishop by Archbishop Absalon; and in the summer he sailed back to Norway, and so north to Bergen. King Sverri sailed in the spring north to Bergen, where a meeting was summoned at which all the Bishops in Norway were to be present to advise with the King, because Archbishop Eirik had sent a letter north to Norway and summoned all the Bishops of the land to go to him. All the Bishops came to Bergen, and Bishop Pal came there also. The past summer King Sverri had it much in mind to send a force west to the Orkneys to requite the men of Orkney their treason. When this

was told west in the islands, Earl Harald and Bishop Biarni formed a plan to aid them; the Earl sailed from the west with Bishop Biarni and all the chief men of the Orkneys, and reached Norway at the time of this visit of the Bishops to Bergen. The chiefs then held meetings together and formed plans; and it was determined to send messengers with a letter to the Pope. To this letter were set the seals of King Sverri and all the Bishops who have been named. Bishop Thori offered himself for the journey, and Rikard, a Dominican Master, with him; and they set out to see Pope Celestinus on this business.

2.415

Earl Harold of the Orkneys makes his submission to King Sverri.

2.416

125. After this, King Sverri and Earl Harald debated the charge against the Earl. An Assembly was then summoned in Kristskirk yard, at which the Guardsmen were drawn up close around the King's seat, and some sat in front of him. On the outside of the Assembly there also stood a crowd of men, and here was the Earl. He began to speak, and said: "There is now assembled here a large number of good men, and I may need in my speech much encouragement from the people. I am now an old man, as you can see from my beard. I have drawn near to the knees of many Kings, sometimes with much affection, and often in difficult circumstances. How there is a new difficulty on my hands, the anger of my lord, King Sverri. Less blame is mine in this business than is imputed to me. I did not plan the rising of that band. It is true I did not fight against it, for I could not be hostile to all the people in the land as long as I should be Earl over it. The men of Orkney do not always act as I wish; many leave the Orkneys to plunder in Ireland and Scotland, to pillage merchants, and all contrary to my wish. And yet people say that I am not slow to punish. But there is no need here to speak long, as the thing has been done; I commit all into God's hands and yours, Sire." With these words the Earl went forward among the men and fell at the King's feet. The King looked round and slowly began to speak, saying: "Great ravage you caused in Norway when you raised so strong a force

as the Eyskeggs to make war in the land; and it was done to the great displeasure of me and my men. But the Earl has now come here as you may see; he repents of the offence he committed against us, and begs for mercy. Mercy I will grant him, for I shall need from God greater mercy than I have deserved. Stand up, Lord Earl, and receive God's pardon and mine; I will declare the terms of peace between us at greater leisure." King Sverri put in writing all the conditions of the peace which he made with Earl Harald; and he set down in a scroll all the estates and possessions in the Orkneys and Shetland which had fallen to the King's treasury, the property of those who perished at Floruvoe. He fixed a limit of three years in which the kinsmen of the dead might ransom the estates with money, and if they were not then ransomed they all fell to the King's treasury for ever. King Sverri took Shetland under his own control for tax and tribute; and he set Earl Harald over the Orkneys, with the stipulation that the King should receive half of all the fines, and he appointed bailiffs there. Earl Harald swore oaths of fealty to the King before they parted.

2.417

King Sverri dismisses the Bishops to their sees.

2.418

126. Then King Sverri had a conversation with the Bishops before their departure, and he said: "It is my advice to you, good chiefs, that you guard with wisdom the rule which God has entrusted to you; bear ever in mind that it is not your patrimony nor inheritance. So also, if Eirik Blindi drives you from your rule, he will procure you little good in its place, since, indeed, he procures none for himself; he has now not more than nine or ten men with him, and even these are all at another's charges. But if you hold fast to your league with me, then shall I undertake the guidance of our common cause." They all promised him heartily not to forsake the King and his cause.

2.419

Hreidar Sendiman brings a message to King Sverri from the King of the Greeks.

2.420

127. Hreidar was the name of a Vik-man, who had long been absent from the land, and had travelled far and wide. He came this summer to Norway, bringing a letter and a seal, called the Golden Bull Scroll; this seal was sent by Kirialax, King of the Greeks, to King Sverri, and in the letter it was written that King Sverri should send him ten hundred good warriors. The King of the Greeks had sent a man named Petr, who was called Petr Ilska, with a similar message into Denmark to King Knut, and he had sent a third man to the King of the Swedes. Hreidar Sendiman often spoke to the King of his message, and the King at first took kindly to it, saying that he would think of it; and Hreidar stayed with the King the following winter. In the autumn King Knut of Sweden died, and Sorkvi Karlsson came to the rule and kingdom after him.

2.421

Bishop Nikolas is reconciled to Archbishop Eirik. The Pope's reply to King Sverri's letter.

2.422

128. The same autumn Bishop Nikolas sailed south to Denmark to meet the Archbishops Absalon and Eirik, and made peace with them.

2.423

The following winter Bishop Thori and Master Rikard came from the south, from Rome, to Denmark, and with them a Cardinal from Rome; but they were all seized with sudden illness and died there. No tidings of what happened on their journey came quickly to Norway. But some time afterwards Danes arrived, who brought to King Sverri the letter and seal of the Pope, and said that Bishop Thori and Master Rikard had pledged this letter; and they asserted also that the Bishop and his companion had received money from them on loan. They brought the letter to the King, and he gave them as much money as he thought fit. King Sverri caused the letter to be read aloud to the choir, and showed the Pope's seal with the letter. There stood in the letter that as soon as the Pope knew for certain that the King spoke more truthfully than

the Archbishop, the Pope freed the King and his whole realm from all excommunication. The King said he had been certainly informed that the Cardinal and Bishop Thori and his companion had accepted the hospitality of a priest, and that poison was mixed with their drink during the evening, and they all died.

2.424

Rise of the Bagals under Bishop Nikolas [1196].

2.425

129. The following spring Hreidar Sendiman asked of the King whether his errand there would succeed. The King answered thus: "There does not seem to be the promise of peace here in the land. I hear that the Danes are again feeding wolves to prey on us if they can effect it; and within the land some abide in whom I should put little trust if a hostile band raised its head. I am not willing in these circumstances to send my troops away." Then Hreidar asked if the King would give leave to yeomen's or merchants' sons to go if they were willing; and the King said that might be done. So Hreidar raised a company and set out from the land with it, in the summer, south to Haleyr, where was a market and a trading town. Here came Bishop Nikolas and a great multitude of Northmen with him, mostly Vik-men.

2.426

Bishop Nikolas and his followers had with them a boy whom they called Ingi, son of Magnus Erlingsson, but the Birkibeins asserted that he was a Dane, and his name Thorgils Thufuskit. At the Eyr they raised a band, which was joined by a great multitude, and Archbishop Eirik resolved to go with them. With this band they sailed north to Norway, where was Sigurd, son of Earl Erling, and many men of rank with him. This band was called Bagals.

2.427

King Sverri and the Bagals at Salteyar-sound. Of King Sverri's son Lavard.

2.428

130. King Sverri was then east in the Vik. The Bagals sailed until they came into Salteyar-sound, and King Sverri, who was in Seims-fiord,

heard of them and went to meet them. The King himself went forth to observe them, with Nikolas of Vestness; he learnt what force the Bagals had, and their strength seemed to be great. The King spoke to Nikolas and Sigurd Lavard that they should lay the ships near the homestead called Sonaberg, and taunt the Bagals if they could manage it. He himself rowed to Hastein, where he found watchmen of the Bagals and chased them. Thence he rowed to his fleet. The two forces now shot missiles at one another, but there was small loss of life. The cutter which the King steered lay nearest the shore. The Bagals were on land at a place now called Mugo-fields, and had beached their ships close by. They had five long-ships and a hundred small ships. King Sverri had thirty ships, mostly small. And when the King saw that he could do nothing against the multitude before him, he bade his men act warily and not let their ships be dragged to shore under them. He then placed them out of range on the other side of the sound, close to the island, where he lay for a time.

2.429

On a rock over against the ships of the Bagals King Sverri had a catapult raised, and in the evening when it was ready for use, the Birkibeins shot with it for a while and injured the Bagais' ships. And when the evening grew dusk the King set his son Lavard and Eilif Raudi to keep watch over the catapult. The two had one ship, which was manned by nearly eighty men. And the King said to them, "Be on your guard lest the Bagals come here in the night," and then he went to the ships. The weather was piercing cold, and many of the men kept on foot and strove to warm themselves; others lay huddled close to the catapult. The night was pitch-dark to the utmost. Between the land and island lay a reef, and in the night at low tide the Bagals walked over it and came up into the island. They had a hundred men, all wearing coats of mail, and the Birkibeins under the catapult saw nothing of them till they felt their spears; then they sprang up. Eilif Raudi said, "Drive them off; they are but a handful of men." Then, with a few others, he faced them and defended himself; but they fell, almost

all. Sigurd Lavard, the King's son, tumbled over a cliff, and with him the greater part of the men. They made their way to the ships, as also those who escaped from the fight. The Bagals pursued and overtook them; but the Birkibeins were much aided by the darkness, foe being undistinguishable from friend. However, more than twenty Birkibeins were slain. The Bagals broke the catapult to pieces. When tidings of these things reached the ships, the Birkibeins summoned their men to land, Nikolas of Vestness being first on shore. The Bagals then gradually withdrew to their force. King Sverri soundly rated his son Lavard, telling him the truth when he said: "I kept another manner of watch when we strove for the land against King Magnus. Woe betide the King's son who looks so badly after his men as thou hast done. Get thee on shore, and come not into my sight before day dawns." Many then went on land and kept watch till day.

2.430

Interchange of contemptuous language between Bishop Nikolas and the Birkibeins.

2.431

131. It happened one day while King Sverri lay in Seims-fiord that his men were rowing him on a cutter, close under the land, and the Bagals came forward on a rock and shouted at them. And Sigurd Earlsson said, "Is my meat-giver, Sverri, on the cutter?" Liot Haraldsson answered him, "lung Sverri is here on board, and I may say with truth, he never gave meat to a worse man, and you now show it." Then Bishop Nikolas exclaimed, "Why don't you come, on land, Sverri? Are you not willing to fight now, you renegade? You think no life equal to that of robbing and harrying. Now I will wait for you here. Behold my sleeve" (and with that he held up his shield); "the mitre and staff which by the Pope's command I bear against you are this helmet and sword; I will carry these weapons until you are slain or driven from your realm." As he spoke the Birkibeins ever broke in with cries, and said, "We should find it no hard task to land, if there were only such opponents as you, dastard; you will carry those weapons till the day of doom." Others

spoke thus, "You will carry your weapons to your own hurt, as you have done in the past." The King bade them cease, and not waste breath in talking to him. The Bishop again called out, "You ever question my courage, you Birkibeins. Now do you, Sverri, come on shore alone, and I will meet you alone. We shall then see whether the Apostle Petr and Saint Hallvard will afford me more aid than you will get from that Gaulish ogress in whom you trust." King Sverri's reply was addressed to his men: "If Nikolas and I had a duel, men would call it a dog-fight, in which neither combatant showed pluck." The King then rowed away to his force.

2.432

Birkibeins and Bagals separate without a battle. King Sverri goes north to Throntham, the Bagals to Sarpsborg.

2.433

132. The morning after the skirmish the King held a council, and inquired of his men what plan should be taken. Nikolas of Vestness answered, "It seems to us ill to lie here, Sire, our provisions being scanty; we wish now to attack them and fight, to conquer or fall valiantly; or else let us sail away where we can get provisions." The King replied, "In what you say, Nikolas, you utter the thought of many, and I know that the levies long to go home. But however ill it seems to them to lie here, it will seem no better to any of those who lie within the Sound; if we abide patiently, they will break up their gathering. Yet, as you wish now to go away, it shall be done." The King bade them make ready the ships for going away, and so it was done. The day was Sunday, and the King caused the bodies of the slain to be removed to the church in Salteyar-sound. This done, he directed his course north with all the fleet, and had a fair wind to Bergen. He now permitted all the levies to depart, but he himself held on his northern course, and spent the winter in Throntham. The Bagals meanwhile advanced north into the Vik, and summoned an Assembly at Borg, at which King Magnus's son Ingi was chosen King. The whole of the Vik and the Uplands now submitted to them, and they appointed men to all the

bailiwicks. Bishop Nikolas was at his see in Oslo during the winter, and at times south in Denmark. Ivar Skialgi was now consecrated Bishop of Hamar-Kaupang. The Bagals were now joined by Hallvard of Sasteads, Kolbein Strinef, and many others. This winter Bishop Nikolas and Sigurd Earlsson took much money belonging to King Sverri out of the wall of Mariukirk, in Hofudey, and carried it away with them.

2.434

King Sverri summons a full levy, and sets sail with it from Bergen. His address to the men [1197].

2.435

133. The next spring Bishop Nikolas and Sigurd Earlsson went up into Heidmork, whence they despatched a force north over the fell. It came down to the fiord named Aldi, above Rugsound, and there slew Thori Dari and Einar Lygra, King Sverri's bailiffs, and their company. The nearest bailiffs, Thori Krak and Thorgils, escaped to King Sverri, and the Bagals marched back to the Uplands.

2.436

In the winter, after Yule, King Sverri held an Assembly of the yeomen, and called out a levy over all the communities of the Thronds, Halogaland, North and South Moeri, and Raumsdale, and summoned all the troops to join him early in the spring. By Hallvard's mass-day he had come with all the force south to Bergen, thirty hundred men, all on shipboard. The King remained in Bergen a long time through the summer, until Margret's mass-day, waiting for the full levy which had been summoned from all the country south of Stad; and before he set sail from Bergen, troops had collected around him to the number of sixty hundred. He sailed south with the force into Groeninga-sound, and men thought it strange that he did not proceed on his voyage, but he gave no heed to what was said. The King held an Assembly of the yeomen, and made a long speech in presence of his troops, so that he was heard both by them and the yeomen. He had a great multitude of men in the levies, and they were in many ways a turbulent and unruly force. The King addressed them at this Assembly, and thus spoke: —

2.437

“It is unbecoming in you, esteemed sons of yeomen, to come from Thronðham, or Halogaland, or Moeri, or maybe shorter distances, that you may make war on yeomen’s farm implements, tubs, or other household utensils, hewing them and cutting them, just because you find them in your way. It shows neither skill nor prowess in you, and is a loss to the owners. I bid you do so no longer, and this language would not be heard from a King unless there were need. I cannot be called ruler of this land if I do not take measures to stop this disorder and to prevent its growing. I bid you, in friendly words, to cease this unruliness, for I am very unwilling to punish you; but punishment will have to be inflicted if there is no improvement. I deem that I have so fully attained to the rule and government of this land, though Bishop Nikolas denies it, that I need not proclaim it twice or thrice when there is no greater reason than what I have just mentioned. But I don’t think I understand what Bishop Nikolas means when he says that I cannot be King over Norway. Many have borne the name of King who have only been sons of handmaids; but I am a true son of King Sigurd and of Gunnhild. Now many know of what family she is; but if there are some here who, as I suppose, have not that knowledge, I am able to tell them something of it.” Then the King set forth all her lineage to the whole Assembly, and many recognised their own relations to be akin to him, both on the father’s side and the mother’s side, who had no knowledge of it before. The King ended his speech by saying that he knew of no one at that time in Norway who had a better right, before God or man, to bear the name of King than he himself. “And though Bishop Nikolas would prefer another,” he said, “we Birkibeins will care no more about that now than aforetime. The King who governs the realm needs to be both severe and upright; and though Nikolas is glib of tongue, he seems to me to have the heart of a hare and the falseness of a fox; such has always been my experience of him. Yea, though we reckon up all the progeny of Ingirid, none will be found faithful. Magnus was not true, nor was Buriz true, of whose faithlessness there were evident proofs.” But it is best to leave such matters in quiet, for it

will be seen at last of every man what he is. In a short time, I expect, we Birkibeins will go and seek a meeting with those Bagals, and we shall then see how faithful and true is Master Brushtail to those plotters against us Birkibeins.”

2.438

King Sverri plans an attack on the Bagals in Oslo.

2.439

134. The Assembly broke up after this speech; the yeomen returned home, the Birkibeins and the levies went back to the ships. After a short delay a fair breeze blew, and the King gave the signal for departure; they hoisted sail and sailed east coastwise, not stopping till they came within the fiord to Oslo, where the Bagals confronted them with all their force. The afternoon of Jacob’s mass-day, King Sverri anchored his fleet at Hofudey, and next morning he went on shore to attend service. On his return to the ships he held a council with his men, and thus spoke: “The Bagals are in the town with a very great force ready to receive us; listen now carefully to my arrangements for the attack. My son Hakon, with all his cutters, shall row to the Leira, [the muddy shore] within Nunnusetr, where the men will land and thence march to the town; let them attack the men on the quays in the rear. My barons, Gregorius Jonsson, Sigurd of Modasteads, and Eystein Rognvaldsson, with the men of Moeri, shall direct their ships to the Eyra, close by Mariukirk yard, land there and march up the southern street. All the rest of the force shall row with my standard to the quays, where their main strength will be posted. Go now to the ships and let us bear in upon them.” The war-blast was blown, the whole host rowed towards shore, and the ships fell into divisions, as the King had commanded.

2.440

Battle at Oslo between King Sverri and the Bagals; the Birkibeins are victorious,

2.441

135. Bishop Nikolas made a speech to the Bagals when arranging all their ranks, and thus spoke: “Sigurd Earlsson with his company, and Hallvard of Sasteads with the Uplanders, shall together draw up their line within Nunnusetr, and take care that the enemy do not land there. Onund Hlynn’s sons and Kolbein Strinef, with a company the stoutest of all, shall be on the Eyra and watch the bridge, lest they come that way into the town; the King’s standard, my force, and the townsmen shall defend the quays. King Sverri has not so numerous a force as you suppose. His ships are thinly manned, only a single man at the most to each half-cabin. Do you not see that they have set up their hammocks in the cabins; perhaps you think those are men? The Birkibeins are under ban, so that their swords will not bite, and they will not dare to begin the attack. Be of good courage, therefore; if Sverri attacks us, the hand of death is upon him. Possibly he may make such an attempt as at Seims-fiord.” The Bishop was on horseback, accompanied by several clerks, and was in the street near his Court when the attack began and both sides raised the war-cry. King Sverri’s ships drove so hard forward that the merchant vessels which lay in their way were broken; for the Bagals had sunk some ships in front of the quays, so that the Birkibeins were unable to come close up, and the two hosts shot bolts and hurled missiles. The Birkibeins pressed to shore over the merchant ships, and the first to get on the quays were Bengeir Langi and Botolf Aufursson. An Englishman at once struck at Bengeir, saying they should not land there. But Bengeir turned the blow aside — he was most skilled of men with sword and buckler — and struck the Englishman under his shield. The blow fell below the nose and struck off the lower jaw. Many Birkibeins now pressed forward to the quays; the Bagals met them valiantly, and there was a hard fight. A man spoke to the Bishop: “*Bide* forward, Sire, and hard,” he said, “our men need you to strengthen them; the Birkibeins’ swords seem to us to be biting now,” But the Bishop replied; “Let us ride off as fast as we can, the devil has got loose.” After this, they ran out of the town, and stopped not before they came to the Giolluras, where they waited for their force.

2.442

Gregorius Jonsson and those with him drove their ships to the mouth of the stream at the Eyra. The water was shallow, and when the ships touched ground the men leapt overboard, waded ashore, and then marched boldly up. The Bagals' company had stayed near the Geita-bridge; but when they saw the Birkibeins had landed, they set on them so fiercely that the Birkibeins gave way and turned to their ships; some were slain, some plunged into the water. When they had come on board they rowed farther out to Thrælaberg, where they landed, and then marched along the fields towards the town. The Bagals, seeing them, hastened over the Geita-bridge to meet them, and a fierce fight occurred a second time with them. —

2.443

Hakon, the King's son, drove his ships to the Leira, so that all the cutters at once ran to dry land. The men leapt on shore quickly, drew up in battle array and marched against the Bagals. At first they threw missiles, then they thrust with their spears. The Bagals did not wait where they stood for the blows, but fled north of the town. The Birkibeins followed, slaying every man they overtook; but some of them turned into the town, to the rear of the men on the quays, and smote them on the neck. King Sverri's standard, the Sigrfluga, had come on the quays, and at this moment the Bagals and townsmen took to flight; some fled out of the town, others into the houses. King Sverri walked up the long street, and when he was come into the lanes he beheld his men out on the fields fighting. He turned, therefore, over the river above the town and went along the fields. His men attacked the Bagals in the rear, and almost the whole of that company was slain. The Birkibeins ransacked the town, broke into the houses, and slew many Bagals; but many ran out and fled from the town. There were companies of the Birkibeins on the fields and companies up at Mortustokka, and they ever fell on the Bagals as they were escaping. There was a very great slaughter, especially of the Bagals, but almost all their chiefs escaped at this time.

2.444

Division of the spoil. Bishop Nikolas sues for peace.

2.445

136. After this, King Sverri summoned his whole force to Mortustokka, and there had speech with them, and said: "God be thanked that He has not been less favourable to us Birkibeins now than heretofore, in giving us the victory; and I should expect that Nikolas Brushtail will scarcely have taken himself off with undaunted heart. Yet I would say to all that I will have the ships moved out to Hofudey; I don't wish to suffer a reverse, and we must guard against surprises, if there are those among them who think of returning to the town as soon as they suppose our men to be careless or steeped in drink. I will not allow them to get to windward of my force." The men therefore went to the ships and did as the King bade. But before they departed they laid hands on all goods in the town, because the yeomen and merchants had borne arms against the King. They seized the long-ships there, and burnt the greater part of them, but took with them the Bokaskreppa, which had belonged to Bishop Nikolas, and the Gullsud, which had been built by Hidi. Hidi now took the Bokaskreppa, and burnt the Vidsia, his former ship; but he saved the nails and the sail, for the tackle belonged to the yeomen. The King now lay close to Hofudey, and the booty to be shared was carried to a field on the south of the island, where it was placed in four divisions. A council was now called, at which the King talked with his men. He then caused them to pass under the pole, and the force was numbered to see how many he had; there were five tens of hundreds.

2.446

At this time a priest arrived from Bishop Nikolas, and he bore a letter to King Sverri, which the Bishop had caused to be written. There stood in the letter that the Bishop desired to be reconciled to the King. The King answered that the Bishop had done the same before, and that nothing had come of it. "I know not," said he, "if this reconciliation will prove any better, but I would grant Nikolas pardon if he came

himself to see me. You may tell him also that I have more ways of winning renown than by slaying him if he falls into my power. He is his own master; let him come if it seems good to him.”

2.447

The King now demanded of his Guardsmen and the levies the ships that had been seized, and all the tackle with them, for fifteen marks of gold. But the men thought the sum would not be a third of the value of what he took; so Sigvaidi Karl, Sigurd of Modasteads, and Eystein Rognvaldsson, with many others, went up and dragged the tackle and sails into the four divisions, like the other booty. The King, informed of this, sprang from the ship; he had a switch in his hand, and used it. Most of the men took to flight, throwing to the ground what they held when they saw the King was angry. Sigvaidi waited and stood his ground, and the King struck him twice across the shoulders. Sigvaidi made no resistance. The King stopped, and said that they acted badly to break his commands; the means to defend the land he would have for himself, and ships also. And so it was; the King paid the price just as he wished. On the third day the force was summoned to the sharing. Lots were cast for the four divisions; then the owners of each quarter divided their shares into twelfths. And so the property was divided, till at last single shares were reached. The booty was so large that each man's share was not less in value than two marks of silver by weight.

2.448

The King stayed here little short of half a month.

2.449

The Bagals surprise Nidaros, and Thorstein Kugad surrenders the castle of Steinbiorg.

2.450

137. We have now to speak of the Bagals. After their flight the chiefs and main body of the force marched by land over the Uplands, and so north to Throndham, and to Nidaros. When they reached the castle of Steinbiorg, they set their troops about it, and gave out that they would fix their tents there. Thorstein Kugad, Bialfi Steinstakk, and Asgaut

were then in the castle, and they had about eighty men with them; they lacked neither weapons nor provisions, nor yet drink. The Bagals could effect nothing. Then they held meetings with the townsmen, and an Assembly in Kristskirk yard, at which they required from the town a contribution of food, and demanded a levy from the yeomen of the district. They now followed the custom of the Birkibeins, and made men swear allegiance to them, and take oath not to serve in any band that opposed them or their King. After this they proceeded to the castle, and showered missiles at the men for a long time. Then they called to them. Bishop Nikolas spake to Thorstein: "It is unwise of you to hold the castle and to be under ban. You will suffer more in another place; for we shall send a force to Stein and Gudrekssteads, your estates, plunder everything there, then set fire to the buildings, and burn down the homestead." Thereupon Thorstein summoned Bialfi Steinstakk, and said that it was unwise to hold the castle long, if the foe should besiege it. Their talk ended in an agreement to surrender the castle, but none of the other men knew of their intention. There was a secret door to the castle, and to this Thorstein went, that he might hold converse with the Bagals. Gudbrand Ungi went to meet him, and they formed a plan between them. Thorstein requested the Bagals to go into the town first, and return in the evening when the men in the castle least expected. "I will then," said he, "let this door be open for you." Gudbrand, in return, promised on the part of the Bagals that all the garrison should receive quarter, and keep their weapons and clothes. So the Bagals marched down into the town, and in the evening back to the castle. Thorstein let the secret door be open, and the Bagals entered. This happened as the men sat at meat, and they perceived nothing till the castle was full of Bagals. Quarter was given to the garrison, and they kept the clothes they had on; but few were allowed their weapons, and none their money. Asgaut and Bialfi went away into the district; but Thorstein Kugad accepted service with the Bagals, and went with them. The Bagals seized all the property in the castle, and then burnt every building of it. They took a dead man and

cast him into the well, and then filled it up with stones. Before they left the castle they called upon the townsmen to break down all the stone walls; and before they marched from the town they burnt all the King's long-ships. After this they returned to the Uplands, well pleased with the booty they had gained in their journey.

2.451

King Sverri and the yeomen, at an Assembly near Godmar, in the Vik.

2.452

138. We have to tell of King Sverri that he sailed out of the fiord of Oslo, turned south to Godmar, and steered to a place called Fyrileif, on the south side of the fiord. Here the King summoned an Assembly of the yeomen, and laid to their charge that they had joined the gathering against him at Seims-fiord, and elected another King over his head. The King's speech was answered by a man named Helgi, who thus spoke: "That band was joined by few men from our districts, and even they were not eager. We see no trace of ourselves, Sire, in this. We are so old — our eye-teeth are cut — that we can see before walking into a blind alley. Our acquaintance with law and the rights of men of rank in Norway, made us know where it was legal to choose a King, and we consider no man rightly chosen to rule the land except at the Eyra Assembly in Throntham. Now, Sire, you may see in your wisdom, that we are not such simple men as to crowd without reflection into a band marked with no better stamp; one, too, that was opposed to you, Sire." He succeeded in pleasing the King greatly with his words. Several speeches were then made at the Assembly, all tending to peace.

2.453

King Sverri in the Vik. He leaves his brother Hidi in Tunsberg.

2.454

139. After this the King sailed away and anchored in Nauta-sound; and he sent his men on a journey through a certain wood, where they met with Bagals, who attacked them and slew twelve men. Afterwards the King sailed to Svanhals, and thence to the Elf; but the people all took refuge in the woods. The King sent a message to the yeomen that they

should come to him in safety, for he wished to make peace with them, and he summoned an Assembly; but they, conscious of their crimes against the King, tarried and delayed a long time. The delay was displeasing to the troops, and they held a secret meeting and planned to break up the levy. A man named Olaf Beitstokk, a House-carle of the King, was chief instigator. But as soon as the King heard of this, he had Olaf seized and put to death, and the others lost all their eagerness for the plan. The King once more summoned the yeomen to an Assembly, threatening to burn up all their districts if they did not come. The yeomen now came and held an Assembly with the King, and finally bound themselves to pay fines to the King for their treason. The following day war contributions, levied tax, and fines came in, many hundred cattle and much money besides. After that, the King sailed north to the Vik, and turned into Oslo, for he now heard that the Basais had returned from Throntham and were coming to Oslo. The King marched to meet them; but when he came upon the Giolluras, he learnt that they had moved south by the upper road as soon as they heard the King was in the town. King Sverri returned to Oslo, and afterwards sailed to Tunsberg, whence he despatched Earl Philippus, son of Birgi Brosa, to the lake Miors, where the Earl was to remain if he could there make onslaughts on the Bagals. The King intended that his own brother Hidi should go there too, but he was not ready. The King sailed from Tunsberg to go to Bergen; he had a favourable wind when he set out, and Hidi was left behind with his company. The King sailed north into Helga-sound; and he here learnt that Sigurd Earlsson, from the north, must have sailed past him, and he deemed that the Earl's voyage would be a danger to Hidi. Early in the morning, therefore, he summoned a council, and thus spoke: "Our men left behind are in an unhopeful state, I fear. My brother Hidi will have a narrow escape. He will think that as I sail north with the whole host the look-out will be well kept, and he will be off his guard. I fear we have not made the harbours sure." So the King took all the cutters and swift ships,

manning them with the best; and he himself went with them, purposing to seek Sigurd.

2.455

Sigurd Earlsson slays Hidi and other Birkibeins at Tunsberg.

2.456

140. Sigurd had used foresight, and sailed out of the usual track. He lay at anchor among the islands called Sveina, whence he watched the King's host as it sailed along the inner main road. In the night he sailed up to the town, and arrived quite unexpected by Hidi and his company. The Bagals rushed into the town, and soon found the Birkibeins, who were in Asleifsgard at their drink, in the south sitting-room. Nearly all sprang out of doors without weapons, and were immediately slain on the spot. The churches were all locked and afforded them no refuge. Hidi ran south from the sitting-room to the brew-houses, and climbed up under the boards of a shed between the buildings, not daring to flee out of the town because the Bagals kept watch all around it. In the morning when it was light the Bagals ransacked the town, slaying the Birkibeins wherever they found them. A scout of the Bagals named Hviting discovered Hidi, and Hidi begged the man not to betray him, giving him a gold ring. The youth made him a fair promise, but at once told the Bagals when he met them, and Hidi was taken and slain. Sigurd sailed away straightway the same day about the time of the morning meal. From forty to fifty men were slain with Hidi, many of them being Guardsmen.

2.457

King Sverri, after a vain pursuit of Sigurd Earlsson, passes the winter at Bergen.

2.458

141. King Sverri rowed first to Tunsberg, and there learnt the tidings that had occurred. Then he told his men that he would go after Sigurd and endeavour to overtake him. He sailed away at once, then east across the Fold, and learnt that Sigurd had sailed in haste east into the Vik, and the King followed him. When there was but a short distance

between them, Sigurd learnt of the King's movements, and turned through Lana-sound and sailed up into Befia. Shortly after King Sverri came and instantly made towards them. Sigurd's men pulled down the awnings and sent forth a shower of missiles; but before the King's ships ran against them, almost all the men had gone on land, and as soon as the Birkibeins sprang on shore they fled, Sigurd hastening over the bridge. When the Birkibeins were come on shore they ran forward in array to the bridge. By this time most of Sigurd's men had passed over, and a few were slain there. The Bagals broke down the bridge and fled up the country. The Birkibeins seized their ships and all that was on them; some of the cutters they took away, some they burnt. The King now turned back northwards and went straight to Bergen, where he abode during the winter.

2.459

The Birkibeins at Nidaros. The Bagals again capture the town the following year [1198].

2.460

142. When the King left his men in Helga-sound in the autumn they sailed away straightway with the large ships north to Bergen, and thence to Throndham. The first to come north were Eyiolf Aflason, Eirik of Ha, and Arni Skadared, with three ships, and they learnt that the Bagals were in the town and had done injury to many. They arrived at Holm about break of day, and Eirik with two ships rowed into the river, while Eyiolf steered to the sands under the castle, and his men made their way outside the town to the bridge. The Bagals were unaware of the Birkibeins before they were already in the town and the trumpets were blowing; then they fled, some to the churches, some to the bridge, where there were men ready to attend upon them. Some fled hither and thither and escaped, some were slain, some received quarter. This was three days before Andres' mass-day. The Birkibeins then dragged their ships to shore on the Eyra, and took the town in charge, as also the bailiwicks of the district.

2.461

In the winter, after Yule, the Bagals slew Jon Magri in this manner. They sent a force to attack him in his house. A man named Solvi went up to the door and bade Jon come forward and unlock it, and Jon, recognising his voice, came to the door. Solvi then said, "Open the door, I have tidings to tell you."

2.462

"They ought to be good," said Jon, and he undid the lock and opened the door. Solvi ran his sword instantly through him, so that the point came out at his back. Jon seized him round the neck immediately and forced him prostrate to the ground, himself upon him. He then tried to reach the sword that hung beside his bed, but swooned away and died there.

2.463

The Bagals had now so numerous a following that all over the Vik and the Uplands were large bands belonging to their force. Hallvard of Sasteads had charge of their young King. They were then in the Uplands, and after Yule marched north over the fell. They came down past the wood of Updale and Rennabu, where they slew Ivar Arman and Thorleif Styria. Then they passed into Orkadale; there they slew Einar Skitinbeini; and at Eggia, in Skaun, they slew Skeggi, and afterwards proceeded to the town. Gunnar Galin and Einaridi Rakki had escaped them and brought the tidings to the town. Gunnar went to the Eyra and set the long-ships on fire, for he would rather burn them than let the Bagals use them. But the ships were slow to catch fire, and the Bagals came upon him before he was aware, and slew him, and Eindridi with him. This took place two days before Brettifa's mass-day. The Bagals then captured the town, but many of the Birkibeins had fled, having had timely notice of the approach of the Bagals. They met with no resistance in the town, and gave quarter to many who submitted to them and asked for it. Here they abode during the spring, and then called out a levy over all Throntham, pushed the ships to the water's edge, and prepared to defend themselves to the best of their power. The Birkibeins dwelt in the woods and forests, having wretched shelter, as

may be supposed, and waited for King Sverri to come and deliver his men out of their great misery. The name of King was now given to Ingi, and Bard was the name of the man who conferred it. The Bagals took both war contributions and men, appointed bailiffs over the districts, and manned their ships. Their host was both numerous and well equipped, and when spring was drawing to a close they moved their fleet over the Fiord to Raudabiorg. It was the week before Hallvard's mass-day that the encounter occurred.

2.464

Drawn battle between King Sverri and the Bagals at Thorsbiorg.

2.465

143. King Sverri made ready his cutters and swift ships, and sailed from Bergen with all speed by way of the Sounds, hoping to surprise the Bagals, as he had ever surprised his enemies aforetime. His voyage sped well, and when he came up the Fiord beyond Agdanes he met with a ship of the Bagals in the haven called Solvi. The Birkibeins rowed up to them and slew almost all the men on the ship; those who escaped got on shore. When the Birkibeins sailed farther up the Fiord beyond Hornbori, they came upon a cutter of the Basais; this crew rowed to land and leapt ashore, but some were slain. The Birkibeins then rowed across the Fiord to Rein, where the Bagals were with a twenty-benched ship. The Birkibeins slew well-nigh all the crew, but some leapt ashore. The Birkibeins seized all the property. Some wished to take the ship with them, but the King thought it would be unable to keep pace with their cutters in the rowing, and they left it behind, but soon repented. The rowing of the Birkibeins now brought them within sight of the Bagals, who straightway took down the awnings, placed their ships side by side, and fastened them together. They had seven ships, all of great size, and they lay off Thorsbiorg. There was a light breeze blowing from the north-east over the Fiord, and the Bagals' ships scudded before it under bare poles.

2.466

When King Sverri saw where the Bagals were, he made the trumpets sound a war-blast, and set up his standard, and called on his men to attack. The Birkibeins rowed up to them and shot at them for a while. They rowed their cutters around the ships of the Bagals, keeping to windward, for they could be where they wished, near or far. The difference in the height of the bulwarks seemed very great to the Birkibeins; and so it was, for the prows of their cutters reached no higher than the war-bulwarks of the Bagals. The shower of missiles was heavy and long. The Birkibeins did not drive their ships so near that the Bagals could fix their grappling-hooks on them. There was slaughter on both sides, and many were wounded. When the King perceived that no progress was made in this way, he bade his men withdraw the cutters; they did so, and brought them together out of range. Then the King spoke: "The Birkibeins are not such as they were aforetime. The old Birkibeins did not go into the fight as you do, with trailing kirtles. Their kirtles were shorter and tighter, and their hearts stouter. Why do we lie here now? Let us row to the town; or else be valiant, and so set on them that you may know whether your swords or theirs bite the keener." But before the King had finished speaking, the Birkibeins raised a shout, one urging the other; and so hard at first did they pull that the long-ships grappled the cutters. The Birkibeins made so stern and fierce an onset with spear thrusts and sword blows, that the Bagals recoiled and went under shelter. Solmund Systrung and his men, five together, boarded the ship of Gudbrand Ungi. Then Gudbrand called on his men to drive them back, and the Bagals made a hard onslaught, so that the Birkibeins fell back, and some were slain. The Bagals then pressed hard after them, hurling both weapons and stones, and having the advantage of their high bulwarks. They threw down on them masses of stone that nothing could resist, and so heavy was the shower of weapons that the Birkibeins were scarcely able to stand under it. Many of them fell. The Bagals fixed their grappling-hooks on the ships of the Birkibeins and held them fast. The Birkibeins all adopted one plan, which no man needed to learn from another.

They pushed their punting-poles against the large ships, and freed themselves as best they could. The crew of the King's ship succeeded in getting rid of the grappling-hooks, and so also Nikolas of Vestness. Solmund Systrung fell and all his company, and another cutter of the Birkibeins was stripped, but the Birkibeins got both ships. Nikolas of Vestness was wounded, struck by a bolt which pierced the front of his steel cap, but the wound did not look dangerous. Then King Sverri said, "We are no match for them in battle at this time; let us leave them alone and row to the town." The Birkibeins then withdrew.

2.467

Birkibeins and Bagals leave Nidaros for Bergen.

2.468

144. A man named Ogmund, who was called Vagapung, had been a bailiff of the Bagals. He was of an Upland family, and had a bailiwick in Orkadale. He had command of the ship that Eyjolf brought in the autumn. The ship was lying close to Ingardale, under a cliff called Hrafnas, and as Ogmund looked across the Fiord he saw the fight between the Birkibeins and Bagals. His crew wrangled about what should be done; some wished to help their fellows, others preferred to go ashore. So this ship afforded no aid to the Bagals at this time.

2.469

King Sverri steered up the Fiord, and between the mouth of the Thina and Thraungvi he met with a ship of the Bagals and chased its crew to land. He next steered across the Fiord to Fladkafiord, where he drove two ships to shore near Kleppsteads; then he sailed to the town and stayed there. The Bagals started to follow him, assured in their hearts that nothing would prevent their taking King Sverri in the town, for his men were few and disabled; many of his force had fallen off Thorsbiorg during the day, valiant warriors, and many were so wounded that they could not bear arms even if they attempted. But the Bagals did not venture to steer their ships to Eyra when they came to the town, for they feared that if they landed with the men they had got in Throntham, these would not be true to them, and would either

join King Sverri or march off home as soon as they put foot on land. Therefore no attack was made, and the Bagals lay at sea under Holm. King Sverri was on the Eyra ready to resist them if they landed there.

2.470

The Bagals now took counsel, and it seemed their wisest plan to sail south to Bergen, to reduce the land everywhere to subjection, and to give no heed where Sverri should go with his cutters; they thought he would have no strength under him should they meet him anywhere and there be need to fight at sea. Nikolas of Vestness gave no care to his wound, thinking it a small matter, and went to the bath; then the wound festered, and he lay but a short time before he died. His loss was great. Afterwards the Bagals sailed south coastwise with all their force, keeping well together, for they had ever a dread of King Sverri, his schemes more than the number of his ships, and feared that if they separated they would suffer some blow from him. The Bagals lay in the harbour of Angr, north of Stad. King Sverri sailed away south from Kaupang after them. He rowed past them the day after he left the Hereys, and sailed beyond Stad on his way south. The Bagals saw him, pulled down their awnings, and declared they would row ahead of him. But it came to nothing. King Sverri gave no heed to them, but proceeded on his voyage south, and they followed him soon afterwards.

2.471

Attempt of Sigurd JSarlsson to burn the castle of Bergen.

2.472

He retires on the approach of King Sverri.

2.473

145. Sigurd Earlsson had sailed from the east, out of Vik, and learnt that King Sverri had gone north from Bergen. He brought his ships therefore to Bergen, where he met with no resistance; he took King Sverri's ships and burnt the Sygnabrand and others that he got. Buildings belonging to the Guardsmen were taken down and carried to the castle, on the windward side of which a great pile was made, where

it seemed likely that a fire would do most harm to the people in the castle. When the garrison saw these things they told Queen Margret; she was then in the castle, and with her Aura-Pal, who was in command. The tidings put her and many other women in great fear; and the Birkibeins in the castle deemed it needful to use precautions. Aura-Pal devised a scheme. They took a barrel, which they filled with chips, birch-bark, and tar. Then they set fire to it, and slung it to the pile of wood, in face of the Bagals, before it was completed and put together. So great a flame arose that the Bagals were unable to slake it before all the wood was scattered which they had brought together. This caused great delay; but they tried a second time and gathered wood together. And now the Queen begged the garrison for God's sake to give up the castle, and make terms to leave it, rather than fire and flame should reach them; the worst plan was to let all perish together, men and goods. Outside, over the castle gate, was a room that had formerly been a prison, and Pal advised that all the women should go there, saying that they would shortly have a chance to leave the castle. Thither the women went, glad in this hope, and when they were come into the room he slammed the door and fixed a bar in front. There was no lack of food for them.

2.474

There was a man named Asgaut who was a shepherd. He took an empty butter-chest, cut holes all over it, and filled it with birch-bark, tow, and brimstone. Then he set fire to it and slung it to the pile, which had been so built as to be hollow in the inside. When the fire caught it, it blazed up into so great a flame that the Bagals were unable to slake it, and the whole pile was burnt up before them. After this, they moved away to the town, and Pal went to the Queen and asked what she would give him if he found a plan to make the Bagals withdraw. He would win much wealth, she answered, and she bade him do it if he knew the way. And Pal asked her to entrust her seal to him, which she did. Then he wrote a letter, which he signed with the Queen's seal and directed to priests Anti and Jordan Skinnpeta. "We suppose," so ran the letter,

“that you will have the highest regard for what touches the King, though now you lean somewhat to the Bagals. We have, however, a secret matter to tell you, important tidings which the King has sent us. He has met his foes north in Thronðham, and happily the end is the same as of old: the King has conquered them, although he has lost brave men, Nikolas of Vestness, Solmund Systrung, and many others. And now the King begs you, of your good faith, to delay the departure of the Bagals from the town. He himself will come in the morning, either early or late.” In the castle there was a Vik-boy, an acquaintance of the Bagals. Him Pal hired to deliver the letter into the priests’ hands; men from the castle accompanied him and left him at a certain rock. The Bagals on the watch saw what went on, and thinking that very likely some one was attempting to desert the garrison, stole noiselessly to the rock, found the boy lying there and took him prisoner, and as they knew him they gave him quarter. They inquired what he meant to do. “I am carrying a letter to priests Anti and Jordan,” he answered, “but I don’t know what is in it.” The Bagals took the letter and carried it to Sigurd Earlsson, who, seeing what was in it, suspected an immediate attack. At dawn the next morning, therefore, he gave his men the signal to depart; and they took much wealth from the priests Anti and Jordan, believing them to be unfaithful. After that, they sailed away south. As the Bagals rowed out of the bay, Pal told the Queen, and she went out on the castle to see, and gave many thanks to Pal for his device.

2.475

Birkibeins and Bagals at Bergen. King Sverri and the men of Bergen.

2.476

146. King Sverri arrived at the town early in the morning, and went straight to the castle, where he met those in command, Sigurd Borgarklett and Aura-Pal, and told them of his movements, and that he was only staying there a short time. And the King said to Sigurd, “You must demand help from the townsmen and take whatever you can, for we shall need help, maybe, when next we come to the town.” King

Sverri sailed away from the town in the course of the day, and steered south to Siggiarvoe. The same day Hallvard arrived at the town with the host of the Bagals and the large ships, and left again immediately to seek King Sverri. The King saw their sails, and bade his men steer the ships seaward out of sight. "Let them sail past," he said, "southward." And so it was that the Bagals sailed past them southward and did not observe the Birkibeins where they lay. As soon as they had sailed by, the King turned his ships back again north to Bergen with the utmost speed. He went up to the castle to his men and inquired what force Sigurd had raised; and Sigurd answered that the yeomen gave no heed to his words, and would do nothing for the King's honour. An Assembly was next summoned in the town, and the King, being very angry, spoke and said: —

2.477

"You men of Bergen show great unfriendliness to me now as heretofore. You are a chief source of all war against me, and have ever been so; since my rule began you have lived in complete hostility towards us. There was some excuse for you while Magnus and Erling were alive; but now it is nothing but sheer hostility to help plundering Wickings against your rightful King, and thus lay waste his realm. But in all likelihood you will fare as before; the more you dishonour me the worse will your own lot ever be. Know this, too, that you shall lose your wealth and your limbs; and even your lives are likely to be lost unless you consent to all that I require." Then Finn Forrædi answered, and spoke against the King; his speech tended to the same end as before, a shirking of the King's demand. But at last, however, they submitted to all the King required, and furnished him with a hundred men, yeomen and merchants. King Sverri sailed forth from the town, having thirty cutters, and when he came south to Salbirni and was lying there, the Bagals sailed thither from the south on their search for the Birkibeins. The King rowed to them before they were aware of his presence, and placed his fleet on the weather side of them, so that he could choose whether he would be near or far. Some fighting now

occurred, bolts were shot and stones were thrown, but the King had the same disadvantage as before in the height of his ships. The Birkibeins, nevertheless, pushed their ships boldly under the weapons of the Bagals, who held some of the King's ships with their grappling-hooks, but were beaten off. But when the Birkibeins perceived that they could not gain the victory over them, they rowed their ships away, and coming north to Bergen at sunrise, they dragged their ships ashore to the north side of the castle and went into the town. The same day about noon the Bagals arrived at the town, and at once endeavoured to go on shore; but they could not effect a landing, as the Birkibeins hindered them. The King set his men in tents all round the town. The Bagals lay at sea several days in front of the town, off Nordness, and then sailed away into Sogn, where they collected provisions. They were absent seven days; and they seized one of King Sverri's bailiffs, Jon Trin, to whom they gave quarter, and he joined their band; and yet more Birkibeins joined the Bagals.

2.478

The Bagals sailed back to Bergen, coming to Nordness from the south, and they anchored off Munklifi. Here they landed and showed no fear, as they deemed the Birkibeins' fate in their hands, and made sport of them. They shot at each other when within reach. The Birkibeins were constantly in the town, having many errands there; some had wives, and many went to get drink. From under the walls of the buildings the Birkibeins constantly shot at the Bagals, and the Bagals did not venture in the town, fearing surprises from the Birkibeins. The Bagals often came to Jons-fields, where they drew themselves up in array and displayed their force to the Birkibeins, shouting at them and questioning their courage. And when they broke up their array, many engaged in games and amused themselves, showing that they cared nothing for the Birkibeins. Their force was exceedingly powerful and fine, well furnished with both weapons and clothes.

2.479

King Sverri's speech to the Birkibeins. Preparations for an attack.

2.480

147. King Sverri held a meeting of his men on the slopes above Nikolaskirk while the Bagals were at their games on Jonsfields. The King then spoke and said: "It must surely be that a panic has come over us Birkibeins; but it will not last long. We again expect from you firm support, such as of old; for I suppose few examples will be found where men have more faithfully supported their King. You Birkibeins enjoy this best distinction, that you surpass other men in courage and prowess. Those Bagals believe now that they hold our fate at their mercy; but I expect it will turn out otherwise, for I believe that we shall have not less than that power over them in a short time. I do not intend longer to endure their scoffing and their mocking, if your wish is the same as mine; but yet we will consider, all together, what is most practicable. There is the chance of fighting the Bagals as soon as you wish; let each one now say what he wishes." But all kept silence. And the King said: "You are not doing me justice by being silent. You ought to grant your King the service of answering his speech, and each man should declare his opinion." Then they answered and bade the King decide. And he said: "That is a good answer, such as I hoped to receive." The King then said: "We have the chance of remaining in the castle, a secure stronghold as long as our provisions last; but when they fail, it will be difficult to get stores. As another course, we may move up into the fells; the Bagals will then chase us and pick off such as they wish; but those who fall in flight never gain renown. Again, there is a course, one usual with the Birkibeins of old, to set on the foe and let sword and spear come into play. Our state will seem to me more hopeful as soon as we stand on a level with them." The men answered that all would rather fight than flee. The King then said: "The Bagals will have observed our meeting, but know nothing of our counsel. We will march, therefore, to the castle first, then go down to the town, two and two, four or five, seven or eight at a time, and all meet at Olafskirk." This they did, and the Bagals did not find out their design, because the Birkibeins usually moved about in that way.

2.481

When the force was assembled at Olafskirk the King set up his standard and said: "We will not draw up in array. Let us rush on them at full speed. Let no man be behind another, and every one do his best. The fight will be short, for the Bagals will behave as before: as soon as they see their men falling their hearts will be struck with fear. In their talk they are very tall, as a fox is long in the tail. Let our onslaught on them be as fierce as we can make it. Men who have hurried from the churn-pail will be ill-pleased with blows. They have never yet seen the way in which Birkibeins are wont to make their swords bite in battle. Forward now, my brave fellows, and God have us in His charge."

2.482

Bagals surprised and put to flight. Warlike feat of King Sverri. Other skirmishes.

2.483

148. After that, they ran to the fields, shouting and inciting one another. And when the levies heard the trumpets sound, and beheld the standards wave, and the host of the Birkibeins come like lightning upon them, crying out and shouting, woe stared them in the face. The Birkibeins, as soon as they were within reach, let fly their spears. And now the Bagals saw the drawn swords glittering aloft, threatening danger to life; and they crowded together and formed their ranks, having Sigurd Earlsson under the standards with them. Their force behaved as the King foretold; for the foremost Bagals soon fled, no less than those who stood behind. Many fell where the two armies met. When the Bagals turned to run away, the Birkibeins had full choice to strike where they would, and were so close to them that all rushed together over the fields towards the sea, past Jonskirk yard. Here, at the edge of the fields, the Bagals rallied for a while; but when the Birkibeins used their swords the Bagals turned and fled. This resistance caused them no smaller loss than the former, and even more of them fell. And so the Birkibeins drove them right out to their ships. Some of the Bagals plunged into the water, but most of them got upon the ships which lay nearest to land. Narfi, son of Hallvard of Sasteads,

commanded a large ship, on which a great crowd leapt, so that it sank down in the water and grounded. Then the Birkibeins came up to it, and while some held the ship fast, others attacked the Bagals on board, who got many sword blows gratis; in the end the Birkibeins cleared the ship. Narfi fell and many others with him. Some leapt into the water.

2.484

King Sverri rode beside his men as they chased the flying host, and his spear was all covered with blood, which ran down the shaft to his hands. And as he went past Jonskirk one of the Bagals turned towards him, and raising two spears, hurled both at once against the King. The King lowered his shield in front of his horse as well as he could, and one spear struck the shield, while the other passed under the horse's belly. The man, seeing that his spears had not struck the King, threw his sword, and it followed the spear that passed under the horse's belly; then he cast himself down and pulled the spear out of the ground. The King now thrust his spear against the man's shoulder, who warded it, but the spear touched the flesh and tore it. The King rode forward so hard that the man fell; then he held in his horse, intending to trample him under foot; and the man as he lay on the ground struck at the King with the shaft of his spear, hitting him a slight blow. The horse now became restive and jumped away. The man sprang up and went off towards the churchyard, but the King turned the horse after him and thrust him with his spear, so that he fell dead to the ground.

2.485

The Birkibeins then went back into the town, and marched up to the castle; and the Bagals henceforth were less eager for their games, and stayed a shorter time on shore. —

2.486

Bishop Nikolas and his force lay at anchor by Toluholm, and the Bishop had the island cleared. Then he set up his tent there and sung mass, and said he would erect a great ecclesiastical establishment and a stone church.

2.487

A part of the Bagals' force lay off Nordness, and part more to the south. The Birkibeins remained now mostly in the town, and visited the country round for provisions, going wherever they wished, in spite of the Bagals. The yeomen of South Hordaland and Hardangr, who had already sent levies and help to the Bagals from their district, thought the Birkibeins, in their search for food, did not sweep over the farms in a gentle way. They therefore sent to the Bagals and said that they ought to be a defence to them and their live-stock. The Bagaïs bade them drive the livestock to them, saying they would then watch, over it. So the yeomen drove up great numbers, of cattle, and brought them to Laxavoe. One night King Sverri summoned his men, and marching from the castle along the higher road over the fell, came round to Alreksteads. Thence he passed along Alreksteads-voe to Laxavoe, where was the host of the Bagals. They had set a watch, and King Sverri, having learnt where the watchmen were, despatched six men, bidding them make great haste and see if they could take them. They came to the two men on the watch; one was asleep and the other awake. The former waked only to die; the latter cried out as a spear passed through him in the midst. The Bagals heard the man's cry, and inquired what was the matter with the watchman that he cried so loud; and the Birkibeins who had slain him answered that it was their play: "We are in good spirits and amusing ourselves." The scouts then returned and told the King of the death of the watchmen, and he said the business was well done. Afterwards he marched with his men against the Bagals so silently that they did not awake before the Birkibeins dragged their ships to shore under them, and many of the Bagals were slain. Those Bagals who lay at anchor farther off heard the noise and the clashing of weapons, and suspecting an enemy, all rowed to the spot whence the shout was heard and the din of arms. Certain that the enemy was there, they sprang ashore prepared to attack. The Birkibeins did not wait, but ran to meet them; such was the shock that the Bagals followed the plan that seemed good, and betook themselves again to their ships. They left many lying on the ground, though, and many

sprang into the water. After that, the Bagals loosed the moorings of all their ships and rowed out of range. The Birkibeins drove the cattle inland to Alreksteads, and the Bagals, reckoning up the loss of their men, saw it was heavy. They had suffered a great disgrace, and they incited one another to avenge it. They knew that the King had a mere handful of men in comparison with them; so they rowed up the fiord and into the Alreksteads-voe, and anchoring at the head of the bay, they sprang on shore and drew up in battle array. It was now full day, and they thought themselves fortunate that the Birkibeins had not passed by. King Sverri saw the Bagals' host, and perceiving that they were not tired of attacking him, spoke and said: "I expect there will be another brush with the Bagals. Let us mount the slope, and thence make as vigorous an onslaught upon them as we can. I expect they will again give way." The Birkibeins set about the task, and ran upon them with such force that many fell in the foremost ranks of the Bagals. The standard-bearer of the Bagals' chiefs was a man named Eindridi Lioxa, a Thronð by race, very valiant and daring. He bore the standard well to the front, so that Bergsvein Langi, King Sverri's standard-bearer, confronted him. So close were they that they exchanged blows, with the result that Bergsvein was wounded and Eindridi fell. The standard of the Bagals fell with him, and they fled when they saw it fall. The Birkibeins chased them, and followed them to their ships. In these two skirmishes the Bagals lost many men, especially of the levies. King Sverri then marched back to the castle with the cattle, and thanked God for his victory; He was now well supplied with meat, and viands were not lacking, being fearlessly sought.

2.488

King Sverri's unsuccessful device to capture Bishop Nikolas. The Bergen summer.

2.489

149. The Bagals now rather shunned the castle and the town; the capture was not so easy as they had supposed. It often happened, if the Bagals came on shore, fifty or sixty at a time, to amuse themselves, and

they saw ten or fifteen Birkibeins with the King himself among them, they would flee to their ships. At times the Birkibeins came on them unawares, and the Bagals, getting the worst of the encounter, rushed wildly to their ships, gaming neither respect nor fame. The night of Jon's Eve, King Sverri went down from the castle with a hundred men into the town. They put on priests' copes, which they took out of the churches, and going in companies of five or six, or even fewer, they met together over at Munklifi. Here they entered a barn in secret, because the King expected that Bishop Nikolas and other leaders of the Bagals would come to mass during the day. Some of the men put on monks' frocks, and sauntered about the churchyard, two and two together, to watch if the Bagals came on shore; but the Bagals remained on their ships, except that some of their boys came to land in boats to get firewood. The Birkibeins seized each one as he appeared; some they slew, others they maimed, so that none might carry information to the ships. A priest also came on shore. The Birkibeins caught him, and asked him if the Bishop were coming at all to mass. The priest said that the Bishop was coming to land as soon as he was ready. As time went on, there came up a man, well dressed, who passed a short distance from them. They started to meet him, and when he saw them he thought it strange that monks wore low shoes and red hose. So he turned aside, and did not go near them. The monks asked him how soon the Bishop was coming to mass. The Bagal answered, "He will come when he is ready. But why do monks wear low shoes and red hose?"

2.490

"The fashion alters with the times," they replied. Then they ran after him, and having caught him, began to strip him of his fine kirtle, for they did not wish to defile it with blood. When his arms were out of the sleeves, and he stood free, he sprang off instantly, and making good use of his feet, ran to the ships like one frantic and furious. And he related to the Bishop the story of his church-going, and as a sign that he lied not, he pointed to an arrow-wound in his thigh, and said he

thought it was more like a present from Birkibeins than monks. The Bishop, Hreidar, and many other men of rank were on the point of going on shore; some were already in the boats before the news came. King Sverri turned back to the castle as soon as he knew that the Bagals were informed of him, and the Bagals henceforth were much more wary about themselves.

2.491

There were many onsets and assaults which might be told, but it is not possible to write all in one book. The forces cut off each other's men, and slew them whensoever they could. In the districts around there was a large number of Birkibeins who joined the Bagals, some of their own will, and many who were taken unwillingly from their homes.

2.492

This summer was called the Bergen summer.

2.493

The Bagals set fire to Bergen.

2.494

150. On the night of Lafrans' mass-day the chiefs of the Bagals carried out a threat which they had already made. They declared that the men of Bergen were a strength and support to King Sverri, whereby he was able to maintain himself in the castle. To Bishop Nikolas is ascribed the design, in which the others joined, of laying waste the market-town of Bergen, and of setting up another market in its place elsewhere, in Hordaland. It would then be seen what the castle would do for King Sverri.

2.495

The Bishop said that the Birkibeins had polluted all the churches, which, as they were frequented by men under ban, were thus no better than brothels. During the night the Bagals rowed up in front of the quays, having two cutters laden with wood. One place to which they set fire was a building close by Krosskirk; a second was opposite Foskaquays at the house of Finn Forrædi; and a third was close to Mariukirk. The townsmen had no means of stopping it; the work was

not easy, for all the gangways had been removed. The Birkibeins had no information before the town was in flames, and they saw that nothing could be done to save it. They feared for the castle lest it should take fire, and they hung up sail-cloths to protect it, and kept them wet. The town was burnt all the way from Krosskirk to Sandbridge on the side of the street nearest the bay, and from the Sandbridge to Nikolaskirk on the upper side. Then, to meet the fire, the Holy Rood was borne from Steinkirk, and the fire was stayed. The shrine of Sunnifa was borne [from Kristskirk] to Sand-bridge and placed there, and by a notable miracle the fire there advanced no farther. The Bagals lay with their cutters in the bay, shooting at all who tried to save the buildings and slake the fire. Many of the men of Bergen had already removed all the property they could when they heard that the Bagals were meditating their design; some went into the districts, some into the castle. Bishop Nikolas was on board the cutter which carried fire to the town, giving orders what places they should fire, and where they should shoot. This design made him greatly abhorred. It brought loss and damage to many, and not a few who were wealthy before the fire were made penniless by it; and the men of Bergen ever remembered it against Bishop Nikolas.

2.496

Mariukirk was then burnt, and five other churches.

2.497

The Birkibeins are defeated in the absence of King Sverri.

2.498

151. Shortly after, King Sverri left the town with a hundred men for a place where he knew that his men had collected for him great flocks of cattle. And when the Bagals knew that the King was absent, they went on land with their force, and came by the upper road down to Olafskirk on the Banks. The Birkibeins hurried out of the castle against them with their men, except thirty who were on the Holm, to see that no ships came there to land. The Bagals now drew up their men in ranks. The Birkibeins, having a fine force, were minded, as before, not to put

themselves in battle array, but purposed to rush on them and so break up their line. At their first rush against one arm of the Bagals, it recoiled before them; but the other arm wheeled in upon them, so that the Birkibeins were surrounded. There was now great odds against them, and the Birkibeins fought but a short time before they saw they had no power to resist further. They endeavoured therefore to escape to the castle, and the Bagals pursued hard after them. Many brave and valiant heroes fell — Sigurd Borgarklett, Finn the Færeyman, Thord Lokk and Bitá-Kari, Einar Biarnason, Bengeir Ehngi, Eindridi Peini, brother of Eystein Kædisman, and son of Hallkel of Lo. Eindridi was the standard-bearer of Earl Philippus, and commanded the Earl's force. So gallant a man was he, that when he had received many grievous wounds and had no hope of escape, he thrust the standard into the ground, and grasping his sword with both hands, struck to right and left; he fell there with great renown. They all defended themselves bravely. The Bagals pursued them right up to the castle; and as the Birkibeins were going in, the Bagals happened to seize one of them by the feet as he was about to enter; the Birkibeins wished to save him, and clutched him by the shoulders. They pulled hard at the man, and he was torn asunder between them before they separated. This was the evening of Mariumass. The Bagals had brought their cutters to the Holm, and the Birkibeins who were to have defended it were slain. The Bagals went close under the castle where the ships were, set fire to them and burnt them all up. After that, they went back to their ships well pleased with their assault.

2.499

The Bagals then composed this verse: —

2.500

“The King on Monday called his Guards,
To clash of arms the men pressed hard;
Yea, Ingi's men resolved to march
In early morn to Sverri's burg.

2.501

Against them came the foe and fought
 Full long beneath the banner-poles;
 Storm of shafts the Bagals stood,
 Ships they burnt while champions fled.”

2.502

But the Birkibeins recited this verse: —

2.503

“Poltroon on Monday called his Guards,
 To clash of arms the men pressed hard;
 But Thufu-skit succeeded not
 In winning Sverri’s burg that morn.

2.504

Against them came the foe and fought
 Full long beneath the banner-poles;
 The Bagals all are under ban,
 They burnt the ships while champions fled.”

2.505

When the King returned to the town he thought this a grievous blow,
 and he said there had been lack of care and foresight.

2.506

King *Sverri’s march to Nidaros. Lord Karl slain at Berg. Speech of Thorstein Kugad.*

2.507

152. Soon afterwards King Sverri went away from Bergen, leaving a garrison in the castle for its defence. From Bergen he marched up to Vors, and thence to Raudafell; and now for the second time he mashed over Baudafell, again with much toil. The force came down into Sogn, and delayed in Aurlands-fiord, because the men were sore; then they marched the whole way north to Throndham, where the King was well received.

2.508

King Sverri here learnt the tidings of what had lately happened. The Bagals had come to the town with three cutters under Kinnad Eldridarson, Thorstein Kugad, and Eirik the Thronð. Karl, son of King Sorkvi, was in the town before they arrived. He had married Ingibiorg, daughter of King Sverri. A rumour of their coming had reached Lord Karl, and in the evening he had left the town by the bridge and was at the homestead of Berg. The Bagals reached the town in the night; they found Lord Karl gone, but they were told where he probably was. During the night they went there and slew Lord Karl and all his company, and then left the town. After that, they held an Assembly at Eyra, at which Thorstein Kugad spoke and said, "You must know, townsmen, that King Sverri will be a long time in coming here to you to defend the land in Thronðham." Then he told of the conflicts of the Bagals and King Sverri, how they had proceeded in the summer, mentioning especially the great events last happened, where the King had lost men under the walls of the castle. Thorstein ended his speech by saying that the King had left the castle, and would probably come to the town by the land road; for," said he, "the King has not so much in ships as even a single boat. The Bagals have taken his ships, and many another thing that was under the King's rule aforetime. The Birkibeins acted as if none could stand before them, and as if one of them singly was a match for three Bagals. You must know, however, that this summer it has come about that we have taken little short of as many Birkibeins as they have now left for themselves. Some of these are flow present with us, no worse treated than among the Birkibeins; and they will afford you no help now, for they believe they can see what great fraud Priest Sverri has long practised."

2.509

Thorstein Kugad sues King Sverri for pardon.

2.510

153. The Bagals had fled from the town, down the Fiord, before the King arrived. King Sverri inquired diligently into all these matters, and was much displeased at the slaying of his son-in-law, Lord Karl The

Bagals sailed from the south with all their host. They had large ships, and when they reached Folskn on their voyage they lay there for a time, for they did not wish to sail into the Fiord when they heard that King Sverri was there. They fell short of provisions, because they had a large force; they despatched a band, therefore, into the peopled districts. Some of the force sailed south to Moeri, as far as Borgund; and as they passed the entrance to Hefni, Thorstein Kugad ran his ship on purpose against a skerry, and wrecked it as he wished. Then with his men he went ashore, and in the night, without their knowledge, he fled with two companions over the fell and came down into Orkadale. Many other men who had homes in Throntham and had been with the Bagals all summer now deserted them.

2.511

Thorstein Kugad remained in concealment at his homestead, and sent a messenger into the town to Gunnar Grionbak, begging him to ask pardon for him from the King. And once on a time Gunnar spoke with the King and said, "Sire, we have lost a very able man, now Thorstein Kugad is with the Bagals, and we would gladly entice him back to us."

2.512

"I do not suppose Thorstein remembers," answered the King, "that he has been my man; and I think him small loss to us." And Gunnar replied, "I am sure, Sire, that Thorstein will have your pardon if we can entice him from the Bagals." The King answered with a laugh: "What does this mean, Gunnar? Is Thorstein now in your keeping? He shall have my pardon; but if the Birkibeins meet him in the street, I know not how matters will go' with him." Shortly after, Gunnar sent word to Thorstein to come to the town. Thorstein went therefore in all secrecy. Then, during the day, Gunnar and Thorstein went before the King as he was at a meeting. Thorstein had a deep hood over his head, so that he was not recognised till he stood before the King. Throwing off his overcoat, he fell to the floor as if he had been struck, and grasping the King's foot, kissed it, and said: "Happy am I, my lord, to have come so near as to touch you, and happy that I have escaped out of

the hand of those devil's men, the Bagals. Under ban they are, and deserving of it; they are robbers and evil-doers, and not chiefs. They show hatred to the best of men, you, Sire, for you are a crowned King, before whom all must bow if they would do right. Receive me now, my lord, and let me nevermore be separated from you. I know not by what means that false Bishop so blinded me that I should not see what fraud they practised, those dastards who swore fealty to you. How could they be good to me who had been traitors to their King." And while he spoke, the Birkibeins threw in remarks, not agreeable ones. "There was no greater dastard than himself," they said; and some bade carry him out to Eyra and hang him. Then the King said: "Stand up, Thorstein, you shall have pardon, and shall tell me of the ways of the Bagals." And Thorstein answered: "Happy am I that my eyes behold you; never again will I falter in your service. Of the Bagals I have much to say, whenever you wish, and chiefly to their discredit."

2.513

Thorstein then received pardon, and the King let him often speak at meetings of the guard and tell of the ways of the Bagals, and he was a constant speaker also at Assemblies.

2.514

The Bagals in Halogaland. King Sverri builds ships of war in Nidaros [1199].

2.515

154 The Bagals seized all the revenues and war contributions over North and South Mœri and Ilaumsdale; they also plundered in places, delaying half a month over the voyage. Afterwards they went all the way north to Halogaland, sailing into every fiord, and behaving with much violence. They seized immense wealth, and took all the best men there into their band, Thori Knapp, Guthorm of Miola and his brother Bryniolf, Biarni Mardarson, Halldor of Hiorleifsvik and his sons, Ivar Nef, Gregorius Kik, Erling of Thiotta, Guzalin Prest, and a multitude of men besides. —

2.516

This autumn, Richard, King of the English, was slain, and his brother John, called Lackland, took the kingdom in England.

2.517

King Sverri sat in Kaupang. And on a time in the winter, after Yule, the King was holding an Assembly with the yeomen, and he requested that they would build ships to aid him, that he might deliver the land from pillage by the Bagals. “We may be certain,” he said, “that as soon as spring comes, the Bagals will direct their course here into the Fiord, and will do you ill turns, because your force is ever opposed to them. We Birkibeins are without ships, and not well prepared to defend your goods or your lives. We cannot run so swiftly across the country by road as they can row here by sea; and although the cost of ships may seem something to you, the loss of money which the Bagals will cause you is greater.” The yeomen answered him: “The plan is good, Sire, of building ships for the defence of the land, but what means will be found here to build them in sufficient numbers and size?” The King replied: “I propose, as the best plan, that in each shire of the communities of the Thronds the yeomen shall pay the cost of furnishing one ship; the townsmen and we Birkibeins shall then build as many in addition as we possibly can. The ships shall not have less than twenty-five benches, and shall rise from that in size. At the battle off Thorsbiorg I did not like to see the beaks of the Bagals’ ships above my eyes. It may happen that we shall now have the like superiority over them in the difference of height.” The following morning the yeomen held a meeting in Olafskirk and reckoned up the cost, and it appeared to them as if each man’s share would not be large. They resolved to submit to it gladly, and said that no expense would be spared by them to do what the King decided. The King then made plans for shipbuilding, and after Easter eight were finished — six on the Eyra, all large; and two in the Kings-court and Bishops-court. The one built in the Kings-court had thirty cabins, and was called Ognarbrand. All these ships were built high in the bulwarks, considering the number of their cabins. King Sverri also caused some merchant vessels

to be cut in two, that their keels might be lengthened, and they might have oars from end to end. Then all the ships in the town that seemed to be seaworthy were made ready with all speed.

2.518

The Bagals enter the Fiord and plunder Inner Throntham.

2.519

155. The following spring the Bagals set out from Halogaland with all their host, and sailed south to the entrance of Throntham, and turned into the Fiord. It was now Whitsuntide. They sailed up to Holm, and their task did not seem easy. They then sailed to Inner Throntham and plundered all the inner Fiord, getting booty for themselves. The yeomen gathered to oppose them and shot at the Bagals, doing them all the harm they could. Bishop Nikolas often addressed the force and thus spoke: "Priest Sverri now holds no more of Norway than a single ness; it would be a very fit lot for him to govern the part of Eyra outside the palisades and be there hanged on a gallows. We Bagals care very little, I should suppose, where he goes with his sea rams that he has got together in the town. Before the Thronds receive any good from them, I expect all their buildings will be charcoal. We will roam over the Fiord as we please, in spite of them, quite free from fear, for they have no force to bring against us." The Bagals then sailed with their host from the inner Fiord and anchored off Depil, within the Hladhamra. They now formed their plan: the crews of the large ships should go on shore, march by land to the bridge, and thence advance to the town; the crews of the cutters should sail into the river and there attempt a landing.

2.520

The Bagals attack Nidaros unsuccessfully. Narrow escape of Bishop Nikolas.

2.521

156. King Sverri had made preparations in the town. A catapult was raised on the Eyra, and another by the river; and from end to end of the town a breastwork of boards had been fixed on the buildings outside the roofs, like war-bulwarks on a ship, and a great mass of

stones carried up. Here, for the defence, were placed the levies and the townsmen. The King himself was out on the Eyra, having a small force with him; the most part of his Guards were up at the bridge, under Hakon Galin and Petr Steypl. The Bagals rowed their cutters into the river in front of the town, and placed them all the way up to Skellingarhella; they decided not to make a landing on Brottu-eyri, for they thought it like a house door beset with trolls when they recognised the Sigrfluga aloft there. They shot at the townsmen, but could nowhere come near them for the shower of stones thrown from the buildings and the quays. The Bagals who marched by land to the bridge were commanded by the young King Ingi, Bishop Nikolas, and Hallvard of Sasteads. They attacked the bridge at once, and at once the Birkibeius came against them; they met on the bridge and the fiercest blows were struck. Men were slain on both sides. The Birkibeins, hard pressed, retreated from the bridge, and the Bagals followed fast after them. There were Birkibeins in the blockhouse at the end of the bridge, and they cast stones in plenty on the Bagals from above. Then the most valiant of the Birkibeins pushed forward to the bridge, and the Bagals gave way; and when the foremost would take to flight, the others stood firm, being farther from the weapons of the Birkibeins. So there was a great crush all along the bridge, and the railings were broken off. Many Bagals were slain on the bridge, and some leapt into the water; the rest were all driven back. There was great slaughter, especially of the Bagals. Afterwards the Birkibeins turned back over the river, and the Bagals made no further attack on the bridge, but went out of range and took counsel together. Bishop Nikolas advised to set fire to the bridge and burn it down. "They will then have no way out of the town," he said, "except past the castle, and we will haste there and hinder them. They must then either starve in the town or else make their way out in face of our weapons." This advice was followed; they set fire to the bridge; but the Birkibeins kept the fire down and put it out, and part of the bridge at the southern end remained standing. Then Bishop Nikolas and the others went to

Helgasetr, and threatening to burn down the monastery, forced the prior and canons to give aid in the fight; they therefore went away with them, and were on board his ship. The crews of the cutters were unable to do much in the battle; they found the town not easy to win, and they let their cutters drift down the river opposite Bakki. King Sverri went from the Eyra to the Smithy-booths, and gave the Bagals opportunity to come on shore at Brottu-eyri; the Bagals prepared to land, but their fears got the better of them. When the King perceived this, he urged his men against them, and they shot arrows' and hurled spears at them with all their might. The Bagals started sharply and turned at once to flee, but one of the ships had grounded and was on the point of being won by the Birkibeins; many of its crew were slain and many wounded. They rowed out of the river to the large ships, and found their fellows who had marched by land to the bridge. All lay there at anchor during the night.

2.522

The next morning the Bagals rowed their cutters past the Hladhamra, and brought them where they overlooked the town. Bishop Nikolas rowed over to Iluvik; he had the Raudsida at this time, the swiftest of all ships, and he was observing where was the best place if they should land their men. King Sverri marked the Bishop's ship and guessed his errand; then he caused a galley, which Onund Ufrid commanded, to be dragged across the Eyra, and so great a crowd of men surrounded the ship that she could not be seen from the sea. But when she came into the water Bishop Nikolas saw her, and bade his men strike their oars into the water with all their might. "Row as hard as you can," he said. "If you row boldly I will give each of you cloth for kirtles, green and red. But you're not rowing! Can't you see our foes speeding like madmen after us, and our cutter seems standing still?" Then he flung himself from the aftcastle and rushed right along the ship, and his mitre was blown from his head overboard. Again the Bishop called upon his men. "Do your best now! They would gladly get hold of me." At first while the Bagals were turning the Raudsida and she was not

going at full speed, the pursuers drew near them. But the Bishop had no need to urge his men, they were all eager enough themselves to row out of danger. And when the Bagals in the other ships marked this, they started with their cutters so as to cut off Onund from land. Onund saw that this would not be to his advantage, and his men turned back from the pursuit, having got nothing more of Bishop Nikolas than his mitre, which they carried away as a token.

2.523

Skirmishes near Nidaros.

2.524

157. After that, a fresh breeze from the north-east sprang up, and the large ships of the Bagals all lay exposed to it. King Sverri supposed that it would not be easy for them to remain there, and he caused eight horses to be taken to the other side of the river; he himself followed, and mounted and rode to the ships by the road above Hladi. He arrived just as the Bagals had sent boats to land to unloose the mooring-cables. They had cast anchor, and the ships were straining at the anchor ropes. The King rode to the men who were unloosing the cables and slew nine of them. Some were forced into the water, and others pushed out in the boats to the ships. The Bagals cut the cables and moved off; they then set up the sails, and sailed out to Raudabiorg, where they lay two days. King Sverri despatched men to Orkadale, Eyiolf Aflason, Bialfi Skinnstakk, and a company with them. On the third day the Bagals sailed over to Orkadale, directing their course to Roaberg and other places along the strand; and as soon as their gangways were pushed to shore they hurried up into the forests and sought for meat and cattle, both in the mountain pastures and the peopled districts. The Birkibeins lay in ambush for them at the homestead called Holta, where Bagals were slain, both at the farm-house and on the way to the river Orkn. Many leapt into the water, some were drowned, the others swam across the river and made their way back to the ships. At certain mountain pastures in another place the Birkibeins lay in wait for Bagals, some of whom were slain, and the others escaped. After this

there were no more descents on land. Then the Bagals learnt where cattle of the Birkibeins were, and despatched three hundred men who went and drove the cattle to the strand and slew every beast. They took a Birkibein prisoner at the homestead of Roda, but he dissembled and said he was merely one of the levy, and not a Birkibein. They cut off one of his feet. The Bagals lay here a week, but made no more descents on land; they then sailed to Holm. After this, they planned to search for booty in the district rather than go to the town. They therefore sailed up the Fiord, to Asfiord in Hindey, where they lay a few days. The building of King Sverri's ships advanced rapidly; their hulls were all complete, but they were not yet furnished. Many urged that they should be launched as soon as there was hope that they would not split asunder under their load of men. The utmost haste was made to get the ships all ready, and they were launched as soon as they could; moreover, all the King's host then in the town was ready to go on board.

2.525

King Sverri sails with his new fleet of ships to find the Bagals.

2.526

158. On Friday, the day after Botolfs-mass, early in the morning, King Sverri sailed forth from the river with his host, his own ship leading the way. And when the whole fleet had followed him out of the river, he ordered the ships to be laid together. Then the King stood on the high deck and bade men give careful heed to what he should say. The King then spoke thus: —

2.527

“A great force is here come together, and if we succeed in our purpose and a meeting with the Bagals takes place, we may not hope that all those here present will return alive. Death hangs over all alike; let each man take the warning to himself. It is my desire and prayer that all go to confession who have not lately so done. Likewise, I advise my men, though it is yet early, to get food and drink, and thereby courage; this may well be done while they take turns at the oar. And if we find the

Bagals, and they wish to row away without engaging in battle, we will follow with ships abreast and in loose order at the distance of a bowshot or farther from one another, and the cutters shall attend each long-ship,”

2.528

It was near the time of the morning meal, the sun shone brightly, and there was a slight wind in the Fiord outside, enough to hold the fluttering banner from the pole. The Birkibeins began to row up the Fiord, and, contrary to the expectation of the Bagals, the ships were exceedingly swift under the oar. They were new and lately tarred, and they carried nothing but the crews. King Sverri went on board a cutter and rowed swiftly up the Fiord, wishing to get information where the Bagals were. Seeing a man on land, they rowed their cutter up and called out to him, inquiring if he knew where the Bagals were. The yeoman answered, “Look within the Horni, there lies their whole host.” Then he wished good fortune to the King and all the rest. The King sailed back to his fleet and told them how they should steer. When they had rowed nearly half across the Fiord they perceived the Bagals’ ships rowing from under the Horni across to Tautra, and their course was to the Fiord north of the island. The Bagals now saw the ships of the Birkibeins, and Bishop Nikolas, Sigurd Earlsson, and Hreidar willed and advised to row down the Fiord and have nothing to do with King Sverri; they said he would not be able to row after them with his large ships. Hallvard of Sasteads and Philippus of Veigin wished to wait for the King. But the Bishop’s advice prevailed, to row out to sea. They changed places at the rudder-bands, and Bishop Nikolas went on board the Baudsida, Sigurd and Hreidar on cutters, and they rowed in front of the long-ships. And now the Birkibeins saw where the Bagals rowed, and directed their ships to get ahead of them west of Tautra, on the Fiord. The two fleets were soon near one another within Omburness. While they were still distant more than a bowshot, the Birkibeins threw up their oars, and hastily put on their armour, expecting the Bagals would attack them. But the Bagals would

not attack, and rowed aside. Then King Sverri said: "I fear they mean to go to the town. They will make the place hot for the townsmen before we arrive, if they plan to go there." And now both sides grasped their oars; four men to every oar on the King's ship, and it flew as it had been a bird, every oar being strained to the point of breaking. The Bagals' ships went with less speed; they were soaked with water and very heavy, for they had been at sea all the winter, and were laden with provisions and plunder.

2.529

Battle on the Strind-sea. The Bagals put to flight [18th June 1199].

2.530

159. Hallvard of Sasteads saw that the Birkibeins would over-take all their largest ships. He sprang therefore on the aftcastle and called to his men, and bade them turn back all their ships, past the Birkibeins, and begin with those in the rear and clear them first. Hakon, the King's son, steered the ship that was rearmost; it was thinly manned, and therefore moved the slowest. When the Bagals would turn back, they succeeded with all their small ships, but their large ships did not run smoothly compared with those of the Birkibeins. Then the King spoke to Thord Finngeirs-brother, who steered his ship, and said, "Do you see Hallvard's ship?"— "How can I not see it, Sire," he answered.

2.531

They were then so near that the forecastle-men on the King's ship were shooting at Hallvard's men; and the King's ship was far in advance of the other ships of the Birkibeins, not less than a bowshot. "Your fortune," said the King, "depends on your striking Hallvard's ship. Our place to-day is close to that ship; she is our match."

2.532

"There is no difficulty, Sire," he answered; "our ship will follow her helm." King Sverri, in giving a name to his ship, had called it Hugro. Hallvard had the ship called Skalp; Petr Steypi and Eyvind Priests-kin had the Ognarbrand; Hakon, the King's son, the Vidsia, and Earl Philippus the Hialp. The steering and the doubling laid the King's ship

and Hallvard's alongside each other to larboard; but Eirik of Ha's cutter had run in between them, so that the Hugro did not lie her whole length alongside the other. Earl Philippus's ship came up soon after, but could not be turned so quickly as to get alongside; it ran forward across the bows of Hallvard's ship, and the Earl's forecastle men caught the figure-head with a grappling-hook. The head came oil, but the grappler held fast to the beak as the ship ran swiftly past. The head was painted, and the ship had a sorry look when it was knocked off. Then they were able to turn the Earl's ship and lay her along the starboard side of Hallvard's ship, from the prow as far aft as the pump-room. The other ships found place as they came. Six of the Bagals' large ships were then entirely surrounded, the Birkibeins' ships lying outside of them. The smaller ships of the Bagals all kept at a distance from the ships of the Birkibeins, for they had no desire to be dragged into close quarters, and they could thus move away wherever they wished. The Ognarbrand, which Petr and Eyvind steered, did not at first row into the fight. When they wished to turn her, they could not do it quickly; though they backed the oars on one side, and all pulled forward on the other, she made so large a sweep they could not turn her. The cutters of the Bagals continually avoided the Ognarbrand wherever she was, not wishing to be grappled, but they attacked her from a distance as long as the fight continued. The battle was severe and long, beginning before mid-day and lasting till mid-eve; it was fought on the Strind-sea. Before it begun, King Sverri had spoken to his men: "If it turns out that we conquer," he said, "as I ween we shall, bear in mind how the Bagals starved you in Bergen Castle last summer; give quarter to no man, except those who come before me. For it is quite clear that in no other way than with the spear and sword shall we lay waste our foes. Today among the Bagals you will come across many an oath-breaker and traitor to his King, and now they shall all pay dearly." The ship which the Bishop had been steering became free in the fight; and when the current separated the ships and gave it room to quit the Birkibeins, it rowed away to land, and all the men that were not disabled, sprang

on shore. King Sverri shot all day from a crossbow, and so also Earl Philippus. The Earl was struck in the arm under his mail-sleeve, but did not pluck the arrow out until evening. The Raudsida, on which were the Bishop and the young King, came no nearer the battle than to see which side conquered, and as soon as they saw that the Birkibeins were likely to win, they rowed down the Fiord to sea as hard as they could. Now when the crew of Hallvard's ship began to fall, the crews of the King's ship and the Earl's made ready to board her, and began to clear her. Hallvard had been driven from the aftcastle to the midships, and was slain under the high deck aft of the mast.

2.533

In the after part of Hallvard's ship there was a handsome man, who wore a steel-cap and a coat of mail, both of Gautish make. Early in the fight he had been struck with a javelin that had sorely wounded and fractured his nose, and when the ship was well-nigh cleared he had gone on the high deck beside the mast. One of King Sverri's Guards, named Askel, a strong man who wore a breast-plate, set about to attack him and went on the deck. They faced each other, and the man walked towards him. He had no arms except a shield, and a stone in his hand; Askel had both sword and shield. A tent stood between them as they met and pointed their weapons at each other for a time. Askel smote hard at him, and the sword struck the tent-pole and remained fixed in it. The man took advantage of this, and struck Askel with the stone, so that he fell off the deck. And now many in the hearing of the King said that the man was able to defend his cabin if he were one of them, and it would be a good thing to give him quarter; but the King behaved as though he heard not. A palstave hurled from the King's ship next struck the man, and he fell from the deck; meanwhile Askel had risen up and seized an axe. Again they made at each other, and in the end Askel slew the Bagal, but was himself sore wounded.

2.534

Hallvard's ship was the first cleared; and then the five others that lay there were boarded one after another. The Bagals now took to flight;

some, drove their ships to land and sprang on shore, but the swift ships rowed down the Fiord to sea. The Birkibeins pursued them for a short distance; they captured all the ships that rowed to land, and in the fighting many men were slain, especially of the Bagals. The Birkibeins then rowed back to the town, and came into the river with the floodtide in the night-time. When the force came into the town, it was found that many captains of companies had given quarter to Bagals who were their kinsmen and friends. Some of the Birkibeins, remembering the King's charge, went into a sitting-room containing Bagals and slew them; and the kinsmen who had given these men quarter went before the King and complained to him. The King answered that he saw a good remedy: let them find out if those who had slain their kinsmen had given quarter to any kinsmen of their own, and he bade them avenge themselves. After this, parties went through the town, each picking out the other's kinsmen until all the Bagals were slain. The next day the King held an Assembly on the Eyra and told his force how to arrange the division of the booty. It should all be taken into the churchyard of Postolakirk, and the King said he would set men to watch over it. Then he despatched men north to Halogaland to follow those who had escaped thither; for he suspected that many of the yeomen had returned to their homes. They seized Biarni Mardarson, Bryniolf of Miola, and many other valiant fellows, and plundered their homesteads thoroughly.

2.535

King Sverri sails to the Vik. Death, of Earl Philippus, slain by the Bagals at Oslo [1200].

2.536

160. There was a man named Erlend, a priest, who chanted the service at Krosskirk; he was a very wise man, and held a prebend in Kristskirk. This priest had a fair young wife named Ingibiorg, who was beguiled by Earl Philippus. The King became aware of this, and bade the Earl, in kindly words, to cease what he was doing. The Earl promised well, but all went on as before. And now Erlend became aware of it, and was

filled with anger against the King as well as the Earl, and was ready for treachery against every Birkibein, if he could bring it about. King Sverri and Priest Erlend had often striven hard with each other on the Archbishop's case.

2.537

After the battle, King Sverri made ready with all speed and sailed away with his host and large ships after the Bagals; but they ever pressed on ahead of him, until they came east to Vik, whence they turned south to Denmark, King Sverri still pursuing them. The King sailed all the way south to Hlesey, where he learnt that the Bagals had sailed over to Jotland; he then turned back to the Vik. Here he remained through the summer, and demanded fines from the yeomen on account of their treason, and collected war contributions. He had with him a very great force, and abode during the autumn in Oslo, where he prepared to pass the winter.

2.538

In the autumn the Earl's leman, the priest's wife, arrived from the north, and the Earl at once received her. The King forbade it, and the Earl sent her a short distance off, to the homestead of Akr, and he often rode there secretly at night to sleep. The King constantly warned the Earl that his conduct was imprudent. "I fear, kinsman," he said, "that it will do us much damage." The Bagals sailed from the south, from Denmark, in the early part of Yule, with a fleet of cutters, one of which, steered by Audun Byleist, was shipwrecked on the voyage, not a child of man being saved. When the Bagals came to Oslofiord, they turned into it with fifteen cutters under the command of the young King and Hreidar Sendiman, and at Hofudey they held a conference. Here Hreidar Sendiman spoke. "I am of opinion," he said, "that the Birkibeins have as yet no information about us; and there will be a great crowd of them in the town, the whole host being drunk with ale. It would be a smart feat to make an onset on them, such as Sverri would plan if he were in our place; let us row up to the quays as silently as we can. I know too where there is a chance of game: Earl Philippus

sleeps over at Akr, and has few men with him.” Then many answered, “That is a good plan, we will not let him escape.” Five cutters afterwards rowed away to surprise the Earl, and others rowed up to the quays and listened; but finding all quiet and still in the town, they did not dare to land, and turned back to join their force. Now, those who landed at Akrs-hagi marched up to the homestead, and the Earl had no knowledge of them before the building was surrounded. He escaped by a secret door, barefoot, and dressed in his linen garments only. A thaw had begun, the snow had gone, and the half-thawed ground was slippery. The Earl was very swift of foot. The Bagals upon the buildings saw in the dark a man rush out dressed in linen clothes, and called out to their men to seize him. These ran after him, and at that moment his feet slipped and he fell. A spear thrown at him gave him his death-blow. He was slain in some enclosed fields a short distance from the homestead, and two other men were slain also. He had a page-boy, Eirik surnamed Svagi, who escaped and bore the tidings to the town. When he entered the Kings-court he was so exhausted that he could scarcely speak, but he called aloud and bade them get up. The King was the first man on foot, dressed, and out in the courtyard; and he inquired what were the tidings. The boy answered, “The Earl is dead; the Bagals have slain him.”

2.539

“This is too near us,” said the King. He thought the Earl had slept in the town, at his rooms, and that the Bagals were come into the town; and he called to his trumpeter and bade him blow as loud as he could, and he commanded the retainers near him to take their weapons. The troops then sprang to arms. Afterwards some one told the King that the Earl had fallen at Akr; and the whole force remained under arms all night until day. This was the night before the eleventh day of Yule.

2.540

The Bagals surprise Nidaros, and flee on the approach of a force of yeomen.

2.541

161. The Bagals now turned down the fiord to sea, and sailed north by the coast, first to Bergen, where they remained a short time; afterwards they proceeded north to Throndham, where they arrived quite unexpected. The Birkibeins present in Kaupang were Hallvard Skygna and his troop, and the Bagals slew the whole company. Hallvard was a brother of Archbishop Guthorn. The Bagals settled themselves in the town, four and a half hundred men. There was a great frost and thick ice at this time. King Sverri's bailiffs and the yeomen determined to march against them with a force and to fight with them. Dyri of Gimsa was over the men of Gaulardale, Eyiof Aflason over the men of Orkadåle, and they had fifteen hundred men. The Bagals, who had no information of them till they marched upon the town, went out to the castle to meet them, and defended the castle, preventing their entrance. The day before, the Bagals had broken up the ice on the river all the way from the castle to the bridge. The two armies exchanged shots during the day; many on both sides were wounded, and Philippus of Veigin was hit with an arrow. The yeomen, having effected nothing, marched home the next day, leaving things as they found them. A few days later they made a second expedition to the town, but the Bagals would not wait for them; as soon as they saw the march of the yeomen over Steinbiorg they moved away. They sailed south to Moeri, as far as Borgund, and some to Thingvoll, where they abode through the spring until Easter was nigh.

2.542

Insurrection of the yeomen on both sides of the Vile,

2.543

162. In the winter King Sverri demanded the war-tax from the yeomen, and that each district of the levy should provide a man, likewise a load [of meal] and a neat. The King then gave the Thronds leave to return home, and collected a force from the districts. This levy caused much complaint in the Vik. Thereupon the yeomen formed a design which brought harm to many. They entered into a conspiracy against the King, which was kept with wonderful secrecy, though all

were in the one plot from Svina-sound in the east, over the Vestfold and the whole of Baumariki. On an appointed day the whole people rose in a mass, theme and thrall called together over the whole of these shires, and slew all the bailiffs round about, each in his own district. The chiefs of the insurrection were Simun the Lawman of Thufn, Amundi Burst, Thorfid Blindi, Thord Ulfgestsson, Thorlak Drafli, Jon Kula, Grim of Grettisvik, Hallkel of Angr. They formed the design in Oslo, and held a meeting in Hallvardskirk, where they bound their scheme together. This was because of the tax which the King had laid upon them.

2.544

On Wednesday of the ember days in Lent they slew Benedikt, the bailiff in Tunsberg, with all his company, Olaf Smiorkoll in Vari, Petr Lucas-brother in Aumd and eight men with him, and the other bailiffs wherever found, and then set watchmen on all the ways that led to the town [Oslo]. The following Friday a rumour reached the King that the yeomen had gathered together, but it seemed to him incredible; then he had a muster of the levies, and discovered that the men from the nearest districts were absent. The King sent after them; but so it was, they came not, either Saturday or Sunday. Sunday, a yeoman came from the country to the King and told him that a host had gathered against him and would soon come; he bade him be on his guard, for it would be there not later than that very night or early morning; and he declared that he had seen the yeomen's host. When the King heard these tidings he straightway summoned the whole force, his own and the townsmen's, as also the merchants. He informed them all of the tidings he had heard, and begged the help of the townsmen and merchants, saying that they would have to defend their property and freedom. His speech was received with applause, and the whole force was divided into companies. The King, bade them go and take their evening meal; after which, he said, he would again summon all the force together. This was done. Then the townsmen and merchants removed into the churches all they could of their property. The King

despatched mounted watchmen along all the ways. Late in the evening he summoned, the second time, the whole of the forces out on the ice in front of the town, and led them over to Akrs-hagi, where they passed the night. The King rode with a few men to Solangr, and leaving the horses on the slope, went down to the lake. On the ice of the lake was an immense host of yeomen discussing their plans. The King, having listened to what was said, went away to his horses, rode down to the ice, and thence outside the Akrs-hagi to his ships. Here he remained for a time, and then returned to his men. Day was now at hand. The King then summoned his force to the ice between Snælda and the mainland, and having called for silence, thus addressed them: "A great force is here come together, and we need, of necessity, that the one Almighty God watch over us. An army has gathered against us, Thilir and Markamen, but I hope they have now turned back. Are all these our men, or have some of the yeomen come over here?" The King was told that they were all his own force." Then," he said, "we must watch over our ships, and must got our men to cut out a passage for them through the ice." Just at this moment a man arrived to say that a force had come from the east over Langamoss, and were then on the Ryginaberg; Skeynir and Eynir, Foldungar, Heggir. The King answered, "Then our plans must be changed." He was on horseback, and riding up to the townsmen's force, he spoke so that he could be heard by his own men as well. "There are two courses before us: we may either flee before the yeomen or attack them. To ask yeomen for quarter is bad; there are lighter blows to be had, methinks, in facing them than in turning our backs to them." His men bade him decide again, as of old, saying that would be the best course. He next asked the townsmen if they were willing to give him help, or should he and they manage their own affairs. "We Birkibeins," he said, "would repeat the old saying to you, 'A friend is for use in time of need.'" The yeomen and townsmen answered that they were willing to give the King such help as they could.

Insurrection of the yeomen. Battles at Oslo [6th March

2.546

1200].

2.547

163. King Sverri addressed his force and thus spoke: "It is my advice that, before the yeomen's host attacks us on all sides, we go and encounter the force that lies near, on the Ryginaberg, a gathering come all the way from Svina-sound, in the east. We will march north of Nunnusetr; let no man enter the town. Pal Belti and a company of Uplanders shall take snow-skates and implements for travelling on snow, climb the rock, and get above their force, and then see how numerous it is." So the Uplanders did. They took their snow-skates and climbed up the rock to the east near the yeomen. There was much snow on the ground and snow-skating was easy; but walking was bad, because a deep snow-drift was near as soon as the road was left. Daylight was coming on and the weather was bright. Pal and his men came to the top of the rock, and saw that all the way from the Giolluras above, down to the Frysia, and right out to Akrs-hagi, the whole land swarmed with men. As quick as possible they went back to the King to tell him. By this time the King had come to Mortustokka, and he halted to hear the tidings, but his standard and the van of his army were marching up the dale and mounting the rock. Some kept to the cart-road in their ascent; others climbed up the slope, which was so steep that a man might easily put the knee of one leg to the ground and stand upright on the other leg. The yeomen raised the war-cry and sprang forwards to the verge of the rock, throwing their spears, which was easy to do on foes below their feet. Those who stood to the west on the rock, to right of the Birkibeins, shot at them in their rear. The road was no broader than would admit of four or five walking abreast, and steep withal. Many Birkibeins were wounded and some were slain. No progress was made in the ascent, the standard-bearer fell, and there was a hard struggle before the Birkibeins saved the banner. The Birkibeins, seeing they could not resist, fled; those highest up the rock

ran down, treading on the heels of those that stood below, and so down to the bottom, where the fugitives fell one atop of another. The yeomen did not pursue them, for they saw the main body of the Birkibeins then ascending the rock. King Sverri now came up and said: "Fie upon you, running away so that one falls atop of another. Don't you see that no one pursues you?" Then he gave the signal for the whole force to fall back to Mortustokka. Seventeen men of the Birkibeins were slain on the Ryginaberg, all Guardsmen, and many were wounded. Then the King said: "Bear up boldly, my gallant fellows, though we have suffered a slight defeat.

2.548

'Happens often so at sea,' as the seal said when he was shot in the eye. The yeomen have all the victory they will get. The dream is now fulfilled that came to me in the night. I dreamt that I owned a book, so large that it covered much of the land; but it was all loose, and one sheet was stolen out of it. That sheet is the men whom the yeomen have taken. But have no fear of their host; the more of them there are, the worse they will fare on their journey." King Sverri spoke again and said:

2.549

"Let us turn along the way to the rock east of them, which lies lower." This was done; but when they had marched a short way up the rock, they beheld, all the way north and down to the sea, a host of yeomen as if they looked on a forest. Then the King said: "Do you, Sigurd Lavard and Hakon, my sons, with your companies, set up your standard and remain at Mortustokka, to oppose the yeomen here on the rock, lest they attack us in the rear; I will go north to meet the force that comes that way."

2.550

After this, the King turned north with his men to the bridge over the Frysia, where was a host of the yeomen. They exchanged shots over the river, and several men were wounded, but they could not come to close quarters. The King then turned to go to the ice, for the Vestfyldir

and Thilir and Raumar were come there; those too who had been at the bridge moved down to the sea. The whole main host had assembled there and was wonderfully large; to encounter it would seem impossible to men who were not completely without fear. One of King Sverri's barons, Ali, son of Hallvard, asked the King: "Shall we not draw up in a line of battle, Sire?" And the King answered: "We Birkibeins have taken to the practice of not drawing up in a line when we fight on land; we run forward in detachments, making all the noise we can. Each man may then be as far to the front as he himself wishes. Let us make a fierce attack, and I think the yeomen must give way. The proverb now applies to us, 'Fall bodes fortunate journey.'" Then he commanded to blow the trumpet, and said: "Forward all, Kristsmen, Krossmen, and men of King Olaf the Saint; march in loose order." The King sat on a dark-brown horse, dressed in a good mail-shirt, a strong jack-coat over it, and a scarlet doublet outside; he wore a wide-brimmed steel cap such as Southmen have, and below it a collar of mail and a jack-cap. He carried a sword by his side and a spear in his hand, and he rode in front of his force so that his horse's breast met the shields of the yeomen. On his two sides the Birkibeins pushed forward with their drawn swords, and made so fierce an onset upon the yeomen that those in the front would gladly have been much farther away if they might; they slunk back among their fellows; nobody would stand before another. Where the yeomen showed bare places the Birkibeins planted their blows. Soon there was a slaughter among them; fear fell on some; a start was made and then the whole host ran and retreated to Akrs-hagi. The Birkibeins pursued them to land, and with blows raised humps on their backs by no means pleasant. Many of the yeomen were slain, and lay all about on the ice.

2.551

The men of Tunsberg and dwellers on the sea-coast had sailed into the fiord, and come with their ships to the edge of the ice. Here they landed. They were a very numerous host, and well armed, for they were the house-owners of Tunsberg and the merchants. They marched

over the ice, thinking they must have been slow. When the Birkibeins saw their array they turned to encounter them. And the King said to his men: "A new task is found for us, after but a short interval. Let us now turn to meet them. This crowd is a much smaller number than the former, and they will do the same trade on their journey as the others." He bade the trumpeter blow vigorously; his host began a violent rush along the ice just as if they had been quite fresh. At this sight the force of the Tunsberg men halted and crowded together, expecting help from the host on the Hagi. But the Birkibeins sprang upon them, dealing heavy blows as they were wont, so that with the first onset the Tunsberg men lay, where the armies met, as thick as wave-drifts on a shore; those who remained turned to run away after a short resistance. The Birkibeins drove the flying host seaward along the ice and slew many, for the pursuers wore sharpened shoes, and the fugitives' shoes had mere soles; and the ice was slippery with blood. The King rode near them; it was his work to give one spear-thrust to every man he attacked, and the Birkibeins performed what further service was needed for death. Many well-to-do merchants fell — Svein Sveitarskit, Sigurd Talgi, and many besides. The others fled to their ships, and some to the Hagi to join the Vestfyldir. A great crowd again collected on the Hagi.

2.552

It is said that when the King mustered his troops they were reckoned to be about twenty-five hundred; but they seemed to be a mere detachment when they came to face the crowd of yeomen who were, as men thought, twenty to one of them. The King would not draw up his men in battle-array, because he thought the yeomen's host might surround and enclose them. In the pursuit each force was much divided and went in companies, some of which had better fortune than others. Fierce fights occurred in many places which would seem worth relating, but to write of the whole in one book is impossible. For the most part those events are described which happened where the King's standard went and he himself was present.

2.553

Insurrection of the yeomen. Battles at Oslo. The Kings sons.

2.554

164. We must now speak of the King's sons, Sigurd Lavard and Hakon, and of the yeomen who lay on the Ryginaberg. These saw the King on the ice pursuing again and again, and thought that the yeomen must need help; so they incited each other and hastened down the rock with their force. When Sigurd Lavard and Hakon saw this, they hastened to meet them. Between the armies and close to them lay a small dale, where they met, and a hard fight took place. The Birkibeins had four hundred men, and the yeomen about twenty hundred. The yeomen pressed hard, and the Birkibeins, overborne by numbers, fled down into the lanes. Sigurd Lavard betook himself to the town, and hurried with his horse into Hallvardskirk, accompanied by many others; but Hakon and Svina-Petr, with some of the force, took the way above Nunnusetr, and thence to the ice to join the King. The yeomen were not active in pursuit of the fugitives; they wished to make sure of their victory, and marched to the town in battle-array. Meeting with no resistance, they dispersed about the town, and arranged in what taverns they would drink during the evening. They also marched down to King Sverri's ships, which were drawn on shore; some wished to burn them, but others said they ought not to destroy their own treasures. In the end they marched their force up past Nunnusetr, and formed in battle-array.

2.555

King Sverri, having just left the Tunsberg men, saw the array of the yeomen, and he called to his men and bade them bear themselves well; "For it will everywhere be known," he said, "who are the bravest. It seems to me," said the King, "as if the yeomen whom we encountered this morning would again have a meeting with us. It is fitting that we should bear in mind against them that they slew our men. We shall now stand on a level with them, and we need not climb the rock to reach them." The King then turned to them with the force that he had,

and a hard fight began. The yeomen resisted, but again there was the usual result. In the end they fled north of the town up to the Valkaberg. The King's son Hakon went after them and slew many of them; and when they saw that the main host did not pursue them, they made a stand on the Valkaberg, and there was a very hard fight. King Sverri turned south past the glens beside the Souter-sheds, and on to Hallvardskirk; and Lavard then came quickly out of the church. And the King said to him: "Thy deeds are all on a par; little hope have the Birkibeins of finding a good chief where thou art. It is with thee as the verse says —

2.556

'Foremost in feats your fathers were of old;

2.557

Unlike art thou to them."

2.558

Again he said: "Unlike are you to the former Birkibeins, who won the land with me against King Magnus. I seemed to be of no use to them in the battles that they waged; but they said prudence was my motive, while others said cowardice was the cause. Yet true is the saying —

2.559

'If youth be coward, not with years

2.560

Does courage come.

2.561

But now every time we fight, there am I in the front, and those who march abreast with me think themselves heroes. I thank them heartily for their support. You are not even like them; they have been victorious to-day, and you have been chased. Go after those yeomen now and smite them in the rear; more valiant fellows than you are have put them to flight." The King then turned from the churchyard, and many kissed the church. And the King said: "You Birkibeins are much more devout now than before. You behave as if you must lick every church you come near. It is not your wont to pay much regard to

churches.” The King then rode through the lanes; a large force accompanied him, and they caught great numbers of yeomen on the road.

2.562

As they looked north towards the Valkaberg, they beheld the brandishing of weapons in the air, and the King advanced against the band of yeomen. Some of them faced him, but others threw down their shields and sought safety in swiftness of foot. They ran as fast as they could, some along the way, others hither and thither, and thus escaped. During the whole day it happened that whenever the yeomen took to flight and ran straight off, they mostly got clear, and thus the greatest part of their number escaped. But yet so many fell that it was difficult to count them, and many bodies of the dead were not found until the spring.

2.563

Insurrection of the yeomen. Battles at Oslo. King Sverri sails to Bergen.

2.564

165. King Sverri summoned the whole force to Mortustokka, and when he came there he said, “Let the force sit down and rest; the serving-men will go down to the town and fetch meat and drink.” And so it was done. They set themselves to rest, staying there a long time, and many bound up their wounds. It was about the hour of nones, and as they looked over to Akrshagi, a great force drew together there and collected from every side; it was the host of yeomen with which they had fought that day. They crowded together on the east of the Hagi, close to the ice, and took counsel there. Some wished to return home; but the very stubborn among them thus spoke: “So little only of our force is lost, that we are no less able to fight than at the first. The Birkibeins have lost much of their force, and many must be wounded and weary; we have not to fight with those that are dead. How happened it that no man slew the King when he rode against us? If he dares it again, God knows he shall never get away; we shall never come within closer reach of him. If we go home as we are, and allow the

Birkibeins to have sway over us, we shall never henceforth have a free head to stroke. Let us go to work well, and stand firm, even if the Birkibeins make at us; let every man defend himself and look to his neighbour.” The yeomen’s captains now leagued themselves all together, and pledged each other by taking hands that no one would abandon the rest. Then they stood up and formed their men in battle-array, carefully settling who should protect others, who should use the sword and who the spear; and they set their bowmen together. Now they thought themselves secure against the Birkibeins.

2.565

The Birkibeins perceived that the yeomen made ready for battle. And the King stood up and said: “The proverb may be very truly applied to these yeomen, ‘He that has the worse case is slow to withdraw.’ It seems to me as if they were again ready for battle, and we Birkibeins have to see that they cause no wavering among us. Let us go and meet them, and raise such a storm about them that they will wish themselves at home rather than have to do with us any longer. Make a last effort, throw the basket after the bread, and act as if you were fresh.” Then he had the war-blast blown, and went down with his men on the ice. The Birkibeins made a fierce onset. The yeomen withstood it valiantly, and there was a great battle. The King himself rode forward against the yeomen’s line to make it give way; when he failed here, he rode against it there, so that he was seen in various places. The yeomen knew the King full well, and called one to another, “Slay him! smite him! spear him! kill the horse under him.” That was said, but not done. After the fight had lasted a while, its end is told in the yielding of the yeomen’s line. Their force broke up and began to disperse; their lime-wood shields failed them, and were of no avail against the spear thrusts of the Birkibeins. The yeomen had trodden the snow hard where they drew up their line, and when the Birkibeins came upon the hard snow by their side there was no fulfilment of the promise that the yeomen had made in their league. For so it was, that the very men who had said they would never separate now fled every one his own way.

2.566

When the yeomen's host all took to flight, they spread themselves on every side, and fled away in directions without number. The Birkibeins, divided into small bodies for the pursuit, followed hard after and slew a great multitude of them. Away on the Hagi was a thicket of brushwood, into which Ali Hallvardsson rode, and a few men with him. He was dressed quite in the same manner as the King. The yeomen came around him of a sudden, and slew him, giving him a mortal blow on the neck under the ear. They stripped him of his armour, and then raised a loud shout, crying out that the King was slain. The Birkibeins heard it, and relaxed their pursuit. Soon the rumour spread abroad both among Birkibeins and yeomen, and the companies of the two forces gathered again. When the King heard it, he ordered a war-blast to be blown, and rode forward boldly; and the yeomen discovered that they had a smaller steak on the spit than they imagined. The Birkibeins pushed forward through the brushwood, the King's standard first and foremost. Then they passed over some meadows, and found a great force of yeomen collected on a hill. They made a rush upon them at once, and there was a hard fight, in which many took part, for men of both hosts thronged to the spot. The yeomen again became very toothsome as before, tired of the fight, and wished themselves at home. They ran away in all directions; the Birkibeins pursued them until nightfall, and slew all they overtook.

2.567

During the day King Sverri gave quarter to every one who came to him and asked for it. Thorfid Blindi was taken, and the King gave him quarter. There was one yeoman taken three times in the day, and the King gave him quarter each time; and each time he escaped to the yeomen and joined in the fight. A fourth time he was taken, and slain. In the evening the King went back to the town, and on all the ways leading to it he set watches for the night. The next morning he summoned an Assembly, thanked the townsmen for their help, and his own men for their support and fellowship. He addressed them in many

fair words, and related good and bygone incidents of them, and evil incidents of the yeomen. “We were fortunate,” he said, “that this multitude did not rush upon us all at once. Such odds will not come often against us. Scarcely an example will be found, I believe, where a force, no larger than we had, has fought against such a crowd. And now I wish to have a passage cut through the ice to the open sea, so that our ships may float. Four men shall cut a fathom in length and four fathoms in breadth, and clear away the loose ice after them; so shall the work be continued day by day until the sea is reached.” Then the King had a measuring line laid upon the ice, and men were counted out for the work — Guardsmen, townsmen, and merchants — so that it was finished in a few days. As soon as might be, the King floated the ships and moved them from the town; then he made them ready and sailed away out of the fiord into the Vik, and thence north to Bergen, where he arrived on Easter eve. This was the second time that the townspeople were all glad to see him, and especially so, as they had heard a rumour that the Bagals were on their way from the north and intended to arrive soon at the town.

2.568

King Sverri's encounter with the Bagals at Bergen.

2.569

166. On Easter day, soon after sunrise, the watchmen saw the cutters of the Bagals off Hegranness; they were rowing from the north direct to the town. The watchmen blew their trumpets and roused the host, and the Birkibeins pulled down the awnings straightway. The King bade them not be too eager for the booty, but to let the Bagals row into the bay. The high decks were not in position on the King's ships, and the Bagals supposed them to be merchant-ships when they saw them. But when they ran into the bay, another sight stared them in the face, for the Birkibeins had already turned their ships seaward, seated themselves at the oars, and were rowing furiously toward them. The Bagals recognised the Sigrfluga, King Sverri's banner, and Andvaka, his trumpet, and they all took one way: they backed the oars on the

starboard side, and pulled their hardest on the larboard side, and so turned away south. But before the Bagals had quite turned all their ships, the Birkibeins rowed into two of their cutters, which instantly capsized. Both fleets now rowed as fast as they could.

2.570

The Bagals, when the others came near, ran some of their ships ashore at Grafdale; the young King and Hreidar with some of the ships ran into Gygisvik, and others turned yet farther south. The Birkibeins pursued and slew many of them. King Sverri rowed into Gygisvik, took the Bagals' ships that were there, and slew many men; but their chiefs escaped. The King then sailed back to the town; and the Bagals, collecting themselves together, found their way east to the Vik. The yeomen welcomed them heartily, and they joined their quarrels against the King into one.

2.571

King Sverri visits the yeomen of the Vik.

2.572

167. King Sverri tarried for a time in Bergen, and summoned troops and levies from the districts; and he set out in the spring with a great host. He had many large ships; the great Hofdabuza was then with him. He sailed south, coastwise, and east to Vik; and when he reached the Vik and Tunsberg he came upon the Bagals. Hreidar Sendiman and a large company sat there to defend the land against the Birkibeins, on the part of the Vestfyldir. They had settled on the rock, and raised much on it for its defence — two blockhouses, one on the north side of the rock, and the other on the south, over the lane which leads up from Lafranskirk. King Sverri did not delay at Tunsberg at this time; but he said, as his men rowed away from the town, "However highly you Bagals esteem the rock now, you will think just as ill of it some day." King Sverri then sailed east into the Vik, and the yeomen had gatherings everywhere to oppose him,thane and thrall together. The King and his men came nowhere on the mainland but the yeomen slew some of them or shot at them wherever they appeared. The yeomen

had with them at this time Sigurd Earlsson, Hallvard Bratti, Lodin Palsson, Amundi Burst, and many captains of companies besides. The King sailed east, coastwise, as far as Konungahella. Here he summoned an Assembly of the yeomen, and as the King had a large force, and there were no yeomen who had marched against the King to Oslo, they came to the Assembly. The King then demanded a levy and the district war-tax, and found many reasons for other charges. The yeomen submitted to all the imposts, for they had no other means of dealing with the King. The King then turned back and held an Assembly of the yeomen in Ordost. He made the same demands from them and thus spoke: "I will ask you yeomen for the loan of all the horses here in the island. We wish to use them, but you may appoint men to look after them and bring them back when we have had them. If you do this of good-will, you will have our thanks; but be that so or not, we must have them." The yeomen yielded their horses; and the same thing happened in Thiorn and other islands. They carried [the horses with them north into the Vik, and the crowd of yeomen ever kept pace with them on land.

2.573

When King Sverri came north to Sotaness he turned from the road towards the land and came to anchor at a place named Tharfa. The Bagals had a host here, and the King would not at first allow his men to land. The Bagals then marched inland to join the yeomen's host, and they held an Assembly together at Forskirk, where they discussed their plans. The yeomen were eager to march against the King and fight with him; "If not," they said, "he will burn the homesteads." They decided to fight, and so the Assembly ended. All in a body turned to march against the King, and Sigurd Earlsson set up his standard.

2.574

Battle with the Bagals and yeomen at Skarfsteads, in the Vik.

2.575

168. King Sverri went from the ships to land and told his force that he would seek an encounter with Bagals or yeomen, whichever came in

his way; declaring that he had been tossed quite long enough in sight of land, and had obtained from the yeomen nothing of his due. He divided his force, left one part to watch the ships, and the other, which was the greater portion of his force, marched inland. They used what horses they had, and some of the men were on foot. They marched through the day, and found the homesteads all abandoned by the yeomen. About the hour of nones the King came to a certain rock, where he halted and said, "We must now turn back again and we will burn every homestead on our way." Shortly afterwards a man came to the King and called out, "The yeomen's host is now marching down the dale to the north of the rock." And the King said, "Our plan must be to go there and encounter them, and see how matters turn." He had the war-blast blown; the force came around him, and he turned immediately to go north into the dale, his own company marching in the van. When the yeomen saw them, they threw off their wallets, seized their weapons, and marched to meet them; and the two armies met where on the one hand was a certain wood, and on the other a small muddy brook. And there were some cornfields near. As soon as the King came up he rode to attack the enemy, the foremost of whom were the followers of Sigurd Earlsson with his standard, though he himself was nowhere near. There was a hard fight; but when the King's men drew together quicker than the yeomen expected, these debated which would be the better plan, to go forward or backward. The company of the Bagals which was in front were almost all slain, and the standard was hewed down. The yeomen were now all firmly resolved to shun the Birkibeins, and the whole host of them took to flight. The Birkibeins pursued, and slew many of them; and in the evening they returned to the ships. This battle was fought close to the homestead called Skarfsteads.

2.576

King Sverri burns homesteads in the Vik. Skirmish with the Bagals at Sandafjord.

2.577

169. King Sverri removed his host and turned north into the Vik. He came to anchor in the fiord called Hornesfiord, and sent a command to the yeomen that they should come and reconcile themselves to him. Some came to be reconciled, some not; the more part east of the river [Raum-Elf] over Agdi came not, for they trusted that the Bagals would come to their aid. After the King had waited for a time, he marched into the peopled district in the north and all the folk there had fled from their houses. After he had gone a long way, and the day was declining, the King said they must turn back. "My son Hakon shall march down on the other side of the settlement with a part of the force," he said; "and we will go on this side, and burn, one and the other, all the homesteads." Then they set fire to the buildings and burnt every one on their march; many large homesteads were burnt. They burnt at this time the Great Dale, which Havard Bondi owned. In the evening a boy ran out of the wood to the King and said, "For God's sake, Sire, don't burn my father's house, here in front."

2.578

"We will certainly not burn his house," answered the King, "since you ask us; and no man's house would have been burnt this day if the yeomen had been at home and sued for peace. Tell them that not another shall be burnt henceforth." The King then marched to his ships, and the next day the yeomen came and pledged themselves to pay a fine. All the folk then submitted to him and paid fines.

2.579

After the King had done there what he wished, he sailed north over the Fold and anchored in Hafsteins-sound, and thence sailed into Grindholma-sound. In the evening he heard that the Bagals, having taken ship at Tunsberg, had sailed out into Hafsteins-sound, and he rowed after them north of Tunna, and darkness then came on. The King sailed to Tunna, and lay during the night at Hrafnsvoe; the Bagals lay a little farther south, close by the strand. As soon as it was dawn the King rowed with his cutters and fleet ships to seek the Bagals, but they had sailed out to sea before day. The King pursued them; and when the

Bagals saw that the Birkibeins' ships gained on them, and that they would not escape, they turned to land. One of their ships, a galley, steered by Sæbiorn Lim, rowed to Tunnaskaga, and the Birkibeins rowed after him. Sæbiorn escaped and another man, all the others were slain, and the Birkibeins seized the galley and all that was on it. The Bagals turned with seven cutters north of Oxney into Sandafiord, to a creek called Heslivik, on its north [west] side. They ran their ships to land and sprang on shore. King Sverri fell on them and slew very many, seized their ships and all that was in them. The Bagals fled inland, and the King turned back to Tunsberg, where he remained for a time.

2.580

King Sverri passes the winter in Bergen.

2.581

170. Shortly after, the King sailed on his voyage north; but when he reached Portyria he turned back to the Vik with a few cutters and fleet ships, intending to cut off whatever Bagals he caught. He sailed day and night, expecting that the Bagals would make for the market towns as soon as they thought he had left the Vik. The King sailed first to Tunsberg and slew seven men of the Bagals. Then he sailed to Oslo, where also he slew several men. Afterwards he sailed back to his fleet, and came up with the large ships in Askeyiar-sound, north, on Limgards-side. King Sverri then sailed with his fleet north to Bergen, and now permitted the troops of the levy to return home. During the winter he abode in Bergen. The Bagals abode in the Vik, whence they drew tax and tribute.

2.582

King Sverri besieges the Bagals under Hreidar Sendiman on the rock of Tunsberg [1201].

2.583

171. The next spring King Sverri called out the levy everywhere from the north of the land, and sailed with a great host east to the Vik. Hreidar abode on the rock in Tunsberg with scarcely two hundred

men; Hallvard Bratti was there and many other captains of companies, but their young King and Sigurd Earlsson were up in the country with a large force. King Sverri sailed east over the Fold and visited the yeomen in the summer, and took fines from them; all the folk submitted to him except the Skeynir. After this he sailed up the river [Raum-Elf] to Borg, and had his cutters dragged past the waterfall Sarp, and rowed up the river. Then he marched his men up into Skaun and burnt all the homesteads. The yeomen then came to be reconciled and paid fines, and the King went back to his ships and sailed north across the Fold to Tunsberg. This was about the time of the later Mariumass.

2.584

King Sverri encamped about the rock and hindered the Bagals from leaving it. He set up tent-booths east of the rock, and between the rock and the town, and north to the sea. He had a trench dug outside his camp, from the bay in the north to Skeliasteins-sound in the south, and erected palisades inside the trench; all this was done to guard against sudden attacks of the land host. The King had his ships laid up on shore and protected. He divided the work of the siege among his force. The Gests were in the north by the road which comes down from the Froda-as; Petr Steypi was their chief, and they took buildings from the town below and removed them there, and it was called Gestabakki. The King slept for the most part in the town, and a large force with him.

2.585

Siege of the rock of Tunsberg. Unsuccessful attempt to storm the rock. Other devices.

2.586

172. King Sverri arranged his force for an assault on the rock. On the south his men ascended with his standard to the shelf of the rock, and the Gests advanced against the northern blockhouse. The Bagals were prepared for the defence, and as the Birkibeins marched up the rock, they hurled down on them stones and missiles. The Birkibeins came quite close to the blockhouse, and men on both sides thrust at one

another with spears. The Bagals in the blockhouse cast stones that flew so fast and were so big that they could not be withstood; they crushed both shields and steel caps, and the Birkibeins retired wounded to the shelf. The King then perceived that the vantage-ground was such that the rock could not be taken by assault. The Bagals then were jubilant and scornful in their language.

2.587

After the King had abode a long time by the rock he despatched men into all the districts round to collect for him war-contributions and provisions, and the Birkibeins succeeded easily in this, so long as they were not prevented by ice from using the ships.

2.588

King Sverri thought it a grievous hurt that no one was found to tell him of the preparations on the rock. So he devised this plan. The church ladders in the town were taken and fastened to one another, and placed against the south side of the tower of Lafranskirk. A man then climbed up to the part of the roof that looked away from the rock. Claspings with his arms the ball at the top, he saw all that was to be seen on the rock. The Bagals observed him, and Hreidar Sendiman shot at him; he sent a first arrow into the ball, and a second instantly after, which struck it between the man's hands. With that he loosed his hold, and the roof sheltered him from more shots. Then he came down and told the King what he had seen. The Bagals had dragged cutters up the rock; their well was a short distance below the northern blockhouse, and they had turned one of the cutters keel upwards, so that they might easily go to the well from the rock. The blockhouses were built on four pillars; on these were fixed sills and a raised platform; below, between the pillars there were hurdles. One night during autumn, when it was pitch-dark, the King sent a man on the rock whose name was Svein Munki; he took with him a cable, and carried two spears, one in his hand, the other, a short-shafted one, in his belt. Having ascended the rock, he fastened the cable round one of the pillars as high as he could. At the other end of the cable were more than a hundred men.

Svein struck the cable as a sign to the men that the one end was fast, and they seized the cable and pulled hard. The blockhouse began to sway considerably, and the Bagals inside were greatly terrified; but at that moment the rope broke asunder. Svein Munki walked up the rock, and on the east side were two watchmen, both asleep. Through one he thrust his spear; the other sprang up, and Svein thrust at him as he stood, and thus slew them both. He then went down the rock on the east side and back to the Birkibeins.

2.589

King Sverri planned many devices to win the rock. He had a great wicker shield made, which he fixed on stout pillars, and had it taken right under the blockhouse; but it was not easy to manage, and the device came to nothing. Every day the Birkibeins went within range, and the two armies exchanged shots, but the Bagals always had the advantage in the fight.

2.590

Siege of the rock of Tunsberg. The garrison send for help to Ingi and Sigurd Earlsson.

2.591

173. Ingi, chief of the Bagals, Sigurd Earlsson, Arni Bishops-kin, and many captains of companies besides, with the main force of the Bagals, were in the Uplands, and at times in the Vik. These chiefs had made an agreement with Hreidar that the one force should come to the assistance of the other if there was need at any time. But Hreidar and his men, being closely beset by King Sverri, thought the help of their men was slow in coming; they felt themselves placed in great danger, and determined to send messengers to Ingi and the other chiefs. For this purpose one night they took a little eight-oared cutter and dragged it over to the west side of the rock near the sea; and having laid oars in it and fastened ropes to it, they swung it off the rock by means of levers. Ten men went on board, under the command of Thord Dokka, and the cutter was lowered by the ropes to the sea. This was an exploit of great danger, especially so because there were Birkibeins in

cutters opposite the rock who kept watch there every night. The Bagals dashed their oars into the water and rowed hard over the sound past the Birkibeins, and sprang on shore within Smiorberg. The Birkibeins rowed after them and captured the empty cutter, but nothing more. The Bagals went on their journey till they came to Ingi and Sigurd, and gave the message of Hreidar with tidings of what had happened. The Bagals declared that they heard only that about the Birkibeins which gave them no longing for an encounter, and said that King Sverri would turn away from the rock as soon as snow came or frost. The morning after the Bagals had escaped from the rock, King Sverri was told of it, and said to his men, "However weary you are of sitting around the rock, you see now that they are more weary still of sitting on it."

2.592

King John of England sends King Sverri two hundred Ribbalds.

2.593

174. In the summer when King Sverri was in Bergen, John, King of the English, had sent him two hundred warriors of those called Ribbalds. They were swift of foot as deer, excellent bowmen, very brave, and did not shrink from evil deeds. King Sverri despatched them to the Uplands, and set over them, as their chief, a brother of Sigurd Skialgi, named Hidi, a man little praised by others. The Bibbalds came down into Haddingiadale, marched by the upper road over Soknadale, and down into Thelamork. Wherever they came they slew every one, young and old, women as well as men. They killed all the cattle they could, and even dogs and cats and every living thing in their way; they burnt, too, all the homesteads they came near. But if people gathered to encounter them, they fled to the fells and inaccessible places, and ever appeared where no one expected them. They plundered homesteads which no hostile force had ever before visited, and committed outrages the like of which no man knew. They came to King Sverri when he was besieging the rock, and ever marched boldly to attack the Bagals, and exchanged shots with them. One day the Bagals hit a Ribbald with an

arrow so that he was instantly slain. The others uttered a loud yell at the sight and shot at the Bagals, running at one time towards the rock, and at another from it. Soon after, one of them shot Viking Nefia with an arrow, which struck him in the throat on the left side and caused his death. He had been a very great warrior.

2.594

Siege of the rock of Tunsberg. Stratagem of King Sverri.

2.595

175. Thord Dokka was sent from the rock because Hreidar felt that he needed help from Ingi and Sigurd. King Sverri had been told of this, and he said: "The Bagals will expect them to come, should they wish to be moved by the message. We will try one trick upon them. At night, in the thick darkness, our men shall march past the Froda-as with a large force, and take care that neither the Bagals nor the townsmen get to know. The Birkibeins who are left behind shall listen for the sound of the trumpet, and seize their weapons. Then both divisions shall draw up in battle-array and make as though you were fighting, but, of course, forbear hurting one another. You who go from the town shall fall before those who are coming to it. Make as much noise as you can and act as if you were having the best of it, but in the end let all turn away and flee. I expect the Bagals will then come down from the rock; so we shall place some of our troops in ambush close to it, and 'trolls will come between house and yeomen.'" This stratagem was carried out. In the morning as soon as it became light, the watchmen of the Bagals observed from the northern blockhouse a large and well-equipped force marching along the way down by the Froda-as. They went at once and roused Hreidar, telling him those must be their fellows coming. Hreidar rose up and bade his men take arms; and when they were armed they went to the northern blockhouse. Thence they saw two standards, one with the force descending the ridge, and the other with the force that went from the town; they heard also much blowing of trumpets. Next, swords were brandished, and they saw that the Birkibeins fled, and some fell. The Bagals then urged Hreidar to

quit the rock and help their men, and not let the Birkibeins come again within the trench. Hreidar answered: "Let us see first how they deal with one another. If the Birkibeins are chased to the trench, they will be slow in getting over the palisades, and our men will slay as many of them as they like." And again he said: "This flight proceeds strangely. It seems to me as if they were playing a game. Do you observe how they seek dry spots to fell on, or else fall on their shields? And do you see any marks of blood on their weapons or clothes? No! neither do I," he said. "This must be a trick of Sverri." When the King saw that the Bagals were on their guard and did not quit the rock, he turned back to his camp with all his force

2.596

Siege of the rock of Tunsberg. Speech of King Sverri.

2.597

176. And now the winter came on with frost and sheets of ice, and the Birkibeins found it harder to rake together provisions, as the yeomen grew more difficult to take by the horns. Their fare became much worse, and a general murmur arose throughout the host, and nearly all the levies wished to return home. The King held a council, and spoke and said: "I hear now that my men consider this a wanton siege, and that it would be good to be at home, and happy would he be that should go home. To murmur thus against your King is unworthy of warriors, even if you don't fill your stomachs as labourers at the flail. You are unlike those men of the olden time of whom the story is told, how they besieged their foes to destroy them so stubbornly that their clothes rotted from them, and they devoured the sheaths of their swords and the upper leathers of their shoes, and abandoned not the siege till they were victorious. Though I take these men as an example, there is a nearer one to mention in the Bagals on the rock, who will not surrender, and show more steadfastness and stubbornness than you. Now, let me hear no longer of any murmuring, for here we shall sit whether it seems to you fair or foul, blithe or harsh, crooked or straight, until we have the Bagals in our power."

2.598

As the winter advanced, food on the rock diminished, and Hreidar saw that they would soon be at their last gasp in the struggle if no help came from Ingi and Sigurd. But no answer came to their message, no answer save one which the Birkibeins made them every day, that their King Ingi would soon come with a mighty force to free them. To the Bagals this seemed a mockery, which it was.

2.599

The Bagals send a force into Sogn to divert King Sverri from the siege.

2.600

177. After this, Hreidar caused a letter to be written to Ingi and Sigurd, in which he said that though in evil plight they might hold the rock until Nikolas-mass; and he begged them with fair words to come with help. There was now a hard frost, and a sheet of ice lay from the rock over the bay. The next night Hreidar despatched a man from the rock, north, with the letter. The man had a pair of snow-skates and slipped away on them, keeping close to land until he was beyond the trench; and the Birkibeins knew nothing of it till he was quite gone. He went on his journey and came with the letter to Ingi, in Hainar-Kaupang. Ingi held a meeting of his captains and had the letter read before them. Sigurd Earlsson thus answered: "We have roamed about in bands a while, we have ever lost our men through King Sverri, and we have caused much loss of life among his men. We shall not now rush headlong to certain death though Hreidar would point the way. We shall try another plan. Let us march north to the fiords and procure ships; and Sverri will hear such news of us that he will think it more needful to defend the land there than to besiege a few men on the rock." This important counsel pleased the whole meeting.

2.601

The Bagals went on their journey north into the dales, and came down into Raumsdale, where they procured cutters, and hastened south, coastwise. When they were opposite Sogn-Sea they turned into it, pulling hard against the wind. In the night they reached Vik, where

they captured a cutter and all that it contained. Jon Stal was on it, and he intended to sail south to Bergen. Jon sprang on shore and escaped with all his men into the wood, and the yeomen supplied them with weapons and clothes.

2.602

The Birkibeins defeat the Bagals in Sogn.

2.603

178. Next morning nearly fifty men of the Bagals went on shore to the bath at Hof. They were seen to go by Jon Stal, who was on the fell with seventeen men; and when he thought the moment favourable he hurried down to the homestead. The Bagals saw him coming, and escaped; but he followed them down to Aldinhagi and there slew one of them. Then he turned back, and the next day began a march overland south to Bergen. In Bergen he found Einar Kings-kin and Dagfinn, and they made ready straightway the force they had got, took shipping, and sailed north to Sogn. Here they learnt that the Bagals were staying in Lusa-Kaupang, and had summoned an Assembly of the men of Sogn and called out the levy. Ingi was there accepted as King. Gunnthiof was the name of the yeoman who gave him the name of King, and the Bagals consented to his words. The Birkibeins rowed in the night into Sogn, and came to Kaupang at dawn. They went straight to the quays, sounded their trumpets, and marched up boldly. The Bagals seized their weapons and fled; some of them were slain. There was a man named Biom Furulegg, a vagrant In the fell above Lusa-Kaupang, in a mountain-shed, he came upon Arni Bishops-kin, who was sorely wounded and had not been able to escape further. Biorn slew him for the clothes he wore and his money, and concealed the deed. The body was found the following spring. The Bagals ran up into Kaupangs-fell and down to Svaforni; some fled to Folka, whence they sailed to Lustr on ferry-boats and smaller vessels. The Birkibeins seized their ships, a great part of their weapons and clothes, and all their money. The Bagals joined one another in Lustr, and then passed over the fell down to Ardala Jon Stal heard of them and went there after them, but the

Bagals had then gone beyond the lake, and the next morning they marched over the fell to Valdres, and so on to the Uplands.

2.604

Surrender of the rock of Tunsberg.

2.605

179. King Sverri still lay encamped about the rock, and the day was now past until which Hreidar in the letter had said he could hold out on the rock. Their condition was now so hard and food so scarce that there was little to eat. They cut up their tackle of walrus-hide and had to manage with that when keeping Yule, and had not even half enough. One night in the early part of Yule, Hallvard Bratti and another man escaped from the rock and came to King Sverri, who gave them quarter. The next morning King Sverri's men heard of it, and were not pleased that the Bagals should have quarter. The Bagals on the rock became aware that the King had given quarter to Hallvard, and many now hoped for quarter who hitherto had no expectation of it. Many escaped from the rock to the King, and all obtained quarter. Then the King became aware of the fact that the Bagals on the rock had lost all hope of life or help, and were at the last gasp, through want of food. Hreidar, too, had caused the King to be told that he would quit the rock the next day, and rather suffer death by the sword than by hunger; but would gladly receive quarter if he had the chance. He asked quarter, too, for all his comrades. King Sverri now summoned all his men to a council, and thus spoke: "I desire now to consult with you, how we shall deal with Hreidar and his fellows, if they come into our power. Should this happen, all our men will rejoice to end this obstinate siege, and those will rejoice the most who behaved the worst in the autumn, and would have abandoned it. Shall we give quarter to any of these men or to none? What do you advise?" Many answered and said: "Collected here on the rock are those who have done the utmost evil to us and our men. It will seem to us a hard lot, to have starved here this winter, and endured much toil on their account, and to take now the slayers of our fathers and our brothers and give them

quarter, and hereafter to share our cabins with them. And King Sverri replied: "Look, my good men, those of you who seem to me too proud, and will not endure to be on a level with me, and bethink you whether any will be reproached hereafter for following my example. Here in Tunsberg the Bagals slew Hidi, my brother; and in Oslo, Earl Philippus, my kinsman, and many besides. And now this winter you must have heard them call Sverri dog, mare, and many other bad names. I am willing to forgive them for God's sake, and I hope from Him, in return, forgiveness of all I have done against Him. You have souls no less than I, and must bear this in mind. No man will ever call you cowards any the more because you so act." All consented to let the King have his way, and the council ended. The King then sent word to Hreidar and his men that quarter was promised them. The next day at the time of the morning meal, Hreidar and his men left the rock. King Sverri had them brought before him, and they all swore fealty to him. They were then dispersed among the companies, and the King took Hreidar into his own company. He bade men have great care in nursing them, and this was done; and he bade the men themselves to be wary at first, both as to meat and drink, but they differed much in that. So near death had they come that they all fell ill before gaining strength, and many died; and of those who preserved life many pined for a long time. Hreidar was long ill, and King Sverri used many healing cures. The King was encamped around Tunsberg for twenty weeks, and soon after the rock was given up he prepared to leave, and launched his ships.

2.606

King Sverri's sickness [1202].

2.607

180. King Sverri fell sick in Tunsberg, but the sickness was not severe. When he was ready to go away he sailed north to Bergen, where he arrived at the beginning of Lent or a little earlier. During the day he lay mostly in the aft-castle of the ship. Hreidar also lay there, close to the aft-castle; a place was prepared for him on the chest near the high-seat. The King bade that he should have the same nursing and care as

himself, and often conversed with him. Hreidar was a wise man and well acquainted with many things. King Sverri was moved to the castle in Bergen, and a couch was prepared for him in the hall. On the Tuesday morning of the second week in Lent, King Sverri fell into a perspiration, and then seemed free from pain. Many came to visit him, though generally there were but few near him.

2.608

And when they had nearly all gone away, the King spoke to Petr Svarti, and said he would tell him his dream. "A man came to me," he said, "the same that has appeared often before, and has never allowed me what was false. In my dream I seemed to be conscious that I was sick and feeble, and I asked him how the sickness would end; and I thought he turned away quickly from me as he thus answered, 'Prepare thee, Sverri, for a rising again.' Now this dream appears to me very ambiguous, but, after it, I think that one change or other will occur quickly." Petr answered, "You, Sire, far more clearly than any other, are able to interpret this; but my heart forebodes that the rising again of which he spoke is at the last judgment, and I would prepare, Sire, as if the vision had so declared." The King answered, "It is not unlikely." And it was so, that as the day advanced a drowsiness fell on the King. The next morning he sent into the town for priests, and they made ready to administer extreme unction. Then he caused the letter to be read aloud which he was sending to his son-Hakon, touching the ordering of the kingdom, and he had his seal affixed to it. He spoke then before all those present, and said, "I call you all to witness, that I know of no son alive except only Hakon, though hereafter men come forward desirous of raising strife in the land, and call themselves my sons. Now before I am anointed, I wish to be set in the high-seat, where I will abide, come better come worse. And if I die here in the high-seat, my friends standing around me, the death and the story of it will be other than Bishop Nikolas Arnason will expect; for he said that I should be smitten down like an ox, and be food for hound and raven. But God be thanked that He has protected me in many struggles from

the weapons of my foes.” Then extreme unction was administered to the King. After that, his strength diminished. And when he perceived that death was drawing nigh, he said, “Leave my face uncovered when I am dead, that my friends and foes may both see if there is any mark on my body of the ban wherewith my foes have cursed and excommunicated me. If the signs are no better than they say, I shall not then be able to conceal them. The kingdom has brought me labour and unrest and trouble, rather than peace and a quiet life. But so it is that many have envied me my rank, and have let their envy grow to full enmity. May God forgive them all; and let my Lord now judge between me and them, and decide all my cause.”

2.609

King Sverri's death.

2.610

181. King Sverri died on the Saturday in Ember week, and his body was laid out with all honour, as was expected. His face was left uncovered, as he had commanded. All who were present observed, and all afterwards bore one and the same testimony, that they had never seen a fairer corpse than his. While he was alive his complexion was very beautiful.

2.611

King Sverri was most polished in manner. He was low of stature, stout and strong, broad of face and well featured. His beard was usually trimmed, and his eyes were hazel in colour, set deeply and handsomely. He was calm and thoughtful. He was most eloquent in speech; his ideas were lofty, his articulation was distinct, and when he spoke, the ring of his voice was so clear that though he did not appear to speak loud, all understood him, even though they were far off. He was a seemly chief as he sat in his high-seat grandly dressed; for though his legs were short he sat high in the seat. He never drank strong drink to the injury of his reason, and always ate but one meal a day. He was valiant and bold, very capable of enduring fatigue and loss of sleep.

2.612

We see in King Sverri, as we often see elsewhere, that the paternity of men is no sign of their characters, for King Sigurd and Sverri, father and son, were unlike in disposition. Sigurd was light-hearted and impetuous, but Sverri was steadfast and calm. Sigurd was credulous and easily swayed, Sverri wary and cautious in the choice of friends. Sigurd was inconstant and variable in temper, Sverri staunch and even-tempered. Sigurd was headstrong and outspoken, Sverri true to his word and reserved. Sigurd was ignorant and irresolute, Sverri sagacious and conscientious. Yet in many ways they resembled each other. Both were ambitious and magnanimous; both were courteous, obliging towards friends, but hard towards foes; both were popular with their Guardsmen and followers, for both were hopeful under misfortune, and their best friends were those who were most intimate with their ways. King Sverri was lamented by his men and loving friends; and even those who had been his enemies declared that no man like Sverri had appeared in Norway in their time.

2.613

King Sverri's burial.

2.614

182. King Sverri's body was carried down to Kristskirk with great pomp. The stone wall of the church between the chancel and south door was opened, and the King's body laid therein. The wall was then built up, and a tablet of brass was fixed, on which was engraved in gold letters [Latin] verses to this effect: "Here lies the excellency of kings, the support and stay, the model and pattern of truth, gallantry, and worth; the manly strength, shield, and defence of his native land and the inheritance of his fathers; the courage of resolution, the destruction of foes, the honour of Norway, the glory of its people, the strengthening of justice, the amendment of law, the affection of all his followers." To the wall was fixed a velvet cloth, and on it were his standard, shield, sword, and helmet.

2.615

King Sverri died on the eighth day before the Ides of March, in the year MCCXV. from the incarnation of our Lord Jesus Christ. The same year died Knut, King of the Danes, and his brother Valdamar succeeded him. Also Earl Birgi Brosa died. The Swedes then took Jon, son of King Sorkvi, to be their King. Jon was one year old, and the Swedes had then an unbreeched King.

2.616

King Sverri had reigned twenty-five years, and eighteen years had elapsed from the fall of King Magnus Erlingsson.

2.617

Here ends now the Saga of Sverri, King of Norway.